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He found himself drawn gradually, against his will, deeper and deeper into the shifting sands of Sicilian politics. Protracted attempts to remove the Queen, to impose a new constitution (modelled on British lines) upon an almost feudal society, and to free Sicily from Neapolitan domination led to Bentinck's becoming a virtual dictator. Benevolent though his rule was, it began to crumble when he conceived an ill-timed plan to establish Sicily as a British Colony. This was resented, naturally enough, by the Sicilian Royalists, but also by his own Government, whose foreign policy at the time did not favour the move. Bentinck's irresponsible behaviour as commander of an expeditionary force in Italy brought matters to a head, and he was recalled in disgrace in 1815.

The war ended; Britain ceased to take an interest in Sicily's domestic troubles, and all traces of the abortive Parliamentary system gradually disappeared.

Such, in outline, is Dr Rosselli's theme; and his telling of it is no less entertaining than the full story itself. His book will interest not only students of European history and British foreign policy, but all those who are concerned with the moral issues that arise when a great power interferes in the affairs of a smaller power.



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LORD WILLIAM BENTINCK AND THE
BRITISH OCCUPATION OF SICILY
1811-1814

M. de Metternich a raison, une raison de barbare si vous voulez; mais il ne ment pas en avançant que le gouvernement de l'opinion ou des deux Chambres n'est pas un *véritable besoin* pour l'Italie; ce n'est un besoin que pour quelques âmes généreuses qui ont vu les pays étrangers ou fait des voyages. Et encore ces âmes délicates, arrivées *au fait et au prendre*, s'amusent à exprimer de beaux sentiments, comme les Girondins, et ne savent pas agir. Je ne vois nulle part des Mirabeau, des Danton, des Carnot.

STENDHAL, *Rome, Naples et Florence*

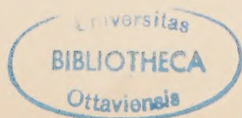
JOHN ROSSELLI

LORD WILLIAM BENTINCK &
THE BRITISH OCCUPATION
OF SICILY

1811-1814

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To

HERBERT BUTTERFIELD

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PREFACE

This book—there is no disguising it—started out as a dissertation for the Ph.D. degree in the University of Cambridge, and later turned into a Thirlwall Prize essay. But I have revised and in part rewritten it for publication. As it stands it rests on a good deal of earlier work by British and Italian historians, notably Sir Charles Webster's great work on Castlereagh. But I have tried to tell from the point of view of both countries the story of events which have to do at once with diplomatic and with local political history, as well as—in their abortive way—with the history of British colonial expansion.

His Grace the Duke of Portland allowed me to use Lord William Bentinck's papers, now on loan to Nottingham University Library. Professor Walter Maturi, of Turin University, let me read his transcript of King Ferdinand's Diary, which together with the other Bourbon papers in the Naples State Archives was destroyed in 1943; he also gave me much helpful advice. Miss H. M. Lackland (Mrs F. Best) lent me books and notes which she had made for her earlier study of the subject. The late Senator Benedetto Croce also let me see copies of documents in his possession. Professor Gaetano Salvemini read an early version of the MS., questioned a number of points, and so led me to do all I could to strengthen my argument. Mr G. Ellis Flack, librarian, and Miss J. Renshaw, archivist of Nottingham University Library, gave me much practical help; so did Mr R. H. Ellis and other officials of the Public Record Office, and Dr E. Librino and Dr L. A. Pagano of the Palermo State Archives. I have also had advice and encouragement from Mr C. W. Crawley, Mr D. Mack Smith, and others. I am thankful to them all. What I owe the Master of Peterhouse the dedication tries to say.

March 1955

J. R.

POSTSCRIPT

When the Bourbons were driven out of Naples in 1860 they left behind one collection of State and private papers and took another with them into their Bavarian exile. The first collection, after having been made public only in 1930, was destroyed in 1943. The second has now been bought by the Italian State and returned to the Naples State Archives. Most of it was there made available to students in the late summer of last year, when this book was already in page-proof. Through the courtesy of Count Filangieri, Superintendent of the Naples Archives, I was able on a recent visit to read some of the papers and to go through the inventory. Much of the collection, as it turns out, duplicates that which was lost in 1943 (and which several historians had previously studied). The new material concerning the Napoleonic period seems likely to yield some interesting details rather than to alter anyone's interpretation of important matters.

January 1956

J. R.

NOTE २

In transcribing from English documents of the period I have modernised the spelling and punctuation: with this exception, that to keep the flavour of Bentinck's Journal I have left his punctuation (or the lack of it) unchanged, as well as his spelling of foreign words.

An asterisk in the text refers the reader to the notes at the end of the book.

INTRODUCTION

I

When a Great Power defends a small one in time of war the Great Power often finds it hard not to meddle in the domestic concerns of the small Power. At the same time the Great Power is often less interested in these domestic concerns than the small Power (or the later historian) imagines. The British occupation of Sicily between 1806 and 1815 illustrates both these truths. What is surprising is not that Britain interfered, but that her Governments twice decided to interfere in full and deliberate strength. The first attempt, in 1806, came to nothing. The second, in 1811, the Government entrusted to Lord William Bentinck to carry out as Minister to the Sicilian Court and Commander-in-Chief in the Mediterranean. This time the consequences were far beyond what anybody—Government or envoy—had had in mind at first.

At the end of 1805 the Court of Naples, for the second time in seven years, abandoned their continental possessions to the French and fled to Sicily. From then on British Governments provided money, troops, and ships to keep the island—but for Sardinia the only piece of Italian soil outside French control—in friendly hands. For most of the next six years this was all they cared for. It was a negative policy: the highest stakes lay elsewhere. To people in Sicily, of course, things looked very different, and in particular to the British agents there. A month's voyage separated them from home and left them mostly to their own devices. The problems they faced were thorny and seemed urgent. They distrusted the Court and the Court distrusted them. As the years wore on relations became steadily worse. By 1811, when the British Government made up its mind to intervene, and stuck to its decision, a succession of Ministers and Commanders had long been urging it to do so.

What made this intervention notable was that it became inextricably mixed with a crisis in the domestic politics of Sicily. The internal struggle that led to the revolution of 1812 could not have taken the course it did without British help; nor could

Britain have intervened as she did had that struggle not provided both occasion and warrant.

The British Government, which thought it was trying to achieve immediate military ends, found itself forwarding a liberal revolution in Sicily and plans for independence and unity in continental Italy. This happened not merely because the chief agent, Bentinck, behaved as he did, but because (as so often before and since) diplomatic and domestic affairs could not be kept separate: they depended and acted on one another.

What happened in Sicily to help along this interplay was the rise of a movement of resistance to royal power which in the end became the 'English party'. But what was this movement? It has not even an accepted name: the 'patriotic' movement, a name used at the time, must do as well as any. Some historians have seen in it a straightforward liberal opposition to despotism, some (more recently) the embodiment of class privilege and insular tradition. But this is too simple. For it was their very particularism that led the more advanced patriots to attempt a reform, along English lines, of the country's institutions; and if they had succeeded they would have ended by jettisoning many of the privileges which their movement as a whole had begun by defending. But although this attempt at making reform grow from an enduring root of conservatism had (not quite by chance) an affinity with English practice, it did not work in Sicily: the outcome was not a resolution but a lasting contradiction which the movement was never able to get over.

The movement began and ended as the affair of a small number of nobles and their dependents, mostly lawyers and clerics. Useless to look for political consciousness or strength elsewhere; useless, too, in a country where land-ownership conferred the highest prestige and tended to draw what wealth there was away from industry or trade, to look for a middle class apart from these people and from a number of landlords' agents or chief tenants.* This aristocracy faced two dangers. One was external—the inroads of a monarchy bent on centralisation and authoritarian reform; the other internal—the gradual worsening of the barons' own economic position. The one scratched the juridical shell of Sicilian feudalism; the other threatened to eat it away from within.

The policy of the central Government—it was the typical enlightened absolutism of the time—was launched by the Viceroy Caracciolo in the 1780's; his successors then carried it forward with more or less determination.

Caracciolo tried to restrict the extremely wide powers of alienation and succession which the barons had enjoyed ever since the period of feudal anarchy under the Aragonese kings; he investigated dubious titles; he attacked feudal jurisdictions; and above all he attempted to deprive the barons of their virtual freedom from taxation. All these measures constituted the first serious threat to the aristocracy as the ruling class, and led to a constitutional conflict between Crown and Parliament.* The conflict never came to a head in the 1780's and 90's, because the Crown chose to yield or compromise; but it was only put off; and meanwhile Parliament had begun to appear, for the first time, as the focus of baronial resistance to the Crown. This Parliament, the only one of its kind in Italy, had until then been no more than an Estates General, meeting once every four years to vote supply—an automatic process—and present petitions. But now its one real power, that of distributing taxation—a power of the greatest importance to the barons—had been challenged. From then on its members gradually became better aware of their constitutional rights than they had ever been while those rights were still unquestioned.*

At the same time the barons were beginning to notice a more radical threat to their predominance. It has lately been pointed out* that the growth of absentee landlordship in the 18th century was accompanied by a sharp rise in prices: so that while the barons' expenditure increased, the real value of the fixed rents they drew from their estates tended to fall. In other words, the barons, while they gradually surrendered to intermediaries their functions as feudal landlords, began to lose the benefits which those functions had once brought them. The greatest families were often unable to avoid huge burdens of debt and mortgages; some even went bankrupt. Hence the restrictions which the feudal system still placed on the alienation of lands began to appear burdensome, and the system itself to lose its *raison d'être*. This helps to explain why, in 1812, the barons' triumphant assertion of the constitutional rights of Parliament went together

with a spontaneous renunciation of feudal privileges—that is, of the very privileges in whose defence the rights of Parliament had in the first place been invoked.

But these economic straits alone are not the whole explanation. It will not do to assume that men are always aware of their own interests. In fact, conservatism and *esprit de corps* often led a majority of the barons to act against what might have seemed their economic interest; and, in contrast, another reason for the growing concern with reform was the spread among the small class of educated Sicilians of the commonplaces of Enlightened thought. These motives in turn were often mixed. It is striking to see how the particularism and attachment to tradition characteristic of an island on the edge of Europe infused into the Enlightenment a distinct local colour. It is curious, for instance, that the historian and jurist Gregorio, writing at the end of the 18th century, should have based his assertion of the supremacy of public law over private, and of the monarchy over particular privilege, on an appeal to the past—to the Norman Conquest and to the golden age of strong central government that followed it, as against the Aragonese period of baronial anarchy. Reform, in Gregorio's view, was to be achieved not by wiping the slate clean, but by restoring the Sicilian Constitution to its pristine purity, shorn of later and 'unnatural' growths.* Similarly, the Abate Paolo Balsamo, a professor of agriculture and political economy, while he followed the teaching of Arthur Young and Adam Smith in these subjects, looked, when he came to deal with constitutional issues, to the Aragonese period as to the fount of Sicilian liberties; and when he turned to Blackstone for guidance in drafting the 1812 Constitution, he drew not merely on Blackstone's paraphrase of Montesquieu, but on his interpretation of the English common law—between which and the inherited mass of Sicilian law a parallel could be drawn.*

One may see as another sign of the Sicilians' insularity and traditionalism the scant interest they took in the egalitarian ideas of Rousseau and the French Revolution, and, in contrast, the sympathy they shewed with English institutions. At a time when educated Sicilians were taking greater notice of local economic problems, it was natural enough that, comparing the backward condition of their country with England's, they should

ascribe England's wealth to her political constitution, and should see in that constitution a possible panacea for Sicilian ills.

'Were we happy enough', a Sicilian nobleman told the English traveller Brydone as early as 1770, 'to enjoy the blessings of your constitution, you might call us rich indeed, many hidden doors of opulence would then be opened which now are not even thought of, and we should soon re-assume our ancient name and consequence; but at present we are nothing.'*

English institutions took on an added prestige in Sicilian eyes from the common origin of both nations in the Norman Conquest. The example of the English Constitution could therefore be quoted in defence of Sicilian liberties; it seemed an attractive model to those who wished to mend rather than end their ancient institutions.*

But Sicilian particularism took yet another form, and this the most deep-rooted, most widespread, and most lasting: resentment at seeing the country ruled in the interests of Naples, by Neapolitans who were too familiar to be foreigners, too foreign to be compatriots.* This resentment, fed by centuries of past rivalry, was re-awakened by Caracciolo's attacks on local institutions; it could only be exacerbated by the presence in Sicily, in 1799 and again from 1806 onwards, of a Court bent on recovering Naples and seemingly indifferent to Sicilian concerns, and of a Neapolitan Ministry hostile to Sicilian privileges. The revenues of the island were being used 'to recover a kingdom which, once reunited to the Crown, would again reduce their own country to the harsh condition of a province'; and to support a flock of 'foreign' pensioners and officials.* Desire for independence and an end to Neapolitan meddling was the one feeling that could be counted on to unite the Sicilians; it was shared even by staunch conservatives, devoted to the monarchy.* This local jealousy contributed more to the growth of the patriotic movement than some Italian historians—with the later unification of Italy in mind—have been willing to allow.

Thus the French Revolution and the ensuing wars widened and intensified the conflict between Crown and Parliament. True, the Revolution at first frightened the Court into calling a halt to the attempt to make Sicily a modern absolutist State; and the loss of Naples at the end of 1798 forced it once again

to give in temporarily on the recurrent matter of the distribution of taxation, which had looked like bringing it into conflict with the Parliament of that year.* But the times fed the spirit of 'speculation and independence' which Caracciolo's reforms had aroused; and the presence, after 1805, of both the Court and the British helped to bring together all the causes for dissatisfaction and gropings towards reform already described, until in the end what had begun as a baronial protest against the loss of privileges took on more and more the appearance of a national movement of revolt.

So much for the outline of a growing conflict. But when we come to look beyond outlines, classes, or abstract forces for the motives of individual men who took part in it, we find some curious blanks. The fact is that (for reasons that have less to do with Sicily's backwardness at the time than with its backwardness since) we are worse informed about the leading Sicilians of a century and a half ago than we are about many ancient or medieval characters. Most of them are names to which we can tack a few anecdotes. But even what we know shows clearly enough how hard it would be to fit these men into a convenient mould. Among the 'patriots' motives and actions were as various as the influences that set the movement going, and often no less contradictory.

Take, for instance, the Prince of Cassaro: A leader of baronial resistance in the 1798 Parliament; later reconciled with the Court; re-emerging to head the patriots in the 1810 Parliament; following afterwards a line of conduct equally ambiguous and variable—this enigmatic figure seems nevertheless to have acted from some consistent principle besides mere opportunism: one may perhaps see in him a man attached to the old aristocratic constitution and equally opposed to royal interference and to liberal reform.* No such consistency, however, can be found in his sometime henchman the Prince of Aci, who throughout his various and violent shifts of allegiance seems to have been little more than a hothead.* As for the two most prominent patriotic barons, the Prince of Belmonte and his uncle the Prince of Castelnovo, character and convictions differentiated and, in the end, divided them.

Belmonte, rich, handsome, witty, a man of parts as well as a

grand seigneur, had made a grand tour through England and the Continent, and had been one of the first Sicilian noblemen to mix on equal terms with men of learning. Although 'his worst enemies dared not deny him eloquence, dignity, courage, liberality and other heroic virtues', even his hagiographer had to admit his unbounded vanity and occasional lack of judgement.* Castelnuevo, like Belmonte, had travelled and read widely: but while Belmonte was for a time on intimate terms with the King and Queen, and remained a fast friend of Louis-Philippe, Duke of Orleans, Castelnuevo led an austere and retired life, shunning the Court, which, indeed, thought him inclined to democratic ideas; while Belmonte had the confidence and the gifts of an active politician and party leader, and seems to have been somewhat shallow and volatile where issues of public policy were concerned, Castelnuevo was rather the political theorist, the conscientious administrator, the dispassionate and often despondent observer, little suited for the rough-and-tumble of everyday politics. His friend Balsamo, though he praised 'the uprightness and ready perspicacity of his mind, the firmness of his character, his delicate sense of honour, the purity of his morals and his disinterested devotion to public affairs', nevertheless had to admit more than once that Castelnuevo was liable in moments of crisis to throw in his hand, with deplorable results, rather than compromise his Roman firmness in the cause he held right.* In both Belmonte and Castelnuevo an aristocratic, authoritarian streak came out often enough: but if Belmonte may be compared to a great Whig nobleman, Castelnuevo's convictions sprang rather from an idealisation of Republican Rome and America; and his concern for equity led him into policies which could only undermine the existing aristocratic system.

These men, and their no less varicoloured friends, the British representatives came to know very well. But in the early years of the occupation they were more familiar with disunity and inconsistency at Court. Here too several persons or cliques meddled in affairs of State, often at cross purposes—the Queen and her friends; the King when he took the trouble; the King's favourite Ascoli; the Ministers. Jealousy and intrigue had endless play: it is not surprising to hear that the Sicilian Ambassador in London, Castelcicala, once received three conflicting instruc-

tions on the same subject; let one person instruct him, he begged, else 'que peut faire votre dévoué serviteur?'

Ferdinand, or 'Nasone', with his great gawky body, his plebeian manners, his superstitious, diffident mind and his bursts of Neapolitan *bonhomie*—here was (the British representatives who dealt with him agreed) a man who might be trusted to act sensibly and loyally if only he was not bedevilled by intrigue. And if he took no more than a momentary interest in affairs, that was mere weakness and indolence. Certainly the King preferred to lead a simple life at one of his country villas, hunting or tunny-fishing. But his 'indolence' was rather a propensity for leaving others to do the dirty work of government and take the consequences. He always tried not to commit himself on important issues, and if he had to, he preferred to do so through members of his family or through subordinates who might later be repudiated. He could on occasion prove a master of delaying tactics in defence of his prerogative; and when he did take a hand in affairs he shewed a good deal of native shrewdness and common sense.*

His wife, Maria Carolina, then in her fifties, had given birth to seventeen children, and the vicissitudes of her life had affected her health and mind, never very stable at the best of times. Bentinck was not far wrong in his impression 'that with exceeding good abilities, she probably never had any common sense and that her mind enfeebled by age, by vast quantities of opium and the operation of violent passions has reached a state little short of insanity'.* She talked volubly and endlessly; she poured out her lamentations in innumerable letters whose breakneck style outran spelling, punctuation, syntax, and often sense. Occasionally she struck the dignified attitude of the daughter of Maria Theresa; but she generally lived at an extreme pitch of exultation or—more often—of despair; she saw treachery on every side; she would, she knew, perish at the block like her sister Marie-Antoinette. And since all opposition seemed to her disloyal, she surrounded herself with compliant French émigrés, Neapolitan adventurers, spies and dubious characters.* Through them she directed a traffic of intrigue and espionage which cost much but produced little; and as she lavished money on this and on charity she was perpetually insolvent. Her one

great desire was to recover Naples; she hated the Sicilians and they her.* Very likely the Queen had less to do with bringing about the critical state of affairs than her contemporaries believed; but she herself, by appearing to do so much, gave them every reason to believe it.*

Between these two poles of Court life swung the several members of the Royal Family. Somewhere about the middle stood the Hereditary Prince (later King Francis I), whose wariness and submission kept him as inconspicuous before Bentinck's arrival as they were to make him unhappy afterwards; while a curious outrider was Louis-Philippe, Duke of Orleans, who, though Ferdinand's son-in-law, was still a little suspect for his antecedents. But he shewed signs of what he was to become when interest and conviction led him to side with the British and with his friend Belmonte. As for the man the British saw most of, the Marquis of Circello (Foreign Secretary from 1806 to 1812), he had to put up with remonstrances against measures he knew little about and had had no share in concerting. An elderly, affable Neapolitan courtier of the old school, he complained only on occasion of 'all the *tracasseries* which really make my life very hard'.* Neither he nor the British agents had a happy time of it during the years of attrition between Great Power and small Power. Maria Carolina, indeed, was not the only Red Queen in Palermo.

II

The story of Anglo-Sicilian relations from 1806 onwards opens with a bang and goes on for five years as an extended whimper. It was after the failure of the 1806 peace talks with France that the Ministry of All the Talents decided to intervene. At first they tried to exhort without threatening; but very soon they decided on measures which, had they been enforced, would have brought about then what did not in fact take place until 1812.

These measures would have turned Sicily into a virtual British protectorate in peace as well as war. Howick, then Foreign Secretary, proposed to remove the Queen's Franco-Neapolitan faction from the Government, replace them by Sicilians, and put the Sicilian army under the British Commander-in-Chief.

The Court's improvidence and ambiguity, Howick thought, had already lost Naples; if they were allowed to go on as before they might lose Sicily as well. But he and Grenville, it seems, also wanted to get value for money during the war and to secure Sicily as a useful naval and trading station in peace-time. What all this might have led to we cannot tell: the necessary instructions were drawn up, but the Talents fell just in time to stop them from being sent out.*

Canning, when he came to deal with Sicily, made no demands on the Court beyond vague ones for their confidence and co-operation. Later on he did insist—as Howick had—that Britain could not guarantee the return of Naples at a peace, though she would do her best. He also asked that the Sicilian army should come under the British Commander if the island was attacked; but he seems not to have been particularly worried about this, for the question still stood unresolved when he left office.* Otherwise Canning's Sicilian policy, so far as he had one, was conciliatory; he wished to set at rest any suspicion the Court might entertain of England's abandoning Sicily or meddling in her internal affairs. So far, indeed, was Canning from thinking of the British subsidy as a possible means of coercion that when a new treaty raised it to £400,000 a year he removed its payment from the hands of the British Minister at Palermo to those of the Sicilian Ambassador in London—and this on no more urgent grounds than that whoever paid it out bore the loss on the exchange.*

The fact was that the strategic situation had changed. In 1806, after Maida, one could still think of using Sicily as a springboard for an invasion of Italy. In 1807, after the Peace of Tilsit, that hope was, for the time being, as good as lost. Sicily was now of little positive importance. The British Government accordingly treated the garrison as a reserve which might be drawn upon for service elsewhere, and whose task was the merely negative one of holding the place.*

As for Howick's envoy to Palermo, William Drummond, he had approved and even urged 'measures which would have in fact rendered Sicily a province of Great Britain', and had at first gone so far as to suspend the subsidy. But he changed his mind even before he knew of Howick's fall. Drummond had

lost his early hopes of the Sicilians' fitness to regenerate their country under British tutelage; but he came to believe that he could by his own influence neutralise the Queen and lead the King along the path of reform and cooperation. He therefore resumed payment of the subsidy, and took up a conciliatory attitude which, on the whole, he maintained until his recall in 1808, despite recurrent friction and disappointment.*

Occasions for mutual ill-feeling were not wanting. The Court, the Queen especially, wanted above all to recover Naples: not only would the British Government not guarantee Naples, but their generals had year after year to put off, for one reason or another, the expedition on which the Court pinned their hopes. And when an expedition was at last attempted in 1809, its failure coincided with the disastrous defeat of Austria. The Court were plunged into deeper dismay than ever. They could not be sure that England would win the war; and if she did, they might still be left stranded in Sicily at a peace, or worse, be deprived even of that. The Queen remembered with horror how close they had come to such a fate during the 1806 peace negotiations.* Perhaps, too, she knew something of the drastic measures Howick had planned: at any rate Lord Amherst, Drummond's successor, found it difficult to remove from her mind 'an impression to which she willingly recurs that it is still the intention of the British to render themselves masters of Sicily'.* She filled her letters with complaints of the English who 'overpowered, humiliated, ill-treated' her, and their least request seemed to her the beginning of subversion.*

The British representatives had no less cause for anxiety. Invasion was always a possibility. The British forces were often depleted, and the subsidy seemed to bear no fruit whatever: Drummond had hoped to see the Sicilian army put into fighting shape, but three years later Amherst found it still 'weak, ill-provided . . . dissatisfied', and he urged that since the Court refused to grant a united command, the British Commander should at least be given control of the subsidy.* The Queen's influence seemed the root of the trouble. She could not be kept out of affairs, as Drummond found after a premature announcement that she and her faction 'ruled no longer, either in appearance or in reality'.* But the worst was not her meddling and suspicion.

From time to time alarming reports came in of the Queen's intrigues with one or other of the Powers: Russia, or Austria, or even France or Murat. Her object was always the same: to restore her family to Naples by some arrangement, if necessary by the surrender of Sicily. These reports, though convincing, did not amount to proof; they grew still more alarming after the Austro-French alliance, for was not Marie-Louise the Queen's granddaughter? But protests only drew counter-protestations of loyalty from the King and Circello, and furious re-creminations from the Queen.*

Drummond had thought the Queen a mere dupe of the French faction, and Amherst would not at first believe the reports. But the military had no such scruples. As early as 1807 Sir John Moore—then second-in-command—had urged that the Queen should be expelled and Sicily annexed to the British Empire. Even Sir John Stuart (commander 1808-1811), though at first more favourably disposed towards the Court, eventually lost his temper and blurted out in public: 'as for the King, his cause is desperate; he has lost one kingdom, and he must lose the other. There is no alternative for England but to take Sicily for herself, or to abandon it altogether.' To Amherst he wrote that 'we may (as eventually we must do) dictate to the Government its measures as well as its policy'. The staff officers at the Messina headquarters, long convinced of the Court's treachery, derided Amherst and Stuart as fatuously blind to the perils that threatened them, and clamoured for drastic action.*

This state of anxiety and frustration might perhaps have gone on indefinitely, had present danger not broken in on it. In May 1810 Murat came down to the Straits of Messina to attempt an invasion. But not only did the Court profess a 'strange incredulity' as to the danger; not only did they persist in refusing the united command: they failed, for all Amherst's remonstrances throughout the summer, to provide a single soldier for the defence of the Straits. Murat's landing, when it came in September, was repulsed by British soldiers and by Sicilian peasants armed with rifles, axes, and sticks.* Only with the greatest difficulty did Amherst induce the Court to make even a verbal stand, and to deny Murat's published assertion that they awaited him as a liberator. Fresh evidence of the Queen's traffic with

Naples came tumbling in to confirm the general belief that the Court were in league with Murat. Even the cautious Amherst became at length convinced that 'jealousy of the designs of Great Britain predominates in the Queen's mind over the hatred she may entertain for Bonaparte': it was high time, he declared, 'to put an end to a system of duplicity and intrigue the existence of which I have been almost the last person in Sicily to believe'. He too now preached the need for interference. Britain, he said, could no longer afford to leave her troops open to defection in their rear: if the Queen continued to 'separate her interests from England', then England had better 'direct the concerns of those who are themselves unequal to the task, and . . . administer by force the remedies on which the salvation of this kingdom will ultimately depend.'*

Amherst had another ground for this opinion: the Sicilian people, he thought, detested their government to the point of welcoming foreign interference; if the English did not help them they might turn to the French. How much stronger, then, was the contrast that summer between the Court, who had 'trifled and temporised, and sought to palliate ambiguous conduct by plausible but unsatisfactory explanation', and the people, who had 'shewn themselves boldly and openly the foes of France and the friends of England'. Their feeling for national independence seemed to provide the only alliance England could count on. One finds the official British paper appealing to it as the surest means of rallying the population: Murat's design on Sicily, it said, was 'to make her an *integral part* of the Kingdom of Naples; as they have destroyed law and religion, so they wish to do away with history as well.' Sicily's independence had been recognised by every King since Roger, but 'Signor Murat now wishes . . . to humiliate the good Sicilians, and strip them of all the rights and prerogatives they have ever enjoyed'.* So when the 'patriots' appealed to Amherst for help in defending these same rights, he was much more inclined to listen to them than before.

What had happened was that a political crisis coincided with the military emergency of 1810; and that the conflict between Crown and Parliament now shifted decisively from merely fiscal to political and institutional ground. But taxation remained

the first matter for dispute. The Court were badly short of money when Parliament met for its regular session in January 1810.* The Speech from the Throne—whether as a sop to constitutional sentiment, or a warning against insubordination—exhorted members to safeguard from the democratic peril their Constitution and privileges, ‘institutions lost by other nations for lack of public spirit and national energy, and preserved only in the two most famous islands in the world, Great Britain and Sicily’.* The Government let it be known that they meant to obtain not only an extraordinary subsidy (*donativo*) of 360,000 ounces a year (about £235,000), but also a fairer distribution of taxation. The Barons, alarmed, and led by Belmonte and Cassaro, countered by voting to pay a larger share of a smaller sum. On the one hand they cut the *donativo* down to 150,000 oz.; on the other they adopted a plan for tax reform far more radical than the Government had intended. This plan, drawn up by Balsamo, swept away the ‘monstrous multiplicity’ of the old *donativi* and the cumbersome machinery for their collection; instead it established a single tax on every kind of real property, to be assessed according to a new survey. Thus ‘every Sicilian’, said Balsamo, ‘was according to strict equity to pay the Exchequer in proportion to what he owned and consumed’; and the barons could no longer be accused of merely defending their own privileges. When the Ecclesiastico followed suit it came about that Parliament, by a curious reversal, passed in 1810, against the Court’s wishes, the very reforms it had rejected when Caracciolo proposed them in 1783.*

But after taking this first step Parliament was still unready to go any further. Belmonte, Castelnovo, and Balsamo tried at the end of the session to carry several political resolutions: the most important of these would have made supply run for one year only, thus establishing an annual Parliament. But most of the resolutions failed.* This helps to explain why Belmonte and his friends then shifted their ground and started negotiating with the Court.

These negotiations went on for several months after Parliament had risen. They were complex and obscure. Belmonte’s friends, it seems clear, feared that the Court might take to unconstitutional measures if it was left badly short of money.

With Orleans' support they approached the Queen and proposed a bargain. The Court was to dismiss the Neapolitan Ministers and put in Sicilians—among them, apparently, Belmonte and Cassaro. Orleans was to command the army. Parliament would meet again and effect a certain amount of constitutional reform; for their part, Belmonte's friends would make sure that enough additional supply was passed to meet the Government's needs. The Queen hesitated and toyed for some months with this proposal.* When, however, Parliament did meet for a second session in August, the Court—it is not clear from what motives—chose to secure the political defeat of Belmonte's party by sacrificing the hope of increased supply. That is to say, they bought off Cassaro and a majority of the Barons—first with a reshuffle which made Cassaro a Councillor and two Sicilian nonentities Ministers; then with an undertaking that no more *donativi* would be asked for. Belmonte and his friends thus found themselves left out of the Government and outvoted in Parliament: oddly enough, they voted for more taxes than the Government majority.*

At this point Belmonte's party secretly appealed to Amherst for his and England's help in getting concessions from the Crown. The old Sicilian Constitution, they told him, was in theory enough to maintain Sicilian liberties; but in practice it was constantly violated.

What was needed was a reform of the Constitution inspired by that of England, but not copied from it; a genuine Sicilian administration; and the control of the Army by the British Commander. Parliamentary demands, they foresaw, would meet with no success. If England did not intervene, Sicily might yet rebel and call in the French.

Amherst told them his instructions did not allow him to do anything of the kind; he dissuaded them from taking action. But—as he wrote to Wellesley privately—he agreed with them entirely. The Court's behaviour during the invasion scare made intervention of some kind necessary. If that intervention were not only to remove the Queen's influence but to establish a native administration and a free Parliament, with a Sicilian Constitution remodelled along English lines, then one could expect as 'natural consequences' such reforms as would give

the Sicilians 'the comforts and the blessings intended for them by nature, and of which nothing but a faulty and ill-administered government deprives them'. True, the government was not alone to blame: the Barons would have to give up some vexatious privileges; but he believed the patriots knew this. The King and Queen would not easily adapt themselves to free institutions, but a British Minister backed by the authority of his Government might induce them to do so:

'I think that if the language of earnest and friendly representation offered in respectful terms, and urged for His Sicilian Majesty's benefit should fail of effect, the blind and interested counsels of certain weak and unprincipled advisers should not be suffered to stand in the way of the universal wishes of the country . . . I am aware, my Lord, how repugnant it is to the principles and practice of the British Government to interfere in the concerns of an independent sovereign; but if His Sicilian Majesty is to be preserved on his throne, he must be induced to listen to the admonitory voice of his disinterested ally.'

There might be advantages for England too in such a reform: for the nation was ripe for resistance, and

'to become a province of England would not, I believe, be looked upon as a misfortune by the major part of its inhabitants. But an independent Government and a free Constitution would be considered as a boon, the attainment of which would irrevocably bind the Sicilians to the nation which should procure it for them.'

Amherst, however, was not to carry out the intervention he recommended: both he and Stuart resigned their posts in disgust.* For nothing ever seemed to go right after the summer of 1810. Even a fairly simple matter—a dispute over a ship under British licence which Sicilian privateers had seized—now took on a suspicious tinge and led to a string of acrimonious Notes.*

But these diplomatic tensions mattered little amid the political storm that blew up in February 1811. The Court had won a hollow victory in Parliament, since it had cost them the chance of adequate supply. They could get no more out of the British.* At a loss for money, the Government in February 1811 issued three decrees imposing, by the King's authority alone, a tax of 1 % on all money payments whatever, a sale of Church and

common lands, and a lottery. There was little doubt that this was an unconstitutional act.* The Decrees at once rallied and strengthened the patriotic party, especially among the Barons, disunited since the last Parliament. Belmonte's house became the headquarters of a group including not only the reformers but also a number of conservative Barons: Orleans gave them open support. On March 1st a majority of the Peers then in Palermo addressed a petition to the delegate body which was supposed to watch over the enforcement of laws between Parliamentary sessions—the Deputation of the Realm. They asked the Deputation to remind the Crown of the ancient and unquestioned privileges of Parliament; protested against the Decrees; and asserted, nevertheless, their willingness to provide all necessary supply by constitutional means.* The Deputation dodged the petition for some weeks by failing to meet. But delay only increased the political tension. Amherst, about to leave, feared 'the most fatal consequences'. The Decrees, he foresaw, would not solve the Court's financial problems, while 'general discontent' would certainly be produced, and 'ultimate resistance' might perhaps be expected.*

It was at this point that the Foreign Secretary, Lord Wellesley, offered the mission to Lord William Bentinck.

CHAPTER I

BRITAIN INTERVENES

'A brilliant and unbalanced egoist,' writes Sir Charles Webster, 'all the more dangerous because he was also imbued with a species of idealism'; but then the second son of the Duke of Portland 'could not be denied a high military or diplomatic post'. That is one view, though an authoritative one; there are others. Was the Cabinet so careless, or its motive so irrelevant, when it chose Major-General Lord William Bentinck to fill at once the Palermo mission and the Mediterranean command? At 36 Bentinck had experienced a good deal of responsibility as a soldier and administrator; and he had already been in trouble. His Governorship of Madras (1803-1807) had ended in his recall amid bitter controversy; in earlier years (1799-1801) he had served as a young officer in Northern Italy and had learnt something of the country; earlier still he had fought in the Netherlands. More recently, at the start of the Peninsular War, he had carried out a mission to the Spanish Junta and held a command under Moore in the retreat to Corunna. If what the Government wanted was an orthodox diplomatist he was not their man. But if, as now seems clear, they had made up their mind to intervene in the domestic concerns of Sicily and needed a proconsul for the purpose, then their choice seems less arbitrary.*

It was indeed an arduous task. In Sicily Bentinck was to be at once diplomatist, politician, even for a time dictator, besides commanding two separate armies, one of them scattered as far abroad as Lissa, the Ionian Islands, and Catalonia. We have a picture of him at Palermo, immersed in a roomful of plans and documents and waving aside as so much waste paper the letters of recommendation brought by a young newcomer from England—let him work hard for promotion, he said bluntly.* We hear, too, from another who, just arrived from occupied Italy, found Bentinck a shrewd questioner: 'he sucked me so dry that I came home in the shape and likeness of a squeezed lemon...'.* Neither a careful subordinate nor a place-hunter of the kind that made up his father's and other 'connexions', Bentinck had

about him something of the energy and forthrightness of the Victorian public servant. However one may judge what he did, he did it thoroughly and, in the circumstances, efficiently. A soldier, he shewed a rough but undeniable skill in the tactics of political management: where immoderate sentiments prevailed, his was often the moderating influence. Just as at Corunna, seated on his 'quiet mule', he had talked to Charles Napier through the heavy gunfire 'as if we were going to breakfast . . . with perhaps an increase of good-humour and placidity'—'this chap takes it coolly or the devil's in it', Napier exclaimed—so now in Sicily he often got his way by cool persistent bullying, stopping short of the limit beyond which he would have lost control.*

Thus far the public man in Bentinck—and the public man is nearly all we can see of him. This figure, as it appears in official papers, is almost extravagantly simple. We see a man who must be doing; to whom *le mieux est l'ennemi du bien* meant little; who had such an appetite for responsibility that, while he could rise to situations that would have tried most men hard, he in the end took too much upon himself and caused his own downfall. Through his eyes, again, we see men and events in black and white: character sharply defined, right and wrong sharply divided. Yet this is not the whole truth. There is a private Bentinck, who sometimes disconcerts us by confessing to 'a great deal of irritable shyness'—such a great deal that to have to wear the K.C.B. newly awarded him strikes him as 'the infliction of a positive misery'.* There is a Bentinck who, far from being the doctrinaire Whig one would expect, shews in his political dealings a variety of moods—empirical, diffident, even despondent—which he none the less banishes from his official despatches. Altogether there seems to have been in him a divorce between 'official' beliefs and private feelings—feelings of which he was perhaps not quite aware, or which he hesitated to define clearly even to himself. It is a human condition, and among some men a peculiarly English condition. Bentinck cannot be charged with duplicity towards others. But because he wanted to see his world steadily he failed to see it whole: he deceived, if anyone, himself.*

This, then, was the man the Foreign Secretary had chosen. But exactly how did Wellesley judge the state of affairs in Sicily,

and what kind of intervention had he in mind? It is not easy to tell. Until then he had taken virtually no interest in Sicily. Even now he apparently set little store by the reports of the Queen's 'treachery'. Though he later claimed more general motives he may have been moved by a simple fact: the resignation of Amherst and Stuart. Both men had from the start, most exceptionally, done their best to placate the Sicilian Court; now that Court's behaviour in the face of the threat from Murat had led both of them to throw up their posts in disgust. After that any Foreign Secretary must have found it difficult merely to go on with a policy of hopeful conciliation, or to avoid reaching some kind of decision.*

But whatever his motives Wellesley, it seems clear, acted to meet a specific military and diplomatic crisis: he took no more notice than Canning had ever done of the demands for intervention on general grounds which some people in England had been putting forward for years. The Opposition regularly used the annual Commons debate on the subsidy to press for such a change of policy: the defence of the island, they said, would be surer and easier if its people could be relieved of an oppressive system of government; some of the London newspapers echoed them, one or two going so far as to contemplate the annexation of Sicily to the British Empire.* More important than these casual references were the writings of one or two publicists, particularly G.F. Leckie: with some knowledge of Sicilian conditions, he called for a wholesale reform under English tutelage: this was to induce the Italians to rise and unite against the French. At the same time Leckie looked forward to an expansion of British power all over the Mediterranean, such as would simultaneously benefit British trade and prove to the world that 'while France conquers to devastate, Britain conquers to do good'.* Finally, the British merchants who at this time carried on most of Sicily's foreign trade asked many times for redress of what they said were discriminatory practices by the Sicilian Government: but the Board of Trade turned a deaf ear to their petitions, and Wellesley seems to have given little thought to commercial advantage.*

Instead of settling from the start on a detailed policy of intervention, Wellesley asked the commander- and Minister-

designate to submit his own proposals. Bentinck, after studying the diplomatic files, wrote a memorandum in which he reviewed at length the precarious situation of Sicily. The Court, he admitted, by failing to cooperate, had shewn only a negative kind of hostility; but so persistent had they been in this that 'treason itself could scarcely have taken any other course'. Still it was not on the score of treachery—though it existed—that he proposed the British Government should act, but 'upon the broad basis of mutual self-defence and welfare'. Everyone said the Sicilians were basically friendly to England, though disaffected to their own government almost to the point of revolt: their help would be essential if the island was ever to be safe. Britain should therefore demand: the united command, carrying with it control over the subsidy; a Sicilian administration; and a reform of abuses. Without a Sicilian administration the Queen's party would never be curbed; as for reform, one might think it a 'natural consequence' of the change of administration, 'but the demand will please the people, and it may have a very great political effect in Italy, whenever . . . the Italians shall be prepared to assert their independence'—for Bentinck, like Leckie, already thought of Sicily as a stepping-stone towards the liberation of Italy. Should the Court reject these demands, he would withdraw to his camp, proclaiming his determination to defend the King and the country in accordance with the alliance and 'in concurrence with the Sicilians'. Such a policy, Bentinck admitted, amounted to interference in the domestic affairs of Sicily, 'almost a forcible seizure' of the government; but it would be justified and disinterested, and its effect would be

'to place the King safely on his throne, to give happiness to an oppressed people, to make their island forever independent of French invasion, and to exalt the British character'.

This course, he said, should prove 'plain and easy' if the British Government agreed to it; but if they still preferred a policy of mere representation, then he was not the man to carry it out.*

Wellesley did not altogether accept Bentinck's proposals, and Perceval objected to them strongly; they were, he said, neither justifiable nor necessary. The soldiers all claimed that Sicily could

not be held without reform, and yet it was still held. Reform would in any case be a hazardous undertaking, and would have to deal with feudal as well as governmental abuses. The Queen's 'treachery' he discounted, commenting that her distrust of England was only natural after the revolution which Grey had planned and which the British in Sicily had freely canvassed ever since. Eventually, after some discussion, Bentinck yielded to Wellesley's arguments, and to those of his friend Sir Edward Pellew (who was going out to the naval command in the Mediterranean): he agreed to carry out what instructions the government thought fit to give him.*

These instructions, when they were drawn up, embodied an uneasy compromise between Bentinck's view and Perceval's. Bentinck was to represent that 'the evident tendency of the measures now pursued being not only to destroy the resources of the island, but to exasperate the people to acts of violence against their Government', Britain must warn the Court of the dangers to which they exposed themselves and their allies. If, on the one hand, the Court treated the island as they ought—if they granted the Sicilians a greater share in the government, attended to the wishes of Parliament, and remedied abuses—then the British Government would do all in its power to maintain them in Sicily and to bring about their restoration to Naples. But if on the other hand they persisted in their present course,

'neither the terms nor the spirit of the alliance would require that the British arms should be employed to assist . . . in enforcing such a system of government against the resistance of the people of Sicily'.

It was 'not however inconsistent' with these warnings to assert that not for a moment did the British Government mean to interfere in the domestic affairs of Sicily, or to change or upset the Constitution. Bentinck was not allowed to go beyond discreet representation: he might threaten to recommend the suspension of the subsidy if it seemed ill-spent; but the decision would rest with London. Wellesley's instructions were like Howick's of 1806—those which he gave Drummond before the Talents chose to intervene in full strength—in that they coupled unwelcome advice with professions of delicacy, and provided no means of enforcing it.*

So closely, indeed, did Wellesley's policy during the next few months follow Howick's in its change from good advice to the threat of force that the British intervention in 1811-12 reminds one of a theatrical performance, once rehearsed, then put off and given only after a lapse of five years. But those five years of mounting tension within Sicily and between the two allies made the final clash look inevitable, as it could scarcely have done in 1807.

Bentinck landed at Palermo in July 1811 to find the Court in no mood to listen to advice. The Queen, apparently having got wind of the British Government's intentions, had decided that only the most unbending resistance could foil what she saw as a plot to annex Sicily. For two months past relations between the Court and the British Legation had been poisoned by a matter trivial in itself—yet another dispute over the recognition of British shipping licences—but inflated out of all proportions in the tension of the moment. At the same time the Court had dealt with the Barons' protest against the February Decrees: they had got the Deputation to say that the decrees were legal, and the protest invalid; and three days before Bentinck's arrival, five of the protesting Barons—Belmonte, Castelnovo, Aci, Anjou and Villafranca—had suddenly been arrested and imprisoned on various islands off the coast of Sicily.*

Bentinck, though he had no hope of achieving anything by persuasion in such a state of affairs, followed his instructions to the letter. Circello's reply to his first representations was simple: if the British Government said they did not wish to interfere, then why did they in fact interfere? Besides, they must have been misled by malicious gossip, for Sicily was perfectly contented: so there was no case to answer. Bentinck could make no headway against a refusal even to discuss the situation. For this obduracy he blamed the Queen: her mania for Naples and distrust of England would wreck any chance of an improvement until she was removed from the government. 'The Court', he declared, 'must be frightened into their duty to themselves and to us. Otherwise we shall all be sacrificed in the ruins of one of the best people upon earth'—by which he may have meant the Sicilians, but more likely the Italians, who might be freed if Sicily was once set in order. Meanwhile all he could do was

to return home for fresh instructions. This he did, after lecturing Circello on the great chances thrown away by the Court's improvidence: had they respected the liberties of the people and of Parliament and won their support, Sicily would have been an inspiration to the Continent of Italy, and an army might have been spared for service there:

‘Those times are past when personal attachment to a chief or a family was the greatest incentive to human action. At this time the world is too enlightened not to have discovered that the only security for individual liberty or national greatness is a free Constitution where the interests of the Sovereign and his People are happily blended and identified.’*

The chance that Italy might rise against the French and win her independence with English help was another reason for returning to London. In June, Wellesley and Bentinck had discussed a proposal lately received from the Archduke Francis of Este—then in Sardinia—for the formation in the Mediterranean of a force made up of Italians and of Austrian officers unemployed since the Austro-French peace treaty. Its intended purpose was to raise the standard of revolt in Italy or in the conquered Austrian provinces, and eventually to establish an Italian Kingdom under the Archduke, at least as large as that founded by Napoleon. Bentinck had supported this plan warmly: Italy, he said, was thoroughly discontented with French rule and might prove another Spain; the country offered not only a long coastline accessible to British seapower, but also ‘a people equally brave with the Spaniards, and equally enthusiastic in the cause of liberty, but much more intelligent and more tractable’. All Wellesley had given him was a vague authorisation to look into the matter: the Government, taken up as they were with the Peninsula, could spare little attention for Italy, and Bentinck had had no illusions on the point.* Now, however, he had met the Archduke, and intelligence from the Continent confirmed his enthusiasm for the plan. On his return to London he pressed for, and got, an authorisation to promote it actively: he might form an Italo-Austrian force and make ready for a possible rising in Italy by getting in touch with the patriotic party there; for these purposes he might spend up to £100,000. At the same time it was ‘not the intention . . . to

excite the people of Italy to any exertions which they may not think necessary' or to act before the time was ripe: any plan for an expedition must be concerted with Wellington and other British agents in the Mediterranean.*

To Bentinck's mind intervention in Sicily was clearly connected with this plan for the liberation of Italy: the one must precede the other. Whether it was the same view that led Wellesley to agree to stronger measures in Sicily is not clear.* At any rate he allowed Bentinck to press not only for the changes already asked for, but also for the united command, the recall of the imprisoned barons, and the removal from the government of persons hostile to the alliance. Bentinck was given great freedom of action: the only real limitation to his powers was that he must not resort to force so long as he had no proof of the Court's treachery—but if such proof should come to hand it would justify 'the most decided measures'. Meanwhile he could control and suspend the subsidy on his own authority; beyond this, the utmost retaliation to which the British Government would agree if the Court rejected their demands was the withdrawal of the garrison.*

Bentinck now sailed again to Sicily, confident of success. His mood was not unlike that of a proconsul setting out on a punitive expedition: writing to Wellington, he compared the Court to a native Indian Durbar; to Wellesley he had already hinted that what he was now carrying out was 'the same enlarged and enlightened system of policy, which has already saved another Empire . . .'.* He was by no means alone in his confidence or in his high hopes of Sicilian and Italian regeneration. He sailed, as it were, amid a chorus of good wishes from high-ranking generals, admirals and diplomatists. These men detested the Queen—'the she wicked one', they called her, or 'the Lady', or 'the very high author of so much mischief', or simply '*She*'—and they had no doubt that she would be worsted in 'a contest where treachery and deceit are pitted against virtue truth and honour'. Some hoped the birth of Sicilian happiness would 'take its date from the time of your arrival among them'. Leckie had sent Bentinck his books and his blessing. Amherst sent him suggestions for reforms, culminating in the maxim 'Assimilate generally as much as possible to the British Constitution'. Others

shared his view that Italy might soon rise, and Sicily therefore take on an 'incalculable importance'. One voice alone preached caution, Wellington's: he advised Bentinck merely to 'maintain our position' in Sicily; as for Italy, 'trust nothing', he wrote, 'to the enthusiasm of the people. Give them a strong and a just, and, if possible, a good government; but, above all, a strong one, which shall enforce them to do their duty by themselves and their country . . .'. Still, Bentinck might well believe, as he approached Palermo, what Pellew wrote to him at the time:

'The battle you have nobly fought, and the conquest will reward you amply . . . I think every obstacle will now fall prostrate and the Q . . . be very happy to put herself in your harness. You have, or will now have, quite a smooth path and see your way clear.'

Bentinck landed at Palermo on December 7 to find things no better than he had left them. His departure had at first startled the Court into a more cautious frame of mind; but they were unable to settle on any definite policy against his return. As usual the Queen and Ascoli were at odds. Ought they once again to try calling in the Russians? (The Queen wrote off to Petersburg.) Ought they to release the five Barons and so draw Bentinck's teeth? (Afterwards the Queen and Ascoli each claimed to have advised this and to have been thwarted by the other's influence.) Anyhow nothing was done.* At the same time all the old suspicions of treachery had flared up more strongly than ever during Bentinck's absence: fresh correspondence came to light between the Court's agents and the enemy, as well as various plots seemingly designed to bring about new Sicilian Vespers, this time against the British. The whole business was tangled and obscure, but Ascoli and, by inference, the Queen seemed to be involved. If the British staff and legation were highly alarmed, poor General Maitland, left in charge by Bentinck, was in despair: 'I am quite sick of *spies* and *devils* Where is Lord William and when will he come—I am *groping* in the dark . . .'. Bentinck, hearing this news on his arrival, considered that it entitled him to take those 'most decisive measures' contemplated in his new instructions—that is, to use force if necessary.*

At first, however, he attempted to bring the Court to heel

by milder means. He began at once by suspending the subsidy. The Court were in no position to resist: if the ensuing crisis lasted as long as five weeks that was no doubt because they could not agree among themselves. The King fled at once to La Ficuzza, his shooting-lodge in the hills, leaving his wife and Circello to cope with Bentinck's demands as best they could. In his fright he tried several times to abdicate: it was all the Queen could do to stop him. Bentinck, when consulted about this unexpected resolve of the King's, advised abdication: it would save the King from a humiliating change of front, which coming from the Prince would be more like an act of grace. But he had to make it clear that he could not and would not *ask* for such a step.* The Queen, for her part, swung between despair and defiance. She knew she could not count on the King or on Ascoli, and she feared—rightly—that they might use her as a scapegoat.* At times she tried to conciliate Bentinck—she had always been English in feeling, 'and now, she added smiling, I must be English *par nécessité, vous voyez comme je vous parle franchement*'; once she actually asked for a ship to take her away from Sicily. At other times she railed at him, accused the British of having always planned to seize Sicily, and refused to make the slightest concession. She sought for ways of doing without the subsidy; she harangued the Guards from the Palace window, bidding them resist the King's enemies. They might use force, she cried, 'but she would never yield, she could but die in the contest'.*

The hubbub was at its height. There was talk of invasion; there were rumours of assassination. Some feared for Bentinck's life, some for the five barons who were still in exile.* Altogether Bentinck's negotiations with Circello could scarcely follow a coherent course. With some difficulty Bentinck won two points: the recall of the barons and the command of the Sicilian army. On the first he was willing to help the King by letting the barons' recall look like a spontaneous act of grace: he wished, he said, to act as 'a mediator between the violence of parties'. But the command was useless to him without a trustworthy Ministry. The Court, however, stood out longer against the change of administration than against any of his other demands. To Bentinck's mind, the exiled Barons would make the most

satisfactory Ministers; when Circello asked him whether he meant to impose them on the King, he replied that 'those . . . who had created the embarrassment must take the Court out of it as well as they could . . . to the feelings of the King, the interests of the Nation were not to be sacrificed'. Still he tried not to be drawn into actually dictating a specific Ministry; in the end, after long bargaining, he and Circello reached a compromise. Cassaro was to become a sort of interim Prime Minister (for he now appeared in the guise of a patriot and a man who could withstand the Queen's influence); Circello might stay, while the other departments would be left to under-secretaries until such time as some of the exiled barons might decently come into them. No sooner had this arrangement been accepted in principle than the Court changed its mind—apparently after the usual tussle between the Queen and Ascoli, who was the more frightened of the two. A partial reshuffle was announced, which left the existing Ministry almost unchanged—the very arrangement to which Bentinck had objected most strongly in previous discussions. At the same time Circello stated in a Note that the Court could listen to no more demands.

Bentinck now decided to use force: he ordered part of the British garrison in eastern Sicily to sail to Palermo. In a long conversation with the Hereditary Prince he recapitulated Britain's grievances, and at the same time assured him of her good intentions:

'The fact of our never having assumed the possession of the island, when it had been in our power for six years together, and when it had been the general wish of the inhabitants, was the best proof of our intentions. . . . I concluded . . . by saying that I should use force if my representations were not attended to. This force was not against, but for the benefit of the King and his family. . . . If he himself at the head of the army should resist me unsuccessfully, I should, if his father still persisted in his retirement, be the first to place himself on the throne, and if he declined, to support the succession for his son. It was against the enemies of the Crown that my opposition would be directed. He was much struck with this statement and made me repeat it.'

In the face of this threat the Court's resistance collapsed. On January 16th the King announced that ill-health compelled him

to hand over power temporarily to the Prince, who was to be Vicar-General for Sicily and to act as his *alter ego*. The Prince at once repealed the 1% tax and recalled the barons. British troops garrisoned Palermo. The King stayed on at La Ficuzza and the Queen repaired to a villa in the suburbs.

Bentinck had got a delegation of powers that he had not asked for, but he had not got a change of Ministry. The King, he was aware, had secretly arranged to keep the diplomatic correspondence in his own hands. He did not, however, realise as yet how little real power the King and Queen meant to delegate to their son; besides, he had formed a very favourable first impression of the Prince's character and good intentions. He therefore resumed payment of the subsidy without exacting an immediate change of men or measures: 'I was disposed', he said, 'to place all reliance in the Prince's word and his assurance that certain things would be done would be satisfactory to me.' At the same time, he agreed to give a personal guarantee of the Royal Family's possession of Sicily (though not of Naples); he tried to moderate the novel anti-Neapolitan zeal of the Prince, who claimed that 'now it was necessary everything should be Sicilian'; and he refused the offer of a seat on the Council:

'I thought it would not look well . . . and would not be pleasing to my Government—our principle had always been not to interfere in the internal concerns of our neighbours. We had only done so now because we were compelled.'*

Bentinck sent his government complete and detailed accounts of all these transactions, as he was to do with hardly any exception throughout his mission. By the time they were received, Wellesley had resigned and Castlereagh was Foreign Secretary.* Castlereagh hastened to send Bentinck the government's approval of his conduct in the 'very delicate and arduous circumstances' he had been faced with. In a private letter he asked for proofs of the treachery which had regrettably compelled Bentinck to use his full powers: the proceeding might have to be defended in Parliament. Although his approval was unqualified, there was perhaps a slight hint in his expression of satisfaction at Bentinck's having declined a seat on the Council: it shewed, he wrote, 'that Your Lordship's views were strictly confined to

the removal of evils incompatible with the defence of the island, the safety of the British troops and the preservation of the alliance'.*

The guarded and conciliatory policy which these words of Castlereagh's implied was just what Bentinck himself had in mind immediately after the proclamation of the Vicariate. So eager was he to let the Prince and the Patriots carry on the government with the least interference possible from the British that he even decided to leave Palermo for a while. Yet Bentinck could neither think his task completed nor refrain from making plans for the future. As early as January 31st he noted

'my plan for Sicily—Parliament—Constitution and national force to protect it. . . .' But, he added, 'I wish to go on gently and to accomplish by degrees and by fair measures rather than by force.'*

Parliament, he thought, must meet in any case, as the government could scarcely go on without additional supply. But a new Constitution was rather more than the mere reform of abuses which he had been instructed to achieve. No doubt the patriots were convinced that the present Constitution would no longer work: it must be made anew; only thus could Sicily be restored to her ancient glory, and her inhabitants enabled to cry out one happy day 'We too are a Nation!' Bentinck met them more than half-way: when he saw Belmonte and Castelnuovo on their return from the islands he was the first to broach the subject, and he is said to have told the Queen: 'Constitution or revolution: there is no middle way.'* But it seems likely that what he wanted was rather *a* Constitution than a particular collection of reforms; that is to say, a political gesture which might have a resounding effect in Italy. Sicily was still to his mind a stepping-stone to the Continent; and he was stating his own opinion when he told the Prince that Sicily could

'contribute most powerfully to the conquest of Italy, not by its arms, but by the example of its happiness. The Italians are an intelligent people. They have long desired a Constitution which should give them national liberty. They never will submit to be transferred from one despotism to another. . . . If by the desire of the Prince a Constitution is given to Sicily which shall assure a moderate and reasonable freedom to its people, and shall promote its happiness and prosperity, from that period I should con-

sider the conquest of Italy and the restoration of Naples as half achieved. All eyes on the Continent will be turned to Sicily'—and, he threw out as a further inducement—'possibly not only Naples but many of the surrounding States may desire the blessings of the same Chief and the same Government'.*

To achieve all this, Bentinck had to set up the Prince as a constitutional monarch, and the patriots as a responsible Ministry. Both these ends, as it turned out, were harder to achieve than Bentinck had expected: indeed it took two months merely to change the Ministry. The Prince seemed at first disposed to make Bentinck his confidential mentor; he professed the most laudable constitutional sentiments, and he may even have meant them at the time, for it soon became clear that he could not think or act decidedly on any matter. He was afraid of his parents, of the British, of the barons. To Bentinck he 'confessed his doubts and fears . . . they turned his head'—but, he added apologetically, 'perhaps they are the effect of my anciennes habitudes which in time I shall overcome'. Bentinck combated these vacillations, assuring him that 'no Prince ever had so fine a game'; but after a few weeks' inconclusive discussion, his early esteem for the Prince began to wilt. This, he decided, was not the mere hesitancy of a novice; for when 'a truth so evident was not acted upon', must there not be 'some secret cause which got the better'? Still he excused it, and rather blamed the influence, past and present, of the Queen.* The Prince's good intentions ought at least to be put to the test, as he told the barons: for they were inclined to stand on their dignity and refuse office altogether. 'Why was I alone to act?' he asked them:

' . . . take office and see if your advice is followed—if not go out and then I shall have ground to go on. Belles Paroles will not do—we must take things as we find them and act accordingly'.

The use of force against the Royal Family, which Belmonte rather favoured, might achieve quick results, but no lasting settlement; whereas

to persuade a stupid distrustful man would be a work of time and difficulty, but not impracticable—the good if done would be permanent.*

Even so it was difficult to form a Ministry combining the

right principles with the political skill needed to guide the Prince. Castelnovo was too stiff, Aci too violent, Cassaro too conservative. Belmonte, on the other hand, though somewhat glib and transparently vain, seemed by his intelligence, boldness and fluency the only man able to hold the Prince and the barons together. Orleans—Bentinck's new friend and counsellor—pressed Belmonte's claims; and Bentinck set out to build him up into a Sicilian Prime Minister. Yet this course had disadvantages which he could not perceive at the time. Belmonte united a desire for quick and forcible action (by the British) with a high regard for 'public opinion'. By this he meant something akin to 'face': without doubting the sincerity of his political convictions, one may say that he had something of the typical Southern Italian faction leader of later times—he and his personal followers must achieve power, and be seen to achieve power, to the exclusion of all others.* Bentinck thought little of Sicilian public opinion, judging on past performance, though he appealed to it often enough when urging the Prince to carry out the desired changes; in any case, he told Belmonte, 'the only way to retain it was to deserve it and be indifferent to it'.* Nevertheless he gave in to Belmonte on several important points. The new 'system', he had thought at first, should start out by alienating as few sympathies as possible: advances from the sitting Councillors and Ministers (and there were plenty) should therefore not be rejected out of the hand, and some provision should be made for them. But Belmonte would not have it: he was sure he could manage both Government and Parliament alone; and he persuaded Bentinck to demand a Ministry and Council made up of none but supposedly safe Patriots. Now the Prince wished, as he said, to 'unite all parties' and consult all shades of opinion: Bentinck had therefore to expound to him the doctrine of Cabinet solidarity, a doctrine which, though he might hold it good in itself, he had not previously thought of applying so drastically in Sicily. Bentinck was similarly induced, against his better judgment, to foist Aci on the Prince as one of the proposed Ministers: this was a man whose incompetence everyone admitted, but whose recent exile gave him, according to Belmonte, a claim to favour.

In any case Bentinck was steadily losing patience with the

Prince, who plainly had no wish either to call Parliament or change his advisers. He had been mistaken, he admitted, in trusting him in the first place: now he exacted the new Ministry and Council from the Prince by reminding him that he had merely delayed, not given up, carrying out the British Government's instructions. The new Ministry, consisting of Belmonte (Foreign Affairs), Castelnovo (Finance), Cassaro (Justice), and Aci (War), came in at the end of March; but only after the Prince had so far abandoned his constitutional professions as to insist on Bentinck's signature to a document urging the change and so in a sense taking responsibility for it. 'He was indeed acting very magnanimously towards me', Bentinck told the Prince on this occasion. 'I had wished to give him all the credit and none of the blame. He was now making me a return, by wishing to make it appear that he was compelled to the change, that he was always attached to the old system and to its agents.'

Bentinck was irritated at having lost two valuable months, at a time, too, when the rumoured approach of Franco-Russian hostilities promised a chance of action in Italy. Conciliation, he concluded, would not work after all: stronger measures would be needed, and steady support from home:

'Nothing but the firm and just exercise of our superiority will . . . secure to this country that better administration from whence its own happiness and greatness and our safety can alone be derived. I beg the British Government not to be deceived on this point.'*

In three months Bentinck had come to see the need for nothing less than a continuing British protectorate over Sicily. His early hope that the new 'system' might go on almost by itself had rested on several assumptions: now these props were falling out one by one. He had wanted the Patriots to carry on the government by themselves, with the British Minister a mere paternal counsellor in the background: he soon found that they could not; by sheer force of circumstance, as will be seen, he himself had to become an active political leader. He had thought the Royal Family little more than a spent force: presently he found that he could not impose on Sicily a policy acceptable to the British Government without engaging in a running contest

with the King and Queen; and the contest went on almost without intermission for a whole year.

But of all broken reeds the Prince was the most obvious. Not only had he delayed bringing in a new Ministry; he would not modernise the Army. In January he had accepted Bentinck's plan for a smaller, efficient, national Sicilian Army, fit for service anywhere in the Mediterranean. But he was, after all, no less a Neapolitan at heart than his parents: he had no desire to lose his large inefficient Neapolitan army, and with it (as he thought) the chance of recovering Naples: try as Bentinck might, he could not get the Prince to act. The Prince proved equally reluctant to call Parliament, as his new Ministers at once urged him to do. Bentinck did his best to support them; he played on the Prince's hopes of Naples, declaring that although the day for action in Italy might be near at hand, he could not take a single soldier out of the island until a Sicilian Parliament had given Italy the example she was waiting for. But the Prince feared a Long Parliament, and Bentinck's guarantees did not reassure him. Even when he resigned himself to it, he objected to the mention of constitutional reform which Castelnovo had inserted in his draft of the Royal Despatch summoning Parliament: and although Bentinck hammered away at the familiar tack of Italy, the magic word *Constitution* had to be omitted from the Despatch when it was finally issued on 1 May.*

Bentinck's regard for the Prince had by then quite evaporated. The man, he concluded, was inherently weak, distrustful and dilatory, at bottom as despotically-minded as his parents, superstitiously afraid of them and incapable of taking an independent line. Fear and fear alone would make him go on in the path of constitutional monarchy.*

Yet the Prince remained an ambiguous figure. The fact—more obvious now than at the time—was that although he had a policy of his own, he had not strength enough to be a free agent. He wished to conciliate the British, not out of conviction—his constitutional fervour, if sincere at all, was only momentary—but out of fear, a realisation of his own impotence, and a desire to save what could be saved for his family. Bentinck certainly frightened him into a wish to comply—'gettiamo acqua! gettiamo acqua!' he would cry on receiving one of Bentinck's

peremptory Notes.* But what pressure from one quarter did, pressure from another undid. The King had ostensibly delegated power to his son. But, he asked Bentinck on one occasion, 'if I had appointed my son to manage my Estate [should I] not expect him to be subordinate to me?' This was the King's candid opinion: he regarded his kingdom as his personal property; he was 'displeased at the Nation being mentioned . . . it was a new mode which did not exist in former times . . . his power came from God'.* His view of the Vicariate—like the Queen's—was simple. Their position at the centre of affairs was for the moment inconvenient: the Prince must therefore take it over, and with it the embarrassment of dealing with Bentinck; but he was to be 'like an egg in [the King's] hand which he might preserve as long as he pleased and crush' or rather set aside when it suited him.* This device was not new to the Royal Family; it had served at Naples in 1799, and it was to serve again in 1821.

The King and Queen, then, considered that the government was still theirs, with the Prince as their puppet, and that the Ministers ought to be their Ministers: indeed, they dropped circuitous hints to Belmonte and his friends that their accession to the Ministry would be invalid unless they asked for and got the King's approval.* The government ought to do nothing of importance (so the King thought) without first obtaining his consent: his insistence it was that delayed the summoning of Parliament until May, and then caused the text of the Despatch to be altered.* He rejected the Prince's view that conciliation was safest: for a long time he refused to believe that Bentinck was not exceeding his instructions; stubborn and suspicious, he went on hoping that the British Government would recall or disown their Minister even when his own intelligence from London gave him no grounds for comfort.* He and the Queen therefore wanted the Prince to resist Bentinck at every point; if he deviated in the least from their commands they castigated him as an 'enfant pervers', an 'ambitious and ungrateful son'.* He, for his part, was too weak either to assert or to resign his authority, though Bentinck often forced him to the former, and he himself often threatened the latter.

In this dilemma, the Prince took to playing off one party against the other. If Bentinck wanted something to which the

King and Queen objected, he would ask Bentinck to 'make a Note of it', preferably a strong one which he could produce to his parents as evidence of the British Minister's *terribilità* and in justification of his own compliance. If the measure was important—like the change of Ministry or the meeting of Parliament—he would get Bentinck not only to press it in strong terms, but also to guarantee the Crown against any dangers to which it might give rise.* In this way he presumably thought to escape responsibility; but at the same time he played into Bentinck's hands: for Bentinck could afterwards maintain that, since he had pledged himself to see that a particular measure did no harm, he must demand that it should be carried out as he wished. Thus the Prince bought present comfort at the cost of future trouble. Caught between two forces greater than his own (sometimes, to his despair, between three, when his parents were at odds)—or, to put it on a higher plane, with 'Hell on one side and the reproach of Posterity on the other'*—the Prince swung to and fro, anxious to please everybody, unable to please anybody, and rightly accused by all of weakness and duplicity.

Bentinck knew the Prince's subjection to his parents, but not the full extent of it; he thought the Prince more responsible for his own actions than he was, and he did not at first guess how far the King interfered. This error was easy to fall into: Ferdinand had been notorious for decades as one of the idlest monarchs in Europe; in his present retreat at La Ficuzza he assiduously fed this reputation, declaring to all and sundry that he was suffering for his sins and wished to be considered a dead man. Bentinck naturally assumed that he cared no more for affairs than formerly, and—when he did act—that someone else was pulling the strings. Who then was to blame? Obviously the Queen.*

Much has been written on the long struggle between Bentinck and Maria Carolina, perhaps too much: for the personal conflict, though dramatic in itself, was really no more than an outgrowth of the essential political conflict, a somewhat irrelevant descant. Bentinck, it is true, spent needless time and energy in his campaign against the Queen, only to discover too late that her expulsion—first from Palermo, then from Sicily altogether—was no remedy for the island's political troubles.* But then all circumstances told against the Queen. She was the perfect scape-

goat for everyone, above all for her own family. She was notorious, to begin with, as an insatiable meddler. The King had the sense to lie low; but she could not stop the flow of her wild talk and fruitless activity. To all who would listen she confided her fears of the block or of a trial before Parliament; her tirades against the 'bestia feroce' Bentinck; her sudden and ephemeral resolves to retire to Catania, to Vienna (where her nephew the Emperor had invited her), even to England.* She ever clung to the belief that Bentinck must shortly be recalled for exceeding his instructions, and she clutched at straws to justify it—a platitude of Castlereagh's in a Commons debate, or the prattle of a visiting Englishman.* She dabbled in preposterous intrigues to bring the King back to power as a constitutional monarch; and the riffraff of spies and agents continued to infest her antechamber.* Then rumour amplified the whirl of her activity; she was alleged to be fomenting popular disorder, plotting a counter-revolution, appealing to Austria and Russia for help.* Naturally those whom her fall from power had compromised now did their best to blame her. Her son, even while he was begging Bentinck not to 'act horribly' towards her, shewed plainly that he thought her the skeleton in the family cupboard, beloved but utterly irresponsible. 'Ma mère a une telle tête, une telle tête', he would cry. Her husband did the same; and his two confidants, Cassaro and his confessor Father Caccamo, scarcely let slip an opportunity of setting Bentinck against her. She was, they told him again and again, the arch mischief-maker; the King was under her thumb, though he would willingly be rid of her: 'he had been married 44 years . . . they were so many years of Martyre'.* So general was this attitude that when the Prince at one time became dangerously ill, she was suspected of having poisoned him: Bentinck suggested to the Prince's physician that heat might be the cause, but 'he cried out shaking with palsy all over, *Ce n'est pas la chaleur—c'est sa mère—sa mère*'.*

In fact the Queen, as her letters shew, did interfere in affairs as much as she could. Her husband and son may on occasion have found her a convenient scapegoat, but there can be little doubt that they were often genuinely harassed and influenced by her outcries. It was quite natural that Bentinck should fasten

on her the blame for the delays and difficulties he experienced. He therefore concluded that only her removal to a safe distance from Palermo could put an end to her evil influence over King, Prince and populace. She herself talked of going away; she even said she would leave Sicily altogether if England paid her debts. But Bentinck set no store by this, for, he said, 'human nature was the same everywhere—She could not divest herself of habits of forty years' continuance, that of governing . . .'.* What he needed was a pretext. This came to hand unexpectedly in March 1812, when one Cassetti, once a spy of the Queen's, and now in prison, confessed to having acted as go-between to her and Murat and revealed her so-called plot for new Vespers against the English.* Bentinck did not take this information very seriously: 'I did not believe that she had any serious intention of giving up the island. She had been instigated by her love even to madness of intrigue . . . this I believe to be the truth.' But he could use the 'proofs' to attack what he really feared, the Queen's political influence: he wrote her a letter respectful in manner if not in matter, suggesting that after this discovery—which he hoped to keep secret—she would do well to withdraw to a remoter part of Sicily.* Six weeks' negotiations ensued; letters flew back and forth between the Queen, the King, the Prince, Bentinck and Caccamo. The King wanted Bentinck to shew his proofs to the Prince, to Cassaro, to anyone but himself; while Bentinck refused to shew them to anyone else. Finally, at the end of April, the Queen agreed to join the King (much against his wish) at La Ficuzza. The distance from Palermo, about 25 miles, still seemed too short to Bentinck; he contemplated using force, but—reflecting that 'the pushing things to an extremity might have had an appearance of cruelty'—he let the matter drop for the moment. He could still return to the charge if necessary, brandishing his proofs, the validity of which the King had tacitly admitted by refusing to see them.*

Castlereagh, whom Bentinck informed of all these transactions, took the proofs very seriously indeed: they justified, he said, all that Bentinck had done in Sicily; and he left it entirely to Bentinck's discretion how far they should be disclosed, and 'what conditions with respect to Her Majesty's residence and her abandoning all interference in the Government it may be

expedient to require'. In the Commons he had already described Bentinck's conduct as 'not less remarkable for mildness and forbearance than for a rigid execution of his instructions'. Now, in giving Bentinck fresh instructions, he agreed that there was still a lot of work for him to do:

'To recommend such necessary reforms of the Sicilian Constitution as may ensure the affections of the people, and make the Neapolitans anxious to receive equal advantages, together with the return of their lawful sovereigns; these will continue to be the objects of Your Lordship's attention.'

With the Queen's influence apparently out of the way, Bentinck could now address himself to the task of constructing a new political 'system' for Sicily.

CHAPTER II

THE PROTECTORATE AND THE 'BASES'

The theme of British policy in Sicily—so Bentinck had written home at the end of March—must be 'the firm and just exercise of our superiority'. What exactly this might mean in practice was Bentinck's chief problem throughout the ensuing year.

By her intervention Britain had established a *de facto* protectorate over Sicily; but it was a protectorate born under an ambiguous star. Apprehension and distrust, carefree optimism and good intentions, had all gone into the original decision to intervene; it is not surprising that the result was a diplomatic muddle. Britain could not very well appear to adopt Napoleon's methods: the fiction had therefore to be kept up that the two nations were equal and independent allies. Castlereagh allowed Bentinck to go on using the language of force—though not force itself—to achieve British aims; but he repeatedly insisted that the 'honour', 'dignity', and 'security' of the Sicilian Royal Family must be safeguarded.* There was a pretence that somehow it was all for the good of the Crown and people of Sicily. Not the least reason for muddle was that this was not wholly a pretence. Bentinck really believed it; 'an interference merely to carry some British object,' he said, 'might not be justifiable'; but

'listening to the call of the whole country and having no view but their benefit and most of all of the Royal Family themselves, the British Government will surely be considered by the present and future generations as only fulfilling the duties of a good and great nation.'

Castlereagh, for his part, seems to have taken the fiction for granted until it became too inconvenient to keep up. Besides, no one had attempted to think out the possible consequences of intervention: Bentinck, Amherst and other British observers, by inference Wellesley himself, all had assumed that, the first crisis over, the 'machine' would run on smoothly without further interference. The negotiations over the new Ministry and the calling of Parliament had begun to undeceive Bentinck; they also provided a pattern for that vicious circle of demand, delay, mutual irritation, and finally grudging concession leading

to further demands, which was to bedevil nearly the whole of Bentinck's mission.*

Yet, in spite of the constant difficulties he experienced, Bentinck's power seemed great, almost viceregal. He did, after all, control Sicily's finances through the subsidy, and her army through his Captain-Generalship. His house was the headquarters of the Patriotic party.* He conferred with Orleans and Belmonte daily; saw the other Ministers, nobles, and politicians frequently; discussed military business with the Prince and the Sicilian staff. He raised public loans, distributed corn when it was short, arranged the redemption of Sicilian slaves from Tunis, and gave magnificent entertainments, some of which the Prince attended.* Noble families asked him to arbitrate their contested marriage settlements; the very Ministers he had driven out of office—one, indeed, into exile: Ascoli—now cringed to him and solicited his favour.* He did not hesitate to rebuke the Prince of Butera in strong terms when that first baron of Sicily became involved in riots against the government;* if a monk betrayed to the Queen a confidential letter of his, he made the government deport the monk to Lipari.* The supporters of the 'good cause' he marshalled and encouraged: true, his diplomatic position prevented him at first from appearing quite openly as the leader of a party: he refused, for instance, to see the masters of the Palermo guilds when, in the election of May 1812, they chose to flout tradition and the Prince's wishes and came to him for advice; but secretly he sent a message urging them to stand firm. He was, in fact, already playing a dual role as British Minister and Sicilian politician; the new 'system' was patently his creation. To the Patriots he seemed, anyhow at first, the redeemer of Sicily, and in his praise they wrote a great many stanzas, satires and sonnets.*

It may seem strange that with all this display of power Bentinck constantly complained of delay and frustration. The chief trouble was, of course, his running battle with the Royal Family; another was the peculiar character of the British intervention, which at once made Bentinck's power irresistible, and prevented him from exerting it to the full. Furthermore, the weakness of the Patriots—which their accession to the Ministry soon revealed—hindered him even while it forced him to behave like an active local politician.

When the new Ministers came in at the end of March, Bentinck conceived of himself as their friend and confidential adviser; he did not then mean to lay down the law. True, he and Belmonte were so close that it is difficult to speak of their acting independently of one another: a later but typical entry in Bentinck's journal runs, 'He [Belmonte] wrote me a Note asking it and helped me to write the refusal of it.*' Even so, Bentinck allowed Belmonte, as newly installed chief Minister, considerable play: he had previously seen and exhorted the Prince nearly every day, but he now left to Belmonte the task of managing both Prince and—later—Parliament. This Belmonte was confident he could do; and his confidence outlasted that of all his friends.

Everyone had assumed that the Ministry would be united and that they would be responsible, in the sense of being in actual control of the government. United they certainly were not. Aci proved a liability from the start: he and Bentinck clashed, and went on disputing for months, over details of day-to-day army administration. To Bentinck's mind the Minister for War ought not to concern himself with this any more than the Secretary of State at home. Aci had larger views, and quoted a French Encyclopaedia (art. *Ministre de la Guerre*) in support. He promoted officers, moved troops without Bentinck's knowledge, quarrelled with the Sicilian Chief of Staff, and generally displayed what Bentinck thought intolerable wrongheadedness and vanity, until Bentinck decided that he 'would not permit' such behaviour any longer. But the Prince had taken a fancy to Aci, probably because of his very disagreements with Bentinck; if asked to dismiss him, he could retort that Bentinck had imposed Aci on him in the first place. Belmonte, whose nominee Aci had been, could neither control nor dislodge him. Indeed he asked Bentinck on occasion to write a Note to the Prince and so prevent some step which Aci was about to take and which he, Belmonte, disapproved.*

Similarly Belmonte, finding that Cassaro was giving the Prince constitutional advice at variance with that of the other Ministers, asked Bentinck to tell him that 'England would not allow any opposition to its views for the interests of both countries'; and Cassaro himself wanted Bentinck to intervene

and prevent what he apprehended as revolutionary developments.*

The fact was that nothing like a Cabinet system had ever existed in Sicily or Naples. The Ministers were still very much the Prince's secretaries; so true was this of Belmonte that the Prince did not even allow him to read the foreign despatches, in spite of his and Bentinck's protests.* They worked independently of each other, meeting officially only in Council, with the Prince in attendance; and though they might hold informal councils of their own—which Bentinck sometimes attended—no discipline could be imposed on an individual Minister such as Aci or Cassaro. Furthermore, though there had been powerful chief Ministers at Naples in the past—Tanucci, Acton—it gradually became clear that Belmonte was not, after all, the man to emulate them: but it took Bentinck some time to realise his friend's shortcomings.

Altogether, the relations between Bentinck and the Sicilian patriots could only be described as peculiar. He must try to lead them, and most of them still wanted his advice and support; yet he was not of them. He was inevitably a foreigner, had still something of the East India official, observing with detached amusement the antics of the natives.* 'I began to know my compatriots the Sicilians', he said sarcastically; 'vanity was the great defect of the country—I never had seen anything like it in any part of the world'. And he thought he detected in the blustering Aci the vices of a nation: 'the Sicilians in general are bullies and are only to be managed by fear. They take advantage of the least concession and always construe conciliation into weakness'.* What, then, led him to persist in doing what he could (as he conceived it) to help the Sicilians? 'Bonaparte made Kings, England makes Nations', he is supposed to have said at one time; at another, that 'England ought to give liberty to every country she could reach'.* Perhaps, too, pride forbade him to abandon an attempt the success of which he had confidently prophesied in his first despatches: he seems to have realised quite early how unlikely the new 'system' was to survive the withdrawal of British force—though this was probably the kind of truth which he could perceive but did not dwell upon.* Yet he seems also to have been moved by a genuine concern for

the Sicilians' welfare—a concern of which his indignation at their shortcomings might well be the *revers de la médaille*. This it was that led him to lecture the uninterested Prince on the greatness and prosperity which Sicily might recover through a better road system and a colonisation of the land; to oppose the grain-tax that crushed the peasantry; to realise (what many of the patriots did not) that the aristocracy were as unpopular as the former Neapolitan government, and their abuses no less burdensome.* He could so far shed insular intolerance as to attend Mass, kneeling side by side with Orleans in Alcamo church (they were on an excursion to Segesta) and feeling embarrassed because he did not know enough to bow at the Elevation.* Altogether his ironic detachment was not complete, his exasperation with the Sicilians not permanent; in an odd, intermittent way his affections were becoming engaged. Later on this emotional commitment was to lead him into steps both drastic and damaging to his own career; meanwhile he could only do his best to shore up and hold together his friends in office.

In these circumstances, then, Bentinck set out on the more specifically political part of his programme. By May 1812 he had got several of the things his Government and he himself had wanted. The Queen's mischief seemed temporarily checked; the Prince, though a disappointment, did not yet seem irretrievably lost to Bentinck's and Belmonte's influence; and on the first of the month the Royal Despatch had at last gone out to summon a new Parliament. The time had come to launch that constitutional reform which Bentinck ardently desired as a rallying-cry for Italian patriotism, and which Castlereagh was at that very moment directing him to strive for.

The Sicilian Constitution of 1812 has won some notoriety as that 'which for the first time laid down in writing the glorious principles of the unwritten constitution of Britain'.* But this deliberate copy of an elusive foreign model came about partly through a chapter of accidents; Bentinck, far from imposing it, deplored it before he came to acquiesce in it.

The Patriotic leaders began to discuss constitutional reform in February, soon after the establishment of the Vicariate. Balsamo undertook to draw up, in consultation with Belmonte and Castelnovo, proposals for specific reforms. Bentinck saw

this draft in April; he had not helped to prepare it except in the way of general conversation; it was only later that he discussed specific proposals with Castelnovo and Belmonte, and that some of them were amended at his suggestion. Nobody at this early stage thought of drawing up an entirely new constitution; Balsamo and his friends agreed that the old one should be adhered to as much as possible. They wished on the one hand to restore it to its original state in the Aragonese period, and on the other hand to adapt it to modern conditions. To this end the reformers took as their guide the English constitution, 'recommended by the experience and success of centuries', while they rejected the Spanish and French, 'which are too democratic, and therefore tending to anarchy; and which assume in society that wisdom and virtue, which may be imagined, but are not to be found in man'. But when Balsamo produced his draft late in April, it was already clear that the Ministers and their followers were anything but unanimous, either as to the reforms themselves or as to the means of carrying them out.*

All were agreed on two points: first, the power of the Crown—on the increase for the last thirty years, and lately asserted in defiance of the Constitution—must be curtailed; second, Sicily must shake free of Neapolitan domination. A return to the Aragonese capitularies, such as Balsamo's draft provided for, would serve both these purposes. But beyond this there were many points of disagreement.

Constitutional reform had to resolve the crisis of 1810-1812. Not only had the conflict between Crown and Parliament then come to a head, but the barons' standing as a class had been called in question. To some it might seem that Bentinck's defeat of the Crown meant the setting up of a baronial oligarchy: that was what the Queen feared and Cassaro, for one, desired: he would be quite content if the clock was merely turned back to the *status quo ante Caracciolo*. He had formerly stood up to the Crown in defence of the barons' privileges; now that the Crown was beaten he feared any innovations which might weaken or destroy the feudal system. This fear led him to ally himself with the King, and to advise the Prince that he had no right to call Parliament or set about reforming the Constitution without the King's consent.* At the other extreme from Cassaro

and those barons who, like him, had resisted the Crown from purely conservative and class motives, stood another group with Castelnuevo as its head and Balsamo as its purveyor of political doctrine. Castelnuevo realised that the barons' defence of Parliament had lately come to involve interests wider than those of their own class: though he wished to avoid the French 'spirit of theory and system', he declared that the barons would have to 'make some significant sacrifice of their interests and prerogatives for the sake of the Nation's general welfare'.* Some of his friends went further: Airoldi, for instance, combined a vague philosophic republicanism with a desire to concentrate most of the powers of government in the legislature; in this his fear of the Crown led him to follow that very French theory and practice which he professed to dislike.* Apart from these two groups, the rest of the patriotic party was typified rather than led by Belmonte, who seemed to have no very clear notion of what the reformed constitution should be like. He too wished to diminish the power of the sovereign, who was 'now a Sultan'; one guesses that he inclined to an aristocratic form of government: 'H.R.H. could not suppose', he asked the Prince, 'he wanted revolution and that born to the situation he was he could wish to lower himself to an equality with his groom.' He talked at one time of reverting entirely to the old constitution, at another of having it 'revised, well washed and cleaned and put into an English dress, habillé à l'anglaise'. Yet he must have been won over temporarily to Castelnuevo's views, for Balsamo's draft—which they both approved—included a clause abolishing feudal privileges.*

Bentinck deprecated this somewhat conservative attitude of Belmonte's: he agreed with Castelnuevo that the day was past when the nobility could claim a monopoly of power. Yet he once again gave in to Belmonte on the important question of how constitutional reform was to be carried out. Castelnuevo, no less than Belmonte, feared democracy and the backward mob: for the very reason that he wished to establish political liberty and a measure of social change, he dreaded a recrudescence of faction and class egoism in the new Parliament; he therefore proposed that Parliament should be presented with a *Constitution octroyée*. Belmonte, fundamentally much less of

an innovator, preferred to please 'public opinion' by letting Parliament set itself up as a Constituent Assembly. Bentinck sided at first with Castelnovo and the Prince in this matter; but Belmonte eventually persuaded him that Sicily should be allowed 'spontaneously to give herself a constitution, without the interference of any authority, much less that of Sicilian or English bayonets'.

This decision made the election of a new *Braccio demaniale* or Third Estate all the more important. It took place in May, against a background of general economic confusion. The Ministry, faced from the outset with a running deficit of 40,000 ounces a month,* could scarcely pay the army, let alone their creditors, for all Bentinck's loans and advances. Corn had been short for months: and Castelnovo made things worse by removing the traditional controls on the sale of bread. Popular discontent failed to move him: he knew the Palermitans, he said—'it did not answer to caress them'. In this doctrinaire policy he was supported by Balsamo with the arguments of economic liberalism, and opposed by Bentinck with those of common sense. As a result there were bread riots at election-time in Palermo, and later on in other parts of the island.*

The election itself was marked by a few incidents. In Palermo the masters of the guilds traditionally elected to the Demaniale their Lord Mayor (*Pretore*). Now, however, Aci and others—from motives of personal jealousy, it seems—induced them to break with custom. This was a mistake, for the *Pretore*, the Count of San Marco, though aristocratically inclined could have been made into a useful ally. Besides, independence went to the masters' heads; they threatened to elect one of their own number instead of the pocket candidate whom Aci and his friends had provided for them. But in the end they fell into line. Elsewhere too the Government, like its predecessors, influenced the elections—to what extent it is impossible to tell.*

Parliament was due to meet on June 18th. One month before that date the Ministers were still divided on constitutional reform; and the attitude of the Crown was most doubtful. Cassaro continued to assert that Balsamo's draft went too far, and that in any case Parliament was not entitled to change the constitution without the King's leave. Fear of the King appar-

ently moved him, as well as conservatism—‘they might suffer with their lives’, he said.* As the King’s confidant he had reason to know that his master was opposed to any change. To the King the word *Constitution* was as meaningless and distasteful as the word *Nation*: he was ‘a little displeased’ to learn from Cassaro what he professed not to have known before—that he had been a constitutional monarch in Sicily these 53 years. As early as January 29th, a fortnight after his delegation of power, he had warned the British Government through Castelvicala of the dangers which constitutional reform would entail. There is no sign that his attitude had changed in the meantime; and it was certainly not he who (as has been stated) first thought of adopting the English Constitution—quite the contrary. In fact he was the last to reconcile himself to reform of any kind; only later did he set himself up as the champion of the pure English Constitution.* The Queen, now her husband’s unwelcome companion, was said to be plotting for his return to power. The Prince wavered: he did not know exactly what reforms his ministers proposed, for Belmonte, fearful of future harm, would not shew him Balsamo’s draft without a written order; and this the Prince, no less fearful, refused to give. He and Belmonte both tried, for different reasons, to draw Bentinck into taking part in discussions with the other Ministers and so achieving an agreed draft. Belmonte wanted Bentinck to silence Cassaro’s feudal opposition; while the Prince still hoped for a *Constitution octroyée* as the lesser of two evils, and probably wished to throw the burden of responsibility for it on Bentinck. Bentinck, however, had come round to Belmonte’s view that Parliament should be given a free hand; besides, he said, ‘I would rather be left out . . . it was an interference which my Government might not like’. Still he gave in to Belmonte’s argument that Cassaro could not be persuaded otherwise, and that his interference would be quite unofficial. No sooner had he done so than the Prince decided, on May 29th, to put off the meeting of Parliament, on the pretext that it might lead to popular commotion. Bentinck, plausibly suspecting the influence of the King and Queen, riposted by holding up a badly needed loan. But with the Crown plainly hostile, and Cassaro still unreconciled, the prospect for reform was bleak.*

At this point came the proposal to adopt the English Constitution in its entirety. It came from the unlikelyst quarter—Aci and the Prince of Moliterno—and it came linked with a plan for an immediate expedition to Italy. Aci, volatile as usual, seems to have acted on his own. He merely conceived a brilliant notion and put it to the Prince: if Sicily adopted the English Constitution, Naples would want a similar boon; an expedition would most likely succeed. Then Sicily would be independent with the Prince as her King; or, if Ferdinand persisted in his retirement, the Prince would rule at Naples and his brother at Palermo.* Moliterno, for his part, had long been full of wild schemes for the unification of Italy into one kingdom, with—of all people—Ferdinand as its constitutional ruler. He had approached Bentinck in March, proposing the formation of an 'Armée de la Constitution Italique' to be subsidised by Britain, and vaunting his connections with the Italian patriots; but Bentinck had thought him no more than a crank and an adventurer. Now, however, Moliterno once again urged his plan on the King and Queen. An expedition meant a constitution: his own ideas on the subject were rather vague; since the prestigious English Constitution was now in the limelight, why not take it as a model and a slogan?*

These proposals of Aci's and Moliterno's did not spring fully armed from the inventors' brains. Anglomania, as we have seen, already prevailed in Sicily at this period. It had not abated by 1812: the very terminology of British politics seemed to bear some magical virtue. The new constitution, when it came to be written, talked of *bills* and *budgets*; Aci thought to entice the clergy with the offer of a *Convocation*; those who considered the new constitution not 'popular' enough complained that 'it even established Star Chamber'. The learned Balsamo himself wondered for a moment whether Sicily had not better adopt the elaborate comedy of 'fine and common recovery' as a means of getting round entails.* When Aci spoke to the Prince, the English Constitution had already been chosen as an 'inspiration'; Aci merely changed 'inspiration' to 'model'. The state of Sicilian thought explains why he could do so. The circumstances of the moment explain why his proposal pleased nearly everybody.

It pleased the Patriots for several reasons. A successful expedition would mean a wonderful chance to get rid of the Neapolitans and wrest from the King the independence of Sicily under a separate dynasty. The English Constitution they already admired; even so they took to it—as will be seen—not so much with the intention of copying it *in toto* as with a desire to gloss over their present differences. It suited Castelnovo's moderate reformism, as well as Belmonte's aristocratic leanings and his hazy preference for the popular solution. It even suited Cassaro and Butera: on first hearing it proposed Cassaro 'grew pale', but presently his son 'translated' it—from what text we do not know—and he 'read it with great pleasure'; Butera too thought 'anything was better than the speculations of those wild politicians'.*

The Prince 'jumped at it' naturally enough, since he saw a chance of moving against Murat with the support of both the British and the Sicilians. This the Bourbons could not do without; and they must not let Bentinck move without them, else he might throw them over in favour of the Archduke Francis and Naples might then slip out of their grasp. Perhaps, too, the Prince was ready to contemplate with momentary favour the separation of Sicily from Naples, since it would give him a kingdom to himself. But if there was to be an expedition there must be a Constitution; that was Bentinck's price. And if there must be a Constitution, the English was safer than most: it would be something like a *Constitution octroyée*; it would, he said, calm the hotheads; Parliament would soon be over, 'and we can then turn our views to other matters'. Besides, it would keep Bentinck and his friends busy, and draw their attention away from more perilous matters. Above all the English Constitution had the great advantages of 'the devil you know': the Prince was so ready to accept it (Bentinck concluded) because

'he [had] always thought he would have less power than the King of England. . . . He had often remarked to me, when I had talked of the Civil List and of other parliamentary interference—*mais le Roi d'Angleterre a ce et ce pouvoir*, not adverting to the particular point in question but generally as if it was intended to make a complete cypher of him.'*

So the Prince took up Aci's twin notions of expedition and English constitution with great zeal; he decided not to prorogue Parliament after all, and undertook to convert his parents. The King was suspicious from the first. The Prince's ideas, he noted at the beginning of June, were 'diametrically opposed' to his own; in his son's enthusiasm he thought he detected a mask for unfilial ambition. He still objected in principle, he told Cassaro, to any kind of new Constitution, and he wanted the meeting of Parliament put off until September, by which time he hoped Bentinck would have been recalled. But, he added, if Bentinck promised an expedition to Naples 'he would consent to some *Novità* being introduced'. For a moment it seemed the Prince and Cassaro had persuaded him.* The Queen, however, was up in arms against Aci's proposals, which she denounced to her husband as 'malicious' and 'erroneous'. She urged him to set his face against a new Constitution and above all against the 'rebellious proposal' of the separation of Sicily from Naples. The King replied cautiously that he agreed with her but that British pressure might force him to accept some kind of Constitution for fear of 'fatal consequences'. But he changed his mind once again: two days later (June 9th) he sent Bentinck, on his own initiative, a questionnaire which shewed that he still thought Bentinck's conduct revolutionary and probably unauthorised; he hinted at a desire to resume power, and demanded a pension for himself and his family (not including the Prince) in case Bentinck really meant to 'annihilate' him. At the same time he plunged the Prince into dismay by again refusing to countenance the opening of Parliament, which was now only a week off.*

Bentinck was most annoyed. He replied that he had faithfully followed his instructions; if the King resumed he expected to see those engagements fulfilled which the Vicar had entered into—that is, Parliament, reform, and army reorganisation; and he seized the chance once again to press his case against the Queen, including the famous proofs. Encouraged by Cassaro, he blamed her as usual (and not altogether wrongly) for the King's recalcitrance: 'I had been justly punished for my moderation towards the Queen . . . it was only since her sejour with the King that H.M. had become uneasy, had interfered in the public business, and was now induced to resume the Govern-

ment.' The King, to be sure, had good reasons of his own for balking at the separation of Sicily from Naples; and Bentinck's plans for Italian independence were not such as to reassure him. But the Queen's loud presence at his side may well have helped to goad him into action. However, this latest proof of Bentinck's inflexibility swayed the King: he appeared to give way to his son's views. But he did no more than suspend his obstruction: he did not commit himself to outright approval of the proposed constitution. The Queen went further in her sudden reversal. Persuaded, apparently, by Moliterno of the overriding advantages of an expedition to Naples, by June 15th she was writing to her son in favour of the English Constitution for Sicily and a constitutional settlement for anything they might acquire on the Continent. 'A most sensible letter,' Bentinck thought; '... it was much to be regretted that she could talk and write so well and acted always so ill. Her misfortune is to have all sense but common sense.'*

One person was not at all pleased with Aci's plan—Bentinck. To him both the English Constitution and (just then) the proposed expedition came as unwelcome surprises. He was still ready to use the prospect of an expedition as a bait and so get the Royal Family's consent to a Sicilian Parliament and Constitution; but he thought Aci was 'pushing' them too much, and he did not wish the Patriots to use his own influence to impose on the Crown the independence of Sicily and the English Constitution 'as if I had insisted on it which I had not and when I even thought it would not suit them'. Independence might be good for Sicily, but not necessarily for Naples, Italy, or Britain; he had no powers to secure it. As for the constitution, he told Belmonte,

'I was very sorry that they had adopted the English Constitution which no one understood or could define. . . . It would cast a ridicule upon their measures. . . . I infinitely preferred his plan which was founded upon the principles of the English Constitution.'

So slavish a copy might be dangerous as well as absurd—'some leading principles might be omitted by mistake, an omission which might be fatal to their liberties by being construed into an intention'. He greeted the 'translation' by Cassaro's son with

sarcastic congratulations; when Aci read him 'the leading principles of the British Constitution as compiled from Delolme, Pinkerton(?) [sic] Blackstone in the course of *two days*', he refused to pronounce on them—'I was no legiste'. But in the end he relented. Apparently Balsamo came to the rescue by putting together yet another draft which followed the English system but modified it to suit Sicilian conditions—and Balsamo was much the most reliable draftsman at hand. Anyhow when Bentinck wrote home he had so far changed his mind as to say:

'I must confess that at first I was very much against the adoption of the English Constitution. I doubted very much whether the people have sufficient steadiness, wisdom or virtue to execute it. I was however much better disposed to it when I saw that no other plan presented so few difficulties; and my fears were very much lessened when I read the outline of a Constitution formed upon that of England, but with great moderation and wisdom modified and adapted to the debased state of this society, by certain salutary restraints upon the liberty of the Press, and by suspending for the moment the Trial by Jury.'

For this great work he gave credit to Castelnuevo and Belmonte, 'men who would do honour to the most enlightened and virtuous nation'.*

Did Bentinck really believe all this? Or had he perhaps made up his mind to stand by the new 'system' even though an important element was brought into it against his better judgment? At all events his enthusiasm did him no good: by commending the English Constitution (however modified) he implanted in the minds of Ministers at home the notion that it was all his own work; and so enabled them later on to 'cast a ridicule' on his mission.

Aci's other main proposal—the expedition to Italy—was one which Bentinck himself had often talked of since his arrival; he had used it effectively as an inducement to reform in Sicily. But coming from the Prince at this particular moment the proposal was most embarrassing. Bentinck certainly wanted nothing so much as to liberate Italy. But the British Government had allowed him only to look into the possibility of doing so, and had told him to move only after consulting with Wellington and with themselves. Finding, on his return to Sicily in December 1811, disappointingly little evidence that Italy was ripe

for revolt, Bentinck told Liverpool so in a despatch of January 25th. To him and to Wellington he suggested various uses to which part of his troops might meanwhile be put; one of them was making a temporary diversion in Catalonia. Nothing could have suited Wellington better; and Liverpool ordered Bentinck on March 4th to carry out the diversion, provided that the Sicilian situation allowed it and Italy remained quiescent. On May 17th Bentinck decided to send 6,000 men to Spain, though by then he would rather have kept them on hand; 'we all think', he noted, 'that this force will do no good'. But Murat's departure for the Russian campaign had left Sicily in safety; and Italy continued disappointing. The Archduke Francis' plan to raise and liberate the country depended on slow and tenuous communications with Vienna via the Balkans; months passed and nothing was done. Overtures to the Italian Patriots were more easily thought of than made: 'I am taught to believe', complained one of Bentinck's agents, 'that there is no more communication with Italy than with China.' Overtures from Italy there were none. As Bentinck told the Archduke,

*'Le malheur est que l'Italie est trop humiliée par la police française. Elle ne fait aucune démonstration de cette décision sans laquelle sa cause n'intéressera jamais beaucoup le public anglais. Ils sont mécontents sans doute, et deviendraient puissans contre les Français. Mais ils sont passifs. Je ne reçois aucune proposition de l'Italie, une circonstance que ne marque ni une inquiétude très pénible avec leurs souffrances, ni le caractère de Grandeur d'Ame qu'on a vu dans les Espagnols. Ce sont les plaintes d'esclaves plutôt que les murmures d'un peuple magnanime qui veut vaincre ou mourir pour la liberté et l'indépendence.'**

Bentinck wrote this in October, and it expressed the accumulated disappointment of several months. At the beginning of June, when the Prince proposed an expedition, he was still fairly hopeful. None the less he now found himself committed to acting in Catalonia; and he had no evidence from Italy that would justify a change of plan. Just as the Court was ready to cooperate he could not. Perplexed, he asked for time.*

At this very moment, decision came to Palermo in the shape of one Lucius Concannon, an Irishman connected with the Archduke's party, who had travelled from Vienna by way of

Italy. He reported the country to be at a high pitch of discontent, ready to rise for religion, peace, an end to conscription, and a British alliance—'*That cry* from Venice to Naples . . . would not leave one Frenchman alive in three weeks . . .'. Switzerland and Tyrol were also ripe for revolt. Riper than any were the Neapolitans, but they would bear anything sooner than the return of the Bourbons. Concannon's enthusiastic reports might normally have made little impression on Bentinck; in his present dilemma, however, they seemed to justify that change of plan which he personally inclined to. Even so Bentinck was not going to take so much upon himself unless he could run the expedition on his own terms. These he put to the Prince in an interview of June 8th—he had, indeed, mentioned most of them in earlier exchanges, but only hypothetically. Now he told the Prince outright that 'the only chance of success was to declare at once to the people that the deliverance of Italy' (and not merely of Naples) 'from the French yoke was our sole object. The choice of a constitution and a chief must be left to the free will of the people'. He would neither mention the Royal Family in his proclamations nor allow any of them to accompany their own forces; for, he said, to thrust them upon Naples from the first would alienate the people. All that Bentinck would concede to the Prince, either then or later in the month, was that he would 'do all in his power to persuade the Neapolitans to accept the Hereditary Prince for their sovereign', and that he would take no other prince—meaning the Archduke or Orleans—with him to Italy. Bentinck's terms naturally dismayed the Prince, though they were not entirely news to him; still he did not at first reject them.* Bentinck accordingly countermanded the Catalan expedition on June 9th.

In doing so he exposed himself for the first time to the charge that he had disregarded his instructions without sufficient cause. Wellington was of course much annoyed at the news, and so were Liverpool and Mulgrave. Bathurst, however—who was Bentinck's only friend in the Cabinet—was more indulgent. Apparently he was not averse from Bentinck's Italian plans in principle, and thought a descent on Venice a promising possibility. His Under-Secretary, Henry Bunbury—an old Sicilian hand—was more favourable still: if Russia held, he thought,

'the time is not far distant when we shall see all the nations from the Lake of Constance to the sea of Malta up in arms against Buonaparte'. Between them they passed over Bentinck's step as an exercise of discretion which was permissible if ill-judged. Castlereagh, for his part, warned Bentinck privately that the Government would not hear of his encouraging the Neapolitans to 'elect' Ferdinand, whose recall, 'however voluntary on the part of his continental subjects, should be in fact a restoration rather than an election'. To which Bentinck replied that the Neapolitans would have resisted a plain restoration:

'I... thought that the expedition proposed to me could not succeed without the cooperation of the people and that this cooperation could not be obtained without the inducement of getting rid of the French Government and of substituting Freedom for Tyranny. Upon my own responsibility I can proceed on no other grounds... though the condition required seemed contrary to the King's interest, yet in my opinion it was directly the reverse.'

Of Bentinck's wider visions of Italian independence and self-determination Castlereagh, it may be noted, said nothing.*

Meanwhile the prospect of an expedition, however stiff the terms that went with it, was enough to keep the Royal Family attached to the English Constitution. More than ever it seemed the one safe haven in the storm of constitutional speculation which then prevailed at Palermo. On the very eve of the opening of Parliament the Prince took fright at an anonymous paper proposing that Sicily should adopt part of the new Spanish Constitution. This he thought 'the precursor of democracy and revolution'; he refused to open Parliament unless Bentinck pledged himself to see that the new constitution did not differ from the English. Bentinck objected that 'this would have committed me directly and personally in the affairs of the Parliament and of the Government, which I have carefully avoided'. He did, however, sign a guarantee of his support to the legitimate exercise of the Prince's authority against any possible disorder. The statement concluded:

'I certainly would not undertake to establish by force and against the will of the people even that Constitution which to my conviction were

the best. Y.R.H. knows that I have had no part either in the recommendation or selection of the British Constitution. Y.R.H. has the sole merit of deciding upon a Constitution which agreeing in many respects with the Constitution of Sicily, and sprung as it were from the same root, does promise under salutary modifications to confer the greatest degree of happiness and prosperity. . . . The period with all its circumstances is truly glorious to the Prince and to the People.'

This statement, by eliciting which the Prince as usual hoped to escape responsibility, later served Bentinck as a pretext for the assertion of his own power; it also started a popular legend that Britain had in fact guaranteed the Constitution. For the moment it reassured the Prince. Parliament met on June 18th, and the Speech from the Throne pointed to the English Constitution as the fount of wise and moderate legislation.*

But the honeymoon was brief. Bentinck knew he had taken a risk in deciding on an Italian instead of a Spanish expedition. Opinion among his military and naval colleagues in the Mediterranean command was divided. All agreed that Italy was in principle a much more fruitful battleground than Catalonia; and some shared his hopes of independence for the whole of Italy. But Pellew, Maitland and his second-in-command McFarlane warned him that only the certainty of a resounding success could justify his disregard of instructions—a certainty which his Italian intelligence was too flimsy to establish. Then Nugent reported from Spain that the authorities there and at home were quite set on the Catalan expedition; they would not, he thought, take kindly to Bentinck's about-turn. Even this advice—so Bentinck later said—would not have swayed him if the Court had gone with him all the way; but after some hesitation they found his terms too much to swallow and rejected them. He accordingly changed his mind once more, and decided on June 28th to send the troops to Spain after all. They sailed at once under Maitland.*

Thus the whole *raison d'être* for the Crown's acceptance of the English Constitution fell to the ground. As a result the Prince threw himself back into the arms of his parents, and appeared openly as what he was, 'the King's Prime Minister', their differences made up. He began to complain of Bentinck's interference; government business came practically to a stand-

still; he took advice from Circello and other relics of the past regime; Parliament met no more after the State opening. The Royal Family fell back on the policy which had served them in 1810, that of playing off the aristocratic against the progressive section of the patriotic party. The King let it be known that he was ready to revert to the Sicilian Constitution as it had stood at the beginning of his reign; that is to say, he would give up all the 'enlightened' legislation of the Neapolitan Viceroys, all the inroads made on the power of the nobility, all the fiscal reforms the Crown had attempted, for the sake of averting the present danger of revolutionary innovation. He did add that if innovation there must be, he would prefer the English Constitution to any other; but this was plainly a second-best. In order to convert Parliament to his proposals the King set about forming a party through the Neapolitan Archbishop of Palermo and through Cassaro, whose fears for feudal privilege had re-emerged. By juggling with proxies and by persuasion both sides in the conflict attempted to make sure of a majority when and if Parliament met.*

This *volte-face* destroyed what little was left of Bentinck's regard for the Prince, and of his early conciliatory attitude. Delay, he decided, was the cause: had he forced a meeting of Parliament in January, none of this would have happened:

'I have done violence to my own judgment and feelings in endeavouring to attain the objects of my instructions by the means of conciliation only. I regret the sacrifices of great advantages to the common cause which have arisen from this undeserved delicacy. I am not ashamed to confess that I have been deceived, because when acting for a great and magnanimous nation, I should have been sorry that from any illiberal construction of the motives of this court I had for a moment abused the power committed to my charge. Every act and advice on my part has been most sincerely and anxiously intended to promote [the Prince's] own honour and greatness in the eyes of his own subjects and of the world. It has been all in vain. And I am now in the decided conviction that fear and nothing but fear can direct a mind which many believe to be as false and cunning as it is certainly weak.'

Bentinck now counterattacked on all fronts. In a Note he urged that Parliament should be reassembled. He made the Ministers tender their resignations. He suspended the subsidy

on the ground that the reorganisation of the army, promised since January, had still not begun. These, he admitted, were negative weapons, 'but I could do no more and with respect to the Ministers, although I could not name those who should be appointed, yet I could do as much by objecting to such as might be offered'. To Belmonte's qualms he replied that 'the more embarrassment there was the better'. He warned Cassaro and through him the Archbishop that 'the Constitution must be carried—that was my business—It must be done either by the Parliament or by force'. The Prince tried to stand firm on the army question; but Bentinck returned to the charge, rubbing in Sicily's need for British help; he urged the Prince to follow the example of Portugal by abandoning an ambiguous attitude which might seem 'a lurking hatred, too weak to refuse obligations, too ungenerous to acknowledge them'. The present Sicilian army, he said, was a drag on Britain, even a danger; the subsidy treaties had not foreseen 'a case . . . by which the one buys the privilege of defending the other at the price of £400,000 a year, and is repaid by enmity and insecurity'. Finally, he threatened that if Britain resumed

'the right which the bad faith of the high Personage who directed the preceding administration has given [her] of adopting the most extreme measures, a right waived from mere respect and confidence in Your Royal Highness' upright intentions, she will stand acquitted before God and man for preferring an open enemy to such a friend, the most active hostility to such an alliance'.

'Quite a declaration of war', the Prince thought it; but he had to bend before the storm. The Ministers' resignations were not accepted; and a meeting of Parliament was called for 20 July.*

On that date, in the course of an all-night sitting, Parliament passed fifteen fundamental articles or 'Bases' of the new Constitution. These were taken mainly from the draft in which Balsamo had sought to distil the quintessence of the English system while modifying it to suit the 'debased state' of Sicily. But Parliament made changes in the draft which shewed that the chosen model would not escape unscathed. On the contrary, it already faced a double challenge from conservative and 'democratic' forces.

The Bases established the separation of powers, with Parliament taking to itself, besides the sole power of taxing and legislating (subject to the Royal Assent), that of trying and punishing Ministers, officials and magistrates. The three houses were reduced to two—Peers and Commons—the temporal and spiritual peers being merged into one house, and deprived of their plural votes; money bills were to originate in the Commons; and Parliament was to meet annually. No Sicilian could be deprived of liberty or property without due process of law. The articles where Parliament departed from Balsamo's draft were those concerning finances and feudal rights. Article X gave the Royal Domain to the nation, in exchange for a Civil List, and vested the administration of the nation's property and revenue in Parliament. This was the result of 'democratic' feeling, especially in the Braccio Demaniale, and ran counter to the Ministers' opinions—Castelnuovo in particular objected that it would make him, the Minister of Finance, 'a Comptroller only'. Articles XII and XIII abolished all feudal dues, jurisdictions, and privileges, and converted all fiefs into alods. But an amendment of Cassaro's was carried by the barons—Belmonte, Castelnuovo, Aci and seven of their friends dissenting—which made the surrender of certain privileges, such as local tolls and monopolies, subject to compensation by the communes benefited. This amendment met with resistance in the Demaniale: Belmonte, however, went down to the lower House; overcoming his own distaste for the measure which he had just voted against, by his eloquence he persuaded the Demaniale members to overcome theirs also and thus maintain a united front. In the Ecclesiastico the Archbishop of Palermo could muster only a little less than one-third of the members to vote against the extinction of their own Estate. The final article of the Bases looked forward to the filling out of the Constitution by Parliament along the lines of the English model.*

The Bases of the Constitution, particularly those concerning feudal rights, have given rise to a question which is still debated—how far did they spring from a genuine surge of national and reformist sentiment, how far from the desire of the baronial class to maintain, perhaps even to increase, their power in the state? The question must be considered later on. The Bases did

hold the seeds of those differences over institutional and feudal matters which were later to wreck the Constitution, and class egoism certainly damped the Barons' reforming zeal in the matter of compensation. All the same we can have little doubt that the great majority of parliamentarians sincerely and (at any rate) consciously believed they had sacrificed their particular interests to the general good of the nation. The sitting of July 20th was thus the high-water mark of the patriotic movement, and in the eyes of the participants it stood for the rebirth of Sicily. Bentinck wrote home exultantly:

'So strong an expression of national feeling is scarcely upon record . . . an unanimity almost without a precedent, and more than ever surprising upon an occasion when the ancient privileges and jurisdictions of families were to be resigned, when long cherished prejudices were to be sacrificed, and when the two more powerful orders of the State were called upon to give up their preponderancy, to unite themselves into one Chamber, and co-operate to confer upon the third an influence which it had never possessed. These things are really honourable to the Sicilians, and the exultation and hope which prevail are universal'.

In a quieter strain, he confided to G.F. Leckie—in a sense the first father of British intervention in Sicily—his satisfaction, tempered though it was with regret that feudal privileges had not been abolished outright:

'The business is new to all, but notwithstanding there is a good deal of vanity and egoism among the great and that there will be a good deal of scrambling for loaves and fishes among all, yet there is a great portion of good sense, honour and patriotism, that I hope will keep the ship right, even should she be in danger. There is also at hand our independent protecting force that I trust will be able effectually to secure this infant Constitution from all mishap—and a very gratifying and proud duty this is.'*

This was undoubtedly the culminating point of Bentinck's mission: never afterwards could he feel so unmixed a satisfaction. The credit for this golden moment he gave to his Sicilian friends, to Belmonte in particular. But it was he who received the congratulations of his British friends—of Amherst, for instance, who wrote that Bentinck had accomplished, without

the usual attendants of bloodshed and confusion, one of the most complete and important revolutions recorded in the history of our eventful times. There now opens indeed a fair prospect of happiness, as well as of political power, to the inhabitants of the rich and beautiful island of Sicily.'

CHAPTER III

THE CONSTITUTION AND THE 'PROMISE'

'A work of Herculean labour. . . . It is the triumph of humanity and Reason over darkness, cruelty and oppression and stamps you the Benefactor of Mankind . . . you will enjoy the prayers of millions who will ultimately derive freedom and happiness from this distant example . . .

Thus Pellew, on hearing of the Bases of the Sicilian Constitution. That this was not the mere effusion of a politically naive sea-dog is shewn by the chorus of praise and encouragement which reached Bentinck from British observers, both after his first victory over the Court in January and after the voting of the Bases on July 20th. It was perhaps not surprising that the generals and admirals should expect Sicily to reap great and sudden benefits from the change—like nearly everyone else they believed in her potential prosperity, which (they thought) only misrule had stifled, and only the Queen's mischief still imperilled. Nor was it strange that they, like Bentinck, should see in 'regenerated' Sicily a great accession of strength to the British cause—'the world may be *saved* by it', exclaimed Pellew. No doubt these illusions were the outcome of a classical education. But it was noteworthy that the Prince Regent himself, according to one report, praised Bentinck's conduct highly in private; it was, one supposes, unusual for the Under-Secretary of State to tell the envoy who had just revolutionised the country to which he was accredited: 'I congratulate you *du fond de mon cœur*'. This enthusiasm for Bentinck's achievement was not confined to one party; it sprang from the most disparate motives: from the Benthamism of a pompous East India official who wrote that Bentinck had done 'that for a sea-girt isle in the Mediterranean, which *one* of your ancestors assisted in doing for the island of your birth'; or from the forthright John Bull attitude of the Bishop of Limerick, who trusted that 'that miserable country will now be . . . made sensible of its good fortune in being placed under the control and protection of the British Government'.*

What doubts and suspicions there were likewise cut across party lines. A Government supporter like Lord Sheffield disliked

'crusading with our Constitution' no less than did Sir Robert Wilson, Grey's ambassador-at-large, for whom Sicily was an example of 'the march of usurpation in English policy'. A Cabinet Minister—Harrowby—thought Bentinck 'Whig-mad' on the evidence of the new Constitution, which of course he took to be Bentinck's own work; while another Benthamite—Blaquiere—complained of the 'overstrained moderation' of Bentinck's measures. Indeed, those who knew something of Sicily and agreed most closely with Bentinck—Amherst, Maitland, Pellew—had had their doubts at first; they had seen some of the difficulties of the situation, and particularly the danger that Sicily might lapse into feudal reaction: 'these proud barons', they agreed, must be induced to 'lay aside *selfishness*; and take the *people* (not the mob) for something'. But they, as well as Bentinck, were quite satisfied on this score by the resolutions of July 20th. Not so Leckie: he complained bitterly that Bentinck had been deceived; the 'English' Constitution was 'one of the greatest fallacies ever exhibited'; it would lead to an 'unbalanced oligarchy' more oppressive to the mass of the people than the former despotic monarchy. Bentinck was sensitive to this charge, which French propaganda in Italy fastened on from the first, and he had it refuted in the official British paper: significantly, the article was written, not by a Sicilian, but by a professed agent of the Italian patriots, and described the Constitution as the symbol of a *risorgimento*, a raising up of the whole people to a better condition of life.*

To Bentinck these tokens of British commendation or blame mattered less than the official opinion of his Government. From Harrowby's outburst, already mentioned, and from Liverpool's later strictures, it is plain that those Ministers who considered the matter at all had no liking for the new constitution: they were ready if need be to explain it away as the by-blow of Bentinck's Whiggish enthusiasm. Castlereagh was more cautious: he had, in May, made constitutional reform one of Britain's official aims in Sicily; and he told Bentinck in September that

'under the corrections and alterations which some of the articles are susceptible of and appear to require, there is a fair prospect of Sicily holding out to Italy and to Naples the safe and honourable example of

a reformation without violence, and a regenerated constitution, under the sanction and with the aid of the legitimate sovereign'.

But there remained unresolved a lasting, and, one may say, a fatal ambiguity in Castlereagh's thinking. A statement of his in a Commons debate of April 1813 illustrates this. Whitbread had asked him whether the new measures taken in Sicily at Britain's suggestion were likely to give the people those political advantages which had been hoped for. 'It was a very great question', Castlereagh replied, 'which had been put to him'; the constitution was still incomplete, but

'he was sanguine enough to hope great advantages from it. He trusted it would prove beneficial to the Sicilians and their posterity, and secure their attachment to this country . . . this country had never attempted to exercise such a controlling power in Sicily as would be inconsistent with the independence of its government. It had been the endeavour of Ministers to unite the feelings of the people, and embark their whole means of defence in the common cause.'

Thus the Sicilian constitution could be seen in three different ways: as the outcome of deliberate British policy; as the hobby-horse of a Whiggish proconsul; or as the spontaneous achievement of the Sicilian people, with which Britain and her Minister had nothing to do. The trouble was that Castlereagh held all three views simultaneously, kept them all, as it were, in reserve; or if, as seems likely, this statement implies a greater and more calculated attention than he could give to Sicilian policy, one may say that he never thought out until too late which view the British Government should adopt. True, Sicily was far away and he had to leave Bentinck great latitude. But flexibility is one thing, letting matters take their course is another. That the Foreign Secretary should keep in mind, and prepare for, every eventuality was not the same thing as that he should scarcely realise or even inquire what his own policy was leading to.*

Meanwhile the Bases were only a beginning: the Constitution had yet to be worked out in detail; and the attitude of the Royal Family was still uncertain. They had been defeated in the attempt to avert a new constitution; they must now be made to acquiesce in their own defeat. This acquiescence Bentinck and

the Ministers decided to obtain at once. Even Cassaro was with them in this: Bentinck, he realised, having guaranteed that Parliament should not disturb the peace, was now entitled to demand that the Crown should not drive Parliament into violent opposition. In fact Parliament already looked like getting out of hand: only a week after the voting of the Bases, Bentinck had, at Belmonte's request, to go to the Demaniale lobby and urge moderation on the more radical members, who shewed signs of wanting to set themselves up as a Long Parliament of Sicily. Here Belmonte's own brother, Ventimiglia, was one of the leaders and another member—Sperlinga—threatened, if the Royal Assent was withheld, to move for a parliamentary committee to investigate the abuses of the previous regime. Bentinck and his friends, however, decided—partly as a sop to Cassaro, partly as a safeguard for the future—that the King, not the Prince, should give the Royal Assent to the Bases.*

The King, however, proved stubborn. Possibly the current report was true that he and the Queen had countenanced the English Constitution in the first place only because they had never expected Parliament to adopt it—the clergy would never agree to abolish their own Estate. At any rate the King, when Cassaro first approached him, began by threatening to dissolve Parliament and refusing to sanction any of the articles. Cassaro pointed out that Parliament had kept fairly closely to the English Constitution: 'but who wanted, he cried, the English Constitution?' The Queen agreed that *they* did not. On August 1st Bentinck himself saw the King for the first time since January. The King still said he would never sanction the Bases, 'mai mai mai'; he obviously thought the Parliament null and void, reform abhorrent, and Bentinck's acts unauthorised. He shifted his ground, however: he would sanction the English Constitution 'but this was neither carne nor pesce neither English nor Sicilian . . . he had not slept for 15 nights . . . his conversation was very much mixed with religion'. He tried to bargain with Bentinck—let Britain, he said, guarantee the safety of the whole Royal Family (meaning the Queen), as well as the Civil List—and 'no man royal or common ever played the beggar better'. But he found Bentinck, as he put it, 'like an inanimate statue of the hardest marble', and the interview ended

inconclusively. The King, however, was now isolated. On one side was the Queen, plagued as ever with visions of Marie-Antoinette's scaffold: '*YOU ARE LOST FINISHED DISHONOURED*', she fairly screamed in one of the notes that passed between them at La Ficuzza (underlining the last word nine times), 'if you accept this [instead of putting] an end to these infamous deeds of a government, of Baboons, and Scoundrels':

'the Tears, the blood, the harm to subjects entrusted to you by God, you want dishonour, you may have it, but to ruin Subjects, family, all and end dishonoured after 60 years, while you had the people, and the troops, on your side, I repeat to you, conquer this criminal poltroonery, awake from criminal lethargy, go tomorrow to Palermo, take up your duty again, or if not, expect the contempt, curse of a sacrificed people, of your ruined family, so much my duty forces me to tell you, praying God that He may enlighten you, your desperate afflicted most unhappy wife.'*

We should not underrate the effect of such outbursts on a man who liked a quiet life. But on the other side Cassaro urged the King to give way, and so did the wretched and flustered Prince, whom Bentinck's thunderings on the army question had deprived of any will to resist. Even so the King stood his ground as long as he could; he urged his son to dissolve Parliament and summon another to choose between the old Constitution and the English. In the end all he would consent to was to scribble a note authorising the Prince to sanction such articles as 'conformed absolutely to the English Constitution'.

There was reason to fear that this was one of the King's usual devices to avoid committing himself; but it is doubtful whether any oath or signature would have bound him. What did matter was that from then on he invariably insisted that the new constitution must not depart by one iota from the English. He probably had no very clear notion of what the English system was like—he later decided to send to England for an authoritative version—but it was at any rate known or ascertainable; it would set bounds on innovation; and it was something to which Bentinck could not easily object. The Prince's assent to the Bases was accordingly published on August 10th. By agree-

ment with Castelnuevo and Bentinck—who now attended an official meeting of the Council for the first time—the Prince vetoed the article concerning the Civil List and the administration by Parliament of the national revenue, and reserved judgement on the proposed compensation for feudal rights—this last in the hope that the Barons might later be induced to surrender their privileges outright.*

But the difficulties over the Royal Assent marked only the first act in the conflict that summer between Bentinck and the King. The second centred round the army question. The Sicilian Army was still not reorganised, and therefore the subsidy was still suspended. Bentinck decided after eight months' delay that the matter must be brought to a head. He had, on July 22nd, suggested a new and more binding Anglo-Sicilian treaty of alliance; he now demanded several specific measures. A Sicilian corps in British pay must be formed to serve outside Sicily—first in Spain, later if possible in Italy; then the Captain-General must be given greater powers, designed to get round Aci's meddling; and finally the King's Neapolitan Guards must be reduced and partly replaced by Sicilians. This last measure was aimed at the Queen, who supposedly pinned her hopes on the Guards' support if the King should attempt to resume power. The negotiations over the proposed treaty dragged on throughout August and into September. Meanwhile the army could not be paid, and the government were left at one time with only three days' bread and forage in hand. The Prince kept up his threats of resignation and his desperate appeals to his parents, but the King found his letters 'impertinent' and 'incomprehensible', while the Queen denounced him as 'a traitor, a revolutionary!' When the Prince tried to convince them, on the strength of fresh despatches from Castelcicala, that Bentinck had the full backing of the British Government, 'the answer sent back was that Castelcicala was either a fool or a traitor. The Hereditary Prince cried out *que diable puis-je faire*'. The King wanted to deal separately with Bentinck through Cassaro and Caccamo; once again he tried to bargain for a guarantee of the pure English Constitution and of the Civil List. He fought especially hard to keep his Guards intact; but once again he could not resist indefinitely, and once again he left the Prince the responsi-

bility of signing, on September 12th, a new treaty. This embodied all of Bentinck's demands, together with a British guarantee of the possession of Sicily—though not, as the Prince had wished, of Naples. The King might, and did, assert that the treaty was invalid without his own assent; he tried to undermine it through Castelvital, who was much more his personal ambassador in London than the Prince's, let alone the government's; but the treaty could not be undone.*

Bentinck now had in fact complete control over the Sicilian army; in a moment of optimism he foresaw that as soon as Parliament finished its work of constitution-making all Sicilian problems would be solved, and he would be able to join his 'distant flock'—'the best and dearest part of my army'—in Catalonia. To his Government he wrote that the new treaty 'may be said to have been made not only between the two sovereigns, but between the two nations, sealed by the unanimous gratitude of the Sicilians, and indissolubly fixed in the feelings of political interest, of liberty and of independence common to both'. To his friend Bunbury he had written a few days earlier: 'We are now masters and kings if you please.'*

Yet there was still one more act to come, and one more problem to be settled: the Queen's interference. Ever since January Bentinck had had to complain of delay and obstruction at almost every point: the new Ministry, the summoning and later the meeting of Parliament, the reorganisation of the army, the sanctioning of the Bases, the new treaty. The ostensible cause was the King's stubbornness: as he told the Prince:

'His Majesty, who had before renounced all business, now insisted upon seeing every paper, and directed every measure till at length the Government exhibited the singular spectacle of an ostensible head without any power, unable to decide upon any question, without the previous permission of a superior; and that superior at a distance from the capital, in no communication with the leading persons of the country, unacquainted with the temper and circumstances of the nation, and viewing them through the false medium of the passions and prejudices of the single person in whom he reposed confidence.'

The Queen, as usual, seemed the real source of the trouble. Everyone said so: the Prince repeated that 'if his mother was gone the King would be easily reconciled'; the King himself

had hinted something of the kind in the interview of August 1st; Cassaro and Caccamo kept saying that he really wished to send her away, but could not withstand her influence—‘if the King gave an opinion which the Queen disapproved’—Cassaro reported during the treaty negotiations—‘she gave him a nod and said that it went for a non-dit’. Cassaro also said the Queen’s emissaries were intriguing for fictitious protests against the new Constitution to be sent to Palermo from the provinces; a reputed agent of hers had recently thrown a bomb into the Parliament building; and rumour, as ever, had her plotting for the King’s return to power.*

Bentinck therefore felt he had ample grounds for demanding her utter removal from the political scene, taking up the question where he had left off in April. Occasion served him: he had received at the end of August Castlereagh’s instruction giving him complete discretion in matters concerning the Queen; and she herself had made a fatal slip during the interview of August 1st—when she and Bentinck had met face to face for the last time—by saying, in her distraction, that she meant to go to Vienna, and by asking for a frigate to take her away. In subsequent weeks she announced and cancelled her departure several times. Bentinck was of course all for it; but ‘desirable as this event might be’, he felt ‘very great reluctance to enforce it—at the Queen’s time of life, in the state of her health, and at this advanced season such an act might appear cruel’. In the letter to the King with which he opened his attack on September 13th, he accordingly referred only to ‘positive orders’ from his government which made it imperative that the Queen should remove to a greater distance from Palermo—that is, by implication, that she should part from her husband. It was the resistance this demand met with that raised Bentinck’s terms to include, first a verbal, then a written promise by the King of her departure from Sicily altogether.*

For this act ran its course like the other two—the limit of the King’s powers of resistance seems to have been a month or six weeks; this time he did not give in until October 25th. The tedious and familiar events recurred—the letters flying back and forth; the proofs tendered and refused; the Prince’s entreaties; the King’s stubbornness; the Queen’s fury; the am-

biguous shuttling to and fro of Cassaro and Caccamo, the Rosencrantz and Guildenstern of Sicily. As before, the Queen's debts complicated the issue. Who was to pay them if she left Sicily? When, somewhat later, Bentinck suggested that the King might, the Prince made a face 'expressive of the opinion that he would not give her a farthing'. Bentinck himself had no authority to pay them, and in any case he thought power, not money, was the Queen's object. Another difficulty was the way the King and Queen fastened on Castalcicala's reports from London—and in particular on what Castlereagh and the Prince Regent had said about the Queen. Castlereagh had told the Sicilian Ambassador, and was still telling him at that time, that the Queen ought to go away—perhaps not out of Sicily altogether, though he could promise nothing; but he was sure Bentinck would 'act with all due delicacy and forbearance'; the notion that force might be used against her was repugnant. The Regent had dropped some well-meaning remark to the effect that the Queen might come into Palermo now and again to see her family. The King and Queen took all this to mean that Bentinck had no powers to use force in the last resort: his threats and demands could therefore be discounted.* Faced with this opposition, Bentinck did contemplate the use of force: '... it was impossible for me to recede. My influence and authority depended upon the result'. On October 8th he considered sending troops to the neighbourhood of La Ficuzza and facing the King with the choice of abdicating or giving in; he even got Belmonte to draw up a form of abdication. If need be he was ready to expel the Queen bodily from the island, should the King refuse either alternative. After a further flurry of letters and talks Bentinck rode up to La Ficuzza on the 15th, with the form of abdication in his pocket; but the King would not see him, for fear of an attack of bile, and Bentinck had to deal with Father Caccamo.

'The question must be decided,' he told him; 'I had been burlato for the last six months by the Queen's continual declaration that she would go away... I had always known she would not and I told him now that until I came at the head of a British force she never would.'

He therefore gave the King an ultimatum: if he did not hear

from him by the 19th, 'I should consider myself to be at liberty to do what I pleased'.

The King gave way: Circello was called out of retirement; he and Cassaro together persuaded the Queen to go to Santa Margherita, in the southwestern part of Sicily, for the winter, and to announce her intention of going to Vienna in the spring. Negotiations went on for ten more days over the wording of the written promise which Bentinck now demanded from the King: Bentinck wanted the word 'assurance' to be included, while the King wished him to be merely 'informed' of the Queen's decision. Bentinck won in the end; even then the 'assurance' was signed, not by the King, but—according to true Bourbon practice—by Cassaro and Circello in his name.*

Bentinck was exasperated by this continuous succession of crises:

'I have found myself in very great embarrassment about the Queen,' he told Bathurst. 'I had quite made up my mind to take her away by force, fully convinced that, if the British Government would not support me, it was better for this country and for our own that I should rather be sacrificed than she allowed to remain. . . . They cannot resist decided language, and it is a pity that what has been so easily and so justly done should have been left undone for six years. The Hereditary Prince said to Belmonte the other day, *il n'a qu'à montrer ses dents et ils* (the King and Queen) *cederont tout de suite*. I have done my best to keep up all the forms and have sacrificed to the desired appearance of conciliation real and substantial advantages. If I had been empowered at first to have said 'this must be', I could have arranged in one month what has occupied a year, what has deprived Spain of the aid of many thousand men, and what has given to Sicily a much worse and more impracticable Constitution than she would otherwise have had. . . . I trust that the Government will not relax in anything, even the least trifle, respecting the final arrangement that I may make with the Queen. The way is not smooth at all. . . . There will always be abundant means with which she can put in practice her wicked and artful designs. She is I think now completely beat, if I am supported.'

At last Bentinck could look forward to leaving for Catalonia, where his staff officers were steadily clamouring for him to come and take charge. Now that the Queen was 'beat' he might be able before leaving to settle the whole internal Sicilian situation and even (he began to think) to reconcile the King to the Constitution.*

Parliament and the Constitution had, indeed, been constant sources of concern to Bentinck throughout this series of diplomatic crises. We have seen that in his opinion delay had produced a constitution much more impracticable than it need have been. In the same letter to Bathurst he had to complain, of the very Parliament to which three months earlier he had given such high praise, that there was 'but a very moderate proportion of public spirit among them'. Experience had taught him that a *Constitution octroyée* would have done better after all: 'at first all would have received with thanks whatever had been proposed, but by delay cabal and intrigue has got ahead and the Parliament has been entirely for a long time past out of all control'.* How had this come about?

The Parliamentary session of 1812, during which the Constitution was worked out, lasted from July 20th to November 4th; it revealed dissensions among the Patriots which, by choosing to adopt the English Constitution, they had only glossed over. Dividing lines were not always clear. There was, on institutional questions, the old split between, on the one hand, the conservative barons and their friends, led by Cassaro and the Archbishop of Palermo, and attached to baronial, ecclesiastical, sometimes to royal privileges; and on the other hand the strictly 'constitutional' majority led by Belmonte and Castelnovo. But these 'constitutionalists' were not always united; the new radical group which had emerged in the May elections to the *Demaniale*, the Ventimiglias and Sperlingas, sometimes led them into measures which the Ministers disapproved, or else broke away altogether. More important, on the feudal question there began to appear a split between Belmonte and Castelnovo, which was to grow in subsequent months and eventually to wreck the movement altogether.

The split originated partly in personal jealousies among the lesser members, and partly in differences of opinion and temperament between the two leaders themselves. Belmonte was brilliant and fertile in expedients, but—as Bentinck gradually came to see—he was not the man to be Prime Minister except in his own fancy. He had little notion of Ministerial leadership in Parliament: 'when he passed the doors of that House', he told the Barons, 'he forgot that he was the Minister of the Prince.

He came there as a Sicilian Baron and his duty was to his country.' This attitude—aristocratic at bottom, however veneered over with liberal ideas—was one cause of friction with the more systematic Castelnuevo. Early in the session Orleans complained that, partly through ill-health, partly through his princely neglect of details, Belmonte was losing his grip on his followers; after the first few weeks he attended Parliament less and less often, until towards the end he scarcely turned up at all. He was just as nonchalant in matters of day-to-day administration: 'business was not his fort', Orleans complained; 'he would neither write nor read. His delight was in lounging and conversation.' Besides, he was as usual quite unable to impose unity on his colleagues, and all too ready to fall back on Bentinck for support. Bentinck and Orleans would meet and shake their heads together over their friend's shortcomings: his vanity, they agreed, blinded him to the dangers of the situation; though he was still supremely confident of his own ability to manage everyone and everything, Prince and Parliament, his followers were practically out of hand and 'nobody [was] so humbugged by the Hereditary Prince as Belmonte himself'.

Then it was that Bentinck began to prize Belmonte less as a politician, and Castelnuevo more. Castelnuevo had the virtues of Belmonte's defects; but he had adopted 'the unalterable system of not giving in to anyone or on any issue when he believed truth and reason to lie on his side'. This was shewn in his management of the finances: moved (as the Prince put it) by 'a morality too philosophique', he refused at one time to pay out the army credits, on the ground that the State's debts were not yet all discharged: until that was done, 'there were no credits'. On that occasion and on others he tried to resign and had to be dissuaded by his friends. Bentinck thought him 'wrong-headed' in this: still 'it would be a great pity to lose him . . . a man of the same character for integrity and firmness was not to be found—I regretted in some respects his inflexibility—If I could remake him, I would alter him, but as he was he must be taken and he was the man of all others calculated to establish the public credit.'*

As the split between Castelnuevo and Belmonte became more obvious, Bentinck took to lecturing them and the other Ministers

on the need for solidarity. They ought to realise that 'one department was inseparably connected with another'. The Government, he complained, 'has in fact no power and energy—they are afraid of the people—the Parliament is the same—they all want character'. Castelnuevo was too austere to be popular, while Belmonte 'did not see the necessity of collecting round him a strong party—the consequence was that the Parliament was under no guidance and were doing what they pleased'. In fact the whole political system was far too fluid: 'there must be two parties—those who had the places—and those who had not and wanted them . . .'. But if the idea of a strict two-party system was new enough in England, it was quite unthinkable in Sicily: Bentinck might grumble, but he could not alter the existing confusion.*

In the proceedings of Parliament Bentinck seldom interfered directly. He did once or twice, at Belmonte's invitation, lecture the more intemperate members—they of course protested that 'they wished to do nothing disagreeable' to him, but little came of it. One member of the Demaniale was a paid British agent, and as 'he was supposed to speak my sentiments' Bentinck arranged that they should meet to concert his attitude to specific measures. But on the whole Bentinck confined himself to giving advice in conversation with members and Ministers; in fact the constitutional leaders complained that he was too reticent and did not interfere enough.* Only at the end of the session did he throw his weight into the scales: and then on a matter which, typically, stirred Belmonte and Orleans all the more because it touched their interests rather than their principles.

At the end of October the Demaniale passed the new Civil List: after the usual fashion of Civil Lists it provided separately for each adult member of the Royal Family. But when the bill went to the two upper Estates some members threatened to amend it so as to give the whole of the Civil List to the King and let him look after the distribution. Cassaro and the Archbishop of Palermo, apparently, were behind this move, together with a boon companion of the King's, the Prince of Pantelleria; and their inspiration could be traced easily enough to La Ficuzza. All this quickly threw Orleans into high alarm (then as later nothing moved Louis-Philippe like money); the Prince,

too, faced with the prospect of being kept in leading-strings by his parents, became 'very reasonable' and talked of proroguing Parliament on some pretext before the fatal amendment could be carried; his sister Marie-Amélie, for her part, was 'very much montée . . . sure if left to the King and Queen they would get nothing'. Of course they all looked to Bentinck for help; and Belmonte automatically complained that Bentinck had not interfered even though he himself, by neglecting Parliament and allowing dissension to grow between his followers and Castelnovo's, had given Cassaro and the Archbishop their chance. Nor was this all: not interest merely but principle also agitated Parliament. The Demaniale claimed—mistakenly, for the English Constitution was not yet in force—that the other two Estates had no right to amend money bills, and it sent the Barons a message to say so; at which the Barons were furious and drew up a counter-remonstrance. Bentinck, visited by one after another of these men with a grievance, was annoyed: 'the fault', he told Belmonte, 'had been that the Ministers had not been united. They opposed each other in the House—I could only support them as an administration, it being their business to lead the House.' Still, if they could gain time 'I was sure I could obtain a majority'. This he set about doing by means both informal and official. He argued with Cassaro, who hastened to put the blame on Pantelleria but still seemed afraid to offend the King; he tackled Butera, the wayward but influential first baron of Sicily; on Belmonte's advice he wrote a Note opposing the amendment, which the Prince could lay before Parliament (the grounds for this unwonted interference being that changes in the Civil List would affect the Army supply). Meanwhile Lady William Bentinck had canvassed Princess Cassaro on Marie-Amélie's behalf. Forty-eight hours after the original alarm Parliament met in the evening and sat until 3 p.m. on the following day; Butera made a long speech against the amendment in the Militare; the Civil List was finally carried according to the original draft; and so the situation was saved.*

The chief matters for dispute in the three months' debate on the new Constitution were: the powers of the legislative and executive branches; the freedom of the press; judicial and administrative reform; and, most important, whether in the back-

ground or in the open, the abolition of feudal rights, in particular the question of entail. The one major question on which all were united was, as before, the independence of Sicily.*

English Constitution or no, it became clear early in the session that Parliament meant to depart from it—and from Balsamo's draft—over the executive and legislative powers. True, Anglomania was as strong as ever: members paid lip-service to the English model and used it as a justification, claiming that unless the executive was hemmed in on every side it would reduce Sicily to slavery 'like England in the time of Henry VIII'.* But their motives were plain fear of the Crown; in some quarters, a new interest in French and Spanish constitutional doctrine; in others a desire to preserve the financial and administrative control which the Barons had exercised through the old Deputation. For these reasons Parliament adopted once again the article (vetoed out of the Bases by the Prince) which vested the Crown lands and revenues in the nation. This time their administration was left, on Castelnuevo's advice, to the executive; but the spirit if not the letter of parliamentary dictatorship prevailed, so that when the time came to vote supply, Castelnuevo as a matter of course did no more than present his accounts, leaving it to Parliament to distribute taxation. In the same way Parliament, while it adopted the structure and procedure of Westminster wholesale, interpreted the Commons' right of arrest, trial and impeachment rather in the spirit of 17th century than of early 19th century English practice; it tended to follow the Spanish model in making nearly all Government servants ineligible; and the radicals would have made Parliament appoint to all offices. In the end Ministers were not, as in Spain, excluded; but once again the spirit of the new constitution was such that they had scarcely more initiative or authority than any other member. Still departing from Balsamo's draft, and against the strong advice of Castelnuevo and Belmonte, Parliament lowered the property qualification for electors and candidates, and freed the municipal councils almost entirely from central control. None the less the Crown was given a real power of veto; so that formally the executive was no weaker than in England. What was missing was any notion of Cabinet government.*

All this made Bentinck uneasy. He had no wish to see Parliament enthroned as the arbiter of the new constitution. In fact he shewed a moderate spirit rather at variance with the flamboyant tone of some of his despatches. When, for instance, Aci argued with him that the Lockian doctrine of legitimate resistance to royal authority ought to be included in the Constitution, he replied that 'there was no necessity to sanction those acts which were acts of revolution, perhaps necessary, by law'. He told Anjou—one of the five Barons arrested in 1811, now a prominent radical—that present fear of the Crown ought not to influence Parliament:

'They were now legislating for Posterity . . . though there was now an interest different from that of their Nation, that must cease hereafter . . . a broad line must be drawn between Executive and Parliament . . . the Executive would not have the responsibility they ought and the Houses of Parliament would be a scene of perpetual intrigue.' But 'I did not convince him'.*

Bentinck's attitude was much the same on the other two institutional questions which agitated Parliament, the Press law and the reform of the judicial and administrative system. He had originally approved, because of 'the debased state of this society', the restrictions placed on the freedom of the Press in Balsamo's draft. But when the radical group in the Demaniale voted to make the Press quite free, and when, after a conflict with the Ecclesiastico, a compromise was reached freeing all but religious publications, he did not object: not because he approved the principle—he apparently did not—but because it seemed as well to let Parliament have its way unchecked and uncriticised in matters not of the first import.*

As for judicial and administrative reform, it was the occasion for the first serious disagreement between the constitutional leaders. Castelnovo and Balsamo had devised a plan to divide Sicily into 23 districts, each with its own court, sheriff and other officials. The districts were to be drawn less arbitrarily than the French Departments; all the same, Castelnovo, so far as he meant to impose uniformity on a country ridden with multiple jurisdictions, seemed to accept some of the administrative practices of the new France even while he rejected its political doctrine. He also claimed—though dubiously—that his plan

would strengthen the judiciary against the interference of powerful individuals. Inevitably the plan ran into opposition: from Palermo, whose many lawyers—strong in Parliament—saw their livelihood threatened by the setting up of new courts elsewhere; from a number of other towns, which kept up the enduring spirit of Italian municipal rivalry and feared domination by their neighbours. Belmonte took sides with the opponents of the plan; and Bentinck too argued against Castelnuevo that it would prove cumbersome, expensive and hard on the poorer districts—they had better have half the magistrates and pay them well. In the end Parliament passed the plan in part; but the whole question was left unsettled, as was that of the new criminal and civil codes; in fact judicial reform was never completed or properly tackled until the Restoration period, when the Constitution itself had been destroyed.*

The rock on which the Patriotic movement split beyond mending was the feudal question. The abolition of feudalism on July 20th has long been a matter for debate. Some have held that it was largely a gesture and did not effectually cut down—was not in fact meant to cut down—the social and economic power of the Barons. In this view the whole movement of opinion among the Sicilian parliamentary classes in these years, and its culminating point the 1812 Constitution, came to no more than an attempt by the Barons to defend their position against the inroads of the central government, even to strengthen it. By converting feudal tenure into personal property—so the argument runs—they gave up more burdens than they did benefits; they exacted compensation for the loss of local privileges like tolls and monopolies; and they saw to it that the nobility as a class and a power in Parliament was kept intact.* But this seems too simple. The night of July 20th was a time of high excitement; Castelnuevo's followers, and even for a time Belmonte's, were swayed by the thought of the Enlightenment; in latter years, too, their cause had seemed to develop into a national one. So far as we can judge their motives many of the barons did at first believe they were abdicating their privileged position in the State. None the less there was already a conflict between conservatives like Cassaro and reformers like Castelnuevo. As the initial fervour faded away the conflict spread; an

increasing number of barons began to take fright at what they had done; gradually they slid back into the conservative camp.

Parliament, under Castelnovo's influence, did confirm the abolition of feudal privileges, this time without compensation. But the opposite tendency manifested itself in an article abolishing common rights on former feudal lands—a step akin in its effects to the contemporary English enclosures. The clash came when Castelnovo's followers proposed the abolition of entails (*fidecommessi*). Members at once recognised how important was this proposal. They might and did quote Blackstone at one another in debating it; but they seem to have been clear in their minds that what was at stake was the survival of the barons as the exclusive ruling class. On one side Castelnovo and Balsamo foresaw that abolition would lead to an increase in small property and to the rise of a new class of middling landholders, like the English gentry the pillars of the Constitution: this meant the partial break-up of great estates. Cassaro, on the other side, was extremely worried: he hoped Bentinck 'would not permit the nobility to be destroyed.' All the same the issue was not quite so clear-cut. Many barons, burdened with debts and mortgages, might have welcomed a chance to alienate their lands: but they were 'moved less by private interest . . . than by vanity and class considerations or prejudices'. In the end the majority of the Barons voted against abolition 'for fear of seeming enemies to their own order and degenerate sons of their illustrious ancestors'—had the vote been secret, thought Castelnovo, it would have gone the other way. As the other two Estates voted for abolition, the question stood unresolved.*

But politically the conflict had already had far-reaching effects. The split now ran not only between Castelnovo and Cassaro, but between Castelnovo and Belmonte. For Belmonte, whether from a desire to conciliate the Barons, or from his own aristocratic leanings, voted against abolition, as did his followers. The full consequences were not felt at once; but the question—which was, indeed, fundamental—remained a source of dissension. In the next few months it was to split the constitutional majority into 'Belmontisti' and 'Villermosisti' (so called after Castelnovo's other title, Villermosa), and gradually to estrange the two leaders.*

Bentinck took little part in this stage of the debate. His sympathies were with Castelnovo, for he too thought the barons were unpopular and their privileges a burden to the country. It is not clear whether he already despaired of their political capacity—as he was later to do—and therefore, like Castelnovo, wished the middle classes to come into a greater share of political power. But it was bad enough that the dispute over the feudal question should have still further split the Ministry.*

'The Barons wanted an aristocracy, and . . . all wanted to avoid paying', said the Prince about this time. He was right, at any rate, about the Sicilians' willingness to pay: only at the very end of the session did Parliament bring itself to vote even an unsatisfactory budget. The economic situation was no better than before: the grain shortage continued, leading here and there to riots;* and Castelnovo's patriarchal notion of political economy only matched the antiquated financial structure of Sicily—a state with no modern system of banking or tax-collecting and no funded debt, quite unable to bear the strain of a long war even with a British subsidy. To these difficulties were added the reluctance of Parliament, first to vote supply at all for fear of a dissolution, then to vote adequate supply; and Castelnovo's own reluctance—whether from delicacy or for fear of unpopularity—to put pressure on Parliament. The upshot was that the deficit remained almost as large as before.*

This was a serious disappointment to Bentinck; and so was the failure of Parliament to do much for the Sicilian Army except keep Neapolitans out of it. 'They want the most contradictory things,' he complained; 'they first vote that foreigners shall not be employed in the army, they next vote that no Sicilian shall be forced to serve. . . . They then desire a large army and navy but will not vote any money for it.' Still, Parliament was over by November 5th and the Constitution made. After several stormy months, Sicily lay for a few weeks in the doldrums.

Early in December Bentinck foresaw that in about a fortnight the Royal Assent to the Constitution would be published. The next step would take him to Spain.*

CHAPTER IV

THE KING'S RETURN: THE QUEEN'S DEPARTURE

Unhappily for Bentinck what happened in the winter of 1812-13 was not his own departure for Spain; it was the King's return to Palermo and his attempt to resume power. The resulting crisis lasted from December to April: if it proved to be the longest and fiercest yet, that was because it brought to a head not only Bentinck's contention with the Royal Family but also the conflicts that had for some time been growing up among the patriotic Ministers and their followers. The ostensible question was whether the King or the Prince should rule; the real question, whether the new 'system', launched with British help and now embodied in the Constitution, should stand.

The King's decision to delegate his powers in January 1812 had been an accident: Bentinck, taken by surprise, neither able nor willing to press the King to the point of abdication, had accepted it. Since then nothing had, on the face of it, prevented the King from putting an end to the Vicariate at any moment. He had not done so; all the same Bentinck had been unable to preserve the new 'system' from continual trouble and delay, due in part to the King's obstruction.

Now, at the beginning of November 1812, Bentinck held in his hand what looked like several strong cards. He had just exacted the 'promise' of the Queen's departure; Parliament had risen, and the Constitution, which it had at length drawn up, seemed likely to be no longer a matter for dispute. Yet Bentinck was aware that the King's means of interference were not exhausted; he wished before leaving for Spain to improve on his latest victory by reconciling the King once and for all to the existing state of affairs. No sooner, indeed, had he exacted the 'promise' than he hinted to Caccamo that Ferdinand 'the Queen gone would make an excellent King. He had a good understanding and an honest heart.' Why should he not leave his self-imposed retreat at La Ficuzza to come and shoot at La Favorita, the royal villa near Palermo? 'I would carry the King's gun for him.'*

The King's own intentions, however, were not clear. There was certainly talk of his returning to power; the Queen continued to agitate for it from her own retreat at Santa Margherita; and Bentinck foresaw that she would do all she could to evade the 'promise'. But when the Archbishop suggested to the King that he should at any rate return to Palermo, he 'put his hand upon the Archbishop's mouth and said Tace Monsignor. . . . What I am doing is right and one day you will be of the same opinion.*' No less difficult was it to make out the King's attitude from the behaviour of the Prince. The various crises of the summer and autumn, throughout which the Prince had been the helpless advocate of compliance, had left a coolness between father and son. The Prince now put on a tentative show of independence; when Orleans advised him to be *l'homme des Anglais* 'si vous voulez rester sur votre throne' he 'made a face and said—Je le veux bien'. The King complained that he was kept in the dark; he threatened to wash his hands of the whole business: the ratification of the new treaty, the sanctioning of the Constitution—his son might attend to them alone and take the consequences. Yet the Prince was more dilatory than ever: the Constitution awaited his assent, but Bentinck—now an *ad hoc* member of the Council—was shortly to complain that in three months there had been three Councils on the subject. All the Ministers complained of the Prince's distrust and mania for detail, which slowed down the course of business almost to a standstill. He conferred with subordinate officials without telling their Ministers; he sent for paper after paper until the departments ran out of despatch-bags, and he kept the papers for weeks without doing anything about them. The Ministers had found, on taking office, that many of their subordinates were hostile to the new 'system'; but they could not induce the Prince to replace them: as usual, he promised much but performed little. And over one important appointment the Prince, as will be seen, seemed determined to thwart Bentinck and the constitutional leaders.*

The only explanation Bentinck could find for these difficulties was that the King was still interfering and still unreconciled. As Orleans put it,

'The King was at present as it were retired into his citadel from whence he was ready to make a sortie whenever he pleased, waiting for the turn of events and encouraging by his hostile position all those who were unfavourable to the Constitution.'

How was this state of affairs to be remedied? Orleans and Belmonte suggested on December 17th that Bentinck should present the King with these alternatives: he should either resume power, or else give his 'decided countenance' to the Prince's administration. Bentinck doubted whether the King's 'countenance' would in fact turn the Prince into a satisfactory ruler; but it seems he was already toying with the notion of bringing back the King on terms that would put an end to delay and dissension.*

For what moved Orleans and Bentinck to make their suggestion was the split within the Government. This was no news, but it had lately gone so far that the Government could scarcely carry on as it stood. Bentinck was losing patience: 'although Belmonte was always complaining of the backwardness of the English . . . the Ministers must be the principals . . . the British Minister could only be an auxiliary'. The Ministers, he insisted, must work together at all costs; if they did not, England could do no more, short of assuming the government; as it was 'we appeared to have everything our own way and to have all the power in our hands while in fact we had nothing at all—We had our own Ministers, but they were not united together did not know how to manage business and had no power over the Prince'.*

Aci and Bentinck had been at odds for months; but since the end of Parliament Aci had come into conflict with Castelnuevo as well, over the Army credits which the 'too philosophique' Castelnuevo refused to pay out. This quarrel became further embittered in December when Castelnuevo proposed various appointments designed to give him effectual control over his own department, among them that of Balsamo as Under-Secretary (*Direttore*). The Prince objected to Balsamo as a 'republican'; when Castelnuevo threatened to resign Aci urged the Prince to seize the opportunity of getting rid of his inflexible and 'democratic' Finance Minister. Bentinck came to the rescue with the usual expedient of suspending a loan—Castelnuevo's

hold on the public purse-strings, he said, was a security essential to the British Government. But the Prince shewed unexpected powers of resistance: was one thing after another, he cried, to be extorted from him by Bentinck's 'couteau à la gorge'? At the New Year the matter was still unsettled. Bentinck had, however, decided that Aci must go: 'His opposition to me I forgive—but his attempt to get rid of Villarmosa to put in his place a creature of his own I shall never pardon.' He guessed that Aci was 'achetable': he did not know that for the last five months Aci had been conducting a secret correspondence with the King.*

If personal jealousy and spite accounted for Aci's defection, Cassaro's was a symptom of deeper differences among the patriots. He, too, opposed Balsamo's appointment, but he did so because in the Parliamentary debates Balsamo had supported the abolition of entail. When at the end of December the Prince seemed on the point of giving way to Bentinck and Castelnovo over the appointment, Cassaro tried to resign, but was dissuaded by the Prince and by Bentinck himself. Bentinck was at pains to puzzle him out: 'his prejudices against the new system I had seen with concern, but I respected his integrity and always recollected with pleasure his uprightness and firmness under the administration of the Queen'. Cassaro was, he thought at one moment, 'an honest man in his way . . . he liked the old system well administered'. Yet his behaviour was disquieting: he had begun to complain that the Prince was a hopeless failure as a ruler, while he hinted that 'the King was now as desirous of governing as he had been all his life averse to it'. Bentinck began to reconsider his estimate: Cassaro was (he decided at the end of December) 'a very ambitious man . . . in the last administration he could not bear Ascoli—now Belmonte. He is violent and cannot command his temper. . . . He sees no chance of being Prime Minister.'*

Here Bentinck put his finger on a part of Cassaro's motives: the fact was—and Bentinck took a surprisingly long time to find it out—that Cassaro was the chief engineer of the King's attempt to resume power. He may well have been moved by jealousy and thwarted ambition, as Bentinck and the Prince believed; and he managed for a while to throw a smoke-screen

about his intentions. But although constitutional issues seldom came to the surface in the ensuing crisis, they were there all the same and they mattered at least as much as personal motives. Cassaro's action meant at bottom that after much ambiguous behaviour—and perhaps real hesitation—he was seceding from the Patriots outright and going over to the King in opposition to the constitutional leaders, Belmonte and Castelnovo. Other great noblemen—people like the Prince of Trabia and the former Lord Mayor of Palermo, San Marco—also moved closer to the King about this time. Some of them had, like Cassaro, defended baronial liberties in the past; we must suppose that in their minds the abolition of feudalism (and its more effective corollary, the abolition of entail which they feared would 'democratise Sicily') now outweighed the political advantages of the new Constitution: the King seemed their last refuge.* Ferdinand, of course, had his own reasons for wishing to forestall the sanctioning of the Constitution: the loss of the Royal Domain in exchange for a Civil List, and—most important—the separation of Sicily from Naples, were measures he could never stomach.

Such was the confused and perplexing situation when on January 4th the Queen produced a *coup de théâtre* by returning to the King's side at La Ficuzza. She acted most likely on her own impulse—or as she put it by the will of God—though Bentinck disbelieved it. Cassaro at any rate had tried to dissuade her; he deplored her coming as likely to complicate matters unnecessarily by antagonising Bentinck from the start. As for the King, his wife's move put him (according to Caccamo) 'nel inferno': 'I am in the situation of Tantalus', he said, 'I know what I ought to do, I wish to do it, but I cannot do it.' What in fact ensued—and Bentinck was not at once aware of it—was a backstage tug-of-war between the Queen and Cassaro, with each of them trying to make the King resume on his or her terms: Cassaro telling the King that 'tutti i buoni' desired his return, but that he ought first to send the Queen away again; she hoping by the King's return to undo the 'promise', forestall her own expulsion and regain her influence. The King's inability to make up his mind between these alternatives prolonged the crisis.*

About this intestine conflict at La Ficuzza Bentinck was at

first in the dark; and Cassaro, who as usual acted as go-between, managed to keep him there for some time. Bentinck was faced with two happenings, which seemed related but need not be equally objectionable: the breach of the 'promise', and the King's desire to resume power. About the former there could be no doubt: when the King tried to explain it away—he had merely stated the Queen's intention of going, and if she now changed her mind he could not help it—Bentinck lost no time in shewing 'very great anger . . . for the indecency and meanness of this attempt to declare nugatory a solemn assurance of the King certified by persons of such respectability as Prince Cassaro and Marquis Circello'.* But the King's wish to return to power was another matter: Bentinck might use it as a lever to obtain the Queen's removal and the fulfilment of the 'promise': and this he tried to do during the next six weeks. Besides (Bentinck began to think) the King's return, if properly managed, might even be useful in itself as a settlement of the whole Sicilian situation.

In the first place, the King was popular, as Bentinck tried to convince Orleans:

'I said there were four points upon which there was a very general sentiment in this country:

1. Popularity of the King
2. Hatred to the Neapolitans
3. Do. — — Queen
4. Dislike of the Barons.

He did not believe the first and last. I asked him how it could be otherwise with the general oppression exercised by the latter and their refusal at all times to contribute to the public burthens. He was not convinced. He said it had always been the policy of the Court to destroy the Barons and their privileges thinking by that means more easily to govern—this had been the object of Caracciolo's administration.*

The Prince had, on the contrary, so lost whatever popularity he had had that the King's return would (Bentinck thought) be greeted with joy. True, the Prince had latterly seemed to acquiesce in the truism that (as Orleans kept telling him) 'when a sovereign for his protection received from a foreign power a large subsidy and a large force, that sovereign could not be called independent'; he appeared genuinely to desire the Queen's departure; and whether he liked the Constitution or not, he

had 'neither ability nor courage enough to attempt its destruction'. But this very weakness was a disadvantage so long as the Prince remained open to his parents' pressure. The King, on the other hand, would be his own master, provided his wife was absent; and although Bentinck thought it would never suit him to resume as 'he had been a despot all his life had never attended to business and could never give up his old habits and prejudices', yet this legendary idleness (in which Bentinck plausibly but mistakenly believed) might mean that, if the King did resume, he would subside into a King Log and let the constitutional machine run without hindrance. Above all, Bentinck still thought him 'the innocent instrument of the Queen's will'; if he could be got to Palermo alone, the 'fatal charm' might be broken, and the King reconciled to the new 'system'.*

It took six weeks' negotiations to undeceive Bentinck. At first he was prepared to act moderately; he objected to Belmonte's and Orleans' policy of 'frightening' the King and his associates; he refused to be drawn (as the Queen hoped he would be) into making it a condition *sine qua non* that she and her husband should live apart. As he later pointed out to Cassaro,

'I must be always prepared for my defence . . . I was liable to be attacked in England . . . I was threatened with the publication of everything in Russia and Germany, and therefore I could let nothing pass without its refutation.'*

He began with a Note (15 January) to Cassaro and Circello, recalling the King's 'parole sacrée' and requesting that the Queen should go back to Santa Margherita. He had already privately suggested to the King, through Caccamo, three possible courses: he might live with the Queen at a considerable distance from Palermo; or he might abdicate, in which case the Queen would be free to go where she chose; or he might come to Palermo and resume power if he wished, provided the Queen fulfilled the 'promise'. There was no reply for a fortnight: confusion reigned at La Ficuzza: the Queen refused to budge, and the King did his best to dodge the issue.* On the advice of Cassaro (who apparently hoped thus to frighten the King into action) Bentinck wrote a second and stronger Note (29 January) in which he stated that so far the British Government had considered the

Queen alone 'comme ennemie des intérêts de l'Angleterre, comme cause de tous les désastres de la Sicile'; but now the King's breach of promise had placed him in a position hostile to the interests of both countries, and might lead to the most disastrous consequences for him and his family. Bentinck therefore demanded prompt action. This Note had the effect Cassaro desired: the King decided on February 2nd that he would go to La Favorita, near Palermo, and the Queen to Castelvetro in south-western Sicily. On the 6th he arrived at La Favorita: to Orleans he 'spoke . . . with horror of the 14 months he had passed [at La Ficuzza] . . . he was now in a paradiso'.*

But the situation was not so rosy as the King thought. Outmanoeuvred by Cassaro, the Queen still refused to leave La Ficuzza: snow, she said, made the roads impassable; and she went on urging her husband to resume at once. Bentinck, on the other hand, refused to see the King while the 'promise' remained unfulfilled. On the 10th he got a reply to his Notes from Cassaro and Circello: this amounted to a blank denial that there had ever been any promise, and a rejection of his charges. Orleans and Belmonte urged a strong reply; but Bentinck preferred to enter into conversations with Circello and Cassaro. The outcome was a mutual withdrawal of Notes, and a fresh and more conciliatory reply by Cassaro and Circello, in which they promised that the Queen would go to Castelvetro as soon as the snow thawed.*

Meanwhile the Prince and the Government had been carrying on as best they could. Councils on the Royal Assent to the Constitution were held in the intervals of the political crisis, and the Prince even seemed, for the first time, in a hurry to get the business over. He kept aloof from the crisis, but was obviously displeased with Cassaro for attempting to play Grand Vizier, so much so that he shewed favour to Belmonte and even to Castelvetro. At the same time the conflict between Aci and Castelvetro over the appointment of Balsamo had come to a head. Aci was now openly on the King's side; relations between him and Bentinck became more and more strained until, at the end of one heated exchange, 'di Aci continued to talk but I took my hat and walked out of the room'; the man was (Bentinck decided) 'a miserable dirty fellow'. Aci finally resigned

at the end of January, with a flourish: 'surely', he cried, 'the English Minister was not to govern Sicily . . . he was no intriguer . . . he cared not what priests were made Archbishops or Abbots or Archangels . . . if he had listened to the calls of ambition he might have been the first man in Sicily . . . his influence over the King might have made him Prime Minister years ago.' After a fortnight's delay due to the Prince's customary doubts and fears, Ruggiero Settimo, a friend of Castelnovo's, was appointed in Aci's place. Thus three out of the four Ministers were now staunch constitutionalists; while the fourth, Cassaro, continued to hint that he too would presently resign, or else become Prime Minister if the King resumed power.*

For the King was still thinking of resuming. Cassaro brought the matter up during the negotiations with Bentinck (13-18 February) which led to a mutual withdrawal of Notes and a momentary *détente*. Bentinck realised that he could not openly object, nor did he as yet particularly wish to. Nevertheless, he told Cassaro, he had made himself responsible for the tranquillity of Sicily, and he must therefore demand of the King an undertaking to sanction the Constitution and to make no great change of men or measures for some time. Cassaro agreed, with the proviso that the King would sanction the Constitution so far as it conformed to the English—in fact he meant to send it to England for examination; this made Bentinck uneasy, for it implied a long delay. Cassaro also declared that the King could not accept the separation of Sicily from Naples, as it was quite contrary to the 'English system'. The representative of the United Kingdom could not press this point officially; but as a matter of 'private sentiment' he strongly urged that it should be accepted. Bentinck, however, still doubted whether the King would resume, and thought that if he did, he would most likely find the work too much for him, and would end by abdicating or restoring the Vicariate.*

But these exchanges were only informal; and Bentinck was in two minds whether to approach the King direct. He was reluctant to leave the King wholly in the hands of Aci and the other enemies of the Ministry, who were now clustering about him at La Favorita; on the other hand a letter setting out Bentinck's terms for resumption might seem an invitation,

especially as 'I knew he would make no difficulty about the terms'. Besides, Bentinck still would not see the King while the Queen remained at La Ficuzza. When, however, Bentinck did sound Cassaro officially on February 24th, Cassaro replied that the King meant to resume at once, whether the Queen went away or not; since Bentinck refused to see him, the King would have '*le déplaisir de n'entendre que postérieurement de Votre Excellence ce qu'il aurait désiré savoir avant de reprendre le gouvernement*'.*

What had happened is still not clear. One conjecture, put forward at the time by the Prince, was that the King had promised the Queen to resume power when he returned to Palermo on February 6th; finding himself still caught between the twin intransigences of the Queen and Bentinck, he had changed his mind. 'The Queen's answer was rage', however, and now the King had given in to her; 'the present plan as he believed made by di Aci was to resume and to endeavour to upset the Constitution by Parliamentary numbers.' Another possible explanation is that the King was induced by Cassaro to gamble on Bentinck's making no effective resistance, and was encouraged by some 'pleasant' news he received from Castelcicala on February 23rd: the contents of Castelcicala's despatch are not known, but he very likely reported Castlereagh as saying or implying that Bentinck was not empowered to use force.*

Whatever the reasons for this sudden decision, it shook the scales from Bentinck's eyes. He now saw 'the impossibility of placing even the least reliance on His Majesty's word or good faith'; he quarrelled with Cassaro—in whom he at last detected the chief instigator of the King's move—and told him that 'if the King resumed I was determined to enlever the Queen':

'This was a trial of strength. It was the first effort of a long and concerted plan to destroy the system of liberty, to which in every part of its progress every impediment had hitherto been thrown, but in vain.'*

He refused to deal with Cassaro any longer; negotiations would henceforth be carried on through regular channels, that is, through Belmonte. To him Bentinck announced that 'it was necessary that I should not be compelled to retreat a step'.

Bentinck's prevailing mood was confidence: 'in such crises as these I had always gained more than I had asked.' Might he not either prevent the King from resuming, or else carry out his threat to expel the Queen by force? Yet on second thoughts he decided to continue negotiations. The fact was that Bentinck's position was hazardous. The Sicilians seemed useless—they were all afraid and would do nothing . . . they were run already to kiss the King's feet . . . on the side of the Nation and of liberty not a man would stir—we were now completely the principals.' The recent split had disheartened as well as weakened his friends; and he was no more certain of support at home. Ministers were 'slippery chaps' at best; presently he heard from Nugent, who had just arrived from London, that

'it was very comical to remark the conduct of Ministers in England about Sicily. They were very anxious . . . to see *what had been done next* and who was to get the better—as if the business was entirely left as far as regarded them to itself'.*

Here the King uttered one of his Neapolitan *boutades*, which so impressed Bentinck that he underlined it heavily in his journal and (perhaps as a hint) in his despatch to Castlereagh:

'But that's what the English always do,' the King exclaimed when Belmonte tried to convince him that Bentinck was following instructions; 'they let their Minister act as he pleases; if he succeeds they approve him; if not they break his neck.'*

There was enough truth in this to make Bentinck keenly alive to the dangers of proconsulship in his present circumstances.

Bentinck's verbal threat to 'enlever' the Queen made the King put off his resumption until she should have left La Ficuzza. Negotiations went on. In his first Note to Belmonte (26 February) Bentinck laid down his terms for the King's return: they were those he had put verbally to Cassaro a week earlier, but included—besides guarantees of the 'promise', of the Constitution, and of a constitutional Ministry—an undertaking to summon Parliament by April. The King's answer (1 March), like Cassaro's, accepted these terms in principle but insisted on the pure English Constitution, and on his constitutional prerogative to choose his own Ministers.

'His Majesty', Bentinck commented, 'had no difficulty in giving a general assent to future measures which not requiring immediate execution might hereafter be evaded. We were now at one of the moments the most critical for the successful establishment of the constitution. It was upon the point of being sanctioned and carried into execution. I was deeply impressed with the King's ill will and bad faith. To overturn the constitution by force he knew to be impossible—but it was easy to attack it by sap—to get rid of the Ministers one by one—to bring in by means of the Sheriffs, all in Prince Cassaro's nomination and under his influence, to whom the first formation of the lists of the electors is entrusted under the constitution, persons attached to the old Court party. It became necessary to put the King's sincerity to the test, to discountenance this bold and menacing behaviour—and to obtain such a Ministry as would give confidence to the public, and would not be blindly subservient to the King's projects.'*

In fact, Bentinck was determined to stop the King, if he could, from resuming at all; the Prince he now thought 'infinitely preferable'.

Bentinck therefore raised his terms: he demanded (3 March) that the date of the Queen's departure for Vienna—announced for the spring—should be fixed, and that Cassaro should be dismissed.* The King (6 March) evaded the first demand and refused the second. To Belmonte he remarked that the English 'wanted to get Sicily and that was the object of all their measures'; at the same time he thought Bentinck had no powers to use force and his bluff could therefore be called: 'before the troops went to Spain he was obliged to be quiet but now . . . he had the means'. So when Bentinck sent in a still stronger remonstrance (8 March) in which he warned the King that his hostile attitude might endanger the Alliance, the King did not even read it. For on the same day the Queen, her protests overborne at last, left La Ficuzza for Castelvetro; on the evening of the 9th the King drove from La Favorita to the palace, hastily summoned the Prince and the Ministers, and—to the 'great surprise' of Bentinck, who had never expected him to take so bold a line—announced that his health was restored and the Vicariate at an end.*

The King was, for the moment, exultant. Bentinck, he said, might do as he pleased, but he would not be his 'Maestro di Scuola as he had been that of Francesco . . . he consigned himself

to the hands of God'. Next day he drove in state amid cheering crowds to a *Te Deum* service at the Cathedral. On the same day (10 March) Bentinck got an answer to his last Note, in which the King merely stood his ground. He therefore 'determined to go personally to the King and see if I could not frighten him'. Bentinck's arrival at the Palace on the morning of the 11th threw the King into a panic, but (as he himself relates) he 'made the Holy Sign of the Cross' and brought himself to face Bentinck for the first time since August. The interview was stormy: Bentinck repeated his recent warnings, and stated that the British Government would not permit the Constitution to be destroyed: 'The King took fire at the word Permit. Permit, permit, permit, he repeated, England has no right to interfere.' When Bentinck began to hint at the past 'treachery', not of the King but of his government, the King cut the interview short: 'Ni moi, ni mon gouvernement. Je ne peux pas écouter de pareil langage. Ecrivez-le, écrivez-le! And he left me.' No sooner was the interview over than the King—'alterata la bile'—had an attack of nerves and took to his bed.*

Meanwhile Bentinck was counter-attacking on another front. The King had planned to stage a second popular demonstration in his own favour by attending yet another thanksgiving service that evening. The city was in a ferment:

'Amidst the exclamations of God save the King it was said that cries of "Out with the English" had also been mixed. Money was universally stated and believed to have been spread among the populace, and all the partisans of the Queen were zealously engaged in exciting disorder.'

Bentinck therefore warned the Sheriff of Palermo that, since he was responsible for the tranquillity of Sicily, he would march British troops into the city to 'protect' the King. The King decided to go on being ill, and called off the service. Meanwhile 'the troops had already been in motion and the passage of some cannon through the town made a very good effect greater said someone than all my Notes for the last year'.*

The King, though frightened, still would not yield. For his sins God had plagued him with this man, he exclaimed—'ma poi questa tribulazione will operate to my salvation. . . . Under the cross of Jesus Christ was J. Nazarenus Rex Judaeorum—on

his tomb would be written *Ferdinandus Rex delle due Sicilie*. His attempt (12 March) at a face-saving compromise—among other things he wanted Bentinck to pay the Queen's debts before she left—fell on deaf ears. For Bentinck, despite the failure of all but a few Sicilians to rally actively to his side—or rather in a sense because of it—was convinced that he 'could not retreat': he must now hold out for nothing less than complete surrender.* He was therefore ready to declare the alliance at an end if need be, and to treat the King as an enemy. Britain (he later explained to Castlereagh) would have been justified in doing so at any time by the flagrant 'treachery' of the Sicilian Government in 1810-11. But

'Where the one party was so entirely at the mercy of the other, it was essential that moderation forbearance and disinterestedness should distinguish every part of our conduct. It would have been easy—it would have been fortunate for all the parties concerned, had a decisive stroke at once . . . terminated and adjusted this question. The interests of Sicily and of England, the happiness and dignity of the King and of the Royal Family would have been eventually saved. The necessity and humanity of such a proceeding might have been evident to the nearest spectators, but to the distant public and to posterity the honour of Great Britain might have received a stain.'

Persuasion had been tried for a whole year, fruitlessly. Now that the Constitution, in the success of which 'our honour, the interests of both countries were involved', was imperilled by the 'faithless and evil advice' of the King's counsellors, Bentinck felt justified in using force unless the King gave way—as his instructions had always empowered him to do in an extremity. This decision he embodied in a final Note (14 March): at the same time he sent for part of his troops from Spain, and contemplated deposing the King by force if necessary:

'The principle of the arrangement was to be that we took possession of the country and gave up the right to the nation. The Parliament must nominate to the vacant throne' (i.e. the Prince would be 'elected' to succeed his father, rather than visibly imposed on the country by the British).*

The tension was at its height: Government business had come to a standstill; some of the constitutionalist leaders, including

the Orleans family, were preparing to take refuge aboard British ships if the King held out to the point of hostilities.* He, indeed, did not yield at once: still apparently unconvinced that Bentinck meant what he said, he drafted a reply (15 March) conceding nearly every point but asking for time and, where the Queen was concerned, for money. Belmonte, however, refused to sign the draft; a few hours later, at Bentinck's instigation, all three constitutionalist Ministers resigned. The King, who had already thrown Cassaro to the wolves, was left without a single Minister. Almost abandoned in his half-empty palace by his relatives and courtiers, he began to lose heart. Orleans, whom he sent for on the 16th, found him distracted: Bentinck might blow him up with grapeshot, he cried—'he had a pain in his breast and in his side—me ne vado—I am dying—Oh, how I wish to be quiet'. He had committed a *bestialità* in resuming; for most of his misfortunes he blamed the Queen. Yet, in spite of his fears, he still would not commit himself to making her go away, especially so long as Britain refused to pay for her; and he categorically refused to consider abdicating. Finally, faced with a 24-hour ultimatum from Bentinck, the King did as he had done in January 1812: he announced verbally, on the evening of the 17th, that he meant to restore the Vicariate and not to resume in future without the consent of the British Government. He then decamped to La Favorita.*

At this point Bentinck could perhaps have pressed the King as far as abdication, and indeed Orleans urged him to do so; but he had no authority for such a step. Instead he went on demanding the Queen's departure; and he insisted that the Vicar's new powers should specifically include all those matters—such as Parliament, the Constitution, foreign affairs, and appointments—in which the King had kept interfering since his first delegation of powers in January 1812. The Prince agreed with Bentinck that sooner than accept such another delegation in general terms—absolute in theory, at the mercy of the King's whim in fact—it would be better to let the King resume again; though (Bentinck added privately) 'if he resumed, it should only be with the condition that he should be bound hand and foot'. Finally, Bentinck demanded the dismissal from their Court functions of three of the King's partisans, among them Cassaro:

this he did at the insistence of Belmonte, who wanted revenge. It was unnecessary and rather weak of Bentinck, who would himself have preferred forbearance.*

The King's remarkable powers of resistance dragged out the crisis for ten more days. At first he would not discuss the new delegation of powers at all; then he took his stand on the vague powers of January 1812; then (21 March), goaded by another ultimatum from Bentinck, he chose to delegate 'in accordance with the English Constitution', which meant nothing. Meanwhile Bentinck had taken alarm at rumours that the King meant to slip away and join the Queen and her guard of Calabrian brigands at Castelvetro: 'I never should catch him again and he might involve us in a civil war.' Bentinck therefore posted, on the night of March 21st, a troop of dragoons outside the gates of La Favorita: a number of members of Parliament spent the night there too to await the outcome, and 'many of the common people flocked thither as to a spectacle, buying nougat and other trifles that were being sold there, as they commonly are at religious processions and similar events'.* In the morning Bentinck himself rode up, withdrew the troops, and met the King, who had been sitting quietly in the front garden since dawn. The King greeted him with an announcement that as a token of his loyalty he meant to go to Malta, among the English. Bentinck, somewhat taken aback, decided not to require—as he had intended to do—the King's signature then and there to the full delegation of powers: if he did so he might appear to be driving the King into exile. Instead he asked for a verbal assent, which the King gave at once. There was a kind of reconciliation: Bentinck told the King 'I was not that méchant homme that I had been represented to him—he took me by the hand'.

In fact the King had momentarily outwitted Bentinck: he did not, of course, go to Malta, but he did go back on his word. It took another week's hectic coming and going to secure the full delegation. By now the proceedings were taking a grotesque turn: witness a proposal by the King's chief counsellor at this time, the Duke of Sangro, that the King should be allowed to resume on condition that he made Bentinck his Great Chancellor for life. Bentinck's patience was exhausted:

'As for the King and Queen, there was no argument but force that had any weight with them', he told Sangro. 'Shew it and they were down to the ground—withdraw it and the next moment they were on their high horse.'*

He therefore despatched a body of troops to the neighbourhood of Castelvetro—where, rumour had it, the Queen was hoping to raise the local population—with orders to make her embark, if necessary by force. By yet another ultimatum he finally made the King sign, on March 28th, a full delegation of powers to the Prince, together with an undertaking not to interfere in the government, and not to resume it without Britain's consent.

On the evening of the same day, by an ironic coincidence, despatches arrived at Palermo from Castlereagh and Castelfidardo, which if they had come sooner would almost certainly have forestalled the whole crisis.* For Castlereagh had impressed it on Castelfidardo that the British Government required the Queen's departure for Vienna; furthermore, 'the only hope of our cooperation' towards the recovery of Naples '... rested upon the absolute extinction of her Majesty's authority, and upon the establishment of a system in Sicily which by commanding the public confidence might prepare the Neapolitans to regard the return of the Royal Family with favour'. To speed the Queen on her way the British Government would pay her debts and give her a pension (this decision in particular, if known sooner, might well have shortened or averted the crisis). Castlereagh, in fact, had fully accepted Bentinck's view that the Queen was the chief obstacle in the way of a Sicilian settlement; he regretted that Bentinck had been unable as yet to join his troops in Spain, but commended his 'zeal, prudence and firmness... under the many difficulties with which you have had to contend'; and the same packet brought Bentinck the K.C.B. In his instructions, however, Castlereagh told Bentinck not to use force except (as laid down by Wellesley) in an emergency and in the face of treachery:

'It is of infinite importance in point of *impression* that the object should be accomplished by arrangement and not by force... as it would be difficult to make the world at large understand, whilst the whole military force of the island is in Your Lordship's hands, that there existed an

adequate necessity for forcibly removing the wife of the Sovereign, more especially if no tumult existed, from her family and dominions.’*

Bentinck had been aware throughout the crisis of the risks he was taking; he had already decided to send Lamb, his Secretary, home to explain the complex Sicilian situation to Castlereagh personally. He now doubly regretted that Castlereagh's instructions had not come sooner; for if he had not exactly used force, he could not very well quibble over the distinction between the threat and the deed.

‘I feel that I have taken upon myself the most serious responsibility,’ he wrote. ‘H.R.H.’s gracious approbation can alone determine whether I have really consulted, as was my sincere desire, the real honour of Great Britain, the happiness, the liberty and the independence of Sicily. I anxiously await this approbation for my own comfort, but I still more ardently desire it for the sake of this great population who will view in it the irreversible confirmation of the great charter of their rights and liberties.’*

Castlereagh's reply was approval tinged with regret. In a private letter he hinted that

‘in giving to our adherents the support they are entitled to claim at our hands, and in affording the new system the aid and countenance which the safety of the island requires and without which it would in its infancy perish, we must try so to arrange as to obviate the necessity of frequent acts of undisguised power’.

Bentinck should if possible arrange for the King and Queen to become entirely dependent on Britain for their income, and so acquire a means of coercion over them less flagrant than that which he had been led to use.*

It is somewhat odd that Bentinck should have used in his despatch the glowing phrase ‘this great population’ of those whom, in a private letter to Castlereagh dated three days later, he called ‘this very timid people’. Throughout the crisis he had complained that the Sicilians were not supporting him properly; the slightest appearance of faltering on his part (he was aware) would have had the worst possible effect,

'here where cowardice was carried to such an extraordinary pitch . . . they never looked forward in this country. They only considered the present danger but . . . the greatest possible evil . . . they never contemplated at all, and that was the possible disavowal by the British Government of my acts.'*

No doubt Bentinck wrote his despatches with an eye to publication if the Queen should decide to bring out her side of the story. All the same, one wonders whether he still could not help judging the Sicilians by a double standard—on a particular occasion they might prove cowards, but in the abstract they remained 'this great population'.

At all events Bentinck's victory now seemed complete. After the re-establishment of the Vicariate on March 28th, and the simultaneous arrival of Castelvicala's despatch announcing that Bentinck was fully supported by his Government, the powers of resistance of the King and Queen were broken. Bentinck could prepare to leave for Spain at last.

The King confined himself henceforth to wrangling with his son over the Civil List; he refused to have anything to do with the settlement of his wife's debts—'affatto, affatto, he would not read a word'. In May he even had a friendly conversation with Bentinck, in the course of which he complained bitterly of the Prince—though 'he loved him and forgave him and prayed God every morning *illuminarlo*'. Of the Sicilians 'he said, to speak plainly, we are living in the midst of cannibals. He knew them well . . . the changes which had been made must end in bloodshed and anarchy'. He therefore asked for British protection in case of need. Bentinck agreed to it, but added that he too knew the Sicilians: 'they made a great outcry . . . they barked very loud but had no teeth—they did not dare bite'.*

The Queen made no more serious resistance, though illness and wrangles over her debts delayed her departure for over two months, and the ever-present threat of force—not force itself—was still needed to make her go. She sailed from Mazara on June 14th. Rather than ask for a French *laissez-passer* through Trieste or Fiume, she travelled to Vienna via Constantinople and Odessa. Delayed by winds and quarantines, she reached Vienna only in February 1814. Seven months later she died of a stroke.*

On May 27th, three weeks before the Queen's departure, Bentinck sailed to Spain, though Castlereagh had instructed him to remain in Sicily on account of the crisis:

'When I reflect that the crisis to which this order has reference is past—that the causes of all our past embarrassments have absolutely terminated—that the Queen's influence exists no more—that the King's hostility is neutralised—that full and unlimited powers have been delegated to the Vicar General—that his administration is composed without exception of popular characters—that this administration appears to enjoy the Prince's confidence, I am warranted in saying that the system against which we have been contending for the last six years, and in support of which the last struggle has been ineffectually made, is completely demolished.'

The Constitution, too, was on the point of being sanctioned at last. It was a confident parting flourish. But then it was meant for official consumption.*

CHAPTER V

THE CONSTITUTION FAILS

Bentinck, when he sailed to Spain in May 1813, turned his back for a time not only on Sicily but also on Italy. It looks as though he was not sorry to exchange the heat and dust of Sicilian politics for the warlike quiet of Catalonia, where, indeed, his army had long stood in sore need of leadership. But Italy was another matter: even as he left Bentinck went on pressing for a change in British policy that would enable him to raise, free, and perhaps unify the greater part of the country.

The liberation of Italy had been Bentinck's chief aim at the beginning of his mission; Sicily was to have provided a stimulus to revolt and a springboard for invasion. But his reluctant decision to send most of his troops to Spain in June 1812 had scotched the plan; nothing had come of his attempts at cooperation with Italian patriots;* while the successive crises of the summer and autumn had taken up much of his time and had turned Sicilian reform into an end rather than a means. Still he went on urging his plans for Italian expeditions on the British Government, though with little hope of immediate success. For Ministers at home were unanimously in favour of his concentrating his efforts on Catalonia; at most Bathurst and Bunbury held out vague hopes of action in Italy if and when Spain was wholly freed; and Nugent found, on one of his peripatetic visits to London in September, that '*c'eût été inutile de lutter contre le torrent*'.* The winter and spring of 1813, however, bringing news of the retreat from Moscow, gave new life to the Italian project, which now appeared at once more urgent and more feasible than before. Bentinck renewed his entreaties; moved the Prince to support them; sent Lamb home in April to state that the Italian patriots seemed ready to rise for 'the expulsion of the French . . . and the union of all Italians in a single Nation, governed by a system of representation': apart from the undoubted military advantages of an expedition (Lamb was to argue) England ought to secure the future balance of power of the Continent by giving Italy her protection and so forestalling the 'private ends' of Austria and Russia.* But except for one or

two converts with little influence on policy—Bunbury, Münster, Pellew—neither the British Government nor its agents would budge,* and Bentinck's secret negotiations with Murat, held at Ponza in June—in the course of which he again insisted on the necessity of making all Italy free and independent—came to nothing.* He therefore went to Spain convinced that his army was being frittered away there to no purpose, and a golden chance lost in Italy. This conviction he frequently expressed, and so added another difficulty to his already rather uneasy relations with Wellington; he also laid up another grievance in Ministers' minds against the day when they should decide, in King Ferdinand's words, to 'break his neck'.

If Italy was a reminder of what might be, Sicily was a commitment both tangible and disquieting. Bentinck, as we have seen, assured his Government that there all was for the best. Perhaps that was what he himself wished to believe. Yet even before his departure he had been aware of possible danger ahead.

The Constitution was sanctioned. But the Councils held for the purpose from December onward—part of the time under the shadow of the King's attempt to overthrow the 'system'—had perpetuated old dissensions and given rise to new ones. At first the Council had been divided, over such questions as the freedom of the press, between the conservative Cassaro, with whom the Prince generally sympathised, and the constitutionalists Belmonte and Castelnovo, often though not always supported by Bentinck. The Prince usually gave way to the latter: most of the institutional articles were sanctioned without serious changes. Bentinck was sometimes deputed to find out the 'English practice'; far from dictating to the Council, he was often to be found on the side of compromise; and he failed to carry the Council with him when, for instance, he attempted to secure a clearer separation of powers and a stronger Executive.

The first serious trouble came over the confiscation of the Royal Domain in exchange for a Civil List, and the separation of Sicily from Naples. The Prince wished to veto both measures: he knew his father was irreducibly opposed to them, and he disliked them himself—as for separation, he scarcely concealed his belief that Sicily was a natural dependency of Naples, and the Sicilians 'good for nothing'. He yielded on the Civil List,

however, after thrusting responsibility for it on the Councillors. It took longer to make him accept separation. Bentinck admitted that England 'did not care about it'—in fact it might be against her interests, since while the two countries were united she could always put pressure on Naples through Sicily. But the Sicilians, he pointed out, did seriously resent their subjection to Naples, and they did want independence; the two kingdoms had different interests—'Naples . . . must always follow the greatest political powers of the Continent; Sicily the greatest maritime power'—and that maritime power would certainly not help to thrust them together again by force. Sicily, independent, reformed, properly developed, would be strong enough to stand on her own feet and have 'allies, not masters.' Besides, she might one day take to reunion of her own free will, especially if her free constitution was extended to Naples. The Prince at length gave way to the advice of the Council—this time unanimous; but he did so with obvious distaste, and the setting up of separate dynasties in the two kingdoms was put off until a general peace.*

No sooner had this obstacle been removed at the beginning of May than fresh trouble arose over the abolition of entail. This measure, passed in 1812 by the two lower Estates only, had caused the first falling out of Belmonte and Castelnuevo. When it had come up in Council the two had again opposed each other—with Bentinck supporting Castelnuevo—but at length all had agreed on a compromise which safeguarded the rights of immediate heirs. Now, however, Castelnuevo reopened the whole question by proposing that Parliament should be left free to decide it 'according to the English Constitution': this really meant that he hoped to secure outright abolition later on.* Belmonte and Castelnuevo now quarrelled in earnest: the one flippant and sarcastic, the other angry and immovable. Bentinck tried to make peace:

'He should consider himself as Prime Minister,' he told Belmonte, 'and Villermosa as one of his instruments—whom on account of his utility he should court as a fine lady. He said he had neither time nor health for this operation which would occupy a man's whole life—I said that I knew Villermosa was a very impracticable man but I believed him to have no ambition. . . . I had seen nothing in him inconsistent with the

most straightforward conduct—Belmonte admitted that he could not act without him—that if Villermosa left the Government, he should also. . . . I said . . . I did not think he had always treated Villermosa with proper respect. . . . Why did he refuse to him that great conciliation which he shewed to everyone else . . . their disunion would ruin everything. Belmonte said he knew it . . . but if they did not quarrel now they would do so afterwards.’

Belmonte, in fact, was very ready to take offence. He was nettled when he heard that Bentinck had called Castelnuevo ‘the only *man* in Sicily . . . had I said this of him (Belmonte) I should have said justly’. At length an uneasy peace was patched up between the two; and Castelnuevo carried his point. But Belmonte’s injured vanity might be expected to make more trouble.*

This dispute between the constitutionalist leaders came at the worst possible moment, when elections to the new House of Commons were about to be held. Their party, already isolated by the defection of Cassaro, Aci, and an increasing number of barons on the right, now had to face a new threat on the left from a ‘democratic’ movement that appeared to be forming in the country. Even with Castelnuevo and Belmonte united the Ministry would be none too strong. The two Ministers who had replaced Aci and Cassaro were both nobles with little following in the Commons. Settimo, a member of the princely Fitalia family, was able but young and new to politics; while the Prince of Carini, the new Minister of Justice, an honest man but so ‘perfectly unfit for the charge’ as to ‘throw ridicule upon the Government’, had been appointed merely for lack of a better. Bentinck did his best to shore up the Ministry by preaching union and ‘encouraging’ Carini.* But the trouble, to his mind, lay deeper: as he later told Orleans,

‘The aristocracy in Sicily hangs upon a thread. I never could convince Belmonte that the nobles were universally despised and hated . . . be it ever recollected that my strong advice was to mix the Cabinet of Peers and of such respectable commoners as could have given the best support to the Peerage and to the Crown.’*

But the enlightened middle class whom Bentinck and Castelnuevo hoped to see taking a greater share in the government

scarcely existed as yet in Sicily; most of the available commoners were lawyers and not 'respectable' enough as a group.* This being so, the Ministers could hardly be anything but aristocrats. But their need for unity was all the stronger, especially in the face of a coming Parliament which might 'ride this new liberty horse too hard' as Bentinck put it. Before leaving he therefore renewed his exhortations; he took with him as a precaution a private letter from Belmonte which gave warning of 'democratic' perils ahead and might justify a sudden return to Sicily; and he urged the Prince to 'cling fast to the British Constitution.'*

Bentinck's fears were all too well grounded. A helpless spectator separated from the scene by the whole of the Western Mediterranean, he had that summer to watch the Constitution and its defenders speedily collapse under a double attack by democrats and conservatives. This attack grew naturally out of the previous course of the Patriotic movement; but it was helped to its success by weaknesses in the British and constitutional camp, some of them fundamental, some only contingent.*

The split between Belmonte and Castelnuevo over the feudal question had shewn how unready were most of the original Patriots for a programme of moderate social change such as Castelnuevo advocated. That the split had been papered over only temporarily was brought out by the behaviour of the constitutional leaders during the elections to the new Parliament. Castelnuevo in particular deliberately refrained from using his influence to avert the obvious danger of a large number of 'democratic' victories at the polls. Whether he did so, as Balsamo maintained, from 'a greater reserve and delicacy than the character of the nation, and very likely the stubborn nature of the human heart, should have allowed'; or whether, as the Belmontists claimed, he wished to secure a majority for the abolition of entail, the result was the same. The Ministers and their followers therefore entered the fray not only divided among themselves but scarcely certain of a majority in Parliament.*

Other circumstances hampered the government. The finances, never sound, were now in so bad a state as to be beyond the usual remedy of short-term British loans and advances: a speedy Parliamentary supply would be essential. Castelnuevo's policy

of economic liberalism had increased food prices and with them popular discontent.* But a greater peril, over which the government had no control, was the plague, which had spread from the Middle East to Malta and might spread to Sicily. The measures taken to avert the peril made things worse politically by jeopardising the position of the British as the protectors of Sicily.

The British, it appears, had already incurred some unpopularity by their display of force at the time of the King's return and the Queen's expulsion;* but the plague gave rise to much stronger grievances. Most of the traffic between Sicily and the rest of the Mediterranean, including the infected areas, was carried on by British ships. Amid the alarm caused by the plague, it was easy for the opposition to accuse the British of neglecting the quarantine regulations; it was even convenient for the government, if their policy was attacked, to reply 'the English have obliged us to do so'. The British generals, for their part, were often overbearing and tactless in their protests against what they considered the unreasonable attitude of the government and the local boards of health.* Neither Lord Montgomerie, a British resident to whom Bentinck had entrusted the mission, nor Joseph Smith, his Secretary, had the authority or the strength needed to control the situation: both were in poor health, one was new to diplomacy, and the other to Sicily.* Orleans, writing to Bentinck, complained of the lack of 'une adresse et une circonspection qui n'est pas toujours *congenial* avec le caractère anglais', and reported 'the irritation produced by the manner in which the English Societies mount each other [i.e. *se montent*] against foreigners when there is no superior chief to give the Ton and to take the lead'. In Bentinck's absence the British authorities did not always act in concert: besides, said Orleans,

'I think, My Lord, that generally they don't see enough of the Sicilian Ministers, of the Hereditary Prince and of the heads of this government . . . this lack of communications lessens the English influence over the Sicilians, and . . . it renders impossible to adjust beforehand and privately the points which must afterwards become the objects of official Notes and public discussions.'*

Orleans therefore clamoured for Bentinck's return. All summer long Bentinck was to receive letters by every boat from the Prince, the British authorities, and the constitutional leaders, all bearing the same refrain. 'Oh My Lord, où êtes-vous donc? Croyez-moi, sans vous, cela n'ira jamais.'*

There can be little doubt that had Bentinck been there he would have imposed greater unity on the British authorities and the government and prevented much needless friction. He might also have done something to heal the rift within the government, which became more apparent as Parliament met on July 8th in the intense summer heat and amid an explosion of speeches, pamphlets and petitions.*

Already the forces opposed to the constitutional settlement could be discerned. In the Upper House there was now a majority of conservative barons, in whose minds fear for their interests had damped the early ardour with which they had voted to abolish feudal rights. Their fears had lately been increased by the behaviour of the new municipal councils set up under the Constitution, which had taken to occupying baronial lands and escaping for the first time from baronial control. Since the defection of Cassaro many of the barons could be classed as King's Friends—though the King himself kept studiously aloof to all appearances—and therefore as enemies of the 'system' they had themselves helped to launch.* In the Commons, on the other hand, a large number of members—a potential majority if the Ministers failed to hold their supporters together—could be classed as 'democrats' or 'Jacobins'. The leaders of this party, Rossi and Vaccaro, had spent years of exile in revolutionary France; to the British and the constitutional leaders they seemed bent on setting themselves up as local Robespierres and Marats; and until recently Sicilian historiography has echoed that judgement, or at best has described them as merely factious and irresponsible. An attempt has lately been made to shew the democratic movement not as a rootless faction, but as the emanation of a new and genuine force in the country: the middling landowners of Eastern Sicily—of the Messina and Catania regions in particular—then as now the most advanced part of the island socially and economically.* The democratic movement certainly did embody an attempt by Catania and Messina to shake free of the

aristocratic predominance of Palermo. Whether it was also truly representative of the nascent bourgeoisie may be doubted. Its members were mostly lawyers—that is to say, as often happened in the later history of Southern Italy, they formed an ‘intellectual bourgeoisie’, vociferous but small, largely divorced from its economic origins, talking and acting in a void. In 1813 they seldom rose above petty factiousness in their tactics, or, in their political aims, beyond a noisy but vague desire for equality and Parliamentary dictatorship; and in joining with the King’s Friends to overthrow the constitutionalists they seem to have been moved more by opportunism than by any notion of a lasting alliance between the monarchy and bourgeoisie against the ruling aristocracy. It may be argued, of course, that the constitutional movement was no less insignificant than the democratic—a ripple on the surface of that huge lake, the economic and social immobility of Sicily. But even a Marxist interpreter might admit that the constitutional movement represented, at any rate at first, the only class strong enough to carry out—because it was also strong enough to frustrate—any measure of social and economic change; and that Castelnovo’s aristocratic but mildly ‘progressive’ policy along English lines was the utmost that Sicily might conceivably have been prepared for at this time.

The constitutional leaders and the British may well be excused for thinking they detected in the democratic party ‘all the symptoms of the terrible French Revolution’.* Even Castelnovo could scarcely be expected to see in this band of noisy lawyers the middle class on the English model which he had hoped might arise in Sicily. If his fears were exaggerated, one must remember that the French Terror was still fresh in men’s minds, and parliamentary criticism of any sort still new to Sicily: violent words therefore had a disproportionate effect.

The weakness of the Ministry was made plain immediately after the opening of the Parliament, when the Commons refused to consider voting supply, though the end of the financial year was only six weeks off. No doubt they felt that ‘good government [consisted] in paying nothing’*; but they also feared that a dissolution might follow on the heels of a vote of supply. They went on to demand wholesale revision of the Constitution

and inquiries into the finances and into contested elections; they set up a multitude of committees to which government proposals were referred and never heard of again, and they refused to submit to any rules of procedure—‘the House wants no chains’, cried Rossi. The Ministry might have kept some control if their followers had been united; but the Belmontists voted more often than not with the Democrats against the government; when Castelnovo, Orleans and Montgomerie tried to instil some notion of Cabinet solidarity into Belmonte, he replied—perhaps with some truth—that he could not control his friends. ‘The Council never meets except in the Prince’s presence’, wrote Castelnovo to Bentinck; ‘the Ministers are therefore often at odds over business. . . . Belmonte . . . behaves in such a way that if I did not know and esteem him I should say he was intriguing to make me leave the Ministry.’*

Both he and Belmonte felt that Parliament had fallen into a hopeless anarchy; the only remedy they could think of was a dissolution and the use of British force. Then, on July 18th and 19th, food riots broke out in Palermo and spread to the prisons: they were put down by the troops, but the Council (including the Prince and Montgomerie) panicked and took to unconstitutional measures: that is, they prorogued Parliament for a week without the proper procedure, and they set up a military commission to try the rioters. Belmonte now at last realised his mistake and made it up with Castelnovo. But it was too late: when Parliament met again on the 27th both Houses were out of hand: not only did they persist in refusing supply, but they threatened to pass a vote of censure on the government’s handling of the riots.

At this point the Ministry collapsed. Castelnovo, as Minister of Finance, had borne the brunt of the Commons’ attacks: now, unable to obtain supply, and unwilling either to dissolve or to go on collecting taxes after the approaching end of the financial year, he resigned. The other Ministers, failing to dissuade him, resigned with him. ‘I foresee this egg is about to break’, the Prince told them; ‘I believe you had rather not have it break in your hands’.* Indeed they insisted on going out of office at once, and both they and their followers stopped attending Parliament altogether: so far as they were concerned, the ship of consti-

tutional government was now quite adrift and beyond their help.

Bentinck, hearing this news before Tarragona, felt 'necessarily hurt at so bad a result to all the exertions I have made, but . . . much more disappointed for the discredit that it gives to the cause of freedom'. He had already warned Orleans that, with the Ministry hopelessly divided as it had been, 'a new set of bold Patriots' were likely to spring up and 'put all that weak aristocracy to the rout': if so the Prince and the British would have to 'side with the strongest'. The government had lost control of Parliament

'by their own folly, their own want of energy alone, and then like the carter who prayed to Jupiter when his cart was in the mire, [they] complain of the apathy of the British Authorities, if by a timely parade of cannon through the Cassaro [the high street of Palermo], or by a nocturnal deportation of obnoxious citizens without enquiry or trial, a system of terror is not established'.*

As for Parliament, Bentinck was not too alarmed by its alleged 'Jacobin tendencies', which he rather attributed to the inexperience of

'persons brought up in a country where . . . despotism . . . has established a rooted distrust and perhaps distaste towards all government, where education has been very bad, and instruction very limited, and where the freedom of the Press has not impressed upon the minds of the people that knowledge and justness of political principles and reasoning which discriminate the British Nation'.

Bentinck therefore advised strongly against any recourse to the old despotic system of force, or even to prorogation or dissolution. The government, he said, should keep strictly within the law: Parliament should be given its head; if it should threaten the Constitution itself, the Prince could always use his power of veto. Of course Parliament might go on refusing supply. In that case

'there will and must follow a revolution, as the machine of government as established by the constitution will stop. But in the first place time will be gained by this process, during which ignorant but well-intentioned men may see their error; and they probably will avoid an extremity which will threaten their personal safety; for timidity I consider to be a peculiar characteristic of the Sicilians. In the second, if anything like

revolution is to take place, it had better proceed from embarrassments produced by the conduct of the Parliament. . . . The conduct of government should be marked with the utmost moderation. If in the end it is compelled to extraordinary measures, they should be so obviously just and necessary as to admit of no question. The Government has to act for the future as well as for the present time, and this forbearance cannot lead to active revolution as in France, because the whole military force is foreign, and in the country there are no native troops and no military spirit.*

In Palermo, meanwhile, the Prince had anticipated Bentinck's advice by declining to dissolve and by appointing a new Ministry. He did not, indeed, bring in the successful democratic opposition—they frightened both him and Montgomerie too much. But he managed to find two officials (Marquis Ferreri and Duke Averna di Gualtieri), a soldier (Marshal Naselli) and an aristocrat (the Duke of Lucchesi Palli)—in other words, a parcel of nonentities—who were willing to carry on the government.

To the minds of the outgoing constitutionalists—Belmonte and Orleans especially—the next step was simple: the new Ministers were to be mere puppets set up to carry through the dissolution they themselves had shirked; then the British would 'take the country in trust', and Belmonte expected to ride back to power under that shield. But the British did not fall in with this convenient plan. After a few days' hesitation Montgomerie decided, in agreement with the Prince, to give Parliament another chance of voting supply.* This move worked, if only temporarily: the threat of dissolution did what dissolution itself could not have done. Early in August the Commons partly overcame what Balsamo liked to call their 'niggardness for the restoration of the desolated finances'*—at least so far as to pass, not indeed the whole Budget, but the Civil List and part of the army estimates, and to extend the financial year until November 1st.

None the less Parliament was now wholly in the hands of the Democrats and King's Friends, who grew still more disorderly as the summer wore on. Misunderstandings over the quarantine regulations culminated in a Commons motion to send an embassy to England to protest against the British gener-

als' misdeeds; while Montgomerie had again to threaten force and dissolution to forestall a motion in the Peers calling on the King to resume power. Party hatreds were still further embittered by the appearance of the first political newspapers ever seen in Sicily: amid the resulting uproar the Commons started setting up a cry for the Spanish Constitution, making forays into the executive and judicial powers, interfering with the courts, attempting to try one of their own members, and generally giving an imitation—superficial and in little—of the French Convention. On September 11th Montgomerie, worn out with illness and worry, at last got a letter from Bentinck announcing his return: he therefore asked the Prince to prorogue Parliament for twenty days and so gain a breathing-space. The Prince agreed with some misgiving, but Parliament dispersed quietly enough on the 15th.*

Bentinck had decided at the end of August that he would have to go back to Sicily and restore order. It was with considerable disgust that he gave up his military command, for he thought of himself as a soldier first and foremost. In the first revulsion of feeling he wrote to Castlereagh that such was 'the weakness of the Hereditary Prince, and such . . . the incapacity of any set of men who may be placed at the head of the Government; such also the silly, the interested and depraved character of the people', that henceforth the British Minister would be unable to leave Sicily: he therefore asked to be relieved of the mission and so freed to follow his military calling; and a few days later he asked for leave in England to look after his Parliamentary seat and his private affairs.* This move was a mistake, for it later allowed Castlereagh to put an end to Bentinck's mission without actually recalling him. For the moment, however, Castlereagh asked him to stay on, and tried to soothe his disappointment: 'I know of no hands in which the British influence can at present be satisfactorily placed except in Your Lordship's. . . .' He felt it unnecessary to send further instructions, merely approving 'the general line of policy' which Bentinck had recommended to the Prince and Montgomerie. A month later Castlereagh added that, although Bentinck would be sacrificing his military career,

'... yet I am persuaded that as the new constitutional system of Sicily is in part a creation of your own... you will not be disposed to hazard its fate in all time to come by confiding it prematurely to other hands. I shall not consider the island safe till we see the Parliament acting cordially with the Government, of which as yet there are no visible symptoms'.*

'In part a creation of your own': the words were doubled-edged; for Bentinck was shortly to find that the Sicilian Constitution had become, in English eyes, a very dubious offspring for him to acknowledge. The same generals and admirals who had first greeted it with jubilation now inveighed against the Sicilians as 'miserable wretches', 'a degraded government and corrupt people', fit only to be dealt with by martial law, like the Luddites at home. Bunbury talked of giving up the island altogether except for two or three fortresses, and leaving the Sicilians to stew in their own juice. Liston, remembering his Montesquieu, doubted 'whether the natives of a hot climate were susceptible of the happiness of a free government'.* From London Bentinck heard that the 1813 Parliament had set nearly everyone against the Constitution, and that he was beginning to be blamed for it:

'On est persuadé qu'en laissant faire aux Siciliens leur Constitution, vous n'en n'avez pas eu l'ordre positif du Ministère, mais que vous avez agi d'après vos propres lumières et sur la *Carte blanche*... que le Ministère vous avait donné... il y a même tel Ministre qui le dit ouvertement. Il est probable que si la confection de la Constitution avait réussi, les Ministres auraient dit qu'ils l'avaient ordonnée. C'est ainsi que va le monde.'*

Bentinck landed at Palermo once again on October 4th. By this time his spirits had risen and he was fairly confident of setting matters to rights by 'some bullying and some coaxing'; however extravagant the recent behaviour of Parliament, he thought, the country at large would still look to the British for guidance. Next day he met the Prince and the new Ministers. He had come 'to bring these gentlemen to reason', he told them: 'if Sicily was not true to herself—if instead of pursuing with wisdom her own good and the final establishment of the Constitution her representatives chose to be governed by their own passion... despotism itself was preferable and as I had been

the first to give it [i.e. liberty] so I should be the first to take it away if I found it to be incompatible with the happiness of the Nation.' But he wished first of all to negotiate with the Parliamentary leaders and if possible bring them to their senses—that is, induce them to promise, before Parliament met again, that they would vote the Budget at once. He therefore asked for a further prorogation until the 15th: the Ministers, anxious to conciliate Parliament, objected, but with the Prince's support Bentinck carried his point.*

Bentinck then set about conferring both with the Parliamentary leaders and with his defeated friends the constitutionalists. His meeting with the latter was melancholy: he dined with them and toasted '*les véritables amis de la Constitution*', but they were shame-faced at the mess they had made of the government in Bentinck's absence. There could be no question of their being returned to power by British force, as the incorrigible Belmonte still hoped he might be, 'like the Vizier of a Sultan'. About Belmonte Bentinck was especially disillusioned: politically he seemed quite hopeless, 'dangerous as an opponent, still more dangerous as a friend'; both he and Castelnovo were now too unpopular to make possible Ministers. The best thing his friends could do, Bentinck told them, would be to form a compact and active opposition, 'the Peers protesting—the Commoners speaking and dividing the House upon all occasions. It was necessary that there should be a standard round which the good might rally.' They agreed readily enough, but they were plainly demoralised and frightened by the turn their own Constitution had taken: their countrymen, they concluded, were by no means so civilised as they had imagined. Balsamo was already drafting the plan of a revised Constitution which would strengthen the executive and judiciary: he proposed a partial return to the old system, and the deletion of 'all abstract maxims concerning liberty, equality and the like'; for, he said, 'in France the rights of man did more harm than anything else'.*

Bentinck's negotiations with the Parliamentary leaders did not go as smoothly as he had hoped. He began by telling Rossi and Vaccaro that while he meant to stand by the Constitution 'as long as possible', he would not tolerate anarchy: if they agreed to vote the Budget, however, he for his part undertook

that they would not be dissolved, as they feared, immediately afterwards. If they wanted freedom they must make some sacrifices for it—'I would have them independent both of their enemies and of their allies and I should not use this language to them if Great Britain wanted to keep them in subjection.' But they disbelieved him, and steadily refused to consider voting supply before the very end of the session, even though Bentinck threatened that 'for the sake of the Sicilian Nation of which I was the advocate . . . I was determined to dictate the law to them and I would do so'. After several inconclusive meetings, Bentinck began to suspect that evil influences had been at work—perhaps the French, perhaps the King: the events of that summer, he perceived, had damaged the prestige both of the British and of the new 'system' more than he had thought. As often before, he regretted his early conciliatory policy: when Rossi remarked, perhaps sarcastically, that 'it was unlucky England had not continued them in their slavery for one night longer and given them the Constitution ready made', Bentinck noted it as a 'curious and just remark': had it been possible in the first place to work through the King alone (he began to think) his task would have been much easier. A further prorogation—which Bentinck obtained from the Ministry only by officially taking responsibility for it—failed to bring about any agreement, and Parliament met again on October 20th.

Bentinck now decided to carry the Budget in the Commons by force of numbers. He mustered 53 constitutionalists—'my 53'—and drove them back to the House they had abandoned in July; he also counted on a further (and sufficient) number of votes which the new Ministers assured him they could scrape together. But the Ministers—whether from 'perfidy' or impotence—failed to deliver the goods: the motion was lost by 61 to 53. Bentinck at once went to the Prince and demanded a new Ministry and a dissolution.

He was furious: 'If I had known as much of the general character of the people as I did at present,' he said, 'I do not think I should ever have undertaken the business. I doubted whether these people were made for freemen.' If the next Parliament was no better than this, 'the sooner the country reverted to another form of government the better'.*

What Bentinck was demanding was in fact the suspension of the Constitution, for the government would shortly have to start collecting taxes without Parliamentary authority. Why did he take such a step, against his own advice earlier in the summer not to do so except in the last resort?

No doubt Parliament if allowed to go on sitting would have kept up its practice of voting taxes a month at a time, and so would have been in a fair way to become a Sicilian Long Parliament. But the government could have carried on somehow, and Bentinck's control of the army would have prevented anything like revolution. No doubt, too, Bentinck felt that on the question of the Budget he had committed himself too far to retreat. But even he seems to have felt the need of some other justification, for he told Castlereagh that what had compelled him to act was

'all the bad signs that preceded . . . the French Revolution. . . . Agrarian law, universal suffrage and provisions at low prices were preached aloud among the people. Contempt was endeavoured to be impressed towards the British army. Their small effective force was contrasted with the numerical strength of the nation. . . .'

How true or significant this was we cannot easily tell: we are ill informed about what was going on in the depths of the country, away from the rather empty hubbub of Palermo. But it is difficult not to suspect that Bentinck, for all his complaints of the Sicilians' unworthiness, was emotionally committed to making the 'system' work, to 'regenerating' Sicily; and that that was why he took on a responsibility greater than his mere duty as British Minister warranted. Though his work was now 'all to do over again', he meant to save Sicily from herself by using present force for her future good.

This was made plain when Bentinck turned to the task of forming a new Ministry. The Prince liked his present Ministers, who were accommodating though weak; but Bentinck would not have them, and quickly dropped the pretence of not himself suggesting who should replace them: the new Ministers were to be constitutionalists, and the Prince openly treated Bentinck as the head of the party. But it proved very difficult to find anyone willing to serve: Castelnovo and Belmonte were out

of the running, while all the others dreaded 'the violence of the Parliament and the national proneness to vengeance and blood'. Bentinck felt hurt:

'I stated to them the hardship of my being deserted by everybody. . . . It would have been much easier for him to withdraw to Messina and allow the Constitution to collapse: 'if I went through with it as I was prepared to do, I should have to undertake a great deal of responsibility and I was to do all this in conjunction with men whom I did not know and of whose principles I could not be assured.'*

None the less it took ten days to patch up a Ministry. Of those who finally came in Settimo (War) at first would not serve without Belmonte; Villafranca (Foreign Affairs)—a young Belmontist nobleman 'more respected for goodness of character than for abilities'*—had been one of the five barons arrested in 1811, and his fearful wife had to be pacified before he would serve; Carini (Justice) was no more use than he had ever been; and Gaetano Bonanno (Finance), though 'a sensible bold man', was a lawyer turned Government official.

Even then there remained the question, by what authority were taxes to be collected after November 1st, when the Parliamentary grant lapsed? The Prince wished to issue a proclamation in his own name and the Ministers'; but 'the whole of them were alarmed and wished to have nothing to do with it'. The proclamation was therefore drawn up in Bentinck's name alone—without even a mention of his functions as Captain-General; in it he made himself responsible for the safety and tranquillity of the kingdom until Parliament should meet again, and announced that he would court-martial 'disturbers of the public peace, murderers, and whatever other enemies of the Constitution may oppose the policy of the Government'. On October 30th the proclamation was published; troops marched into the interior to ensure order; and Parliament was dissolved. Bentinck was now in fact dictator of Sicily.*

Reflecting on this turn of events, Bentinck consoled himself with the thought that 'in the progress from slavery to liberty, more or less disorder must have taken place': it was better that it should have come at a time when a salutary check might still bring the Sicilians to their senses.

'Sicily', he wrote to Castlereagh, 'can only be saved from political convulsions by our interference. As the Constitution takes effect and as the liberty of the Press and their new institutions make an impression upon the opinion and character of the people, it may be hoped that more correct sentiments of private and public honour will prevail. The country must rapidly increase in wealth and strength—all the obstacles opposed by the feudal system and a bad government to the prosperity of the agriculture and commerce of the country are rapidly removing—they are clamorous for all the advantages of freedom but nobody will submit to the sacrifices—nobody will pay or serve. This is shortly the state of the country. It may become powerful and independent if the constitution succeeds and the nation is true to itself—but if not, and in the interval of its infancy and weakness, it must be the province of Arcot with its Nabob, which if not governed by us, will be by our enemy. The management required is to make the interposition of this influence the general object of desire both of the Prince and of the People.'*

CHAPTER VI

DICTATORSHIP AND THE 'DREAM'

'The Vicar kept quiet, while Bentinck alone acted and laid down the law, running about from one department to the next, writing instructions himself and having them written at his will.'*

So the King heard at the beginning of November 1813. He was not misinformed: Bentinck was now, as Orleans said, 'the first Minister of the country', and the secretaries of state were his 'clerks'. With them he discussed measures of policy and government appointments; while the British generals and agents in other parts of Sicily acted as unofficial political representatives, recommending local supporters of the Constitution for the places and favours which Bentinck could obtain for them. Actually, Bentinck's power was rather that of a monarch than of a Prime Minister. Great nobles called him in as arbiter of their family disputes; such conservative barons as Butera, Pantelleria, San Marco, Gargallo—some of whom had been unseated by the Patriotic victory of 1812—now sought to ingratiate themselves with him; the Senates of various towns apostrophised him as the Moses of Sicily.* Criticism was stifled at the outset of his dictatorship by the arrest, trial, and imprisonment of two nobles who had published violent attacks on him—one of them, ironically, was Anjou, one of the 'five barons' whom the Court had arbitrarily arrested in 1811.* According to a story current in Palermo, the Prince commented on this state of affairs by telling his wife one day "‘This morning I had to wait a long time in Council for His Majesty’"—his wife, astonished, answered, "‘What, the King?’"—"‘No, I was waiting for Lord Bentinck’"—and laughing he went away'.*

The country was outwardly quiet. From the officers he had sent to garrison the interior Bentinck heard that the great majority of the people appeared to feel nothing but gratitude for British protection. The Royal Family also seemed perfectly docile. The Prince effaced himself, called Bentinck his 'ange tutelaire', and professed the most commendable feelings; but Bentinck, though willing to grant that he was the ablest of his family—his chief defect being mere weakness—never quite

trusted him again. The King kept ostentatiously aloof, though privately he posed as the only man really attached to the English Constitution, which Bentinck's proclamation had infringed. He continued to associate with such conservatives as Cassaro, Trabia and the Archbishop of Palermo, and—Bentinck thought—to encourage them in their latent hostility to the 'system'. To a hint that he should end this silent opposition the King replied blandly that he had not the slightest notion of what was going on ('the greatest imaginable lie'). Bentinck hoped to keep him sweet by playing on his hopes of Naples; indeed, as will be seen, the swift changes then taking place on the Continent brought the two men closer together, and Bentinck went so far as to appear at an interview, to the King's gratification, with his hair symbolically powdered. But this did not stop the King (as Bentinck was aware) from playing his own hand in his correspondence with the Sicilian envoys abroad; he was no more reconciled to the Constitution than he had ever been; and he might be expected to overthrow it as soon as British power was withdrawn.*

The noisy factions of the 1813 Parliament seemed to have melted away. The constitutionalists themselves were now little more than a set of place-holders kept in power by Bentinck's will. Even so, the dissensions which had begun when they formed a real party perpetuated themselves within the narrow circle of Ministry and Council. The formation of the new government had been a papering over of cracks, so much so that care had been taken to give the Belmontists and Villermosists equal representation. This balance was soon upset, however: Bonanno, the new Minister of Finance—who held the key post in the government, since as Bentinck's right-hand man he controlled the local officials and dispensed patronage—had come in as a presumed Villermosist, but soon went over to Belmonte. As a result Castelnuevo and Balsamo began to complain—probably with some justice—that he was making an unscrupulous use of his powers by wholesale dismissals and promotions of officials and by unwarranted interference in local affairs. Belmonte, for his part, had no more cause for satisfaction: Bentinck, taught by experience, was determined not to let him be more than a figurehead.* These enduring differences did not matter

much so long as Bentinck remained there to impose a semblance of unity; but they were enough to suggest that the constitutionalist rump would not long survive Bentinck's departure.

With Bentinck's dictatorship established and unchallenged, the question might have been asked, what kind of political settlement would it lead to? The short answer was that Sicily's pocket revolution, having followed the course of its English and French exemplars through constitutional monarchy and parliamentary anarchy, was now entering a phase equivalent, at any rate in the conception, to the Protectorate or the Consulate. Political liberty had been tried and found wanting; so a kind of benevolent despotism was to take its place, with enlightened but authoritarian reform as its aim.

Here Bentinck's attitude was ambiguous. The official opinion he gave in his despatches home was that the people—except for some of the barons, whom the abolition of feudalism had alienated—shewed 'perfect unanimity' in support of the Constitution; but that, still suffering as they were from the after-effects of misrule, they would be unable for some years to shield it from the attacks of a few mischief-makers. So, although 'our enemies are a faction, our support a people', an interval of British tutelage would be necessary, at the end of which Sicily would have been made safe for political freedom, and the Constitution could be restored to its full and free operation.* Bentinck's personal opinion is not so clear. He seems never to have given up the hope that eventually the free Constitution might be made to work. But for the present he had few illusions. If the King were to abolish the Constitution tomorrow, he remarked, 'not a hand would be lifted against so arbitrary an act'. The best he could hope for was that the international situation would keep Sicily 'free in spite of herself and all her efforts to the contrary'. In conversation with members of the former opposition, he said that while he remained in Sicily he hoped 'to hold up to Europe a whole nation united in the cause of liberty', but in any case he would carry the thing through 'bon gré mal gré':

'It would have been much better if I had done the work in three months . . . but I did not know the nation as well before as since . . . they never reasoned upon what they saw but upon what they supposed

—They were led by their imagination and not their reason—No man calculated that 2 and 2 make 4—It was either 5 and 6 or 2 and 3—They were poets.*

Similarly, in conversation with Sperlinga (a refractory noble whom he threatened to banish from Palermo), Bentinck anticipated a later statesman by declaring that the Sicilians were to be managed only by 'Bonsbons in one hand and il bastone in the other'. In fact, for practical and immediate purposes Bentinck had given up any interest in political liberty and representative government. He did not care who the members of the next Parliament might be, he said—he would make them do their duty in any case. If the barons, as he expected, kept up their hostility, 'I was resolved' (he told Sperlinga) 'to abolish the order altogether'.*

A distinctly anti-aristocratic tone, together with an implied contempt for the representative institutions he had himself helped to set up—these seem to account for Bentinck's state of mind during his brief career as benevolent despot. A friend of his put it more plainly still:

'Tout le monde se demande, que fera-t-on pour la Sicile? Pour moi je demanderois, que mérite-t-elle qu'on fasse pour elle? Rien, si l'on ne considérât que la nonchalance et l'immoralité des nobles et des prêtres, la scélératesse de la seconde classe de la population, celle des gens de loi et des agents des nobles tous compris sous le nom de Paglietti. Mais la populace des campagnes, les agriculteurs, les artisans de l'intérieur de l'île ont quelques vertus, et ils ont besoin d'être soulagés du pouvoir trop arbitraire du souverain, de la tyrannie des nobles et de la rapacité des Paglietti.—Ce fut là votre objet quand vous laissâtes faire une Constitution. Il semble démontré maintenant que pour être utile à toutes les classes il ne faut laisser faire à aucune, mais leur faire faire par force ce qui leur convient.'*

Drastic and effective reform of the administration was a need more essential than representative government: 'both Parliaments', Bentinck thought, 'had been pursuing the shadow and neglecting the substance.' His mood was far removed from the orthodox Whiggism usually attributed to him: in fact Balsamo complained that his chief defect was the unsystematic and excessively pragmatic way he dealt with particular problems. He was

willing, for instance, to throw over the experiment in economic liberalism (which had caused much trouble) so far as to acquiesce in fixed prices for necessities. In general, too, he behaved less and less like a British agent, more and more like a Sicilian ruler: when Anglo-Sicilian disputes recurred over the quarantine regulations, he backed the Sicilian Board of Health; and in his despatches home he scarcely mentioned his part in domestic politics, merely stating that the island was perfectly quiet.*

The need for reform was greatest in the financial and judicial organisation of the country, which the last two Parliaments had done no more than upset without definitely settling on a new system. Balsamo's plan for financial reform, passed by the 1810 Parliament, had laid a new uniform tax on all land and called for a thorough survey as a basis for assessment: the logical consequence should have been the end of the barons' virtual exemption from taxation. But in November 1813 the land survey—the pet project of reformers, both Neapolitan and Sicilian, ever since the 1780's—had still not been carried out; the land tax had had to be collected on the basis of voluntary declarations of value (*riveli*); as a result the barons evaded taxation more successfully than ever. Small landowners, whom Balsamo had meant to benefit, had actually suffered, and so had the Exchequer. Now, however, the new Minister Bonanno at last set out in earnest to prepare the essential survey. At the same time he overhauled the government service: no doubt he meant above all to exert political influence in the constituencies, but he achieved other things as well: a number of redundant offices, relics of the old regime, were swept away, and the Ministers gained control of their own officials—which was more than Castelnovo or Belmonte had had. How far Bentinck had a hand in these practical reforms is not clear, though he and Bonanno were certainly in close touch. That they were not begun until Bentinck took over the government is at any rate significant. He certainly took an interest in financial reform, and he advocated a more equal distribution of landed property.*

Judicial reform was an equally pressing problem. Bentinck had already complained to Castlereagh of 'the total impotence of the laws, venally administered, giving no protection, and therefore imposing no check upon the lively imaginations and warm

passions of the people'. More murders, he reported, were probably committed in Palermo than in the rest of Europe put together, Sardinia and Corsica excepted. The new Constitution had begun to undo the old system without setting up new codes or carrying out Castelnovo's plan for the reorganisation of the courts. Bentinck took a great interest in this question: it was uppermost in his mind when at the end of November he set out on a month's tour of Sicily. He was also concerned, on this occasion, with ensuring that the right people were elected to the forthcoming Parliament, but (he told the Prince) 'my great object was the administration of justice—to hear what the people wanted'; and he returned much impressed with 'the prepotenza [bullying] that generally prevailed—the result I believed of the feudal system and of the administration of justice being in the hands of the barons'. Early in 1814 he discussed judicial reorganisation with Bonanno; and throughout this period a committee of the Council sat to work out new codes.* But all these attempts at reform were cut short by the swift turn of events on the Continent; they bore fruit only after the Restoration, when Sicilian independence and the British protectorate had both come to an end. Abortive though they were, they mattered in that they shewed what might have happened in Sicily if the protectorate had gone on. With Bentinck's dictatorship the wheel had, besides, come full circle, for his policy was now very like that of the former Neapolitan Viceroy—authoritarian in manner, 'enlightened' and anti-aristocratic in purpose. The difference was perhaps not so much that Bentinck still hoped Sicily might later become fit for free institutions, as that his policy was intended to make and keep her independent; while the Viceroy had been very distinctly the agent of Neapolitan centralisation.

But all this (it quickly became clear), and indeed the future of the British protectorate itself, must depend on the fate of the Continent. Of this Bentinck was well aware; immersed though he was in Sicilian affairs he kept an eye on Italy, whose independence he still hoped for. When he set out on his tour of Sicily in late November he had not yet heard of the negotiations between Austria and Murat which were to lead to a treaty of alliance between those two powers, and then to an Anglo-Neapolitan armistice. But he had received instructions from

Bathurst and Castlereagh to give Austria his military and diplomatic cooperation in Italy, if need be to the point of recognising—*sub spe rati*—Murat's possession of Naples, and accepting the principle of compensation for the Bourbons. This Bentinck did not like at all. Murat, he thought, by taking part in the battle of Leipzig on Napoleon's side (something Castlereagh did not know about when he drew up his instructions) had altered matters and made so great a concession inadvisable. None the less great and critical changes were plainly about to take place. How then did Italy and Sicily stand?*

In Italy—Bentinck agreed with his Italian soldier friends at Palermo, the Piedmontese Sallier de la Tour and the Friulan Catinelli—it was 'necessary to do something to be beforehand if possible with the old sovereigns and to give the people an opportunity of asserting their rights, liberty and independence'. True, a small-scale landing on the Tuscan coast, which Bentinck ordered as an experiment late in November, proved disappointing: the troops—Italian volunteers under Catinelli—met with no response from the local population and had to re-embark. But a larger force might yet do better: the setback did not stop speculation about the chance of creating an independent Italian kingdom; and Bentinck's private Secretary James Graham was not alone in seeing him as a possible 'Lord Wellington of Italy, only with this marked superiority'—he would 'draw the sword to create a free government'.*

Sicily, however, was another matter. When Bentinck talked of raising Italy and forestalling the old sovereigns, he meant North and Central Italy; the Two Sicilies he reckoned as quite separate politically from the rest of the peninsula, and he seems to have assumed like everyone else that if the Allies won the war the Bourbons would be restored to Naples.* What would then become of Sicily's independence and constitution? As early as November 20th Bentinck warned the constitutionalists that England could not be expected to go on garrisoning the island after a peace. He already had good reason to guess that the British Government would do little to safeguard Sicily from Neapolitan reaction. Already Castlereagh had asked Lamb—Bentinck's former Secretary—'When is all this interference to cease?' Three months later, on hearing that Sicily was quiet

under martial law, Castlereagh 'smiled and said: "do you know, after all I am of opinion, *that* is the only kind of government for which they are fit."'* In the circumstances—Bentinck told his Sicilian friends—they ought to induce the Prince to nominate a Sicilian Ambassador in London, for Castalcicala was the King's personal agent and actually did his best to discredit the Sicilian government; Belmonte—he suggested—might, if he undertook the mission, prove 'the saviour of the country'. But Belmonte, overconfident as usual, was convinced that England would never abandon Sicily, on which (as he thought) the safety of Malta depended; though the matter was discussed again and again, Bentinck could make no impression on him, and nothing was done.* Clearly, the future of Sicily—of her independence, of the free institutions she might eventually be trusted with, of the practical reforms that were being launched—would depend not on the Sicilians themselves, but on the course of British policy.

It was in these circumstances that Bentinck, during his tour of Sicily in November and December 1813, brought to light the notorious 'philosophic dream' which, if carried into effect, would have made of the island 'after Ireland, the brightest jewel in the British crown'.

Bentinck's tour through the towns of the East coast and the interior was remarkable in that, for the first time since the Court's flight from Naples, someone concerned with the government of Sicily took the trouble to visit it extensively. Bentinck, who like the Royal Family had until then scarcely stirred out of Palermo and its environs, was much struck: 'it was impossible to know the country without having seen it', he told the Prince on his return. His was a quasi-royal progress; everywhere he was received with banquets, balls, triumphal arches, fireworks, and allegorical tableaux of England and Sicily embracing. He 'harrangued' the local councils, urging them to see that the *bricconi* of the 1813 Parliament were not re-elected; he interviewed place-seekers, discussed local affairs with the leading citizens, and returned, as has been seen, convinced of the need to strike at aristocratic quite as much as at royal 'prepotenza' in local affairs. Though the opposition was no doubt merely silent rather than reconciled, still Bentinck's tour was to all appearances a triumph.*

On December 3rd, travelling between Messina and Catania, Bentinck thought out, and, in a letter written that evening, put to the Prince his '*rêves d'un voyageur*'. The dilemma which faced them both—he told the Prince—was that while Sicily was not yet fit to govern herself alone, still she would not let herself be reunited to Naples without bloodshed. He therefore proposed that Sicily should be governed by Britain. Such an arrangement, he said, would be advantageous to all parties. Sicily would prosper; from a burden to Naples she would turn into a friendly neighbour, whose dependence on a Power without continental ambitions would make impossible any conflict between the two kingdoms; and the Royal Family could be compensated either with additional territory on the Continent, or—more likely—with a British subsidy equivalent to the Sicilian Civil List, and with military aid.*

Bentinck's proposal was ill-judged; but in itself it was not fantastic. Since the beginning of the eighteenth century Sicily had passed from Spain to Savoy, from Savoy to Austria, and finally from Austria to the Neapolitan Bourbons. It might have taken one more change in its stride. The Queen had talked of selling it to England or of bartering it against help towards the recovery of Naples. The Prince secretly considered Bentinck's proposal of compensation on the mainland.* As for the Sicilians, they wanted independence; but they wanted it chiefly because they disliked Neapolitan domination and could not forget their own former glories; they hardly thought in terms of the modern national state, and such a man as Belmonte was quite ready to see a permanent British protectorate. Of Italy 'beyond the Garigliano' (the frontier between Naples and the Papal States) they were, as Michele Amari later said, scarcely aware;* of the notion that Sicily might help to make up a united Italy not a trace is to be found in this period. So if one looks at Sicily alone, rather than at the international situation, Bentinck's proposed settlement was at least conceivable.

What led Bentinck to propose it? The question has exercised a number of historians. Balsamo attributed the 'dream' to 'bizzarria', Weil to overweening personal ambition, while Bianco thought it a mere manoeuvre aimed at the unreconciled King's Friends. None of this is very convincing. Then certain

Italian writers—among them such an historian as Croce—suspected that Bentinck's letter was a token of some deep-laid British design on Sicily.* Bentinck's own explanation—which, repenting at leisure, he sent off a few days later in reply to the Prince's agitated enquiries—was this:

'The Sogno Filosofico . . . was the offspring of my disordered brain alone, was brought to light for the first time in the journey from Messina to Catania, and has its derivation from no other source whatever.'*

However that may be, one thing is plain: the British Government knew nothing about the 'dream' until well after it had been put forward, and even then the Foreign Office (though not Castlereagh) first heard of it from Castelficala. It is also clear that the Government's policy before and after the incident was quite opposed to anything like the annexation of Sicily; and Bentinck knew this and said so. Since the evidence was published Italian historians have accepted it and left it at that.* But, as sometimes happens, what one set of documents establishes a fresh set of documents calls in question. The notion that Bentinck had a brainwave and Castlereagh dismissed it out of hand must now be qualified.

The annexation of Sicily was not a new idea. In 1806-7 Howick and Grenville had thought of establishing a permanent protectorate over the island; and Sir John Moore had put it more bluntly still. But neither Canning nor Wellesley nor Castlereagh had ever mentioned it or, so far as we can see, thought about it. Bentinck himself, until his return from Spain in October 1813, always assumed that Sicily was on the way to becoming her own mistress. Britain might keep some permanent influence over her, largely for reasons of geography, but that was all. Since his return, however, Bentinck had come much more openly to doubt her ability to secure her own independence. He himself had had to become in effect a dictator rather than a mere envoy. It may be that at some point in October or November Bentinck began to form the idea of making this British rule permanent; and that what he saw on his tour precipitated it. He had been used—as he told Castlereagh—freely to discuss with the Prince all large matters of

policy, and the Prince for his part encouraged him to do so. Now, all-powerful as he seemed to be, and eager to test the Prince's reaction, Bentinck may have forgotten the difference between a passing remark in conversation and a letter, however private. Why did he act so hastily? When, two months later, he explained his act to Castlereagh, Bentinck recapitulated the dangers that had faced Sicily at the time of his letter: the after-effects of misrule; the King's undying hostility to the 'system'; the prospect of a Neapolitan reaction at a peace; and he affirmed his belief that

'Sicily, in the hands of Great Britain, would become in a very few years a source of wealth and strength, and after Ireland, the brightest jewel in the British Crown. The capacity of the country exceeds all belief. It is only necessary to have seen it fully to believe all the accounts transmitted by history of its former greatness. But I affix more importance to the character that Great Britain will acquire by the successful establishment of Sicilian liberty than to the value of Sicily as a British possession. I wish Sicily to exist as a perpetual example of the blessings of our friendship, in comparison to that of France; and, in the event of a new war, which, if Buonaparte lives, must soon recur, I would have Sicily become not only the model, but the instrument of Italian independence.'*

Here Bentinck seems to have been perfectly sincere. We should not underrate the impact of a Sicilian tour on a mind formed by a classical education. As Croce points out, down to the latter half of the nineteenth century educated men sent up the parrot cry that Naples was one of the most fertile and blessed countries in the world because they trusted more to the lessons of the past than to the evidence of their own senses.* Bentinck could see well enough that Sicily was in a poor way. Messina, which he left on the morning of December 3rd, was politically 'the worst disposed place I have seen'; and the 'horrible road' along which he drove to Catania spoke for the long effects of misrule. (Bentinck had often lectured the Prince on the inestimable benefits which a good road system would bring to Sicily). But on the way there was Taormina in its ruined magnificence, which he had not seen before—a reminder that Sicily had been great and prosperous in happier times and might become so once more; though now, it seemed, only through British protection.*

At all events Bentinck seems to have acted on impulse, without realising what strange reading his letter would make at Palermo. The Prince at once told his father; both of them were highly alarmed and thought they saw their worst suspicions confirmed. Both confided their fears to Castelvicala even before Bentinck had had time to answer the Prince's anxious request for an explanation. But they wrote separately, and phrased their despatches so cautiously as to throw on Castelvicala the onus of any action he might take in London: when it came out that Castelvicala had used the 'dream' to demand Bentinck's recall, father and son accused one another of having put him up to it. For the moment, however, the incident was closed: Bentinck hastened to withdraw his proposal unconditionally; and he dissociated it wholly from British policy.* But the Prince, Bentinck noted, even while he rejected the idea of ceding Sicily to Britain, had dropped the remark that anyhow the proposed compensation would not be enough. This, Bentinck thought, was only 'the ordinary proceeding of Italian intrigue, with the view of making a better bargain';* so, although he took care not to raise the matter again with the Prince, he continued to nurse it in his mind.

But in the meantime changes were taking place in Europe which soon made even less likely the realisation of Bentinck's dream. Only a few days after writing the notorious letter Bentinck heard for the first time of the negotiations then going on at Naples between Murat and the Austrian agent Neipperg. These led, on January 11th 1814, to the Austro-Neapolitan treaty of recognition and alliance; and, on February 3rd, to an Anglo-Neapolitan armistice. The treaty Bentinck thought 'impolitic, inexpedient and unnecessary . . . a sad violation of all public and private principle';—the armistice he resisted as long as he could—that is, until he heard from Aberdeen, the new Ambassador to Austria, that the British Government approved of the negotiations. But even when he resigned himself to going briefly to Naples and signing the armistice he insisted on a mere cessation of hostilities; he would not formally recognise Murat's hold on Naples. This stubbornness annoyed the Austrians and Murat, but—since Aberdeen had accepted the Austrian plan too hastily in the first place—it restored the balance of British policy;

and it proved convenient to Castlereagh then and later. What the new relationship between England and Naples did not suit at all was Bentinck's own plans both for Italy and for Sicily.*

In Sicily the 'dream' was now obviously out of the question in its original form, since it did not look as though the Bourbons would ever get back to Naples. 'I was however resolved to stick by Sicily,' Bentinck declared; and he thought it might still be possible to maintain the British protectorate *de facto* if not *de jure*: for while Murat was at Naples the Bourbons could not do without the British garrison in Sicily.* Immediately after the signing of the armistice, therefore, Bentinck started moving on two fronts—the British and Sicilian—to secure the 'system' as far as he could.

Castlereagh by this time was already on the Continent, at allied headquarters. To him Bentinck sent his private secretary, James Graham, who was to act as his personal representative and deliver the despatch—already quoted—in which for the first time Bentinck revealed and defended the 'dream'. Graham saw Castlereagh at Chatillon on February 21st, had a long talk with him, and handed him a memorandum outlining Bentinck's views on Sicily. But Graham's account of what was said differs from Castlereagh's.

Graham began—he afterwards recorded—by explaining the state of Sicily as Bentinck saw it. Though the constitutional system could at present be kept going only by British influence, yet that system had for the first time led Sicily to contribute effectively to the Allied cause; in any case it was not meant 'for *their* good alone, it is principally for *our own*': through it Sicily would become a real ally not a burden. Next Graham came to what Bentinck privately hoped for: at most, that Sicily should become 'the Queen of our Colonies'—and here Graham recapitulated all the arguments in favour; at the very least, that the British garrison should remain in Sicily, and that the Neapolitan and Sicilian missions should be united, with the Minister at Naples and a good second-in-command at Palermo. In any case, said Graham, Bentinck

'will not desert the Sicilian cause in which he has embarked, and even should he be left there alone without any force, to encounter difficulties

which, he fears, he could not overcome, he will try his utmost to preserve a Constitution which he has reared amidst so many dangers, and while permitted to remain, he will not leave his post'.

According to Graham, Castlereagh 'treated me, I must say, as a friend, and I shall always be grateful for his good humour on this occasion. . . .' But when Castlereagh dealt with the possible consequences of the armistice he 'spoke . . . like one who remembered that the Rod of the House of Commons was suspended over his head. . . .' The 'dream,' he pointed out, was now quite impracticable: 'our engagements with Murat were decisive'; the Bourbons would therefore have to be compensated elsewhere for the loss of Naples, and nothing they were likely to get, even if it was padded out with money, would tempt them to part with Sicily. But if on the other hand Murat should prove treacherous and the Bourbons be restored to Naples, then the 'dream' would become 'feasible and worthy of consideration'. In any case, even if Murat stayed on in Naples Castlereagh agreed entirely that the British garrison could and should be maintained in Sicily after the peace. Nobody would object except Murat, and he could be made to acquiesce. Altogether Castlereagh was 'in the best possible disposition' about Sicily; 'nothing could be more flattering' than his remarks about Bentinck. He also seemed to think well of the proposed joint mission at Naples and Palermo; at all events, he said, Bentinck would keep the Sicilian mission.*

Now we come to Castlereagh's version. Just after the interview he wrote the following brief and non-committal letter to Bentinck:

'I shall not lose sight of your suggestions about Sicily, I agree with you that its safety would be more than precarious if left to its own defences alone. It is however a most difficult problem in all its parts.*'

When a month later, the storm broke over the 'dream' incident, Castlereagh explained his former silence by saying that

'When Mr Graham mentioned Your Lordship's impressions to me at Chatillon . . . and afterwards sent me a memorandum upon the subject, considering the whole, even in Your Lordship's view, as necessarily at an end, in consequence of the connexion formed with Murat, I paid

little attention to the point, and in the press of other business, did not till yesterday read Mr Graham's paper.*

What really happened at Chatillon? Graham's report is so full that it is hard to believe Castlereagh did not take in the 'dream' or grasp the singularity of such a proposal from a Minister to a sovereign. A devil's advocate might maintain that Castlereagh understood quite clearly what Graham had said; that the annexation of Sicily had been, not indeed the aim of British intervention, but in the air as a possible consequence, more or less remote; that now it was impracticable; but that Castlereagh kept it in mind as 'worthy of consideration' if events should take a new turn on the Continent. Castlereagh certainly took the 'dream', then and later, more calmly than did his fellow-Ministers at home. But there is another explanation. It is this. Graham—a romantic young man of 21, given to writing long rhetorical letters—may have bored Castlereagh with a verbose account of Bentinck's views (Graham himself reported that he had 'insisted at great length' on one point). Castlereagh had a great many other matters on his mind; he thought the armistice had settled the fate of Naples; probably he did no more than half-listen to Graham, but now and then uttered some encouraging platitude which misled his interlocutor into thinking that he strongly agreed with what was being said. When we keep in mind Castlereagh's whole European policy this seems much the likelier explanation. But some small doubt must persist.*

This was not the end of the 'dream'. Early in March Castalcala used the incident—which the Foreign Office still knew nothing about—to support a demand for Bentinck's recall. He got a strong rebuff when it came out that he had acted without specific instructions from the Prince. Liverpool, however, was much annoyed. The proposed annexation of Sicily he thought inexpedient rather than immoral, but Bentinck's act was most objectionable—as he might have pointed out, Drummond had been recalled in 1808 for a 'private' indiscretion on a different and less serious matter. Bentinck, he thought, was obviously finding that 'his *new constitution* and the *Sicilian court* are never likely to work together', and the 'dream' was 'a device for

getting out of the difficulties in which his Whig principles had involved both himself and us'.

The despatch Castlereagh wrote to Bentinck when he heard of this was, however, regretful in tone rather than reproachful; William A'Court, who was with him at the time, reported to Lady William Bentinck that 'the *Correspondence*, which was considered as so important in England, is thought of no consequence here, and there does not appear to be the slightest idea of complying with Castalcicala's request'. Bentinck thanked Castlereagh for his 'kindness and consideration', and that was the last of the business. But although Castlereagh never made the 'dream' one of his chief grievances against Bentinck another grain of official discontent had gone into an accumulating store.*

In February, however, all this was yet to come. At Palermo Bentinck was casting about for means of securing the Sicilian protectorate if Castlereagh and the British Government, as he had reason to fear, should prove indifferent. The Prince, he thought, had better be induced to make an official request for a British garrison after the peace; but after the 'dream' incident the Ministers, and not Bentinck himself, must take the initiative. All he could do was to rub in Murat's great military power. In spite of this neither the Prince nor the Ministers proved easy to manage. The Prince, though frightened at the prospect of having Murat for a neighbour after the war, was reluctant to saddle himself with a permanent British force until he was quite sure that there was no other way out. As for the Ministers, Bentinck told Belmonte, Castelnovo and Settimo in confidence of the 'dream' and explained the present situation fully, with all its uncertainties and dangers. Here they were on the eve of great changes in Italy which threatened not to go the way they had hoped; if peace came swiftly England might decide to clear out and then where would they be? But Belmonte 'went into a long harangue upon what he supposed to be the policy of England without attending to the real state of the question', and Bentinck 'could not fix his attention to the subject'. In his annoyance he begged Orleans to remind Belmonte of

'the necessity of their interfering with the British Government to keep a force in Sicily and not to let him deceive himself that England would

do this of her own accord or that she would not be too happy to get rid of Sicily and all its troubles. . . . Lord Castlereagh had said to Lamb when is all this interference to cease—It was needless to fancy how it should be—I was fully convinced of the policy of England maintaining her influence in Sicily, but how did the fact really stand and had England this interest upon the subject—No—'

Bentinck had to throw his weight into the scales after all: he reminded the Prince that the Constitution must be safeguarded as the 'great engine of destruction' against French despotism in Italy. At length, after much dickering between the Prince and the Ministers, the desired Note was handed to Bentinck on February 23rd. He was agreeably surprised at its contents, for it gave as reasons for the need of continued British protection in peacetime not only the security of Sicily, but that of her independence and constitution as well.*

But if the 'engine of destruction' was about as safe in its homeland as fore-thought could make it, the prospect of putting it to good use on the Continent was discouraging. Before the armistice with Murat, indeed right up to January 18th, when the arrival of Aberdeen's despatch forced him to swallow the armistice, Bentinck had considered various moves which would not have suited either Austria or Murat in the least. On January 6th he had urged the King to issue a proclamation full of such constitutional sentiments as would rally the Neapolitans round the Bourbons—and perhaps not only the Neapolitans, for, said Bentinck, other Italians might join them and 'I for one should be sorry to see Italy parcelled out among its ancient petty sovereigns'. The King, however, would have no part of it, and Bentinck went off feeling that 'there was only one way of treating them all from top to bottom without any exception *il Bastone*'. Bentinck had also thought of leaving Murat and the Austrians to fight it out with the Viceroy Eugène in Lombardy while he, on his own account, raised an insurrection against the French by invading first Corsica, then Tuscany and Liguria.* But the armistice sent all these plans up in smoke. Bentinck now found himself in complete agreement with the King on the question of Naples; in the course of their frequent and 'lugubrious conversations' they commiserated with one another on the folly of the Allies and especially Austria in backing Murat; and

Bentinck actually encouraged the King in his refusal to consider giving up his claim to Naples: true, this was one matter in which the King needed no encouragement.* The King for his part declared that he put his trust in 'God, England and Bentinck'; but even while he said it he nursed a nagging suspicion that England and Bentinck, at any rate, were at the bottom of a plot to strip him of his possessions.*

But the Austro-Neapolitan treaty did not affect Naples only; to Bentinck's mind, it tended 'to confirm the slavery of Italy whose liberation had been my constant hope'. Murat, he thought, had hoodwinked the Austrians—'the worst politicians in the universe'—by stealing their thunder and incidentally Bentinck's too: now he would be able to present himself as the champion of Italian independence; the people would probably prefer him to Austria, 'and then we had no chance of dictating at all'. Bentinck regretted more than ever that the British Government had not chosen to intervene earlier in Italy:

'If the British protection and assistance had happened to be within their reach, that great floating force would certainly have ranged under their standard. The national energy could then have been roused, like Spain and Germany, in honour of national independence, and this great people instead of being the instrument of the ambition of one military tyrant or another, or as formerly the despicable slaves of a set of miserable petty princes, would become a powerful barrier both against Austria and France, and the peace and happiness of the world would receive a great additional security—but I fear the hour is gone by'.*

Bentinck, preparing now for joint military operations on the Continent with Austria and Murat, could do no more than hope that Italy might yet contrive her own liberation. At one point he even thought of going to Bellegarde, the Austrian commander, and proposing that Austria should take as much of Northern Italy as she wanted—as far as the Adda or the Oglio—while Bentinck proclaimed the independence of the rest under a free constitution: then Britain and Austria would hold joint sway and Murat would be 'reduced to nothing'. The thing to do, however, was (he decided) not to make plans, but to keep faith and 'put ourselves in the way of Fortune'.*

On February 28th Bentinck sailed from Palermo with his

expeditionary force, to the tune of a proclamation by the Prince—addressed to the very troops who were supposed to fight side by side with Murat's—in which he stated once again his claim to Naples. On March 9th Bentinck landed at Leghorn and met the Neapolitan generals. On the 14th he issued a proclamation to the Italians at large. In it he offered them Britain's help in throwing off the 'iron yoke of Buonaparte': the help through which Spain had already regained her freedom, while Sicily, happier still, had saved herself from the 'universal deluge':

'Through the beneficent disposition of her Sovereign, she passes from slavery to freedom, and hastens to resume her ancient splendour among the independent Nations. Holland will speedily have attained the same object: is then Italy to remain under the yoke? Shall Italians alone contend against Italians, in favour of a tyrant, and for the thralldom of their country? Italians, hesitate no longer;—be Italians, and let Italy in arms be convinced that the great Cause of the Country is in her hands.'

The 'warriors of Italy' he called upon, not indeed to join him, but to vindicate their own rights and to be free. 'Only call, and we will hasten to your relief; and then Italy, by our united efforts, shall become what she was in her most prosperous periods, and what Spain now is.'*

'Be Italians!' *Voilà le grand mot lâché*. But more was let loose besides words.

CHAPTER VII

THE END OF THE PROTECTORATE

Bentinck was away from Sicily for just over three months, until June 8th, 1814. Brief though it was, this period decided the fate of Italy: at the end of February the Viceroy Eugène was still defending himself in Lombardy and the French still held Liguria and Piedmont; by the end of April the Allies had overrun not only Northern Italy but France itself. Bentinck's acts in this short period were in some way the culmination of his Sicilian proconsulship; and the fall to which they brought him had decisive effects in Sicily.*

Bentinck, we may say, shewed himself at this time strikingly irresponsible. Now his position in Sicily over the past two years had been, in the most literal sense, irresponsible: he had been allowed and even encouraged to go his own way with only the vaguest of instructions, while Ministers in England looked on and waited to see 'what had been done next'. Lately he had become the virtual dictator of Sicily. Bentinck was neither the first nor the last proconsul to kick over the traces when, after having in effect ruled a satellite country, he was suddenly told to obey instructions which he disliked.

Power went to Bentinck's head; there can be little doubt of that. Besides, throughout his Sicilian mission he had never quite given up considering it as a prelude to greater things to come in Italy. Now the curtain was up, and time pressed. Italy's independence—possibly her unification—was in the air. Elisa Bonaparte in Tuscany, Melzi in Lombardy, Caulaincourt and Napoleon himself, all talked of 'cette corde à laquelle répondent tous les vœux'; so did Murat, for his own purposes; so did the Austrian generals, though to be sure their proclamations were addressed to the *peoples* of Italy, Bentinck's to the people. Even Castlereagh, in a more general way, had a little earlier described the war, for Metternich's benefit, as a 'war of national independence' in which 'the people are now the only barrier'.* The difference between these pronouncements and Bentinck's was that Bentinck meant what he said. So much did he desire Italian independence that he jeopardised his career in a reckless and

haphazard attempt to bring it about, though his very disciples in the cause—Lamb and Graham—warned him from the start that he would be playing a lone hand in defiance of his government's policy, which in Italy was anchored to Austria's.* Now Bentinck's conduct in Sicily had not been reckless: in spite of certain velleities—as when, in 1812, he decided for a time to attempt a landing in Italy—he had not in the event overstepped his instructions, wide as those were. But in 1814 it was almost as if he had knowingly staked his position on a gamble against heavy odds. Such gambles, when by chance they succeed, often look to later historians like well-laid plans, and their success appears in retrospect to have been if not always desirable, at any rate inevitable. Bentinck's gamble did not succeed.

Both his new recklessness and his stubborn attachment to the Italian cause came out in his wrangle with Murat. Immediately after Bentinck's landing at Leghorn the two men fell out over who was to occupy Tuscany. Murat wanted it to cover his line of communication to the North; Bentinck suspected that he had his eye on a good deal more. The wrangle went on for a whole month; as it grew Bentinck attempted more and more openly to throw Murat out of the coalition altogether.* Murat was from the start a prey to contradictory influences; there is little point in asking whether Bentinck had some excuse for his initial hostility to '*le plus perfide des Gaules*'—a man more like Maria Carolina than anyone he had ever seen;* whether, too, this behaviour did or did not encourage Murat in his duplicity towards the Allies. Nor is there much point in saying that the alliance with Murat had already become more of an embarrassment than a help, even to Austria, by the time Bentinck came along; nor that the Austrian generals shared Bentinck's distrust of Murat if not his pugnacity; nor even that Castlereagh himself shortly came to describe Murat as a 'worthless dog' who had been 'a mere calculator', and later found Bentinck's stiff-necked attitude at this time highly convenient, since it had left a way open for a reversal of British policy towards Naples.* The main points are two: first, Bentinck kept up his hostility towards Murat in spite of Castlereagh's clear and peremptory orders to the contrary; then he did so not only because he genuinely

despised and distrusted Murat, but because he saw in him the one man who might, if unchallenged, unify Italy for his own evil purposes. As Graham had said, 'military tyrants are not hopeful subjects for conversion into patriot Kings'. But Murat was on the spot; he was powerful; he was attractive; he was a rival all the more dangerous because, it seemed, he had a good chance of succeeding.*

Bentinck himself did not trouble to conceal his hopes. His Italian Levy had landed at Leghorn with a banner bearing the device 'Italian union—national independence'; although there is only tenuous evidence that Bentinck actively helped the Carbonari and other patriotic societies,* he certainly said and did enough to deserve Mier's description of him as a 'prôneur enragé de constitutions', and Ferdinand's complaint that he was behaving 'like Dr Sangrado, who wished to bleed everybody whether they needed it or not'.* Constitution and independence was Bentinck's watchword; the making of a united Italy seems to have been a rather hazier ideal, which might come into being through some process of self-determination. This is shewn by the most notorious episode of Bentinck's Italian career, his single-handed revival of the Genoese Republic. Bentinck's short campaign up the Ligurian coast ended when he took Genoa on April 18th, two days after fighting had stopped in Lombardy. A week later he issued a proclamation restoring the Genoese Constitution as it had stood before France swallowed up the Republic, but modifying it in the spirit of the old sixteenth-century constitution. It was Sicily all over again, with this vital difference—nobody had questioned Sicily's independence, whether real or formal; but Bentinck knew quite well, from specific instructions of Castlereagh's, that he was not to restore any of the old Italian sovereigns apart from Tuscany and Piedmont; in fact he had reason to suspect that the Allies would merge Genoa with Piedmont. That, of course, was exactly what the Allies did in the end, to the cost of the supposed 'vertu anglaise' which—as Stendhal reported three years later—this 'fameux manquement de foi' was to brand in Italy as 'pure tartuferie'. From new documents it appears that by this time Bentinck was far gone in recklessness, for he argued that at Genoa 'the most popular would be to make an arrangement

as definitive as possible which it would be the more difficult for the Allies to upset'; while at the same time he blithely found a loophole in the thought that 'it was always in the hands of the Allies to make whatever arrangement they pleased.'*

Bentinck's conduct, indeed, in these first confused weeks of peace came to look more and more like a desperate gamble. He encouraged the Milanese in their hopes of independence—and therefore in their opposition to Austria, the Power which Castlereagh had time and again told him to cooperate with in Italy. He sent troops to Corsica on what proved to be an abortive repetition of Sir Gilbert Elliot's adventure there. He wished success to certain Neapolitan generals when they secretly approached him and told him they hoped to force a constitution on Murat.* But he was not long to be allowed a free hand in Italy.

Already at the beginning of April Castlereagh had told him that, while he had 'very properly' attempted in the past to free Italy by raising an insurrection—the only system which, previous to the revival of the Continent, could afford a prospect of shaking the power of France—he must not, now that 'a different and better order of things' had come about, give the impression of being 'actuated by "*une arrière-pensée*" inconsistent with the arrangements understood between the great Powers of Europe. . . . It is not insurrection we now want in Italy or elsewhere—we want disciplined force, under Sovereigns we can trust'.* Now, a month later, the storm broke. 'We shall have something to unravel in Corsica, and also at Genoa', wrote Castlereagh to Liverpool: Bentinck's proclamation at Genoa was 'very inconsiderate', and his dealings with the Neapolitan generals shewed

'how intolerably prone he is to Whig revolutions everywhere. I am confident his mismanagement at least doubled all the natural dangers of Murat's rascality; and my persuasion is, if the war had gone on much longer in France, we should have had a most disastrous complication in Italy. . . . He seems bent upon throwing all Italy loose. This might be well as against France, but against Austria and the King of Sardinia, with all the new Constitutions which now menace the world with fresh convulsions, it is most absurd.'*

The 'dream' re-emerged from brief oblivion, and added its weight to that of all the other official grievances against Ben-

tinck. At the same time Castlereagh recollected two convenient facts: in September 1813 Bentinck had asked not only for home leave but also for his recall from the Sicilian mission. All Bentinck now wanted—so he told Castlereagh through his aide-de-camp—was a few months' leave, and he was in fact anxious to stay on in Sicily; but Castlereagh replied merely that 'when I have the pleasure of seeing you in England, we can converse on this subject'.* Meanwhile William A'Court would take over the Palermo mission. So, although Bentinck had not yet been officially recalled, he was already in disgrace. When he sailed from Genoa to Palermo at the beginning of June he knew that he would shortly be going home on leave; but he had good reason besides to suspect that this would be his last visit to Sicily.*

He knew, too, that the appointment of A'Court marked a change of measures as well as of men. Castelficala was probably exaggerating when he told the King that A'Court was his candidate for the Sicilian mission; but he was correct in describing A'Court as 'well intentioned' and 'hostile to popular assemblies in foreign countries'. When it came to Sicily the new Minister—who had been Secretary at Naples between the two French invasions—often sounded more Neapolitan than the Neapolitans. As early as February A'Court, already chosen to be Bentinck's *locum tenens*, had recorded that to his mind the Sicilian constitution had virtually come to an end when Bentinck had sent Parliament packing in October 1813; in any case it was quite unsuited to the Sicilians 'in their present state of ignorance and profligacy'. The end of the war, he said, would mean the end of that British preponderance which alone could make it work.* A'Court's secret instructions, drawn up on March 9th, did not go quite so far: whatever the defects of the Constitution, 'it ought to be the policy of the British Government, who were the original promoters of it, to endeavour to support it, at least in its essential principles'. The excessive dependence of the Crown on Parliament was the 'original error' which the British Minister should use his influence to correct.

'The principle of liberty is admitted by the existence of the Constitution itself and until the Sicilian Patriots shall have been trained to more temperate notions of liberty and popular privileges the excesses of faction are more to be dreaded than those of authority on the part of the Crown.*'

With most of this Bentinck could agree; but he was aware of one crucial fact which the instructions did not convey: as he had long foretold, the British Government had lost interest in their protectorate over Sicily. They had acquired it almost by accident during the war; now they prepared to cast it off with, it seems, the same imperial carelessness. If they weighed the pros and cons of the matter at all they looked not at the island itself but at the whole new balance of power in Europe. Sicily, Liverpool had said apropos of the 'dream', would anyhow be very difficult to manage through the new Constitution; but what mattered was that

'the continental states are more jealous of our obtaining power in the Mediterranean than in any other quarter. Circumstances have induced them to make no difficulty about our retaining Malta, but the idea of our possessing Sicily by an act, which in its most favourable light must be considered as a *douce violence*, could not fail greatly to revolt them.'

Merely to carry on the protectorate, without questioning Sicily's independence, would no doubt have been more *douce a violence* than the original 'dream'. But with the war over it was too embarrassing to be worth while: that at least seems to have been the reasoning which the Government followed even if they did not put it into words. Just how Britain would disentangle herself from her Sicilian commitment was not yet clear. But Bentinck could see that his dictatorship had been a desperate and, as it now turned out, a pointless remedy: in trying to salvage the 'system' he had acted independently from rather than in opposition to his Government, for they had given him neither check nor encouragement. Even now they did not so much reject what he had done as ignore it; in practice their new policy meant that they wished to let the whole matter drop.

Even before he knew of his fall from official favour, Bentinck had written to Castelnovo of his disgust at what he had found in Italy, and his one remaining hope that he might yet 'rendre quelque petit service' to Sicily—'et je prie le bon Dieu avec tout mon cœur de la rendre heureuse'. On 8 June he landed at Palermo. By all accounts the heyday of his recklessness was over; he came back chastened and dejected. None the less he now embarked on a last attempt to save what could be saved of the constitutional system.*

The situation he found was unpromising but not hopeless. Even if Bentinck had returned with his powers intact he would have faced a difficult task. For the almost irreparable break-up of the Patriotic movement had only been suspended during his dictatorship; now, with a new Parliament and a resumption of constitutional government in the offing, the dissensions of 1813 reappeared, still unhealed. The general election, held in May, had produced—thanks to Bonanno's energetic and unscrupulous 'management'—a House of Commons irreproachably constitutional.* But it also raised new difficulties: for the incorruptible Castelnovo, objecting to Bonanno's high-handed methods, signified his disagreement in the usual way, by withdrawing to his tent and refusing to attend Council meetings. More important, the conservatives or King's Friends still swayed the Peers: a complete deadlock between the two Houses was to be expected.*

In such circumstances Bentinck had formerly threatened to abolish or at any rate coerce the Upper House; that was now out of the question. But the very change in the political situation of Sicily which made impossible such bludgeoning methods also offered the chance of a compromise. For the end of the war had raised new anxieties in the minds of some of the leading King's Friends: if the King were to regain Naples—they now saw—not only those parts of the new Constitution which they disliked, but the privileges of their order and the independence of their country, which they really cared about, would be in danger. They, as the King's intimates, may well have known that his disposition was anything but reassuring. True, the news of Louis XVIII's Charte had come as a shock to his absolutist convictions. But at the end of May he was still writing to Castalcicala that if, as he hoped, he managed to recover Naples 'in Paris'—that is, by diplomatic action—he might then 'recover' Sicily from Naples.* At all events some of these conservative nobles—San Marco, Trabia, Campofranco—were fearful enough to approach Castelnovo and Settimo secretly in April and propose a coalition in defence of the constitutional principle and of Sicilian independence. These were essential points on which all could agree; apparently the two groups of men did not even discuss their old differences over the abolition of feudalism,

though if they were to come together that would mean that the Patriotic movement would from then on relapse into a purely aristocratic opposition to royal power. In the present emergency, it seems, Castelnuevo was ready to sacrifice such hopes as he still had of social reform for the sake of achieving political unity and avoiding 'faction'. Men not measures stood in the way of the proposed coalition: the conservatives wished to throw out the Belmontists, whom they accused of jobbery; Castelnuevo, though willing enough to be rid of the Belmontist ministers—Bonanno and Carini—still refused to act without Belmonte himself; and the Belmontists, of course, had no wish to sacrifice themselves. There the matter stood when Bentinck returned to Palermo.*

He found his friends in typically contrasted moods—Castelnuevo so despondent that, he said, only loyalty to Bentinck kept him from giving up politics altogether;* Belmonte so absurdly confident of British protection that he saw no danger at all. Bentinck told all the constitutionalist leaders plainly that he could no longer direct the government or prevent the King from resuming if he wished; all Britain would undertake was to protect her friends from persecution. The Ministers must now 'march by themselves'. Though 'it was no longer my concern', he agreed with Castelnuevo that the proposed coalition was necessary if not palatable; the King's Friends, he thought, 'all wished the Constitution—they wished more for place—but place with a Constitution they would prefer to place without it'. The arrangement would probably not last longer than three months, but that would suffice to get through the parliamentary session and secure the Constitution once and for all. Bentinck therefore entered into negotiations with San Marco and his friends. They made difficulties; they complained of great irregularities in the recent general election and demanded a new one. Bentinck admitted the irregularities, but, he said, they were to be expected given the present state of Sicily. The government must go on and make it its business in future to 'discourage that system of prepotenza by which the country had so long been oppressed—from the Sovereign downwards by every agent of every Baron and by all the agents of every Government'. Taking a longer view, he told them that though the Constitution was

certainly in very bad straits, yet he did not altogether despair of its ultimate success; what Sicily needed above all was such a programme of practical reform as he had tried to launch:

‘Institutions made men good or bad. Administration of Justice had the most influence as well upon national character as upon the tranquillity and good order of society—It was this which alone could rectify the evils of which all complained—Before we could say that the Constitution would not succeed we must see the effect of such new institutions and of time—If in the new Parliament—a good judicial system—roads for commerce and a modification of landed possession so as to disperse landed property more generally—could be settled—more would be done for Sicily in one session than by all its Kings together for the last two or three centuries. I had considered the question of the state of Sicily in all its bearings. If the King should return to Naples, he might if England chose it destroy the Constitution . . . but . . . I really thought that as it was difficult for it to go on, so it was infinitely more difficult for it to go back.’

It was not, however, in the conservative camp that the real difficulties arose, but among Bentinck’s own friends. Belmonte would not budge: he still objected to a coalition and fancied that the government could secure a majority in the Peers without one. ‘Nobody but himself thought so’, Bentinck told him; exasperated at this wilful blindness he complained bitterly to Villafranca that

‘it was all our own fault—we had to accuse nobody but our own littleness—folly—and mismanagement—I knew at first that the Ministry could not go on—Belmonte and Villarmosa I knew would not agree . . . I was heartily disgusted and should be glad to go away. I saw no chance of success but by mixing the Ministry.’*

The Belmontists’ refrain was that the King—by common consent the real menace to the Constitution—‘must be made either nul or friendly’. Bentinck’s and Castelnuevo’s solution was to make him ‘nul’ by detaching his supporters from him. This the Belmontists disliked, and they accordingly began to think of making the King ‘friendly’ instead.

There were signs that such an attempt might succeed better than past experience suggested. For at that very moment the King had changed his tune. Suddenly and unexpectedly—Bentinck reported—he had become

'as anxious for the establishment of the Sicilian Constitution as any of its warmest patriots—not from any diminished affection for principles of the purest despotism, or from diminished hatred for the system or authors of Sicilian liberty; but he has been convinced that it is only by the adoption of more liberal principles that he can regain the throne of Naples: whether from the favourable disposition of the Allied Sovereigns at the approaching Congress, or from the good will of his people.'*

The King had various reasons for this change of front. He felt the need to compete with Murat, who had lately promised a Constitution. Then, should he later recover Naples, the Sicilians might raise fewer obstacles to reunion if they could look forward to a joint constitution for both kingdoms. Probably most important, on June 20th the King heard from Orleans—who had gone to Paris—that the Allied Sovereigns, and especially Alexander, disapproved of his past conduct and thought his return to Naples wholly dependent on the will of the people; they therefore advised him to emulate Louis XVIII's liberal policy. 'These gentlemen are very ready to give *me* advice,' the King grumbled, 'but not at all disposed to follow it in their own case.' Still he was, it seems, convinced for a time that he had better put up a front of unimpeachable constitutionalism in the eyes of Europe; and the best way to do so was to begin at home in Sicily.*

This new attitude of the King's may help to explain the peculiar way in which the Sicilian political crisis was resolved on June 23rd. On that date the constitutionalist leaders met at Bentinck's house to decide finally whether they should form a coalition with the King's Friends. There was a long and heated discussion which led nowhere. Then Belmonte, to everyone's astonishment, proposed that instead of uniting with the King's Friends they should 'amalgamate with the King': that is, they should ask him either to support the Constitution or to resume the government, and they should offer for the sake of unity to alter the make-up of the Government according to his wishes. Nobody knew what to say to this proposal; somehow it was adopted.*

It is still hard to tell what made Belmonte and the Council act as they did. Belmonte may well have taken the King's new professions of constitutionalism at their face value. Perhaps, too,

he wished at all costs to forestall the coalition—which would have left his party no more than a subordinate place—and fancied that he could recover, with the King's favour, the position of Prime Minister which Bentinck had taken away from him in 1813. Yet there is also evidence that nobody thought the King would have the energy or the desire to resume the cares of government: so the approach to the King may originally have been a gesture: if approached he would have had to come out into the open and, perhaps, call off the Peers' opposition. It may also be that neither Belmonte nor the others acted from motives capable of logical explanation, but that, tired of argument and unable to break the deadlock, they simply took the first way out that offered. As for Bentinck, he would certainly have preferred a coalition, and Belmonte's move seems to have irritated him even more than usual. But by now he could no longer impose his own solution: indeed, he most likely felt like washing his hands of the whole business.*

The Prince, after he had got over his initial surprise, drew up a memorandum telling his father of the Council's proposal. But he did not merely give him the alternative of supporting or resuming the government; instead he seized the opportunity to urge the King to resume: in this way the King would prove 'your adherence to those liberal ideas which, as you well know, are the spring that can move the Allies in your favour . . . your present conduct will be the best guarantee of what you mean to do at Naples'. Bentinck countenanced the Prince's memorandum, though he refused to sign it himself, since—he said—judging from past experience he could scarcely advise the King to resume. He was right. The King surprised nearly everybody by hastening to take his son's advice. Before resuming, however, he asked Bentinck to release him from the promise he had made in March 1813 not to do so without British consent. Bentinck acquiesced; but since Circello, who acted as go-between, kept proclaiming that his master was now '*furieux constitutionelliste*', Bentinck seized his opportunity too; he dissolved the engagement, he stated, because the King had declared that he meant 'to cherish the Constitution' and to adopt the liberal conduct 'so strongly recommended by the advice and enforced by the example of the highest and most august authorities'. By this

last act Bentinck thought to provide his Government with an excuse for intervening in defence of the Constitution if they should ever be minded to do so.*

On July 4th the events of March 1813 recurred with an ironical difference. The King drove through Palermo amid cheering crowds; next day he resumed the government. At the same time, and once again unexpectedly, he accepted the Ministers' resignations. Then—as if to shew that Bentinck's dictatorship had been no more than an unconstitutional interregnum—he brought back to power all the men whose dismissal Bentinck had previously forced on the Prince: that is, Ferreri and the other puppet Ministers who had gone out in October 1813; and the Court officials—one of them Cassaro—whom Bentinck had deprived of their posts in April 1813. The festivities attending the King's return went on for three nights. 'The people shewed very great satisfaction', and already the outgoing constitutionalists were being hissed in the streets.*

Bentinck, in the official despatch he wrote to Castlereagh just after the King's return—his last despatch from Sicily—spoke of his seemingly unreserved pleasure at 'this happy termination of the long and embarrassing relation which has existed for so many years between the two governments'. In a private letter of the same date he gave a curious account of his feelings:

'The return of the King to power, under all the circumstances, I consider to be one of the best pieces of good luck that ever happened to me; and offers a pont d'or, over which I shall be most happy to make my retreat from Sicilian affairs. My private feelings have long made me desirous of leaving a situation which has materially interfered with my military views.—I however determined to sacrifice every view of my own (and for this reason did ask you to allow me to remain in Sicily) as long as I thought that my presence could contribute to the happiness of the Sicilians—I feel no longer any obligation on this score—the Sicilian Government has again resumed its independence; and agreeing, as all seem to do, in the desire to establish the Constitution and a fixed order of things. I should hope it will be able to go on by itself.—At any rate our interference is no longer a matter of necessity.'

This is at first sight puzzling, since in fact Bentinck saw clearly enough—as we know from his journal—that 'no dependence [was] to be placed' in the King's professions of constitu-

tionalism.* The likeliest explanation is that in writing to Castlereagh, whom he knew to be unsympathetic, he wished to put as good a face as possible on his personal disappointment. But it may be that Bentinck was still trying not to admit his own misgivings, even to himself and even so late in the day as this. If so he was soon undeceived. Of the drastic changes made in the Government he complained to the King and Circello that they betrayed 'too much aigreur and prevention . . . towards the actual system' and belied the King's promise to 'reunite all parties'; but he met with the bland rejoinder that the King was 'the most constitutional of all': the new Ministry was in fact the *old* and, Circello implied, the only constitutional Ministry. He was also depressed to find in A'Court, who had landed at Palermo at the end of June, a self-confessed Voltairean cynic, hostile to all popular assemblies, confident of Castlereagh's sympathy, and armed 'with the worst opinion (not very much undeserved) of the Sicilians and with a deep conviction amounting almost to an irritable determination that the Constitution cannot and shall not succeed'.* Bentinck could do no more. According to one report, he did once contemplate taking some drastic step against the King, but thought better of it; he got A'Court to write a rather futile statement half-promising to defend the 'system' in Bentinck's absence; shortly before his departure he was seen wandering in dejection through the countryside near Palermo. On July 16th Bentinck sailed from Palermo for the last time.*

Bentinck was allowed to keep the military command in Italy until April 1815, when yet another ill-timed display of constitutionalism—this time in Piedmont—brought about his summary recall. But Liverpool already thought him 'mad', and Castlereagh was at one with Metternich in wishing to keep him away from the Mediterranean; he had already fallen into that official disfavour which kept him out of the government service for the next thirteen years.* Looking back on his Italian and Sicilian career, Bentinck was unrepentant:

'Like Cassandra' (he wrote to Hamilton in January 1815) 'I preached in vain. I always thought that Italy alone could have decided the war against Bonaparte. I was very much gratified in hearing the other day that Bonaparte himself had said . . . that the British Government had

never seemed to know its own importance in Italy. He added that we were held in the greatest veneration. True it is that there is no part of the world where the British name is equally respected. It is love and admiration without alloy. They look upon us as the natural friends of independence . . . who from policy and feeling cannot but be always inclined to protect them from internal and external oppression. You can have no idea how rapidly the spirit of discontent and union is spreading throughout Italy. Murat *cannot now* in my opinion be driven out. . . . Every Italian would join him . . . I confess I should be glad to see the attempt made as far as regards Italy, because I think its independence would be established and besides the interest I take in the Italian people, I am convinced that there can be no other effectual barrier against either France or Austria . . . I assure you it grieves me to the heart to see our reputation and interests so unnecessarily thrown away. . . . It seems as if we were anxious and in a hurry, as if it was entirely our own act to sacrifice and disregard all national feeling and supposed national rights. . . . Pardon this political digression. . . .’*

As for Sicily, ‘if the whole Sicilian business were published from one end to the other,’ he wrote, ‘I should be rather glad than sorry . . .’. He could not rid himself of his concern with Sicily, and he still corresponded with the few Sicilians who had remained his friends. He was furious, he wrote to Castelnuovo, when he thought of the golden chances Sicily had missed ‘faute de courage, de vertu, et de patriotisme. . . . Je vous jure que je suis dégoûté de votre pays. S’il n’y avait pas des hommes comme vous et votre digne ami Ruggiero [Settimo], et quelques autres en fort petit nombre, je douterais presque si la Sicile pourrait produire quelque chose de bon. Espérons que ceux-ci serviront d’exemple à une meilleure postérité.’*

In truth both the protectorate and the Patriotic movement had run their course, though outwardly their collapse dragged on until December 1816. Shortly after Bentinck’s departure, the King dissolved the Constitutionalist Commons which Bonanno’s ‘management’ had got together; by another general election he acquired a new Parliament, virtually a replica of that of 1813, both in its membership and in the irresponsible conduct it kept up throughout the winter and spring of 1814-15. In effect the King gave the Sicilians rope enough to hang themselves. He could not afford a drastic change while his return to Naples remained uncertain; and he was shrewd enough to know

—if not wise enough to adapt himself to the fact—that, however suicidal the behaviour of Parliament, it would not freely consent to the loss of Sicily's constitution and independence.* Meanwhile A'Court carried out, loyally enough, his appointed task of trying to have the Constitution revised along the lines of Louis XVIII's Charte, and of protecting Britain's former friends from the King's vengeance. The attempt was fruitless; where even the best-disposed man would probably have failed, limited as the British Minister now was to advice and remonstrance, A'Court found his initial contempt for the Sicilians—'this infamous race' of whom there was 'nothing too bad to be said'—speedily confirmed.*

Sicily's fate was in fact decided not at Palermo, but at the Congress of Vienna, and then—when Napoleon came back and Murat joined him—at Waterloo and Tolentino. In May 1815 Ferdinand dissolved Parliament for the last time and sailed to Naples. There ensued the piecemeal destruction of Sicily's constitution and independence, until in December 1816 Ferdinand proclaimed the union of the two kingdoms and, in the words of a contemporary historian, made of Sicily a 'posthumous conquest of Napoleon':* for almost at one stroke he swept away every one of her native institutions—those handed down from Norman and Aragonese days together with those set up in 1812—and put in their place the centralised French system which Joseph Bonaparte had already introduced at Naples in 1806.

This counter-revolution did not spring from the King's personal wishes alone: he had promised Austria not to allow in his dominions institutions at variance with those of Austria's Italian territories.* This engagement, and its consequences, were quite in line with Castlereagh's policy of giving Austria a free hand in Italy; but they were scarcely in line with Britain's Sicilian policy over the last few years. Hence the last act had to wait on complicated negotiations among the British, Austrian, and Neapolitan Governments, the result of which was that—for the benefit of the British Parliament—there was inserted in the decrees of 1816 a reference to a Sicilian Parliament which had in fact ceased to exist. By this means—so A'Court maintained—the whole course of British intervention in Sicily was made to 'offer a plain, honourable, and consistent tale'.*

The Sicilian adventure was over. Already in 1815 the British garrison had been withdrawn and A'Court had left Palermo for Naples.

Belmonte had died in Paris in 1814; he had gone there, it seems, in the hope of winning Castlereagh's support for the Constitution. He was mourned by the two men—Bentinck and Castelnovo—whom in his life he had most often exasperated. As for Castelnovo, he tried for a while longer to salvage something of the 'system' by cooperating with the King. But after May 1815 he withdrew into private life, steadily refusing to pay taxes to an unconstitutional government except under duress, and bequeathing, at his death in 1822, £25,000 to anyone who should induce the King to restore the Constitution.* Ruggiero Settimo, indeed, lived to see it briefly restored in 1848, and Sicily herself united with the rest of Italy in 1860.

But if Britain's Sicilian adventure was over, could it be quite undone? Castlereagh apparently thought it could. In June 1821, after Laibach, Bentinck presented a motion in the House of Commons calling on the Government to intervene in defence of Sicilian liberties. The point he—and later Sir James Mackintosh—made was that by her intervention in 1811-14 Britain had pledged her 'good faith and national honour' in support of those liberties: she ought at the very least to see that the Sicilians kept the liberties they had enjoyed before that intervention, instead of leaving them infinitely worse off than she had found them. Castlereagh's reply was that in any case it was a mere 'oratorical flourish' to talk of a Sicilian Constitution, old or new; that of 1812 was one of the most unsuitable ever devised, and he ridiculed its makers for having tried to ape British institutions—why, they had even, he believed, sent for the measurements of the table he was leaning upon. As for the union with Naples, he 'felt some lurking impression' that Sicily, far from feeling aggrieved, 'would be happier in consequence . . . that union was calculated to raise her to whatever importance Naples might be supposed to possess'. The heart of his argument concerned 'the nature of the connexion of England and Sicily':

'Although Government had always felt a strong esteem and affection for that country, yet it was not merely on that account, or to secure the happiness of the people, that British troops were stationed there. It was,

in fact, a military occupation . . . with the exception of having guaranteed to the Sicilian people, not to form a constitution, but to protect that part of the dominions of the King of the Two Sicilies, this government had entered into no arrangements of an express nature with them. . . . It was true that while the British troops were in the country it was found necessary that a strong interposition should take place on the part of the British power, for the purpose of impressing on the mind of the Sicilian Government the propriety of supporting a constitution. If this had not been done, the government could not have gone on, and the place would not have been fit for a military station. The consequence of this interposition was, that the noble lord [Bentinck] was "mixed up" in a great variety of remonstrances [a laugh] . . . but he certainly never did feel that in resorting to those remonstrances, the noble lord was doing anything more than what was necessary for his military occupation of the island. He never supposed that the noble lord was entering into any arrangements with respect to the Sicilian constitution.'

Any new interference by the British Government would therefore be 'unjustifiable and impracticable'. The House supported him by 69 votes to 35.*

Castlereagh was of course right in one sense—perhaps the only sense that Governments can safely understand or attend to, though we may wonder. Given his broad European policy from 1814 onward, he could not possibly have gone on maintaining a protectorate or shoring up a constitution that nowhere fitted in with that policy. To the greater end of European balance and peace he had to sacrifice not only Sicily's half-formed aspirations, which doubtless he cared little about, but some small part also of Britain's name. For if morality enters at all into the history of international affairs—and keep it out though we may at the door it flies in at the skylight—a great Power is surely at once unwise and wrong if it fails to 'connect': if, that is, it assumes like Castlereagh that it can interfere in the affairs of a small Power, alter by its weight the course of events, and then withdraw and discard responsibility as though nothing had happened. Something does happen, and something did happen in Sicily. No doubt the reforming movement was weak and weakly rooted; but it was there, and the British intervention, by carrying it to deceptive heights which it could probably not have measured by its own strength alone, made sure that the ensuing fall would seem all the deeper. True, ifs and ans are no

part of history; we cannot say that if something had not gone wrong something else would have gone right. But if causes cannot here be easily disentangled—or the British intervention set apart from the Sicilian movement when in fact both acted on one another—no more can we disentangle their remoter effects and say that this cause mattered while that was incidental. The crisis of these years was an historical event; the conflicts that shaped it, and whose course it in turn shaped, perpetuated themselves, partly in the upheavals of 1848 and 1860, but still more in a divided and half-petrified society, and in that moral divorce between Sicily and the continental Power that rules it which has affected so much of the island's history, even down to the present day. No one who knows how much there is in that history of bitterness and frustration can feel quite satisfied.

APPENDICES

APPENDIX A

WILLIAM DRUMMOND'S MISSION TO SICILY 1806-1808

While the peace negotiations of 1806 were still going on, Fox had reminded Holland of 'the great importance of Sicily, which you, young one, very much underrate'.* After the failure of the negotiations, the Grenville Ministry had to decide on a long-term Sicilian policy. Neither Sicily nor its King could be abandoned to French aggression; but something had to be done to counteract the 'unfortunate' and 'disgusting' behaviour of the Court, to which the outgoing Minister, Hugh Elliot, attributed the loss of Naples.* Besides, Grenville himself considered that England must continue to protect Sicily and Sardinia after a peace, 'and thus make of all these islands in the Mediterranean an important chain of stations highly useful to us both in war and in commerce'.*

The new Minister, William Drummond, was accordingly sent out with instructions to conclude a treaty giving Britain, among other things, the right to garrison Messina in peacetime, and the commercial status of most-favoured nation. He was to secure Sicily's fullest cooperation in the war: therefore, Howick wrote, 'whenever you may see the common safety endangered by the operation of causes likely to defeat this necessary end, you will not fail to interfere with the whole weight of your authority and influence. . . . Observing upon all occasions the respect which is due to an ancient and independent government, you will endeavour . . . to prevent any waste of the resources which Sicily can furnish for its own defence; whether it shall arise from improvident laws and privileges, or from the corruption of the public authorities. . . . The large sacrifices which His Majesty has made and continues to make for the support of the King of the Two Sicilies gives you an undisputed right to interpose with your advice, even if that right were not to be found in the consideration which you owe to the interests of His Sicilian Majesty Himself.' The resources of 'so fertile an island', wisely used, might even prove sufficient to its own defence: to this end Drummond was particularly to urge, though

'with proper delicacy and caution', reforms in financial and military administration. As for Naples, the British Government could give no absolute pledge that its recovery would be made a condition *sine qua non* of a peace, but they undertook to do their best to secure it.*

Drummond arrived at Palermo in December 1806 to find the Court in even greater turmoil than usual. The aged favourite Sir John Acton had been 'wormed out' of the government three months earlier by the Queen's Franco-Neapolitan faction, who now held undisputed control. Acton's and Elliot's advice had been to consolidate the defence of Sicily before embarking on an attempt against Naples; but the Queen wished, as she said, 'd'entamer la chose, de faire une explosion générale', and she encouraged indiscriminate risings by the *masse* (brigands) in Calabria. She was furious at the British generals' refusal to fall in with her plans, though by her own admission the Sicilian army was in a deplorable state, and could have given little help. Moreover, Drummond found convincing though not conclusive evidence that she had been intriguing with Russia for a strong force to be sent to Sicily, and was even then negotiating secretly with France. 'The reason for this detestable treachery', he wrote, 'arises partly from the abhorrence of the Queen and her minions for everything English; and partly from the belief that France is stronger than England, and that sooner or later France will become masters of Sicily. . . . We must remember the enemies with whom we have to contend both without and within the island of Sicily.' The British Commander-in-Chief at Messina, Gen. Henry Fox, was a sick and elderly man, and in his disgust with the Court he scarcely troubled to keep up relations with them. Sir John Moore, his second-in-command, thought the inhabitants were ripe for revolt against their hated government: 'if we do not, as they wish, rescue them from it, they will throw themselves into the arms of France. By what means we are to do this I shall not say, but the possession of Sicily is a most important object, whether as a military post or as a valuable colony. If the Court of Palermo and the present government continue . . . I doubt if we shall hold it. Were they removed and the island declared English we should, with the hearts of the people and the energy which I think they could still be brought to display

in a cause they approved, be able to maintain it against the world'. To cap the crisis, the Sicilian Government rejected the draft treaty in language which Drummond found evasive and even 'apparently hostile'. Faced with this situation, he stopped payment of the subsidy and wrote home for instructions.*

Howick, after consultation with other Ministers, drafted a reply instructing Drummond to achieve four main objects: '1st. The conclusion of the treaty according to the original projet; 2ndly: The removal of obnoxious and suspicious persons from the Councils of the Court; 3rdly. The admission of Sicilians to places of trust and confidence, or in other words, a *Sicilian administration*; 4thly. The enlargement of the powers of the British Commander in Chief over the Sicilian Army.' The fourth point was 'indispensable'. As for the second, Drummond was if possible to obtain for himself a discretionary power to remove undesirable foreigners from Palermo. The Court must be induced to pay attention to the Sicilians' needs 'and even to their wishes'; if necessary they should be persuaded to call an extraordinary Parliament, for 'without the exertions of the Sicilians, His Majesty [George III] was aware that his efforts to preserve Sicily must prove fruitless'. Drummond was allowed considerable latitude as to the means of carrying out his instructions. Amicable methods were best: he might remonstrate with the Government, advise the King, and engage in talks with the Sicilian nobles—Belmonte was suggested as a likely man. If need be Drummond could go on withholding the subsidy: and if any danger immediately threatened Sicily's independence, he and the British commanders were to decide on measures to save it. 'Sicily', Howick wrote, 'must not directly or indirectly fall under the control of France.'*

Howick's draft is dated March 1807. The Ministry of All the Talents fell on the 25th of that month, and the instructions were never sent out. Canning reversed Howick's policy completely. He removed from the draft treaty, as 'unseasonable', the clauses giving Britain commercial privileges and a peacetime garrison: in his instructions to Drummond he confined himself to saying that Britain had a claim on the King of Sicily's confidence and on his cooperation in the war.*

Meanwhile Drummond had anticipated his government's

change of policy by a change of heart of his own. He was by way of being a student of political philosophy; he knew the Court from his residence as Minister at Naples from 1801 to 1803; and he had come to Palermo 'most strongly prejudiced against the Sicilian government, and not without the intention, if I found my opinions confirmed by experience, of proposing measures which would have in fact rendered Sicily a province of Great Britain'. Now, however, he found that there was not *one* patriotic party, but any number of factions, jealous of each other, though 'all united in desiring to maintain those feudal rights, those instruments of tyranny by which they oppressed the peasantry'. Corruption and superstition reigned everywhere; of political vision he found very little. 'So many reports were spread concerning the fate of the island, so many fine projects of change were suggested, so many splendid plans of reform were imagined, and so many little half-developed embryos of revolution began to shew themselves, that neither the nobles nor the people seemed to know very well to what government they were to belong. Every man who had the leisure built his political system according to his own fancy, and to suit his own convenience. . . . The Sicilians desired to receive laws from others, rather than to make laws for themselves. Some wished the French, and some the English to govern here, for men who are not for their country may be for anybody.' Only unequivocal proofs of the Court's 'treachery' would have justified him in overthrowing it; but such a revolution, besides being distasteful to him, could only succeed with the cooperation of the Sicilian people. Any reform of this 'Constitution seven hundred years old in every species of political malady' must therefore attack feudal privilege as well as Court misrule; it was bound to be difficult and dangerous; above all it must be carried out by the Sicilians themselves without foreign interference. 'The seat of legislature should rather be a Sicilian Parliament than a British camp.'*

Drummond therefore decided to come to an understanding with the Court, even before he had received fresh instructions. He agreed to changes in the draft treaty; and he resumed payment of the subsidy on receiving the King's promise that the Queen and the French émigrés would no longer have any share in government, and that all important business would be

transacted among the King, Circello, and himself. The Queen seemed at first to acquiesce in this arrangement. 'She even promised that if I would shew her any degree of confidence she would endeavour to introduce the English Constitution into Sicily. I will undertake to do this without Her Majesty's assistance, which I am not particularly disposed to require.'*

Drummond's assurances that 'the Queen's faction rules no longer, either in appearance or in reality', met with derision from the staff officers at Messina, who thought the Court had merely hoodwinked him. Moore continued to protest that the Court was interested in Naples only and cared nothing for Sicily, and that an invasion of Italy would be useless 'unless we had command of the King's person, and unless the Queen and all her emissaries were removed, and we had the complete direction of the government. Nothing short of this would give confidence to the people or induce them to join us, and without the people it was vain to hope for permanent success in Italy.' He talked of expelling the Queen to Trieste: 'this was never proposed to be adopted', he admitted, '... but only mentioned ... if possible to be done, it would be the surest way to quiet Sicily.' Even when after a few months the King again eclipsed himself, and the Queen openly returned to the Council, Drummond went on asserting that her influence was exaggerated: she herself, he said, was a mere dupe of the French party; the King was a firm friend of England, and would remain one if he was not frightened by the revolutionary chatter among the officers at Messina; and he, Drummond, had good hopes of persuading him presently to effect a gradual reform through Parliament, and to remove the Queen once more from the government. Belmonte he dismissed as a 'Gallicised smatterer', and he complained that the 'speculators' and advocates of wholesale reform made his mission of persuasion difficult. After Moore had been recalled, partly as a result of his obstreperous conduct, Drummond claimed that 'perfect union' now prevailed among the Court, the commanders, and himself: he expected great things of the Court's decision to raise a Sicilian militia of 40,000 men, and declared that Sicily was at last coming out of her lethargy. Yet his optimism was punctured again and again by unpleasant discoveries. He found that the 'infatuated Queen ... with

her usual inconsistency' was intriguing with the Russian Minister for an arrangement whereby Ferdinand would be restored to Naples, and France would receive Sicily as compensation: he then had to bombard Circello with Notes until he had forced the government to break with Russia and hand the Minister his passports. His suspicions were aroused by intelligence of the Queen's clandestine correspondence with the Continent; he was particularly annoyed by a secret proclamation of Moliterno's, intended for circulation on the continent of Italy, and intercepted by the British officer in command at Capri, in which Moliterno bade the Italians rise, proclaim Ferdinand King of Italy, and drive out *all* foreigners. Drummond protested to the King and Circello, but their reassurances failed to convince him. Still, he had committed himself too far to retreat: and he continued on the whole to pin his hopes on the King.*

Drummond was in a difficult position. The Court clamoured for an invasion of Italy, a plan he approved: but it had constantly to be put off during 1807 and 1808, either because the British garrison was depleted, or a French invasion was feared, or the state of the Continent made it impossible. The Court knew, besides, that the British Government still would not commit themselves to the recovery of Naples at a peace. So Drummond got little thanks from the Court, and little support from anyone. It was, one may say, Drummond's vanity in thinking he could manage the Court by his own influence alone, without support, which led to his downfall. He had already irritated Canning by forcing, on his own initiative, a break between Sicily and Russia. A few months later he caused serious embarrassment to the British Government by furthering, again on his own initiative, and unofficially, the Court's claim to the Regency of Spain. Canning recalled him at once, in September 1808.*

APPENDIX B

DOCUMENTS CONCERNING THE 'DREAM'

I

BENTINCK TO THE HEREDITARY PRINCE, CATANIA,
3 DEC. 1813

'... A présent, Monseigneur, je viens vous présenter les rêves d'un Voyageur. J'y suis encouragé par la bonté avec laquelle V.A.R. a toujours écouté mes pensées, qui n'ont jamais eu autre mérite, que la sincérité et le désir du bien général. Depuis que j'ai mieux connu la Nation Sicilienne, sa situation future a été l'objet de mes sérieuses réflexions, et de mes vives inquiétudes. L'indépendance de la Sicile, et la séparation des deux Couronnes a été voté par le Parlement et quoique la Nation soit divisée sur d'autres points, cependant elle est unanime contre toute connexion avec le Royaume de Naples; et je doute que la réunion puisse encore s'opérer sans une grande effusion de sang. Il est certain que l'entreprise deviendra de jour en jour plus difficile.

Mais il est clair en même temps que l'administration du Gouvernement de la Sicile sans l'appui d'une force indépendante sera presque impossible. La Nation ne peut pas être confiée à elle même. Il y aurait à craindre tous les causes de la Révolution Française.

La Nation donc pour le moment ne peut pas se gouverner elle même, ne veut pas être gouvernée par les Napolitains et il ne conviendra pas je m'imagine à l'Angleterre de continuer le frais de l'entretien d'une force protectrice après la paix générale.

Voici donc, Monseigneur, mon rêve. Laissez le soin de la Sicile à l'Angleterre, qui peut seule, j'ose dire, la gouverner avantageusement, et pour la Sicile et pour le Royaume de Naples. Au roi de Naples la Sicile n'a jamais été d'aucun avantage. Elle a été au contraire un embarras. Le Roi n'en a jamais tiré un soldat, et les revenus n'ont pas même suffi pour payer les troupes nécessaires pour la contenir. Le Roi a perdu des hommes, et n'a pas gagné de l'argent. Dorénavant la dépense doit augmenter et V.A.R. peut bien juger si les revenus de l'Isle peuvent être augmentées dans la même proportion.

Sous le Gouvernement Anglais la Sicile seroit tranquille, et avec le temps deviendrait florissante. Elle pourroit être un ami très utile, et jamais dangereux, à Naples parce qu'il ne peut jamais convenir à l'Angleterre d'avoir des possessions continentales.

Pour rendre un pareil arrangement de la plus haute utilité au Roi de Naples, mon idée seroit, 1° Ou que le Royaume de Naples aurait un arrondissement en Italie le quel cependant, à dire vrai, me parait difficile. Parce que, come la conduite de Buonaparte vis-à-vis du Pape est aux yeux de l'Europe un acte des plus injustes qu'il ait commis, ainsi les Alliés probablement se feront une gloire de le rétablir dans tous ses pouvoirs tant spirituels que temporels. 2° Ou si cela n'était pas possible, que le Roi et la famille Royale recevrait de l'Angleterre une compensation annuelle égale à toute la liste civile, et en outre que l'Angleterre s'obligerait de tenir à la disposition du Roi de Naples une Armée calculée sur l'état militaire le plus étendu que la Sicile pourrait soutenir même dans la supposition la plus favorable de sa position future—dites—dix mille hommes (10,000).

Une pareille liaison observée avec bonne foi pourrait mener à des plus grandes avantages, et en cas de nécessité, le Royaume de Naples pourrait avoir l'assistance de toutes les forces Britanniques de la même manière que l'Espagne et le Portugal l'ont eu dernièrement.

Voilà, Monseigneur, mon rêve. Je voudrais que l'exécution puisse commencer avec le rétablissement du Roi dans le Royaume de Naples. Je suis d'opinion que les événements mèneront à une paix générale, et je voudrais que Bonaparte ne fût pas à même de profiter de la surprise dans la quelle l'Europe se trouve par de succès si grands et si inattendus, et qu'il ne fasse pas une paix, avant que les intérêts de toutes les autres Puissances aient été bien considéré dans un congrès général.

Je suis de V.A.R. avec le plus profond respect le très dévoué serviteur.

W. C. BENTINCK

NOTE. The text of Bentinck's letter is that given by Capograssi (p. 156) from the original in the Bourbon Archives. The copy in the Foreign

Office files (FO 70/63) shews a number of variant readings. Most of these are insignificant and seem to have been introduced by the copyist (Andrew Douglas, Bentinck's Secretary of Legation) in order to improve the French. It is interesting, however, that in this copy the sentence 'Je voudrais que l'exécution puisse commencer avec le rétablissement du Roi dans le Royaume de Naples' is omitted. In February 1814, when this copy was sent to Castlereagh, the armistice with Murat had already been signed, and such an expression of legitimist feeling might have seemed inappropriate.

II

GRAHAM'S ACCOUNT OF HIS CONVERSATION
WITH CASTLEREAGH

'... We then discussed the subject of your private letter, and I detailed to His Lordship your plan for the permanent occupation of Sicily as a British Territory: he said in the case where it was built on the restoration of Ferdinand to the Crown of Naples, our engagements with Murat were decisive: he himself had no idea, neither did he desire, that those engagements should be violated: if however Murat still refused to cooperate and remained unsatisfied with the explanation Your Lordship was directed to give him, then, if we could recover Naples, your plan became feasible and worthy of consideration.

In the case of an indemnity, he feared it was not practicable; for no State we could give as compensation for Naples and no sum of money we could offer would, he conceived, be sufficient temptation for the relinquishment of such an island as Sicily.

I then insisted at great length on the extreme impolicy of evacuating it at a peace, and urged the Treaty with Murat as an imperative reason why Sicily never could be safe without a British garrison.

I am happy to say His Lordship coincided most entirely in your opinion; he saw no difficulty in obtaining the consent of the King of Sicily to the arrangement; and the Allies would readily allow us to act in this respect as we chose. France at any other moment would have been an insurmountable obstacle; but humbled as she was, no objection of hers would avail, and in a peace he would particularly guard against any compromise of the question.

The only difficulty he foresaw was in our Treaty with Murat, who, precisely because he would wish for an occasion to conquer Sicily, would violently object to our occupation of it: but this might be met by an article, on which the British Government would insist, stipulating that Murat should consent to any agreement which Great Britain might conclude with the King of Sicily on this point.

On the whole His Lordship entered most cordially into your view of this question and promised not to lose sight of it during the negotiations. . . . I have no doubt, therefore, My Lord, if the present negotiations should happily terminate in a peace, that your hopes for Sicily will not be disappointed. . . .'

(James Graham to Bentinck, 7 March 1814, B.P.)

APPENDIX C

BENTINCK'S CONDUCT AT GENOA

By the middle of April 1814 Bentinck's army had reached the outskirts of Genoa after a short campaign up the Riviera by way of Sarzana and Nervi. On the 18th the Genoa garrison surrendered; two days earlier the armistice of Schiarino Rizzino had brought to an end the Viceroy Eugène's able defence of Lombardy against the Austrians and Murat. Paris had fallen, but the war in France was not yet over officially.* On April 26th Bentinck issued a proclamation in which he declared that, in accordance with the wishes of the people, and with the principle—'recognised by the High Allied Powers'—of restoring the old sovereigns, the Constitution of the Genoese Republic was re-established as it had stood in 1797, 'with those modifications which the general wish, the public good, and the spirit of the original Constitution of 1576, seem to require'. The Austrian generals had been proclaiming the return of the old sovereigns all over Northern Italy; but Bentinck had been enjoined by Castlereagh on March 30th not to commit himself to the restoration of any of them except the King of Piedmont and the Grand-Duke of Tuscany. The result of Bentinck's act was, of course, that Britain had to repudiate it and, by endorsing the annexation of Genoa to Piedmont, to confirm her reputation as *Perfidious Albion*.*

Bentinck, when he came to justify himself, told Bathurst that it was all very well to settle the fate of Genoa at a peace, but

'I had to provide for a state of war. My duty commanded me to ensure the success of the war in Italy, which the weakness of the Austrian army, and the treachery of Murat, might at any time bring to a conclusion the most unfavourable to the Allied arms. . . .' The fact that Genoa as a military place was untenable without more troops than Bentinck disposed of made it 'indispensable for me to secure the tranquillity and cordial cooperation of the Genoese. Without these the further advance of the British force became hazardous and in case of reverse, the preservation of what I had, precarious.—No other measure as I thought but the one I adopted could have effected these objects. . . . I cannot but still continue to think that the form of the Provisional Government was not only advisable but necessary.'*

Bentinck's private campaign diary tells a different story. On April 22nd—he recorded—he told a deputation of Genoese officials that he would set up a provisional government, 'their final disposition necessarily depending upon the decision of the high Allied Powers'. During the next three days he discussed the matter with some of the leading Genoese—Pareto, Serra, Durazzo—and found them aristocratically inclined but 'liberal enough'. On April 26th, the date of the Proclamation, he wrote:

'It was a question whether in the Proclamation it should be stated that this arrangement was to continue until the Allies should otherwise order—but it was considered that the most popular would be to make an arrangement as definitive as possible which it would be the more difficult for the Allies to upset. The union with Piedmont as supposed likely was most of all offensive to the Genoese. With the Milanese they would not equally dislike to be annexed—but their original independence seemed the universal wish—I thought it politic for Great Britain that is for her interests and influence that the wishes of the people should receive her consideration while it was always in the hands of the Allies to make whatever arrangement they pleased.'

We may never know just what Bentinck thought he was doing; to judge from the muddle-headedness exhibited in this curious document, he scarcely knew himself.

NOTES

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landlords' agents or chief tenants. Michele Amari estimated that the Third Estate was at this period no larger, or very slightly larger, than the nobility: preface to N. Palmeri, *Saggio storico-politico sulla costituzione del Regno di Sicilia* (Lausanne, 1847), xxxi.

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a constitutional conflict between Crown and Parliament. The power of the nobility may be judged by the fact that, numbering as they did about 2,300 out of a population of about 1,500,000, they held under their jurisdiction (according to the latest, and incomplete, survey, that of 1747-8) 282 towns and lands (*feudi*) as against 85 in the Royal Domain, and 780,688 inhabitants as against 395,967 (Palermo, then the second city of Italy, with 180,000 inhabitants, was not included in the survey). There was no up-to-date register of fiefs, duties, boundaries etc.; taxes had therefore to be assessed on the basis of *riveli*, i.e. declarations of value by the occupiers. One of the most important points in Caracciolo's programme of reform was the carrying out of a thorough *Catasto* (survey) of all lands; it was also, for obvious reasons, the point over which the Viceroy and the barons in Parliament had their most serious clash: E. Pontieri, *Il Tramonto del Baronaggio Siciliano* (Florence, 1943), 92 ff., 222 ff. (This work gives (pp. 195-283) the most up-to-date and elaborate account of Caracciolo's Viceroyalty; cf. also B. Croce, 'Il Marchese Caracciolo', in *Uomini e Cose della vecchia Italia* (Bari, 1927); F. De Stefano, *Storia della Sicilia* (Bari, 1948), 274-7; R. Romeo, *Il Risorgimento in Sicilia* (Bari, 1950), 50-65.)

those rights were still unquestioned. The Sicilian Parliament was made up of three Estates (*Braccia*), the Militare (barons), Ecclesiastico, and Demaniale (communes of the Royal Domain). Of the great powers it had held under the Aragonese, it had by the 18th century lost the legislative and judicial; but it kept those of voting *donativi* (i.e. taxes designed to supplement the revenue the Crown enjoyed of its own right from customs, dues, etc.; there were ordinary *donativi*—a variety of taxes making up a fixed revenue, voted as a matter of course by successive Parliaments—and extraordinary *donativi* provided for emergencies); of petitioning the Crown; and of electing the Deputation of the Realm—a delegate body supposed to supervise the collection and administration of the revenue, and the enforcement of laws, during the four-year interval between Parliaments. Actually, until the 1780's these powers had been accepted as merely formal. The Deputation was in practice nominated by the Crown, as was the Braccio Demaniale itself. It was never suggested that conditions should be attached to votes of supply. Voting in the first two Braccia was by fiefs, so that their numbers were not large; the Demaniale was smaller still. Voting by proxy was allowed. In 1810, the Militare had 277 members, the Ecclesiastico 60 to 66, the Demaniale 44: Pontieri, *op. cit.*, 127-45; G. Bianco, *La Sicilia durante l'occupazione inglese* (Palermo, 1902), 32-6. lately been pointed out. By Romeo, *op. cit.*, 19-26. The recent works of Romeo and Pontieri have thrown much light on the economic background of the patriotic movement.

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later and 'unnatural' growths. Gregorio combated the interpretation of the Norman Conquest according to which Roger had been no more than *primus inter pares*, as well as the prevailing interpretation of the Aragonese capitularies *Si aliquem* and *Volentes*, which allowed almost unlimited alienation of, and succession to, fiefs. He held that fiefs were historically *precarious* and their enjoyment dependent on services rendered to the Crown: in default of a (restricted) succession, they reverted to the Crown, and they could not be alienated. This contention was embodied by the Viceregal Government in a Pragmatic of 1788 which, however, does not seem to have had much effect. Gregorio also contended that Parliament was no more than the Norman

generalis curia, a mere advisory body without power to legislate or bargain over supply. His opinions were echoed by the apologists of the Viceroy's reforming policy: Pontieri, 15-27; Romeo, 49, 67, 82-3.

a parallel could be drawn. P. Balsamo, MS. considerations on the Sicilian Constitution: Bentinck Papers, Nottingham University (quoted henceforth as B.P.). Balsamo's *Sulla istoria moderna del Regno di Sicilia. Memorie Segrete* (Palermo, 1848; written 1815 or 1816) is an invaluable source for the political history of the period. His economic works are also of some interest. In conscious imitation of Young, he made two journeys (1792 and 1808) through the seldom-visited centre of the island, and published his observations and suggestions for reform: *Giornale del Viaggio fatto in Sicilia . . .* (Palermo, 1809). He advocated a uniform tax on all land as the basis of the national revenue; this was to be accompanied by the abolition of controlled prices, the lightening of consumption taxes, and the removal of internal trade barriers.

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at present we are nothing. P. Brydone, *A Tour through Sicily and Malta* (1790; 1st ed. 1776), 285.

their ancient institutions. The ideas of the French Revolution did, however, penetrate into Sicily to some extent, particularly in the more economically advanced area around Catania, where a new class of middling landowners was rising; it was largely from this class that the few 'Jacobins' of the 1790's and the leaders of the later 'Democratic' movement of 1813 were drawn: Romeo, 78ff., 107, 114.

too foreign to be compatriots. 'If [an Italian from countries other than Naples] came to Sicily . . . he was confused with visitors from beyond the Alps, and given the name of foreigner, unless he had been born at Naples, in which case he did not seem worthy of that honourable title': M. Amari, preface to 4th ed. of *La Guerra del Vespro Siciliano* (Florence, 1851).

'foreign' pensioners and officials. Balsamo, *Memorie segrete* (quoted henceforth as Balsamo), 4. 'The Queen disregards Sicily as unworthy her attention, though it is the only territory she possesses. She never thinks of ameliorating the condition of its inhabitants or adopting regulations for its future improvement. Her thoughts run entirely upon the reconquest of Naples . . .': Sir John Moore, *Diary* (ed. Maurice, 1904) ii, 145 (7 Jan. 1807). The Royalist *Mémoire de Marie Caroline* (ed. R. M. Johnston, Cambridge, Mass., 1912) speaks (pp. 7, 31) of the innate enmity of the Neapolitan and Sicilian nations, and of the hostility of the Neapolitan Ministry to Sicilian institutions.

devoted to the monarchy. Cf. Provenzano, 'Storia della Rivoluzione di Sicilia del 1820' (Bibl. Comunale, Palermo, MSS. Qq F 158), i, 94-6; Tognini, 'I Siciliani agli Inglesi' (Bibl. Com. Pal. MSS. Qq H 115 n. 10). Both these writers disliked the 1812 Constitution and the British intervention; both upheld the independence of Sicily against Neapolitan intrusion. Tognini goes so far as to assert that in twice reconquering Naples from his refuge in Sicily, King Ferdinand, like the Normans before him, proved that Sicily was the natural seat of government of both kingdoms.

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the Parliament of that year. Balsamo, 2-4; Pontieri, 338-50; Romeo, 65-71. Caracciolo's plan for a *Catasto* had actually been passed under his successor Caramanico (1786-95); but it was not carried out; instead it was again dropped in favour of increased supply under the old dispensation.

liberal reform. Balsamo, 2-4. Cassaro, first as Secretary of State for Justice, then as Lieutenant-General of the Kingdom of Naples, had a share of responsibility for the 1799 atrocities at Naples: N. Niceforo (E. Del Cerro), 'La Sicilia e la Costituzione del 1812' (in *Archivio Storico Siciliano*, xli), 323-4. This fact seems not to have detracted from Cassaro's later standing as a leader of baronial resistance in Parliament.

little more than a hothead. Aci's unreliability is illustrated by the following episode.

When in the first 1810 Parliament the Barons passed a plan for financial reform against the Court's wishes, Aci, though one of the opposition leaders, suddenly voted with the Court. 'When he was taken to task . . . for breaking his word, he answered "You already had a majority, and my vote would have been of no use to you. Let me get some credit by it"': Balsamo, 8.

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occasional lack of judgment. Balsamo, 188; Romano, 'Notizie intorno a Giuseppe Ventimiglia Principe di Belmonte', Bibl. Com. Palermo MSS. 4 Qq D 81 f. 76. Bentinck, even while he still thought Belmonte 'the main hope of this country', 'a very liberal, highly accomplished, able man', recognised his defect: 'He is a vain man and [a letter from Castlereagh congratulating him on the conclusion of the Anglo-Sicilian Treaty of 1812] could not well be made too complimentary—but it would be difficult to make it more so than he deserved': Bentinck to Castlereagh, 30 June 1812, FO 70/51; to Cooke, 10 Dec. 1812, FO 70/52.

the cause he held right. Balsamo, 5, 127. Carlo Cottone, Prince of Castelnuovo, was also known as Prince of Villa Ermosa or Villermosa.

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votre dévoué serviteur. Bentinck's minute of conversation with Orleans, 19 Dec. 1811, B.P. The Queen's hatred and jealousy of Ascoli are evident in two works written from her point of view, the *Mémoire de Marie-Caroline* and the *Memorie Segrete des Freiherren G.G. von Cresceri* (ed. Helfert, Vienna, 1892).

native shrewdness and common sense. J.C. Mellish, 'La Cour de Sicile en 1809' (ed. L. Pingaud, in *Revue d'histoire diplomatique*, 1894-5); Drummond to Howick, 11 Mar. 1807, FO 70/30; to Canning, 31 May 1808, FO 70/32. 'When he will take the trouble of interfering in business he generally shews a very good natural understanding': Drummond to Canning, 24 July 1808, *ibid.* This is brought out by the King's diplomatic correspondence, printed in W. Maturi, 'Il Congresso di Vienna e la restaurazione dei Borboni a Napoli' (in *Rivista Storica Italiana*, Sep., Dec. 1938). His unpublished diary (*Giornale d'Affari*) for 1812-15 exhibits a curious mixture of duplicity and candour, sometimes at his own expense. (The original diary was destroyed in 1943, together with the rest of the Bourbon papers in the Naples Archives; a complete transcript is in the possession of Prof. Walter Maturi, of Turin University, who has kindly allowed me to consult it. It will be quoted henceforth as *Giornale d'Affari*.)

a state little short of insanity. Bentinck to Wellesley, 26 Dec. 1811, FO 70/44.

spies and dubious characters. A. Valente, *G. Murat e l'Italia meridionale* (Turin, 1941), pp. 132-5, gives details—taken from the Queen's Journal—of the vast number of persons she employed on all kinds of business. Among the most prominent were St. Clair—a young Frenchman, reputedly her lover; Moliterno—a Neapolitan adventurer, full of weird schemes for the conquest of Italy; and Castrone, the almost illiterate chief of police, who directed the Queen's espionage system and her flotilla of privateers.

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hated the Sicilians and they her. 'The Queen told Mr. Fagan I am not fit to govern the Sicilians because I hate them, and if they were honest both the King and the Hereditary Prince would acknowledge to have the same feeling': Bentinck to Castlereagh, 30 Mar. 1812, FO 70/51. [The Queen being seriously ill] 'You cannot conceive . . . how delighted everybody seemed at the chance of her death, it was really quite shocking to witness the feelings of disgust, and hear the expressions of hatred against her in the mouth of everyone at the time': Andrew Douglas to Bentinck (private), 29 Sep. 1811, B.P.

every reason to believe it. R. de Damas, *Mémoires* (ed. Rambaud, Paris, 1914), ii, 227-9; Balsamo, 193-4; Mellish, 'Cour de Sicile'; Croce, *Uomini e Cose*, ii, 191-2. Of a particularly palpable lie of the Queen's, Bentinck wrote: 'The assertion is notoriously unfounded, but it is like many others of the same nature dictated by the passion of the moment, and perhaps not coming exactly within the description of known untruth. . . . This can only be owing to temporary failure of the senses': to Wellesley, 25 Jan. 1812, FO 70/51. Her friend Damas wrote that 'Elle est née pour embrouiller, traverser tout ce dont elle se mêle, et mourra malheureuse et ayant fait autant de malheureux que d'ingrats, avec un cœur excellent et les meilleures intentions du monde': Damas, ii, 229. The sympathetic and well-documented life by Egon Conte Corti, *Ich, Eine Tochter Maria Theresias* (Munich, 1950), only confirms this judgment.

make my life very hard. Circello to Castalcicala, 25 Oct. 1810 (copy), FO 70/46.

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stop them from being sent out. For a detailed account of Howick's policy, see Appendix A. J. Rambaud, *Naples sous Joseph Bonaparte, 1806-1808* (Paris, 1911) noted these instructions of Howick's (p. 34), without realising that they meant a drastic change of policy.

stood unresolved when he left office. Canning to Drummond, 12 June, 15 Aug., 26 Dec. 1807, FO 70/30; to Amherst, 3 Mar., 16 Aug. 1809, Bathurst to Amherst, 4 Dec. 1809, FO 70/36. The united command had been promised by Castalcicala, and Canning had used this promise to justify, against Opposition criticism in the Commons, his assertion that 'most cordial good understanding and cooperation' prevailed between the two governments. The Court, however, later refused to admit that any promise had been made: *Parliamentary Debates (Commons)*, xii, 1123, 1140 (27, 28 Feb. 1809); Amherst to Canning, 10 Aug., 25 Sep. 1809, to Bathurst, 11 Dec. 1809, FO 70/36.

the loss on the exchange. Canning to Amherst, 3 Mar. 1809, FO 70/36. A treaty of alliance and subsidy was ratified, after much delay, in March 1808; an additional treaty of May 1809 increased the subsidy from £300,000 to £400,000.

holding the place. Canning to Drummond, 15 Aug. 1807, FO 70/30, 4 Nov. 1808, FO 70/32. Castlereagh, however, wrote—while an invasion of Italy was still thought feasible—that 'the jealousy which has appeared on more than one occasion, with respect to our position in Sicily' would make it prudent to leave some of the British troops in the main fortresses there, and to keep the Court's Neapolitan troops as busy as possible 'also with a view to reserve the military power of the island more completely in our hands': to Gen. Henry Fox, 21 May 1807, in Sir H.E. Bunbury, *Narrative of Certain Passages in the Great War with France* (ed. Fortescue, 1927; 1st ed. 1852), 301.

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recurrent friction and disappointment. See App. A for a more detailed account of Drummond's mission.

the 1806 peace negotiations. Bunbury, 204-17, 224-6, 233-6; the Queen to Damas, 15 Mar. 1807, in Damas, ii, 373.

render themselves masters of Sicily. Amherst to Wellesley, 6 Feb. 1810, FO 70/39. There is no evidence that the Queen knew of Howick's plans, beyond Amherst's curious use of the word *still* in the sentence quoted.

the beginning of subversion. The Queen to Damas, 24 Oct. 1809, Damas ii, 416. 'Les Anglois agissent avec plus de suite [que les Français], leur argent, leurs principes, forme de gouvernement, enfin toutes les classes sont cajolées, travaillé et séduite par espoir d'être membre du gouvernement . . . moi je crois bien plus que nous perdrons la Sicile par ce côté que par l'autre, qui n'a pas de marine. L'atrocité de le faire comme alliée, protecteur, fait encore le seul frein et come on voit ne me point pouvoir séduire et que je veille sur cella, de là vienne les infamies, criailleries, immoralité de toutes les

espèces contre moi . . .': to Damas, 16 Mar. 1810, Damas ii, 426 (the spelling is the Queen's).

control of the subsidy. Drummond to Canning, 26 Mar. 1808, FO 70/32; Mellish to Canning, 6 Feb. 1809, FO 70/33; Drummond to Canning, 9 Nov. 1807, FO 70/30; Mellish to Canning, 5, 23 Feb. 1809, FO 70/33; Amherst to Wellesley, 5 Feb., 21 Apr. 1810, FO 70/39.

either in appearance or in reality. Drummond to Howick, 11 Mar. 1807, to Canning, 24 Oct. 1807, FO 70/30.

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furious recriminations from the Queen. Drummond to Gen. Fox, 27 Jan. 1807, Bunbury, 297; to Canning, 27 Jan., 25 Mar., 19 Oct. 1808, FO 70/32; Mellish to Canning, 23 Feb. 1809, FO 70/33; Amherst to Wellesley, 6 Feb., 27 Mar. 1810, FO 70/39.

clamoured for drastic action. Moore, *Diary*, ii, 139; Bunbury, 250; Stuart to Amherst, 13 Jan. 1810, FO 70/41. 'The Court of Palermo sends no succour, takes no notice, laughs at Lord [Amherst]. Ferdinand IV goes a tunny-fishing; and his wife continues her usual pranks, and is pronounced by her own subjects, and convicted in my mind, of acting in concert with Murat for our expulsion. . . . Nought but our presence prevents [the Sicilians] from driving out Caroline, as a demon of discord and tyranny, to live by the alms of such of her relations as might afford her an asylum': The Adjutant-General in Sicily (James Campbell) to Bunbury, 12 July, 19 Aug. 1810, in Bunbury, 317-19.

armed with rifles, axes, and sticks. Amherst to Wellesley, 11 June, 14, 28 July, 24 Aug., 23 Sep., 25 Oct. 1810, FO 70/39.

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salvation of this kingdom will ultimately depend. Amherst to Wellesley, 22 June, 14 July, 25, 29 Sep., 4 Oct. 1810, FO 70/39; 1 Mar. 1811, FO 70/42; (private) 29 Sep., 5 Oct. 1810, Add. MSS. 37,292, ff. 113-18; (secret) 19 June 1810, FO 70/39. Besides news of the Queen's traffic with Naples, information came in that members of the Government were in correspondence with the French Consul at Tunis; and a letter was intercepted from the Queen to Lucien Bonaparte at Malta, in which she said she had a safe and speedy means of correspondence with Paris: Amherst to Wellesley, 5, 25 Oct. 1810, FO 70/39. Amherst at first confined his suspicions to the Queen, Castrone and 'the infamous herd of spies who frequent Her Majesty's antechambers'. The King and Circello, he thought, were sincerely annoyed at an intrigue over which they had no control. But later reports of fresh intrigues with Austria rather shook his belief in the King's protestations of loyalty: to Wellesley, 8 Feb., 1 Mar. 1811, FO 70/42.

prerogatives they have ever enjoyed. Amherst to Wellesley (secret) 19 June, 25 Oct. 1810, FO 70/39; *Gazzetta Britannica*, 4 Apr. 1810.

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regular session in January 1810. The Court had had to appeal to both the British Government and its representatives in Sicily for advances and loans to tide them over: Castelcicala to Wellesley, 9 Feb. 1810, FO 70/40; The Queen to Sir John Stuart, 27 Nov. [Dec.?] 1809, FO 70/41. Parliament had not been asked for extraordinary supply since 1802, when (the King being still in Sicily after his first flight) it had voted an extra 150,000 oz. a year on condition that a 'permanent Royal Court' should be set up in Sicily. The King then returned to Naples, but the promised Court never materialised: Balsamo, 2-4; Pontieri, 350. Palmeri (p. 73) interprets the stipulation of a permanent Court at Palermo as 'an attempt to recover the independence of the kingdom'.

Great Britain and Sicily. Bianco, 75.

Caracciolo proposed them in 1783. Balsamo, 4-8. The new tax system was at first to run concurrently with the old. Actually, it was not put into force until 1814.

most of the resolutions failed. Balsamo, 8-9. Parliament did resolve that the Deputation should publish the accounts of the new financial system. Belmonte and Castelnuevo had wanted it to be responsible for all its accounts.

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toyed for some months with this proposal. She got Belmonte at one point to expound the Sicilian Constitution to the Hereditary Prince. 'It took him 4 sittings 2 hours each to do that—he had found him very dim of comprehension': Bentinck's Journal (Bentinck Papers, Nottingham University: quoted henceforth as Journal), 31 Jan. 1812.

more taxes than the Government majority. The chief, but by no means satisfactory, source for these transactions is Balsamo, 10-25. *Mémoire de Marie-Caroline* (pp. 37-8) confirms that the Queen considered for a while taking Cassaro and Belmonte into the Ministry—the latter as 'le moyen le plus assuré de lui casser le cou'. It states, however, that the reshuffle as it was carried out was a victory for Ascoli's influence over the Queen's: if so, presumably the decision to sacrifice revenue to political victory was Ascoli's too. Ascoli became at this time the King's 'private secretary' or factotum, almost a Prime Minister: Amherst to Wellesley, 13 July 1810, FO 70/39. Belmonte later told Bentinck that the Queen had offered to make him chief Minister, but that he had refused unless the whole system of government was changed. Belmonte's boasts, however, cannot be taken on trust: Journal, 4 Feb. 1812. Amherst seems to have taken a hand in the negotiations, at any rate to the extent of advising the King to recall Parliament and form a Sicilian administration: to Wellesley (secret) 19 June 1810, FO 70/39.

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should procure it for them. Amherst to Wellesley (private), 28 July, 19 Sep. 1810. Add. MSS. 37.292, ff. 51, 97. The Barons approached Amherst in July, before the second session of Parliament; but the defection of Cassaro and others already made their defeat certain.

resigned their posts in disgust. Amherst to Wellesley (private), 16 July 1810. Add. MSS. 37.292, f. 49; Stuart to Liverpool, 23 Oct. 1810, summary in Bunbury, 267.

a string of acrimonious Notes. Amherst to Wellesley, 7 Feb., 1 Mar. 1811, FO 70/42.

no more out of the British. Castalcicala persisted from August 1810 to March 1811 in an attempt to obtain from the British Government an additional subsidy of £130,000, on the grounds of expenses incurred during the invasion scare—this while Amherst's and Stuart's despatches were full of complaints that the Court had not sent one soldier to defend the Straits. Wellesley eventually refused this request in a curt Note of 29 Mar. 1811. Castalcicala obtained the withdrawal of the Note, but no more: FO 70/46.

an unconstitutional act. The Decrees are printed in Bianco, 326. The February Decrees bear a certain resemblance to Ship-money. The justification put forward by Ministers was based on an ordinance of King James of Aragon that the Crown could tax on its own authority when the country was threatened by an enemy (*Mémoire de Marie-Caroline*, 41). This provision had not been invoked since the War of Spanish Succession. In any case it clearly applied only to emergencies. Parliament had been sitting in August 1810 while invasion threatened; in February 1811 the imminent danger had been over for five months: Cesare Airolti's *Memoir on the question*, B.P.

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by constitutional means. Balsamo, 29-30; Bianco, 86. Signatories who took a large part in subsequent events were Belmonte, Castelnuevo, Aci, Anjou, Villafranca, Paternò,

Fitalia. Altogether 40-odd members of the Braccio Militare signed. Cassaro expressed sympathy but said that as a Councillor he could not sign.

'ultimate resistance' might perhaps be expected. Amherst to Wellesley, 2, 26 Mar. 1811, FO 70/42. It was not until July that the Court reacted to the petition by arresting five of the signatories.

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their choice seems less arbitrary. C.K. Webster, *The Foreign Policy of Castlereagh* (1925, 1931), i, 75. Perceval remarked that it would be difficult to find a substitute for Bentinck, even though his views were at the time of writing unacceptable to the Government: Memorandum of 13 Apr. 1811, Add. MSS. 37, 292, ff. 356-61. C. W. Crawley, 'England and the Sicilian Constitution of 1812' (in *English Historical Review*, 1940), was the first to point out how deliberate was the whole decision to intervene.

work hard for promotion, he said bluntly. H.M. Parker to Bentinck, . . . 1834, B.P.

likeness of a squeezed lemon . . . Lucius Concannon to Col. McMahon, Palermo 18 June 1812, in *Letters of George IV* (ed. Aspinall, Cambridge, 1938), i, 117-20. 'He is extremely popular here, shrewd, sensible and penetrating, with a total absence of hauteur, pomp or nonsense—perfectly at his ease himself, he seems not to imagine how anybody can be otherwise.'

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he would have lost control. Sir W. Napier, *Life of Sir C.J. Napier* (1857), i, 96-7.

the infliction of a positive misery. 'This looks like [a] joke, but it is real truth and earnest': to Charles Greville, 7 Apr. 1813, Private Letter-Book, B.P. (Greville was Lady William Bentinck's nephew).

deceived, if anyone, himself. Bentinck, for all his outspokenness, was not given to expressing his private feelings—not at any rate in the letters to soldiers and politicians that form the bulk of the evidence. Even his private Journal is mainly a record of events, written as a rule in a hurry, at the end of a long and arduous day. If Bentinck's family correspondence was available it might throw unexpected light on his character.

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some kind of decision. There is little evidence of Wellesley's views on Sicily, beyond a passage in Bentinck's memorandum (quoted below) which suggests that he did not take the charges of 'treachery' very seriously. But it seems clear that the decision to intervene was his: Perceval found no need for a change of policy; and this failure to grasp 'the difference between a friendly interference . . . for a salutary object' (such as Wellesley advocated in Spain and Sicily) 'and the secret intrigues or open violence of the French' was later given as a reason for Wellesley's resignation: Col. Meyrick Shawe's Memorandum, Wellington, *Supplementary Despatches* (1858-72; quoted henceforth as *W.S.D.*), vii, 264-5. Wellesley told Orleans in 1814 that 'the late changes in Sicily were his measure . . . he spoke of them with vanity': Journal, 14 July 1814.

annexation of Sicily to the British Empire. Debates of 27 Feb. 1809 (W. Smith), 1 May 1810 (Wm. Lamb, Sir J. Newport), 1 May 1811 (Whitbread, Smith): *Parliamentary Debates (Commons)* xii, 1123; xvi, 758; xix, 782. *Morning Post*, 14 Aug. 1810; *Anti-gallican Monitor*, 21 Apr. 1811.

conquers to do good. G.F. Leckie, *Historical Survey of the Foreign Affairs of Great Britain* (1808); Leckie to Bentinck, 19 Mar. 1812, B.P. The anonymous papers 'Some Account of the Present State of Sicily' and 'Hints for the Improvement of Sicily' [1812], Castlereagh, *Correspondence* (ed. Londonderry, 1848-53; quoted as *Castlereagh*

Corr.), viii, 217, 224, bear a strong resemblance to Leckie's writings. The latter paper contains a scheme for the complete colonisation of Sicily by England, as well as a vision of an emancipated and unified Italy. It ends: 'The master of Sicily regenerated holds Egypt under his foot: Tunis is his tributary; and the depôt of the commerce of belligerents, the Barbary powers, cease to have ships of war. He watches the fall of the Turkish empire, and stands with expanded wings to pounce upon Greece. He closes the Dardanelles with Lemnos, and forbids the Russians to enter the Archipelago.' See C.W. Pasley, *Essay on the Military Policy and Institutions of the British Empire* (1811); J. Galt, *Voyages and Travels...* (1812); E. Blaquiére, *Letters from the Mediterranean* (1813); Maj.-Gen. Cockburn, *A Voyage to Cadiz...* (1815). Pasley amplifies Leckie's thesis: the others all appeared when the British intervention had already taken place.

little thought to commercial advantage. Amherst to Wellesley, 24 Sep. 1810, FO 70/39; petitions from British merchants at Palermo to the Consul and the Board of Trade (protesting against the 1% tax), printed in Blaquiére, II, 425-7, 431-6; petitions to F.O. and B.o.T. from merchants at Exeter, Leeds, Sheffield, Nottingham, FO 70/49; Thomas Lack (Asst. Secretary, B.o.T.) to William Hamilton, 17 Sep. 1811, Bathurst to Hamilton, 3 Dec. 1811, FO 70/49. The Board of Trade was reluctant to countenance a commercial treaty giving Britain most-favoured-nation status; whereas the merchants pressed for such a treaty, and Howick had made it an object of his abortive instructions to Drummond (see App. A).

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not the man to carry it out. Bentinck's Memorandum to Wellesley, 4 Apr. 1811, Add. MSS. 37, 292, ff. 313-36.

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the government thought fit to give him. Perceval's comments on Bentinck's memorandum, 13 Apr. 1811, Add. MSS. 37, 292, ff. 356-61. (Perceval had, however, at one time suggested warning the Court that the subsidy might be suspended if they persisted in planning 'improvident expeditions' against Stuart's and Amherst's advice: to Wellesley, [July 1810?] Add. MSS. 37, 292, f. 59). Sydenham to Bentinck [Apr. 1811] B.P. (where wrongly endorsed 'July 8th'); Pellew to Bentinck, 19 Apr. 1811, B.P.; Wellesley to Harrowby, enclosing Bentinck's memorandum and Perceval's comments for circulation to the Cabinet, Add. MSS. 37, 292, f. 354.

provided no means of enforcing it. Wellesley to Bentinck, 30 May, 3 June 1811, FO 70/44. Cf. App. A for Howick's first instructions.

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various islands off the coast of Sicily. Douglas to Wellesley, 11, 12 May, 9, 24, 26 June, 2 July 1811, FO 70/43; Balsamo, 35-6. The reason given unofficially for the arrest of the five barons was that they had written to the Prince Regent begging him to take Sicily under his protection: *Mémoire de Marie-Caroline*, 44; Balsamo, 31-2, seems to confirm this. Belmonte later told Bentinck that after his defeat in the second 1810 Parliament 'he determined that in England and not in Sicily the battle was to be fought... he immediately began to travailler the public mind in England by pamphlets and gazettes and his efforts have been crowned with success': Journal, 30 June 1812. Belmonte's arrest took him by surprise, for, encouraged by a meddling British visitor, Lord Valentia, he thought himself already under British protection and 'in possession of the *habeas corpus*, the grand palladium of civil liberty for all British subjects': Balsamo, 36.

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happily blended and identified. Bentinck to Wellesley, 3, 23 Aug. 1811, enclosing Notes exchanged with Circello, FO 70/44.

no illusions on the point. Nugent to Wellesley, 1811, 'Copy of a paper delivered to Lord Wellesley . . . June 2nd 1811', 'Memorandum of a conversation with Lord Wellesley . . . 9 June 1811', B.P.; Bentinck's secret memorandum to Wellesley, July 1811, FO 70/44; Bentinck to Wellington, 14 Nov. 1811, B.P. The Archduke's chief agents were Gen. Nugent—his emissary to Wellesley in 1811—and the Piedmontese Count de la Tour, like Nugent an Austrian officer. Bentinck told La Tour in July 'he must not imagine that this was taken up with very great interest at home . . . all their attention was directed to Portugal. . . . Nugent might have been there still, if my going to the Mediterranean had not made indispensable a decision': Minute of conversation at Cagliari, July 1811, B.P. Cf. C.S.B. Buckland, *Metternich and the British Government from 1809 to 1813* (1932), 183-4, 209-10, 231 ff., 246-57; G. Gallavresi and V. Sallier de La Tour, *Le Maréchal Sallier de La Tour* (Turin, 1917), 225 ff.

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other British agents in the Mediterranean. Memorandum by Bentinck, Maitland and La Tour, Palermo 20 Aug. 1811, in Gallavresi and La Tour, 261; Bentinck's memorandum of 27 Sep., Bentinck to Hamilton, 25 Oct., Wellesley to Bentinck (secret) 21 Oct. 1811, FO 70/44. Italian prisoners of war were to be sent from England to Sicily to be enrolled in the proposed Italian Levy. Austria's consent to these plans was not thought necessary so long as her relations with France remained unchanged. The Archduke's own position was nevertheless delicate, since he was, of course, a Hapsburg as well as an Italian prince (he was eventually to become notorious as Duke of Modena).

in Sicily is not clear. A memorandum on the defence of Sicily, drawn up after Bentinck's return and approved by him and by Henry Bunbury (Under-Secretary for War) considered Sicily to be probably in no immediate danger of invasion from France or Italy: memorandum enclosed with Liverpool to Wellesley, 12 Oct. 1811, FO 70/49. This might be taken as shewing that the decision to intervene was not made only on grounds of security, and that the Government must have accepted at least in part Bentinck's thesis that Sicilian reform would mean a better chance of Italian insurrection (cf. Crawley, 259 n. 3). Wellesley's instructions, however, speak only of the inadequate defence of Sicily—especially the unreliability of the Court's troops—and the persistence of internal disaffection.

the withdrawal of the garrison. Wellesley to Bentinck, 7 Oct. 1811, FO 70/44. Bentinck had suggested that 'to gild the pill' the Court should be promised help in recovering Naples if they agreed to establish a free constitution there; but his instructions say nothing of this: Bentinck's memorandum on Sicily, 29 Sep. 1811, *ibid*.

already saved another Empire . . . Bentinck to Wellington, at sea, 14 Nov. 1811, to Wellesley, 24 Oct. 1811, B.P.

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see your way clear. Letters to Bentinck from Adm. Boyles (24 Dec.), Wm. Hill, Minister at Cagliari (9 Oct.), Pellew (19 Aug., 15 Oct., 22, 31 Dec.), Lt.Gen. Sir Henry Calvert (20 July, 7 Dec.), Leckie (18 June), Amherst (13 Oct.), Maj.Gen. Frederick Maitland (26 July); similar letters from Lord Forbes (in command at Malta), Maj.Gen. Clinton, Dumouriez and Adm. Fremantle, July-Dec. 1811; all in B.P. Wellington to Bentinck, 24 Dec. 1811, Wellington, *Despatches* (ed. Gurwood, 2nd ed. 1844), v, 424. 'The English may properly be deemed the oppressors of Sicily. . . . We wish the good will of this people and their happiness, yet with a strange inconsistency we enable their rulers to overwhelm them, and then we are vexed that we cannot prevent it. . . . We are fighting ourselves': Maitland (in command at Messina) to Bentinck, 31 Aug. 1811, B.P. Amherst thought the British Constitution would suit Sicily, 'for the genius and disposition of the Sicilians and their Constitution is very like our own. . . . Abuses and deviations have crept in, God knows, in abundance,

but the seeds of reform exist in the Parliament, and only want to be brought to maturity': to Bentinck, 13 Oct. 1811, B.P.

nothing was done. Douglas to Wellesley, 5, 26 Sep., 7 Oct. 1811, FO 70/43; the Queen to Serracapriola (Sicilian agent in Petersburg), 3 Sep. 1811, in Corti, *op. cit.*, 613; *Mémoire de Marie-Caroline*, 66-7; account of Ascoli-Bentinck conversations of 5, 6 Jan. 1812, in Bentinck to Wellesley, 11 Jan. 1812, FO 70/51.

to use force if necessary. Maitland to Liverpool, 15 Sep. 1811, FO 70/49; to Bentinck, 15 Sep., 18, 19 Dec. 1811, 1 Feb. 1812, B.P.; Douglas to Wellesley, 12 Nov. 1811, FO 70/43; correspondence between Douglas, Maitland, and Maj.Gen. Donkin, Nov., Dec. 1811, PRO G.D. 7/1; F. Romeo, *Mirror presented to His Sicilian Majesty* (1820); Bianco, 104-7; Valente, 264-5; Johnston, *Mémoire de Marie-Caroline*, 71 n. ff. It is virtually impossible to tell how far the Court was involved. That something was afoot appears from what the French General Goldemar told Maj.Gen. Donkin (D.Q.M.G., Messina) in February 1812: 'Dans son [Bentinck's] absence il y avait vraiment de beaux moments—mais, de très beaux moments. Si nous eussions pu décider cette vilaine Cour à éclater—mais cette B...sse la Reine avec son machiavélisme a manœuvré et manœuvré tant, que voilà ce diable de Bentinck qui revient... nous aurions dû faire beaucoup si cette femme se fût décidée seulement: votre armée était perdue et la Sicile à nous...': in O. Browning, 'Queen Caroline of Naples' (*E.H.R.*, 1887), 514. Maitland to Douglas, 7 Dec. 1811, GD 7/1.

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would not ask for such a step. Bentinck signed the following declaration: 'Je n'ai jamais demandé ni directement ni indirectement l'abdication du Roi—je n'y ai jamais même pensé...': Journal, 14 Jan. 1812.

use her as a scapegoat. Ascoli had been the first to urge the King to abdicate: Valente, *op. cit.*, 122-5. He tried to shift all the blame from the King to the Queen: 'you see her influence over him' he told Bentinck, 'if she urges him to anything, poor man, he begins to cry. He is weak by character...'. Ascoli also hinted that he was the only man capable of holding power without falling under the Queen's influence: Bentinck to Wellesley, 11 Jan. 1812, FO 70/51.

could but die in the contest. Ibid.; Journal, 2, 4, 10 Jan. 1812; Bentinck to Wellesley, 26 Dec. 1811, FO 70/44. Balsamo, 42-3; Sir R. T. Wilson, *Private Diary* (ed. Randolph, 1861), i, 34-5. The Queen told the British Consul that if Bentinck attempted force 'it will be a most fatal day... blood will probably flow in torrents... if your Government wish to get rid of me, why do not they give me poison, or have me stabbed?... and thus I am to be *Prisonnière des Anglais*, to be put on board a vessel, and sent to England, possibly massacred on the passage, or put in the Tower when I arrive; but I solemnly declare, I will never go there alive', etc.: Robert Fagan to Bentinck, 23 Dec. 1811, FO 70/44. 'She said there was only one way to save their honour, that was [for the King] to put himself at the head of his Neapolitans and return to Naples. The King might perish but he would die like Tippoo Saib upon the breach': Journal, 13 Jan. 1812.

five barons who were still in exile. Journal, 14 Jan.; Cesare Airoidi to Bentinck, 30 Dec. 1811, B.P. Adm. Fremantle (in command in Sicilian waters) warned Bentinck against further delay: the Toulon fleet might elude the blockade (as it had done some years earlier) and Murat's forces might soon attempt another landing: to Bentinck, 30 Dec. 1811, FO 70/51. But Fremantle may have exaggerated the danger for the benefit of the Foreign Office. He was more violently hostile to the Court than Bentinck himself: see *The Wynne Diaries* (ed. Anne Fremantle, vol. iii, 1940), *passim*.

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because we were compelled. Bentinck to Wellesley, 26, 31 Dec. 1811, FO 70/44, I, II, 25 Jan. 1812, FO 70/51; Journal, 1-20 Jan. 1812, *passim*; Minute of conversation with Orleans, 19 Dec. 1811, B.P.; Balsamo, 42 ff. The Prince's account of his decisive conversation with Bentinck is printed in *Mémoire de Marie-Caroline*, 82 n., and tallies with Bentinck's.

Castlereagh was Foreign Secretary. 'I do not congratulate you on the removal of Lord Wellesley. . . . I believe he would have given you every assistance in maturing and perfecting the reformation which you have begun in the Sicilian Government': Amherst to Bentinck, 15 Mar. 1812, B.P. Sydenham sent Bentinck Wellesley's unofficial congratulations, mingled with gibes at Castlereagh and Perceval: to Bentinck, 19 Apr. 1812, B.P.

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the preservation of the alliance. Castlereagh to Bentinck, 6 Mar., (private) 7 Mar. 1812, FO 70/50. In asking for proofs of the Court's treachery, Castlereagh remarked that 'the universal sense which has prevailed both at home and abroad, that without some decisive measure on our part, the island of Sicily and with it the British Army was likely to be betrayed to the enemy, will in all probability shield this transaction against an attack'.

rather than by force. Journal, 31 Jan. 1812.

there is no middle way. Balsamo, 42, 53; various patriotic memoranda to Bentinck (anonymous, for fear of discovery by the Court), B.P.

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the same Chief and the same Government. Bentinck to Circello, 27 Jan., in Bentinck to Wellesley, 29 Jan. 1812, FO 70/51.

influence, past and present, of the Queen. Journal, 27 Jan., 4 Feb., 2, 5, Mar. 1812.

would be permanent. Journal, 28 Jan., 19, 24 Feb. 1812. Belmonte talked at first of setting aside the Prince and establishing a Regency: *ibid.*, 3 Feb.

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exclusion of all others. Bentinck's Journal abounds in instances of Belmonte's rather engaging boastfulness. On one occasion he asked Bentinck, 'where will you find such another man (himself) c'est une âme de fer avec le cœur d'un Spartiate dans le milieu des esclaves . . . had he been in England there would have been siècles since he would have been Prime Minister but at his age he was nothing': Journal, 16 Mar. 1812. Belmonte complained frequently of Bentinck's excessive moderation: 'he was always impatienté with my froideur . . . we English had trop de loyauté': *ibid.*, 15 Mar.

be indifferent to it. Journal 20, 24 Feb. '[The Prince] asked do you mean to dictate the Ministers to me? I answered by no means, I only had to require that those should be selected who enjoyed the public opinion': Bentinck to Wellesley, 17 Mar., FO 70/51.

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not to be deceived on this point. Journal, 20 Mar.; Bentinck to Wellesley, 17 Mar., FO 70/51. For the whole of the negotiations leading up to the change of administration: *ibid.*; Journal, 19 Jan.-26 Mar. 1812, *passim*; Balsamo, 52-3.

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finally issued on 1 May. The Prince was, however, induced to allow the mention in the Despatch of a reform of abuses, and of such improvements in the laws as would 'lead to the happiness of this kingdom': Journal, 21, 23 Feb., 25, 28 Apr. 1812; Bentinck to Castlereagh, 30 Mar., 6 May 1812, FO 70/51. In urging the inclusion of the word

'constitution', Bentinck wrote to the Prince as follows: 'Il m'a paru toujours à désirer que ce que l'on fait dans la Sicile soit un modèle pour l'Italie. La première proclamation que je ferais en Italie déclarerait l'assemblée d'un parlement pour établir les droits et la liberté du peuple, pour reformer les abus, pour ôter la conscription etc. etc. . . . Je représenterai V.A.R. comme le Prince Patriote, qui ne désire que de rétablir le bonheur de votre peuple sur les bases de la liberté. J'enverrai ce papier sur tout les côtes de l'Italie. . . . On ne peut vaincre ce terrible Despot qu'avec les armes de la vérité, de la liberté, et de la vertu, et en toutes occasions il est sage de mettre en avant, et de prouver par les faits que tels sont les principes de sa conduite': Bentinck to the Prince, 25 Apr. 1812, in Bentinck to Castlereagh, 6 May 1812, FO 70/51; printed in part by A. Capograssi, *GI'Inglese in Italia* . . . (Lord W. Bentinck) (Bari, 1949), 92.

the path of constitutional monarchy. Journal, 5 May 1812; Bentinck to Castlereagh, 9 July 1812, FO 70/51.

one of Bentinck's peremptory Notes. Journal, 23 May 1812. See Capograssi, *op. cit.*, 89-91, for an account of the Prince's attitude, based on his correspondence in the Naples Archives. This was destroyed in 1943.

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his power came from God. Journal, 1 Aug. 1812; Bentinck to Castlereagh, 27 Aug., FO 70/52.

set aside when it suited him. A mot of the Prince of Pantelleria's, one of the King's friends among the nobles. Belmonte remarked that 'in speaking to the King it was of advantage to make use of metaphors': Journal, 29 July 1812.

the King's approval. Journal, 30 Jan., 2, 12, 17, 18 Mar. 1812.

caused the text of the Despatch to be altered. *Mémoire de Marie-Caroline*, 118. Bentinck heard from Aci that the Prince had sent his father the draft of the Despatch for his approval: Journal, 2 May 1812. Cf. Corti, 775.

no grounds for comfort. The King's stock answer to what he considered Bentinck's excesses was 'I shall write down what you say and send it to England': e.g. Journal, 1 Aug. 1812. At the end of August 1812 despatches from Castelvicala led him to believe that Bentinck was fully backed up by his Government: Ferdinand's Journal (*Giornale d'Affari*), 20 Aug. 1812. But—as later entries in the *Giornale d'Affari* shew—this belief did not really take root.

an 'ambitious and ungrateful son'. Journal, 27 Apr., 31 Aug. 1812; Capograssi, 87-9. The King filled his Journal, from the very start of the Vicariate, with complaints of his son's disobedience. The Queen cared little who heard her aspersions on the Prince's conduct—'Bete qu'il est—she cursed him in all languages': Journal, 18 Apr. 1812. Bentinck was astonished to learn that the Prince continued to write affectionate letters to his mother, often twice a day, when 'she hates him, he fears her!': Journal 23 Apr. 1812. He could not understand this peculiarly Mediterranean kind of family feeling, which could combine mutual exasperation with mutual devotion, and made the Prince—a man in his thirties, himself a father—as submissive as a child before his parents.

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dangers to which it might give rise. Journal, 20, 24 Feb., 20 Mar., 23 Apr. 1812.

the reproach of Posterity on the other. Belmonte's phrase: Journal, 27 Oct. 1812. 'I stated my belief of the Hereditary Prince being afraid of damnation in the next world if he disobliged his parents . . . [Orleans] said it was not easy to know the extent to which the whole family was influenced by the fears of religion': *ibid.*, 30 June 1812. Cf. the Prince's letters in Capograssi, 73, Valente, 270 n., 271 n.

Obviously the Queen. Journal, 5 Feb., 2 Mar. 1812; Wilson, *Diary*, i, 55-8. 'I think it quite certain that she will endeavour to persuade His Majesty to resume the Royal authority; but I should doubt much her succeeding against the King's indolence and timidity': Bentinck to Wellesley, 11 Feb. 1812, FO 70/51.

no remedy for the island's political troubles. H. M. Lackland, 'Lord William Bentinck in Sicily, 1811-12' (*E.H.R.*, xlii, 1927), 394; ead., 'The Failure of the Constitutional Experiment in Sicily, 1813-14' (*E.H.R.*, xli, 1926), 210-11. The first modern historians to deal with this subject made the mistake of supposing that the struggle between Bentinck and Maria Carolina was the major theme: O. Browning, 'Queen Caroline of Naples' (*E.H.R.*, ii, 1887); Helfert, *Königin Karolina von Neapel* (Vienna, 1878).

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even to England. Journal, 1812, *passim*. Bentinck saw the Queen only twice between the beginning of the Vicariate and her departure from Sicily in June 1813; but he heard almost daily about her sayings and doings—which were mostly public property anyway—from the Duke and Duchess of Orleans, from Belmonte, from Cassaro, and from the British Consul, Robert Fagan—the only Englishman with whom the Queen remained on good terms.

the prattle of a visiting Englishman. Journal, 10 June 1812. Sir Robert Wilson visited Sicily in May and indiscreetly encouraged the Queen's belief that Bentinck's acts were contrary to British policy: Wilson, *Diary*, i, 55-8; Bentinck to Bathurst (private) 6 Dec. 1812. Hist. MSS. Comm. *Bathurst MSS.*, 221-2.

agents continued to infest her antechamber. StClair hinted to Orleans and Belmonte that the Queen would consent to a Parliament in Sicily and a Constitution for Naples if the King was allowed to resume: Journal, 1 Mar. 1812.

appealing to Austria and Russia for help. These rumours were the staple of conversation at Palermo—e.g. 'reports in circulation of Guillotines ordered by the Queen . . . strange reports current in the town of the intention of the Queen to confine me and Lady William, Lord and Lady Montgomerie and Gen. McFarlane': Journal, 27 Jan. 1812. They appear in a mass of informers' reports (particularly those of J. Badge and the Abate Milano, the Queen's librarian) among the Bentinck papers. There is no telling whether Bentinck paid any attention to these reports, which were, like most of their kind, inaccurate and tendentious.

so many years of Martyre. Journal, 12 Mar. (report of Belmonte's interview with the Prince), 27, 30 Mar., 26 May, 4 June, 27, 28 July, 9, 18 Aug., 28 Sep., 8, 15, 19, 29 Oct. 1812 (interviews with Cassaro or Caccamo).

c'est sa mère—sa mère. Journal, 4 Sep. 1812.

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that of governing . . . Journal, 2, 24 Mar. 1812.

new Vespers against the English. Bentinck to Wellesley, 19 Mar. 1812, FO 70/51. Cassetti had been known to the British since 1810 as 'the grand channel of intercourse with the enemy': Bunbury, 320. He was undoubtedly employed by Murat to establish a correspondence with the Queen: J. Rambaud. 'Il tentativo di Murat contro la Sicilia nel 1810' (in *Arch. Stor. Prov. Napoletane*, 1911) 448-9. A Royalist writer who was involved in this affair admits that the Queen used Cassetti for the same purpose: Principe di Canosa, *I Piffari di montagna* ('Dublin', 1821), 46-53. Cassetti had been arrested by the Sicilian Government in November 1811, apparently as an earnest of their loyalty to England; but the whole business is exceedingly obscure: Douglas-Maitland correspondence, Nov. 1811, PRO GD/7/1; Douglas to Wellesley, 12 Nov. 1811, FO 70/43. Cf. also Valente, 258-63; *Mémoire de Marie-Caroline*, 69n.-71. The whole

question of the queen's 'treachery' is difficult (and largely unprofitable) to disentangle. There is evidence that she was in correspondence with Murat and possibly with France. There is also evidence that at various times she thought of giving up Sicily in exchange for her husband's restoration to Naples. On the other hand, there can be no doubt that the marriage of her granddaughter Marie-Louise (which aroused such suspicion among the British in Palermo) genuinely horrified her (see her letters to Ruffo, to the Empress Maria Ludovika, and to the Emperor Francis, 22, 23 Mar., 7 Apr. 1810, in Corti, 768-9, 772). But eighteen months later, after Bentinck's first remonstrances, she was ready to take refuge in Vienna (as she had often thought of doing before) and to ask Napoleon's leave to do so; she hinted that the Emperor should intercede with Napoleon to reconcile him with King Ferdinand and with herself (to the Emperor Francis, 30 Aug., to Ruffo, 9 Sep. 1811, in Corti, 614). At the same moment, however, she was thinking of calling in the Russians (see p. 26 and note). In fact she had no settled plan at all—only a settled desire to recover Naples—and it seems most likely that by this time her mind was too unstable to allow her to follow any coherent policy.

a remoter part of Sicily. Journal, 4 May 1812. In his letter Bentinck, after complaining of the Queen's continued opposition to the new regime, went on: 'If to these causes of dissatisfaction were to be added the fact within my knowledge that Your Majesty has been carrying on a direct correspondence with our enemy, a fact that I hope will not and shall not through my means transpire, I leave to Your Majesty to judge whether it will not be prudent for Your Majesty to retire in time from Palermo before these circumstances can become the subject of further discussion and irritation': Bentinck to the Queen, 16 Mar. 1812, FO 70/51.

refusing to see them. Bentinck to Wellesley, 19 Mar., to Castlereagh, 6 May, 27 June 1812, FO 70/51. Most of the correspondence is printed—with a few inaccuracies—in *Mémoire de Marie-Caroline*, 108-20.

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the objects of Your Lordship's attention. Castlereagh to Bentinck, 19 May 1812, FO 70/50; *Parliamentary Debates (Commons)*, xxii, 187 (debate of 25 Mar. 1812: Castlereagh referred there to Bentinck's acts up to the proclamation of the Vicariate, but his attitude did not change during the next few months). His despatch of 19 May, concerning the Queen, was delayed at the request of Castalcicala, who hoped to gain something from a personal interview with the Regent; but the despatch was sent unaltered on 14 July, with a further expression of Castlereagh's complete approval: to Bentinck, 14 July 1812, FO 70/50.

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must be safeguarded. Castlereagh to Bentinck, 19 May, 24 Sep., 22 Oct. 1812, FO 70/50. A typical example: 'H.R.H. relies on your continuing to press these points [reforms] on the Royal Family of Sicily with the necessary firmness, and at the same time with a due attention to the dignity of their situation': to Bentinck (private and secret) 14 July 1812, B.P.

a good and great nation. Bentinck to Wellesley (secret) 1 Jan. 1812, FO 70/51.

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nearly the whole of Bentinck's mission. This could sometimes appear an advantage: 'I have had sad counteraction and most unfortunate delay has been the consequence, but without the pretexts that such conduct afforded, I never could have asked for or obtained all that I have. The enemy have completely played into my hands. With a little cunning and seeming acquiescence, the Queen might have flouted me from the beginning and prevented me from ever moving an inch': Bentinck to Bunbury

(private) 31 Aug. 1812, Hist. MSS. Comm., *Bathurst MSS.*, 208. This, however, was written in a moment of optimism.

the headquarters of the patriotic party. 'We now stand at the head of a large party of Sicilians who have been accustomed to meet at the Minister's house and with whom this has been the chief means of communication': Frederick Lamb (Secretary of Legation at Palermo) to Castlereagh, 10 Dec. 1812, FO 70/60.

some of which the Prince attended. Bianco, 121; Bentinck to Wellesley, 14 Mar., to Castle-reagh, 5 May 1812, FO 70/51; Journal, 11 May. At one of Bentinck's entertainments, a masked ball attended by the Hereditary Prince and Princess, Orleans appeared as a *liqueur*, Butera's bastard as John Bull ('very good'), and the other nobles in equally appropriate costumes: Journal, 17 Jan. 1813.

solicited his favour. Journal, 19, 22 Jan., 19 Mar., 14 Sep. 1812; Gargallo (outgoing War Minister) to Bentinck, 19 Jan., B. P. Ascoli, whose exile to Cagliari Bentinck had exacted, wrote him no fewer than five comically fulsome letters before leaving (Mar. 1812): B.P.

riots against the government. 'Permettez-moi . . . de vous demander . . . s'il est possible que soit vrai le bruit général qui vous représente vous adressant à la populace en differens quartiers de la ville, attaquant le Gouvernement du Prince Héréditaire, disant des invectives contre ses Ministres, et voulant augmenter le mécontentement par rapport au pain? Est-ce possible qu'un homme de votre naissance puisse vouloir exciter le peuple à la revolte ou que vous puissiez ignorer que vous en seriez la première victime? Je veux me persuader que vous n'avez jamais pu tenir une conduite que comme votre ami je regretterais infiniment, et que, comme Ministre d'Angleterre chargé de la défense et de la tranquillité de la Sicile, je ne pourrais jamais permettre': Bentinck to Butera, 24 June 1812, Secret Letter-Book, B.P.

deport the monk to Lipari. Journal, 27 Apr. 1812. 'They might bring him back the next day if they pleased.'

stanzas, satires and sonnets. Journal, 20 May 1812; collection of patriotic political literature, B.P.

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the refusal of it. Journal, 29 Mar. 1813.

which he, Belmonte, disapproved. Journal, 12, 21, 25 Apr., 26, 29, 30 May, 12 June, 22 Sep., 23 Oct. 1812; the Prince to Bentinck, 29 June, B.P.

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revolutionary developments. Journal, 9 May, 17 Oct. 1812.

his and Bentinck's protests. Ibid., 29 Mar., 27 Oct. 1812.

the antics of the natives. Of an informal council on the grain shortage, Bentinck noted 'Curious scene—[the Prince of] Paternò cried'. And of another conference, 'Fardella and di Aci hating each other most horribly met like friends. They act well here!': Journal, 26, 30 Sep. 1812.

construe conciliation into weakness. Journal, 24 June, 13 Oct. 1812. 'Here as in India, moderation is always ascribed to weakness': to Castlereagh, 9 July, FO 70/52.

every country she could reach. L. Blanch, 'Luigi de' Medici', 163 n.; Wilson, *Diary*, I, 63.

did not dwell upon. 'I have no doubt of being able to bring affairs to such a conclusion as shall be for the honour and happiness of the Royal Family, the prosperity and greatness of Sicily, and the advantage of Great Britain': Bentinck to Castlereagh (private) 31 Mar. 1812, FO 70/51. Three months later Bentinck wrote that if he should lose his power of controlling the subsidy, 'at no distant period it may be expected

that things will revert to their former situation, that a new set of men will be in power, and the ancient system of policy revived': to Castlereagh, 28 June, *ibid.*

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abuses no less burdensome. Journal, 10 Jan., 2, 23 Apr., 22 Dec. 1812. Cf. Romeo, 126 n. *to bow at the Elevation.* Journal, 27 Nov. 1812.

the unwritten constitution of Britain. Webster, i, 82. The Constitution will be referred to as the English Constitution, since that was the phrase generally used by Bentinck and the Sicilians.

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the means of carrying them out. Balsamo, 53-5. Balsamo says Bentinck helped to prepare the draft from the beginning; but it is clear from Bentinck's Journal that he did not see it until Belmonte brought it to him in two parts (12, 25 Apr. 1812).

without the King's consent. Bentinck to Castlereagh, 27 July 1812, FO 70/52; Journal, 17 Mar., 19, 28 Apr., 4 June 1812.

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the Nation's general welfare. Castelnuovo's Memorandum 'Raggioni per la pronta convocazione del Parlamento', 3 Feb. 1812, B.P.; *id.*, Report on Sicilian Finances presented to Parliament, 1812, Arch. di Stato, Palermo, Fondo Fitalia No. 19.

he professed to dislike. Airoidi's Memorandum to Bentinck, Dec. 1811, B. P. Airoidi begins with an orthodox Lockian interpretation of political institutions, but ends by advocating a Parliament almost as powerful as the French Convention.

a clause abolishing feudal privileges. Journal, 23 Feb., 5, 6 June 1812.

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Sicilian or English bayonets. Journal, 10 Jan., 2, 13 Mar. 1812; Balsamo, 59-60, 63-4. Balsamo says the decision was Bentinck's alone, but Bentinck's Journal shews that it was Belmonte who caused him to change his mind.

a running deficit of 40,000 ounces a month. The ounce was worth about 13s.

other parts of the island. Bentinck to Castlereagh, 5 May 1812, FO 70/51; Bianco, 119-26; Alessi's Diary (Bibl. Com. Palermo, MSS. Qq B 7), 30, 31 Mar. 1812; Journal, 20 Apr. 1812. 'For Palermo, show the greatest firmness and vigour against the extravagant ideas of the comon [sic] people and make them steadily understand that they must eat bread at the current price of corn. . . . Without this there never will be security of property and trade, and consequently it will be impossible to have a regular supply of corn. . . . Leave [it] totally to the interest and the exertions of the Merchants and Farmers': Balsamo's Memorandum, 'Remedy for the present scarcity', no date, B.P. (in English). Balsamo conceded that the government might buy corn and release it at times of scarcity to bring down prices. Bentinck thought the government should either continue to subsidise bread, or else explain clearly to the people what it was doing: Journal, 20 Apr. 1812.

impossible to tell. Balsamo, 55-9; Journal, 20-25 May 1812; *Mémoire de Marie Caroline*, 111; N. Niceforo (E. del Cerro), 'La Sicilia e la costituzione del 1812' (in *Archivio Storico Siciliano*, xli, 1916), 332-3.

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suffer with their lives' he said. Journal, 28 Apr., 29 May 1812.

champion of the pure English Constitution. Bentinck to Castlereagh, 30 June 1812, FO 70/51; Journal, 27 May, 1, 2 June; Castelcalca to Castlereagh, 9 Mar. 1812, FO 70/53

(Castelcicala reminded the British Government that they did not care much for Parliamentary Reform at home). Webster (i, 78) says the King first suggested the English Constitution. This is a plausible interpretation of Bentinck's despatches (see p. 49 and note), but it is contradicted by Bentinck's Journal and by the King's own *Giornale d'Affari*, which Webster could not have seen. In fact the King went on denying his son's right to effect any kind of reform through Parliament. Only in August 1812 did he start insisting on the pure English Constitution—after Parliament had voted the Bases of the new Constitution. The deep-laid schemes which Webster attributes to him were not his but the Prince's (see p. 50). All constitutions were anathema to the King; if he later clung to the English it was as a *pis-aller*.

the prospect for reform was bleak. Journal, 26-29 May 1812; Bentinck to Castlereagh, 30 June 1812, FO 70/51. This long despatch has been used as the chief source for the account which follows of the political events of June 1812. Sometimes Bentinck's journal has been used to disentangle the chronology, and to fill in gaps in the despatch.

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his brother at Palermo. Journal, 29, 31 May 1812. Bentinck was aware of Aci's part in fathering this proposal, but did not mention it in his despatch of 30 June—perhaps because Aci had already figured in earlier despatches as a wrong-headed, meddling person; instead he merely wrote that the Royal Family had become enamoured of the English Constitution.

a model and a slogan. Bentinck to Castlereagh, 30 Mar. 1812; Capograssi, ch. v. Moliterno's and the Court's plans for expeditions to Naples had caused Amherst and Stuart much anxiety in 1810; the Queen and the Prince were still talking of such an expedition in 1812: Journal, 31 Mar. Moliterno was a peculiar character, a philosophic republican though a great friend of the Bourbons: 'He called [the Queen] Cittadina Imperatrice—she begged him to leave the cittadina de coté and to make her imperatrice': Journal, 13 Mar., 11 June 1812.

a means of getting round entails. Balsamo, 55, 63; Balsamo's draft of Royal Assent to constitutional article concerning entails, Arch. Stato Palermo, Fondo Fitalia, No. 31.

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those wild politicians. Journal, 8, 16, 17 June. 'I said how lucky it was that Cassaro's son had translated this work. . . . Belmonte said c'est moi qui ai fait tout I told the Princess qui est pleine d'esprit to insinuate to her husband the English Constitution': *ibid.*, 16 June.

make a complete cypher of him. The Prince to Castelcicala (quoted by Capograssi, 121), to Caccamo, 11 June, 29 Aug. 1812 (quoted by Valente, 140-5); Journal, 29 May-6 June 1812.

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the Prince and Cassaro had persuaded him. Ferdinand's *Giornale d'Affari*, early June 1812 (this journal does not always give precise dates); Journal, 2, 4 June.

now only a week off. The Queen's comments on the proposals for a Constitution and expedition (6 June) and the King's reply (7 June) are printed in full from the Bourbon family papers at Munich in Corti, 776-7. The Queen's exhortations may have encouraged the King to draw up his questionnaire, but she disapproved of its terms and urged Caccamo (who, as usual, was acting with Cassaro as go-between) not to deliver it. The demand for a pension, she pointed out, was something they might consider among themselves, but not put openly to Bentinck, as it might then suggest to him a means of obtaining the King's abdication: to Caccamo, 9 June, *ibid.*, 779.

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all sense but common sense. Journal, 4-12, 17 June; the Queen to the Prince, 15 June, B.P. (copy); *Mémoire de Marie-Caroline*, 121-2.

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the most enlightened and virtuous nation. Journal, 29, 31 May, 1, 3, 8, 10, 16, 18, 22 June; Bentinck to Castlereagh, 30 June 1812, FO 70/51. It is not quite clear whether the plan which Bentinck praised in this despatch was Balsamo's. Balsamo himself states (p. 63) that he prepared his abstract in a few days' intensive work; but he does not say exactly when he prepared it, nor can we tell whether it was the same as the draft which Aci shewed Bentinck on June 22nd, and on which Bentinck would not then pronounce. Everybody seems to have gone about with draft Constitutions at this time.

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la liberté et l'indépendence. Bentinck to Liverpool, 25 Jan., to Wellington, 23 Feb. 1812, Liverpool to Bentinck, 4 Mar., to Wellington 5 Mar., *W.S.D.* vii, 289, 296, 300-2; Journal, 17 May; correspondence between the Archduke Francis and Bentinck, 1812, B.P.; Colin Mackenzie to Bentinck, Cagliari 28 June 1812, B.P.; Bentinck to the Archduke Francis, 26 Oct. 1812, Secret Letter-Book, B.P.

asked for time. Journal, 31 May, 1 June.

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did not at first reject them. Concannon's reports to Bentinck, 29 May, 9 June, enclosed in Bentinck to Castlereagh, 25 June 1812, FO 70/51; Bentinck to Bathurst (confidential), 25 Dec. 1812, Hist. MSS. Comm. *Bathurst MSS.*, 218; Journal, 8 June; Bentinck to Castlereagh, 30 June, enclosing Secret Memorandum to the Prince, 20 June, FO 70/51. Bentinck had previously expressed very similar ideas on an expedition to Italy in a Note to Circello of 27 Jan. 1812 (FO 70/51) and in conversation with the Prince: Journal, 20, 29 Feb. He had, however, hinted that Britain would be in a position to influence in the Bourbons' favour the Neapolitans' 'election' of a ruler.

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Castlereagh, it may be noted, said nothing. Wellington to Bathurst, 14 July 1812, Wellington *Dispatches*, v, 743-5; Liverpool to Wellington, 19 Aug., *W.S.D.* vii, 401; Mulgrave to Bathurst, . . . 1812, *Bathurst MSS.*, 223; Bathurst to Wellington, 6 Aug., *W.S.D.* vii, 374-7; Castlereagh to Bentinck (private) 26 Sep. 1812, *Castlereagh Corr.*, viii, 275-6; Bentinck to Castlereagh (private and secret) 26 Oct. 1812 (draft), Bunbury to Bentinck (private) 11 July 1812, B. P. Bentinck described Bathurst as his friend in the Cabinet in a letter to Charles Greville, 7 Apr. 1813, Private Letter Book, B.P.

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wise and moderate legislation. Bentinck to Castlereagh, 30 June, FO 70/51; Balsamo, 63; Guarnieri, 'Sulla tradizione popolare in Sicilia della garanzia data . . . per la costituzione del 1812' (in *Arch. Stor. Sic.*, xiv, 1899); Niceforo, xli, 347-8.

sailed at once under Maitland. Letters to Bentinck from Pellew (20 June), Maitland (4 June), McFarlane (21 June), B.P.; Adm. Fremantle to Bentinck, 12 June (preferring an Italian to a Catalan expedition), B.P.; Journal, 28 June ('Determined upon Gen. Nugent's information that the expedition should go to Spain . . .'), 6 Sep. 1812 ('I told Count Latour of my intention to have gone to Italy if the Court had consented to my proposals'); Bentinck to Castlereagh, 30 June 1812, FO 70/51.

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when and if Parliament met. Bentinck to Castlereagh, 9, 25 July 1812, FO 70/52; *Mémoire de Marie-Caroline*, 124-6; Journal, 27-30 June, 4-9, 13, 16, 20 July.

it is certainly weak. Bentinck to Castlereagh, 9 July, FO 70/52.

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called for 20 July. Journal, 7, 8, 23 July; Bentinck to Castlereagh, 9, 25 July, FO 70/52 (enclosing exchange of Notes with the Prince and Belmonte).

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along the lines of the English model. Balsamo, 65-8; Journal, 21, 22 July. The Bases are printed in full in Capograssi, 281-5, also (together with the various motions, resolutions, etc.) in Società Siciliana per la Storia Patria, *Documenti per servire alla storia della Sicilia*, ser. II, vol. viii (Palermo, 1887). No record of the actual debates was kept in any of the Parliaments of this period.

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gratifying and proud duty this is. Bentinck to Castlereagh, 25 July 1812, FO 70/52; to G.F. Leckie, 26 July (autograph copy), B.P.

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beautiful island of Sicily. Amherst to Bentinck, 28 Oct. 1812. B.P.

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the control and protection of the British Government. Letters to Bentinck from Sir Edward Pellew (4 Feb., 6 Mar., 16, 27 Aug.), William Hamilton, Under-Secretary for Foreign Affairs (private and secret, 26 Feb.), Joseph Thompson, of East India House (27 Apr.), the Bishop of Limerick (16 Mar.); also from Gen. Oakes (Governor of Malta), Lt.-Gen. Colin Campbell (Governor of Gibraltar), Stratford Canning, Col. Torrens, Sir Thomas Graham, Lord Yarborough, C. Yorke (of the Admiralty), Feb.-Oct. 1812; all in B.P.

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a better condition of life. Lord Sheffield to Charles Abbot, 6 Nov. 1812, in *Diary and Correspondence of Charles Abbot, Lord Colchester* (1861), ii, 409; Wilson, *Diary*, i, 37; Harrowby to Bathurst, 17 Sep. 1812, in Hist. MSS. Comm. *Bathurst MSS.*, 214; E. Blaquier, *Letters from the Mediterranean* (1813), i, 567; letters to Bentinck from Amherst (15 Mar., 26 July, 28 Oct. 1812), Maitland (14 Jan., 20 Apr.), Pellew (6 Aug.), Leckie (12 July 1813), B.P.; Bentinck to Leckie, 26 July 1812, B.P.; Alessandro Turri, draft for article in *Gazzetta Britannica*, 1812, B.P. Leckie published an article in the *Morning Chronicle* (10 Oct. 1812) attacking the Sicilian Constitution.

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what his own policy was leading to. Liverpool to Castlereagh, 11, 17 Mar. 1814, in Webster, i, 526-7; Castlereagh to Bentinck, 19 May 1812, FO 70/50; to Bentinck, 26 Sep. 1812, *Castlereagh Corr.* viii, 275-6; *Parliamentary Debates (Commons)*, xxv, 789 (12 Apr. 1813).

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Royal Assent to the Bases. Balsamo, 70; Journal, 20, 22, 27 July 1812; draft of Sperlinga's motion, B.P. Cassaro was at this moment in a key position, as the man most likely to persuade the King to assent; Bentinck was amused to note that the other Ministers 'called Cassaro all the time Eccellentissimo'.

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most unhappy wife. The Queen to the King, 6 Aug., in Corti, 781. I have tried to reproduce the breathless style of the Italian original.

conformed absolutely to the English Constitution. Journal, 27 July–6 Aug.; Bentinck to Castlereagh, 27 Aug., FO 70/52; Ferdinand's *Giornale d'Affari*, 30 July–3 Aug.; *Mémoire de Marie-Caroline*, 134–6. The King's note authorising the Prince to assent, written on Aug. 2nd, made his assent conditional on Bentinck's guaranteeing the pure English Constitution, the safety of the whole Royal Family, and the Civil List. The Prince spent several days trying fruitlessly to obtain the guarantees from Bentinck or else begging his father to give him greater discretion. In the end he had to be content with the King's original note.

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surrender their privileges outright. Bentinck to Castlereagh, 27 Aug., FO 70/52; Bianco, 128–9.

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the treaty could not be undone. Bentinck to Castlereagh, 30 Aug., 13 Sep. 1812, FO 70/52; Journal, 6 Aug.–4 Sep.; *Giornale d'Affari*, 18 Aug.–4 Sep.; the Queen to Fagan, 19 Aug., translation in FO 70/52; *Mémoire de Marie-Caroline*, 137–43. Castalcicala urged the British Government in September to guarantee the possession of Naples: FO 70/64.

masters and kings if you please. Bentinck to Castlereagh, 13 Sep., FO 70/52; to Bunbury (private) 31 Aug. 1812, Bathurst MSS., 208.

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plotting for the King's return to power. Bentinck to the Prince, 17 Oct., in Bentinck to Castlereagh, 24/26 Oct. 1812, FO 70/52; Journal, 1, 10, 18, 28 Aug., 2, 5 Sep. It was at the beginning of September that, the Prince being ill, the Queen was suspected of having poisoned him.

her departure from Sicily altogether. Bentinck to Castlereagh, 20 Aug., 15 Sep., FO 70/52; *Mémoire de Marie-Caroline*, 132. Castlereagh's instruction of 19 May, giving Bentinck full discretion concerning the Queen, was held up at Castalcicala's request, and did not reach Bentinck until 20 August.

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threats and demands could therefore be discounted. Bentinck to Castlereagh, 24/26 Oct. FO 70/52; Journal, 15, 22, 28 Sep., 8, 11, 15, 31 Oct.; *Giornale d'Affari*, 13 Sep.–10 Oct.; *Mémoire de Marie-Caroline*, 144–59 (prints many of the documents); Castlereagh to Bentinck, 14 July, (private) 5 Dec. 1812, FO 70/50. According to Orleans the Queen wished to drive matters to a point where she would either call Bentinck's bluff or—if he did use force—appeal to Europe against him: Journal, 11 Oct. She and the King had indeed heard from Castalcicala at the end of August that Bentinck had full powers and that even the Queen's inviolability might not be certain (*Giornale d'Affari*, 20 Aug.; Corti, 643–4). But this warning seems not to have quite sunk in. The Prince, still recovering from his illness, urged his mother to give in: he 'crawled to her room and the Queen . . . abused him very much': Journal, 23 Oct. Cf. Capogrossi, 75.

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by Cassaro and Circello in his name. Bentinck to Castlereagh, 24/26 Oct., FO 70/52; Journal, 8–25 Oct.; *Giornale d'Affari*, 15–24 Oct.; *Mémoire de Marie-Caroline*, 160–2. The note given to Bentinck by Cassaro and Circello announced the Queen's intention of leaving, ending with 'The King wishes Your Excellency to be fully informed and assured of it by our means'.—Among the Bentinck Papers are two papers ready for signature by the King, one announcing his abdication, the other solemnly promising that the Queen would leave first La Ficuzza and then Sicily; they are endorsed by

Bentinck '... taken by me to the Ficuzza, but the King not seeing me, they were not made use of'. Bentinck did not tell Castlereagh of this decision to demand the King's abdication if necessary. Of his ultimatum to the King he wrote merely that he had threatened to use 'other means' if the King failed to answer (the King had lately returned a letter of Bentinck's unopened).

to reconcile the King to the Constitution. Bentinck to Bathurst (confidential) 25 Oct. 1812, *Bathurst MSS.*, 218; Maj.-Gen. Donkin to Bentinck, 28 Aug., 8 Sep., 7, 17 Nov. 1812, B.P. Bentinck's presence in Spain was all the more necessary as the commander of the expedition, Maitland, had had a nervous breakdown.

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out of all control. Ibid. The 1812 Constitution has been treated in great detail by Balsamo, Bianco, Niceforo, Crawley (full text in Società Siciliana per la Storia Patria, *Documenti per servire alla storia di Sicilia*, ser. II, vol. viii). In the following pages mention will be made only of its general outline and of salient points.

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so humbugged by the Hereditary Prince as Belmonte himself. Journal, 30 June, 24 July, 6 Aug., 14 Oct., 15, 27 Dec. 1812; Balsamo, 72-6, 80-1. According to Balsamo, Belmonte, though 'at bottom he was good and generous and valued Castelnuevo', was led by vanity, ambition and the flattery of his friends into a belief that Castelnuevo was a 'democrat', influenced by French ideas and hostile to the nobility. (Balsamo was, of course, Castelnuevo's lieutenant, but he is on the whole fair to Belmonte). Bentinck, for his part, sometimes wondered whether Belmonte was not still somewhat afraid of the Royal Family and therefore reluctant to press the Prince too hard. Orleans certainly thought that Belmonte's most unpleasant period of captivity at Favignana had sapped his nerve as well as ruined his health. If so Belmonte had every excuse for caution: after the 1799 atrocities at Naples, he could expect no clemency from the Court if British support was once withdrawn from him—his and his friends' heads 'would be the first to go': Journal, 27 July 1812.

calculated to establish the public credit. Balsamo, 72-6; Journal, 15 July, 28 Aug., 20, 22 Nov., 15 Dec. 1812.

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the existing confusion. Journal, 3, 13 Oct.

did not interfere enough. Journal, 22, 27, 29 July, 23 Aug., 2 Sep. The member in British pay was Tommaso Dolce; he received £200 a year: 'Memorandum of the secret missions...', 24 May 1813, PRO GD 7/1. Bentinck told Castlereagh nothing of his informal relations with members of Parliament.

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the situation was saved. Journal, 1-4 Nov.; Bentinck to Castlereagh, 7 Nov., FO 70/52. The King objected to the very principle of a Civil List, and this episode seems to have been an attempt on his part to get round it.

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the independence of Sicily. No objection was raised in Parliament to the harsh policy of the Ministry towards the Neapolitan refugees, many of whom were deprived of their posts and pensions and deported to Naples or Tunis: Niceforo, *op. cit.*, xlv (1922), 113-14.

like England in the time of Henry VIII. Anjou's Memorandum to Bentinck, 22 July 1812, B.P. About this time a 'Compendium of the English Constitution' was published, including Magna Charta, the Statute *de Tallagio*, the Habeas Corpus Act, etc.: adver-

tisement in *Gazzetta Britannica*, 30 Sep. 1812 ('most useful in the present circumstances'). It was needed: the Demaniale tried at one time to shift onto the Peers the unpopular task of originating money bills, but Dolce managed to persuade them that this was not the English practice: *Journal*, 22 July. English practice was also given as an argument for lowering the property qualification for the franchise: Balsamo, 77. *any notion of Cabinet government*. Balsamo, 76-9, 81; correspondence in *Gazzetta Britannica*, 9 Sep., 7 Oct. (on Parliamentary administration of finances); Anjou to Bentinck, 5 Sep., B.P. (on the same question); Bianco, 141-5. If Balsamo is to be believed, Romeo is mistaken in saying (p. 131) that Castelnuevo wished to lower the property qualification: quite the contrary.

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I did not convince him. *Journal*, 22 July, 5 Sep.

matters not of the first import. Bentinck to Castlereagh, 30 June, FO 70/51; Balsamo, 76. *Mémoire de Marie-Caroline* claims (pp. 166-7) that Bentinck advised Cassaro in September to oppose the full liberty of the Press, as it was a great nuisance in England; but that when the subject came before the Council four months later, he argued that the nation's will should not be denied. The latter part of this statement is confirmed by *Journal*, 2 Feb. 1813.

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the Constitution itself had been destroyed. Balsamo, 81-3; [Balsamo], 'Compendiosa idea degli attuali magistrati di Sicilia, ed osservazioni', B.P.; Niceforo, xlv, 99-106; *Journal*, 11 Sep.

was kept intact. This was especially a Neapolitan view in the 19th century: Afan de Rivera, *Pensieri sulla Sicilia* (Naples, 1820), 14-18; L. Bianchini, *Della storia economico-civile di Sicilia* (Naples, 1841), i, 94-5.

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the question stood unresolved. Bianco, 140-1; Romeo, 130-1; Report of Ecclesiastico debate on entail, *Gazzetta Britannica*, 14 Nov. 1812; *Journal*, 17, 26 Oct.; Balsamo, 83-5. The abolition of feudalism, coupled with that of common rights, resembled the proposals of 18th century Neapolitan *philosophes* such as Filangieri: cf. Croce, *Storia del Regno di Napoli*, 187-9. There is, however, no sign that Parliament was influenced by the recent example of the reforms carried out at Naples under Joseph Bonaparte and Murat.

to estrange the two leaders. Balsamo, 83-5. Castelnuevo's estate was entailed on Belmonte, his nephew; this naturally gave rise to malicious gossip.

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still further split the Ministry. *Journal*, 13 Oct., 1 Nov., 15, 16 Dec.

leading here and there to riots. *Journal*, 2 Oct.; Bianco, 156-8. At Catania, the mob 'demandait le gouvernement anglais et envoyait au Diable le gouvernement sicilien...': Capt. Le Vaillant to Maj.-Gen. Campbell, 2 July 1812, B.P.

the deficit remained almost as large as before. Balsamo, 87; Bianco, 127-8, 145-6; Niceforo, xlv, 115-19. Castelnuevo had reported a standing deficit of 777,576 oz., or a little over £500,000 at 13s. to the ounce (expenditure 2,493,810 oz., revenue 1,716,234 oz.). After the Budget the ostensible deficit was 168,402 oz.; but of the supply voted by Parliament, 264,000 oz. assigned to the Army was supposed to come from old credits which the government had found it impossible to collect. One of the chief difficulties was that the land-tax passed by the 1810 Parliament could still be assessed only on the basis of declarations by the owners (*riveli*) in the absence of an adequate land register.

take him to Spain. Journal, 3 Oct.; Bentinck to Bathurst (private) 6 Dec. 1812, *Bathurst MSS.*, 222.

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carry the King's gun for him. Journal, 19, 22, 29 Oct. 1812.

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one day you will be of the same opinion. Journal, 5 Nov. According to Orleans, despatches received at this time from Castelficala strengthened the Queen's conviction that Bentinck had no powers to turn her out: *ibid.*, 11, 14 Nov. Bentinck, foreseeing that she would not depart without a struggle, suggested that the British Government should offer her a pension as an inducement: to Castlereagh, 10 Dec., FO 70/52.

to thwart Bentinck and the constitutional leaders. Ferdinand's *Giornale d'Affari*, end Oct.-early Nov.; Journal, 2, 20 Oct., 14 Nov. 11, 23, 27 Dec. 1812, 6, 29 Jan. 1813. The King and the Prince were at this time at odds over the constitutional article establishing a Civil List, which was due for the Royal Assent and to which the King objected categorically.

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delay and dissension. Journal, 17 Dec.

no power over the Prince. *Ibid.*, 16, 27 Dec.

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a secret correspondence with the King. Bentinck to Castlereagh, 23 Jan. 1813, FO 70/57; Journal, 20 Nov., 13, 15, 19-24 Dec., 9 Jan.; *Mémoire de Marie-Caroline*, 175-8; Balsamo, 88-90. Because the Prince refused to appoint Balsamo *direttore* of Finance, an arrangement was suggested whereby Balsamo would carry out the duties of that office without becoming a government servant, and would receive an abbacy as compensation: Bentinck therefore found himself in the odd position of officially demanding ecclesiastical preferment for a Sicilian priest. Even so the Prince, apparently at the King's instigation, objected to the proposed arrangement.—Of Aci's defection, *Mémoire de M.C.* states (p. 106) that 'dès le mois d'Août [1812] . . . il écrivit au Roi les lettres les plus respectueuses et rendit toujours compte à S.M. de tout ce qui avait rapport aux affaires du Département dont il était chargé'.

no chance of being Prime Minister. Bentinck to Castlereagh, 15 Jan., 10 Mar. 1813, FO 70/57; Journal, 27, 29, 31 Dec.; *Mémoire de M.C.*, 175-8. Cassaro was concerned with the Balsamo appointment in his capacity of Minister for (among other things) Ecclesiastical Affairs.

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the King seemed their last refuge. The abolition of entail was the most controversial of the constitutional articles awaiting the Royal Assent; Cassaro opposed it strongly in Council: Journal, 16 Feb. 1813. According to *Mémoire de M.C.* (p. 101) Cassaro had entered the Ministry in March 1812 only 'sur les instances que lui en fit faire le Roi, S.M. voulant avoir au moins, dans le Conseil, un homme honnête sur la fidélité duquel elle pût compter'. It is true that Cassaro was from the beginning the King's unofficial spokesman, and the leader of the conservative barons in Parliament; but there is no sign that he had, before December 1812, committed himself in any way to a breach with the other Patriotic Ministers. Incidentally, *Mémoire de M.C.* is long and extravagant in its praise of Cassaro: the fact has suggested to Mr Crawley and Prof. Valente that he might have had a hand in the writing of it. Yet *Mémoire de M.C.* is certainly written, if not by the Queen herself, at any rate from her point of view: and she had no reason to be thankful to Cassaro. But then her likes and dislikes were

scarcely rational or predictable. Possibly the work was written by one of her intimates (Prof. Maturi, in conversation, has suggested StClair) who also happened to be on good terms with Cassaro.

prolonged the crisis. Bentinck to Castlereagh, 15 Jan., 24 Feb., 18 Mar. 1813, FO 70/57; Journal, 6, 9, 29 Jan.

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Prince Cassaro and Marquis Circello. Journal, 5 Jan. (conversation with Caccamo).
the object of Caracciolo's administration. Ibid., 16 Jan.

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reconciled to the new 'system'. Bentinck to Castlereagh, 15 Jan., 10 Mar., FO 70/57; Journal, 2, 18, 28 Jan.; Balsamo, 91ff. Bentinck was at this time particularly annoyed with the Prince for his dilatoriness over the Royal Assent to the Constitution and the question of Balsamo's appointment, which was still unsettled.

without its refutation. Journal, 16 Jan., 13 Feb.

did his best to dodge the issue. Giornale d'Affari, 16 Jan.-2 Feb., shews the confused state of affairs at La Ficuzza: the Queen insisted that she would leave only at the request of the Prince Regent (not of the British Government) and at the command of her husband; the King put the onus of a decision on her. There were rumours that the Queen intended to enter Palermo at the head of 5,000 volunteers and overthrow the Government; Cassaro later claimed credit for having dissuaded the King from such an attempt: Fagan to Bentinck, 9 Mar. 1813, B.P.; Journal, 12 Mar.

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now in a paradiso. Bentinck to Castlereagh, 15 Jan., 24 Feb., FO 70/57; Giornale d'Affari, 16 Jan.-6 Feb.; *Mémoire de Marie-Caroline*, 179-90 (prints many of the documents); Journal, 11 Feb. The Prince did not welcome his father's return: he had had enough of interference, he declared—'he would be tout ou rien': Journal, 7 Feb.

as soon as the snow thawed. Bentinck to Castlereagh, 24 Feb., FO 70/57; *Mémoire de Marie-Caroline* 192-6; Journal, 11 Feb.

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if the King resumed power. Journal, 2, 28 Jan., 2, 4, 9, 13, 25 Feb.; 'Substance of conversation between di Aci and Lt.-Col. Dalrymple . . .' [30 Jan.], B.P. By Feb. 16th Bentinck had made up his mind that 'Cassaro evidently wants to be Prime Minister and is urging the King to return because he sees he cannot have the full confidence of the Hereditary Prince': Journal, 16 Feb.

abdication or restoring the Vicariate. *Mémoire de Marie-Caroline*, 196; Giornale d'Affari, 13-18 Feb.; Journal, 13-16 Feb. Cassaro reported that the King had asked him for instruction in the English Constitution: 'it was all new to him and . . . on retaking the Government he did not wish to commit bestialità': Journal, 11 Feb.

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avant de reprendre le gouvernement. Bentinck to Castlereagh, 10 Mar., FO 70/57; Journal, 21 Feb.; *Mémoire de Marie-Caroline*, 196-8; Giornale d'Affari, 25 Feb. Cassaro told Bentinck privately that the Queen had refused to leave La Ficuzza unless the King resumed first: Journal, 25 Feb.

Bentinck was not empowered to use force. Journal, 28 Feb.; Giornale d'Affari, 23 Feb. At this time Castlereagh was having some difficulty in convincing Castalcicala that the British Government insisted on nothing less than the Queen's departure for Vienna: Castlereagh to Bentinck, 9 Feb. 1813, and private letter of same date, FO 70/56.

but in vain. Bentinck to Castlereagh, 10 Mar., FO 70/57; Journal, 26 Feb.

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left as far as regarded them to itself. Journal, 26 Feb., 2, 5 Mar.; Bentinck to Charles Greville, 7 Apr. 1813, Private Letter-Book, B.P.

if not they break his neck. Bentinck to Castlereagh, 20 Apr. 1813, FO 70/58; Journal, 5 Mar.

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the King's projects. Bentinck to Castlereagh, 10 Mar., FO 70/57; *Mémoire de Marie-Caroline*, 201-6.

Cassaro should be dismissed. Ibid. Bentinck did not break with Cassaro personally as he had with Aci, and they continued to meet from time to time on a friendly footing. He told Cassaro's son 'I was sorry for what had happened . . . his father appeared to me to have been led astray by his ambition . . . he was honest and his justification to himself was that he thought he could lead the King right—but he must see the difficulties with a man so prejudiced . . . the Prince was infinitely preferable': Journal, 13 Mar.

the Vicariate at an end. Bentinck to Castlereagh, 10, 18 Mar., FO 70/57; *Giornale d'Affari*, 8, 9 Mar.; Journal, 5, 9 Mar. What had happened, apparently, was that the Queen had finally persuaded herself, or had been persuaded, to let the King resume after, not before, her departure for Castelvetro: she had been saying for two or three weeks that she would suffer any extremity so long as he resumed: Castelli, 'Giornale Storico', Bibl. Com. Palermo MSS. Qq H 208, pp. 25-7.—The following pages, dealing with the events of March 9th-18th, are based mainly on Bentinck's long despatch of 18 March; other sources will be referred to when they are quoted or when they supply information not contained in the despatch. The Notes exchanged are printed in *Mémoire de Marie-Caroline*, 217-46.

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took to his bed. Journal, 10, 11 Mar.; *Giornale d'Affari*, 11 Mar. During the interview, Bentinck, alluding to the way he had been gulled by the King's former promises, said "'J'étais un homme simple." His Majesty answered angrily, "Je suis plus simple que vous, je suis plus honnête que vous"—I made a bow—His Majesty instantly corrected himself by saying "Je suis honnête vous pouvez l'être aussi".': to Castlereagh, 18 Mar. FO 70/57.

all my Notes for the last year. Journal, 11 Mar.

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complete surrender. Ibid. 12, 15 Mar.

visibly imposed on the country by the British. Journal, 15 Mar. Bentinck did not tell Castlereagh of his decision to take over the government if necessary.

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the point of hostilities. Journal, 14 Mar.; Bianco, 168.

decamped to La Favorita. Journal, 15-17 Mar. Orleans' verbatim account of his conversations with the King (16, 17 Mar.) has been published by M. H. Weil, 'Ferdinand IV et le Duc d'Orléans', in *Revue de Paris*, 1 July 1898.

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would himself have preferred forbearance. Bentinck to Castlereagh (private), 23 Mar., FO 70/57; Journal, 18, 21, 27 Mar. The following account of the events of March 18th-28th is based on Bentinck to Castlereagh, 4 Apr. 1813, FO 70/58, and on Journal,

18-28 Mar. Bentinck concealed nothing of importance from Castlereagh, and the King's account in *Giornale d'Affari* tallies with Bentinck's. Notes exchanged are printed in *Mémoire de Marie-Caroline*, 247-60.

religious processions and similar events. Balsamo, 101-3.

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on their high horse. Journal, 27 Mar.

forestalled the whole crisis. Bentinck to Castlereagh, 4 Apr., FO 70/58; *Mémoire de Marie-Caroline*, 264.

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her family and dominions. Castlereagh to Bentinck, 9 Feb. 1813, and private letter of same date, FO 70/56; *Castlereagh Corr.* viii, 298-300 (wrongly dated). Bentinck had suggested to Castlereagh in December that the British Government should offer the Queen a pension as an inducement to leave Sicily (cf. note to p. 83); he had not expected anything to come of it, however, for the Government would have had to ask Parliament for money to pay an annual pension, 'which they would not like'—though 'it would be excellent policy no doubt': Journal, 13 Jan. 1813. Hence Bentinck's refusal, until the arrival of Castlereagh's instructions, to consider advancing money to the Queen.—There was no compassion lost on the Queen in London: 'Whatever you have arranged with regard to the Lady in Sicily I am convinced is the best. . . . If we have not sent you any precise instructions regarding her, it has been because we felt we could securely rest in your discretion. . . . If it is necessary for her to be sent out of Sicily . . . for my own part, I shall be very glad . . .': Bathurst to Bentinck (private) 25 Dec. 1812, B.P. Castlereagh, for his part, was particularly annoyed by the Queen's intrigues in Germany and Russia: cf. also Harrowby to Bathurst, 17 Sep. 1812, Hist. MSS. Comm. *Bathurst MSS.*, 214.

great charter of their rights and liberties. Bentinck to Castlereagh, 4 Apr., FO 70/58.

he had been led to use. Castlereagh to Bentinck, 19 May, (private) 23 May, FO 70/56.

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disavowal by the British Government of my acts. Bentinck to Castlereagh (private) 7 Apr., FO 70/58; Journal, 27 Mar.

did not dare bite. *Giornale d'Affari*, 20 Apr.; Journal, 10, 18 Apr., 24 May; Bentinck to Castlereagh, 27 May, FO 70/58.

she died of a stroke. Ibid.; *Mémoire de Marie-Caroline*, 264ff.; Journal, 15, 17, 18, 30 Apr.; Bianco, 171-5; C. MacFarlane, *Sicily: Her Constitutions* . . . (1849), 23-7 (account of Gen. MacFarlane's mission to Castelvetro). Before leaving, the Queen wrote a fantastic letter to the British Consul, in which she said that if Bentinck had only been willing to lend her a million pounds—£500,000 at once and as much on her arrival in Vienna—'par cette généreuse opération il me fermait par la Reconnaissance la bouche' (the Sicilian Government was to have repaid the loan within ten years or less: it would, by the way, have amounted to two and a half years' British subsidy): the Queen to Fagan, 16 Apr. 1813, in Bianco, 347-53.

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meant for official consumption. Bentinck to Castlereagh, 14 May 1813, FO 70/58.

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cooperation with Italian patriots. See p. 54 and note. The plans made by Bentinck, the Archduke Francis, Nugent, and La Tour to raise an insurrection on the mainland had led to nothing but the formation of an Italian Levy in Sicily, largely made up

of Italian prisoners of war—and the levy had to go to Spain with the rest of the troops. The Archduke was by this time beginning to lose interest in the scheme: cf. his letters to Bentinck, 1812, *passim*, B.P.; and to La Tour, in G. Gallavresi and V. Sallier de La Tour, *Le Maréchal Sallier de La Tour* (Turin, 1917), 341-3, 382-90. The necessary communications with Joseph King at Vienna were impossibly slow, letters taking three months and longer to arrive: King to Bentinck, 17 Sep., 16 Nov. 1812, B.P. A former Consul at Leghorn, just arrived at Palermo, reported 'people of Italy discontented, but quite humble—would not join any invader': Journal, 21 Oct. 1812.

inutile de lutter contre le torrent. Bentinck to Bunbury (private) 31 Aug. 1812, to Bathurst (private) 1 Sep., Bunbury to Bathurst (private) 7 Oct.: Hist. MSS Comm. *Bathurst MSS.*, 207-10, 217; Bathurst to Wellington, 12 Oct., Liverpool to Wellington, 27 Oct., *W.S.D.*, vii, 455-6, 462-4; Nugent to Bentinck, 15 Sep., B.P.; to La Tour, 20 Oct., in Gallavresi and La Tour, 343. At the end of August 1812 Bentinck had given countenance to a Russian proposal for a march to the Adriatic by Russian troops stationed in Wallachia—but only because he wished to seem cooperative; he 'never thought they would come' (they did not): Journal, 28 Aug. One of the conditions he suggested to the Russian representative was 'complete liberty to the Italians to adopt the Constitutions and chiefs most agreeable to them': to R/Adm. Greig, 27 Aug., Secret Letter-Book, B.P. But a few months later he told the Prince that 'by not forcing himself upon the Neapolitans, he would gain many friends—the issue would always be the same, because the British influence if they made the conquest would always direct with ease the will of the people': Journal, 22 Dec. 1812; cf. the same argument in Bentinck to Bathurst (secret) 24 Feb. 1813; Gallavresi and La Tour, 357.

the 'private ends' of Austria and Russia. Bentinck to Bathurst (secret) 24 Feb.; the Hereditary Prince to the Prince Regent, enclosed with Belmonte to Castelfidardo, 23 Feb., FO 70/61; Bentinck to Bathurst (confidential) 7 Apr., *Bathurst MSS.* 230; Lamb to Hamilton, 25 May, FO 70/62 ('I fear there is . . . enough to get me the name of a most troublesome fellow').—It has been a commonplace with a number of Italian historians, both contemporary and modern, that the secret societies (especially the Carboneria) which made their appearance in the last years of the Napoleonic regime were subsidised with 'British gold' and encouraged by swarms of British agents throughout Italy: cf. for instance P. Colletta, *Storia del Reame di Napoli* (Capolago, 1834), bk. VIII, ch. xlix; A. Luzio, *La Massoneria e il Risorgimento Italiano* (Bologna, 1925), i, 118-9, 162-6; O. Dito, *Massoneria, Carboneria e altre società segrete* (Turin, 1905), 208-9; Capograssi, *op. cit.*, ch. xi. Such statements are generally based, if at all, on informers' reports (during the Restoration period), hearsay, and inference. Capograssi even speaks (p. 184) of Bentinck's 'innumerable agents scattered throughout the peninsula'—whereas as late as the spring of 1813 Bentinck decided, because he had hitherto been unable to establish any satisfactory communication with Italy, to set up three intelligence agents at Malta, Vienna and Ponza for the purpose (Bentinck to Castlereagh, secret, 21 Mar. 1813, in M. H. Weil, *Le Prince Eugène et Murat* (Paris 1902), i, 433-4); and a 'Memorandum of the Secret Missions under Lord William Bentinck' (drawn up by his secretary, 24 May 1813: PRO GD/7/1) confirms that these were the only agents dealing with Italy. Moreover, neither Bentinck's despatches nor his private papers supply any evidence that he was ever in direct contact with the secret societies before 1814. The indirect contacts he did have can be listed as follows: 1. The Archduke Francis and his supporters: their plans came to nothing, at any rate in Italy, and after 1812 little is heard of them. 2. One Alessandro Turri, who approached Bentinck in 1811 and apparently stayed in Sicily until 1814. He claimed to represent a secret society affiliated to the Freemasons; Bentinck distrusted him at first, though later on he employed Turri to write propaganda articles for the

Gazzetta Britannica and had him draft his Leghorn Proclamation in March 1814 (cf. page 138 and note). But otherwise Turri's activity seems to have produced nothing beyond a flock of memoranda; there is no sign that Bentinck took his grandiose schemes for an Italian Patriotic army any more seriously than he had taken Moliterno's (Turri even went into the question of what colour the proposed army's uniforms should be, and sought to ingratiate himself with the Nation of Shopkeepers by assuring Bentinck that his scheme would not cost Britain a penny, and that she might later reap commercial advantages in an independent Italy). In fact it appears from a sarcastic comment by C. A. A'Court, Bentinck's A.D.C. (endorsement of Turri to Bentinck, Leghorn, 18 Apr. 1814, B.P.) that Turri was thought something of a joke at H.Q. (Bentinck to Wellington, 14 Nov. 1811, B.P.; Turri's papers, *ibid.*). 3. One Giuseppe Palumbo, who approached the British Commander at Ponza in April 1813 on behalf of a society in the Kingdom of Naples; he was advised to put off his plans for insurrection, and no more is heard of him (Coffin to Bentinck, secret, 23 Apr. 1813, FO 70/58). 4. A few individuals who gave Bentinck information on Italy, without claiming to represent any organisation. This is meagre evidence. Of course lack of evidence is not disproof: Bentinck *may* have had greater contact with the secret societies than his papers reveal; and there is no doubt that towards the end of the war the societies tended to look to Britain for guidance, whether they got it or not. But in the absence of stronger evidence it seems reasonable to surmise that Bentinck never had any direct or reliable contact with the Italian patriots until he himself went to Italy in 1814; that this situation was practically inevitable given the state of communications between Sicily and the Continent; and that his belief in the Italians' desire and capacity to rise against the French was based much less on any knowledge of what was actually going on in Italy than on his own hopes and intuitions.

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nor its agents would budge. Bunbury, 'Memorandum on the present state of affairs . . .', 31 Dec. 1812, *W.S.D.*, viii, 457 (where wrongly dated): Bunbury endorsed Bentinck's views, including his advocacy of a united Italy, but, as he wrote to Bentinck (20 Apr. 1813, B.P.) without success; Münster to Nugent, 4 Mar. 1813, in Weil, *Prince Eugène*, i, 417; Pellew to Bentinck, 30 Apr., Gen. Henry Calvert to Bentinck, 19 Apr., B.P.; Bathurst to Bentinck, 5 June, FO 70/62 (urging him to concentrate on Spain for the time being). Nugent reported that Wellington would not hear of the Italian project: *Journal*, 1 Mar. 1813.

came to nothing. The Ponza negotiations have only been mentioned, as Bentinck's relations with Murat fall largely outside the scope of this study: see Webster, i, 253; Weil, i, 60-75. *to 'break his neck'.* Bentinck's relations with Wellington during the summer of 1813 can be followed in Wellington, *Dispatches*, vi, 564, 666, 709, 742, vii, 10; *W.S.D.*, vii, 648-9, viii, 18-20. Cf. Bentinck to Col. [Torrens?], 22 July 1813, holog. copy, B.P.

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put off until a general peace. *Journal*, 31 Oct., 22 Dec. 1812, 3, 11, 16, 19-21 Feb., 9, 18 Mar., 7, 23, 27, 28 Apr.; Bentinck, 'Observations upon an Article in the Sicilian Constitution concerning the Political Relation of Sicily and Naples to each other', 17 Feb. 1813, *Castlereagh Corr.*, viii, 322-5; The Prince to Castalcicala, 25 July 1813, in A. Capograssi, 'L'Unità italiana nel pensiero di Lord William Bentinck', *Rassegna storica del Risorgimento* (Mar.-Apr. 1934), 233 n. (stating that Bentinck had supported Separation only because it was the unanimous desire of the country); Balsamo, 104-7; Bianco, 133-5. Cf. Castelnovo's written opinions on the Civil List and Separation, Arch. Stato, Palermo, Fondo Fitalia, Nos. 31, 41: he appeals above all to the authority of Sicily's medieval Constitution; as for separation, he hints that Parliament might later be willing to *extend* the Sicilian monarchy to Naples.

secure outright abolition later on. Journal, 16, 19 Feb., 6 May; Balsamo, 108-10. Bentinck still sided with Castelnovo, but considered that it was 'all a difference about words': Journal, 6 May.

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might be expected to make more trouble. Journal, 6, 7, 10-13, 18 May. During another conversation between Bentinck and Belmonte, 'I told him that I had found [Castelnovo] at Carini's. Oh said he endeavouring I suppose to obtain his opinion . . . he (Belmonte) never took such means. I said that neither he nor I knew what passed between them—Distrust!' Ibid., 13 May.

preaching union and 'encouraging' Carini. Journal, 27 Dec.; Bentinck to Castlereagh, 12 Apr. 1813, FO 70/58. The following is a sample of Bentinck's 'encouragement' of Carini: 'Vous avez avec tous nos compagnons une tâche pénible à remplir. Pour faire bien aller cette machine il faut beaucoup de fermeté et de prudence. Votre nation est un peu volage—chacun pense plus à lui qu'à sa patrie. J'espère que cela changera et que le Parlement actuel donnera à la Nation un noble exemple de la sagesse et de la modération': to Carini, 16 July 1813, Private Letter-Book, B.P. Bentinck also arranged for Carini to receive a letter of congratulation from Bathurst. to the Peerage and to the Crown. Bentinck to Orleans, 17 July 1813, Private Letter-Book, B.P.

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not 'respectable' enough as a group. When a few months earlier Cassaro had suggested that a lawyer should succeed him at the Ministry of Justice, Bentinck had replied that lawyers were objectionable as a class, and that a nobleman would be preferable: Journal, 13 Feb. 1813.

cling fast to the British Constitution. Journal, 11, 12, 25, 27 May; Bentinck to Adm. Hallowell, 9 May, B.P. Belmonte suggested that he should write an official Note to Bentinck begging him to stay in Sicily or at any rate to return as soon as possible. 'I told him . . . that having been ordered to stay in Sicily my departure in disobedience to such an order was always a hazard but that my responsibility would be very much increased if I should receive a formal application . . . from the Sicilian Government.' Bentinck suggested, however, that Belmonte should write him a private letter instead: 'It would not tell against me and I might make it useful in respect to Lord Wellington . . . the letter was accordingly written': Journal, 26 May. Belmonte's letter (same date) gave warning of the danger of a *fougueuse démocratie*: B.P.

some only contingent. The political history of the 1813 Parliament has already been narrated in exhaustive detail by Balsamo, Bianco, Niceforo, and H. M. Lackland, 'The Failure of the Constitutional Experiment in Sicily, 1813-14', in *English Historical Review*, 1926 (based chiefly on the FO records and on the Journal of Joseph Smith, Secretary of Legation at Palermo, in the Bentinck Papers). As little new evidence has since come to light I have interpreted and summarised these events rather than tell the story all over again, especially since Bentinck was absent at this time.

a majority in Parliament. Balsamo, 113-14; Balsamo to Bentinck, 4 Oct. 1813, B.P. (in English). For the Belmontist point of view, F. Paternò-Castello, *Saggio storico-politico sulla Sicilia* (Catania, 1848, written about 1830), 61; cf. Smith to Bentinck (private) 17 Aug. 1813, B.P.

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with them popular discontent. The Government's credit was so bad that 'capitalists' refused to lend to them direct, and even a loan underwritten by the British Commissary-General and launched in the spring of 1813 found no takers: Bentinck-Castelnovo

correspondence, Feb.-July 1813, Arch. Stato Palermo, Fondo Fitalia, Nos. 71, 151, 154. Cf. Maj.-Gen. McFarlane to Settimo, 16 July 1813, *ibid.*, Nos. 159-60 (on the wretched state of the army); Bianco, 187-9; Niceforo, xlv, 17-18; J. Badge's reports, June-July, *passim*, B.P. (on food prices).

the Queen's expulsion. Cf. comments by conservative, anti-Neapolitan writers such as Provenzano (Bibl. Comunale Palermo MSS. Qq. F 158, i, 94-9), Tognini (*ibid.* Qq. H 115 n. 10), Alessi (*ibid.* Qq. B 7).

the local boards of health. Montgomerie to Castlereagh, 20 June, FO 70/59; to Bentinck (private) 14 July; McFarlane to Bentinck, 25 June; Dolce to Bentinck, 27 June: B.P.; Castelli, 'Giornale Storico' (Bibl. Com. Pal. Mss. Qq. H 208), 514-30 (correspondence between Maj.-Gen. Montresor and Messina Board of Health). 'I am quite out of favour with our military commanders here... who are all for the most violent measures...': Montgomerie to Bentinck (private) 4 Sep., B.P. Bentinck tried to pour oil on the waters, stating that there must be wrongs on both sides: to Castelnuevo, 17 July, in Bianco, 361-2. For the question of the plague, see Bianco, 199-202; Lackland, 214-15.

the other to Sicily. Montgomerie was a soldier, Smith had been seconded from the British Legation at Cagliari. Both died shortly afterwards, Smith in November 1813, Montgomerie early in the following year. 'The poor man [Montgomerie] has been reduced to death's door by the anxiety and annoyance he has experienced from these people': Bentinck to Adm. Hallowell, 23 Oct., B.P.

official Notes and public discussions. Orleans to Bentinck, 12, 25 June, B.P. (Orleans' letters are sometimes in French, sometimes in English).

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sans vous, cela n'ira jamais. Orleans to Bentinck, 20 July, B.P. Cf. letters to Bentinck from the Prince, Montgomerie, Smith, McFarlane, Castelnuevo, Belmonte, Balsamo, Dolce: *ibid.*

speeches, pamphlets and petitions. For the outburst of constitutional enthusiasm and speculation that took place at this time, see Bianco, 184-6. A pageant held at Catania in August displayed 'the Spirit of Sicily, supported by Justice and Abundance, presenting the text of the Constitution to Catania... the Spirit of Truth with a torch, putting to flight Ignorance and Interest... the divinities of Thames and Simeto, discussing the happy event...'. A cantata was sung 'on the subject of the new Constitution, in which was inserted high and well-deserved praise of the British Nation, of the immortal Lord William Bentinck, and of his worthy consort': *Gazzetta Britannica*, 11 Sept. 1813.

the 'system' they had themselves helped to launch. The King professed not to know the cause of dissension in the 'accursed Parliament': *Giornale d'Affari*, 8 July.

most advanced part of the island socially and economically. R. Romeo, *Il Risorgimento in Sicilia* (Bari, 1950), 111-20, 133-8. Too little is known of the leaders of the democratic movement; and what there is has come down chiefly through the writings of their enemies—Balsamo, Palmeri, Aceto—whom later historians, perhaps for lack of other evidence, have followed without much question. Even M. Amari—himself a democrat and a republican at the time of writing—had little to say in their favour: see his preface to Palmeri, *Saggio storico-politico* (1848 ed.), xxv-xxvii.

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the terrible French Revolution. Castelnuevo to Bentinck, [about 1 Aug.] 1813, in Bianco, 361-2.

paying nothing. Montgomerie to Castlereagh, 18 July 1813, FO 70/59.

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to make me leave the Ministry. Castelnuevo to Bentinck, 14 July, B.P.

break in your hands. Balsamo, 124. See for this whole episode Bianco, 182-96; Lackland, 215-22.

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a system of terror is not established. Bentinck to Orleans, 17 July, 8 Aug., Private Letter-Book B.P.

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no military spirit. Bentinck to Montgomerie, 7 Aug., FO 70/59; similar letter to the Prince, 12 Aug., *ibid.*

another chance of voting supply. This set Montgomerie at odds with Belmonte and Orleans, who taunted him with 'that dread of responsibility which petrifies Englishmen as the head of Medusa did the ancients': Orleans to Bentinck, 1 Aug., B.P. Cf. Balsamo, 128.

restoration of the desolated finances. Balsamo to Bentinck (in English), 13 June 1813, B.P.

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dispersed quietly enough on the 15th. Balsamo, 128-38; Bianco, 198-208; Lackland, 223-7.

The first political paper to appear was *La Cronica*, the organ of the outgoing constitutionalists; they became known as *Cronici* and the ruling Parliamentary faction as *Anticronici*. It was one of its editors, the deputy Aceto, whom the Commons attempted to try after he had got into a fight with an *Anticronico* deputy.

his private affairs. Bentinck to Castlereagh, 31 Aug., *Castlereagh Corr.* ix, 44; 3 Sep. (private), FO 70/59. Wellington was more upset at Bentinck's return to Sicily—which meant yet another change of command in Catalonia—than at his defeat at the pass of Ordal on 12 Sep.: Wellington to Bathurst, 7, 25, 26 Sep., *Wellington Dispatches*, vi, 746, vii, 22-5. The transactions of these years earned Bentinck Wellington's lasting hostility, which in turn affected Bentinck's later Indian career.

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no visible symptoms. Castlereagh to Bentinck, 16 Sep., 19 Oct. 1813, FO 70/56. Bathurst also urged Bentinck to stay on, as 'your own character is so much involved in the wellbeing of that Government': to Bentinck (private) 16 Sep. 1813, 1 Jan. 1814, B.P.

the happiness of a free government. Letters to Bentinck from Pellet (18 Nov.), Campbell (13 Nov.), McFarlane (27 June), Montresor (31 Oct.), Robert Liston (22 Dec.), B.P.; Bunbury to Bathurst (private) 26 Sep., *Bathurst MSS.*, 237. Leckie, now completely alienated from the Constitution, published two 'letters from Trapani' in the *Morning Chronicle*, in which he violently attacked Belmonte and Castelnuevo—and by implication Bentinck—and defended the King and Queen: Orleans to Bentinck, 26 Mar. 1814, B.P.

ainsi que va le monde. Joinville to Bentinck, London, 30 Nov. 1813, B.P.

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Bentinck carried his point. Bentinck to Castlereagh, 30 Aug. (private), Private Letter-Book, B.P. (not in F.O.); 6 Oct., (private) 6 Oct., 1 Nov., FO 70/59; Journal, 5 Oct. The following account of the events of October 1813 is based mainly on Bentinck's very long despatch of 1 Nov.; other sources will be referred to when they are quoted or when they give information not contained in the despatch.

the rights of man did more harm than anything else. Journal, 5, 8, 24 Oct.; Balsamo, 143-5. 'I recollect what you once told me, viz. that the principle of adopting in its totality

the British Constitution could be carried to a dangerous length. Sicily is now for knowledge and morals what was England two centuries back. Too much liberty is for the Sicilians what would be a pistol or a stiletto in the hands of a boy or a madman': Balsamo to Bentinck, 4 Oct., B.P. Balsamo's plan for a revised Constitution (*ibid.*, no date) must date from Oct. or Nov. 1813—to judge from internal evidence and from references to it in the letter quoted and in Balsamo's *Memorie*, 155-6—though Bianco (pp. 183-4) dated a copy he found in the Palermo Archives July 1813. It was after the 1813 Parliament, not before, that the Constitutionalists began to feel the need of a stronger executive power. Some of the changes proposed by Balsamo are curious: he suggests that taxes should be divided into *perpetual* ('independent from any parliamentary grant'), *ordinary* (army estimates), and *extraordinary* (emergencies)—only the latter two kinds to be voted by Parliament; and then, after this return to the old Sicilian Constitution, he goes on to say that 'the Parliament must retain the full power of altering or changing any perpetual or ordinary tax'!

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another form of government the better. Journal, 11-21 Oct.

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of whose principles I could not be assured. Journal, 22 Oct.; Bentinck to Adm. Hallowell, 23 Oct., B.P.; cf. Balsamo, 146-9. Bentinck concealed none of the facts from Castlereagh, but one can detect in the tone of his despatch an attempt to sound more impartial and less committed than he actually was.

for goodness of character than for abilities. Bentinck to Castlereagh, 12 Apr. 1813, FO 70/58. *now in fact dictator of Sicily.* Journal, 21-30 Oct.; Balsamo, 150-3; text of Bentinck's proclamation in Provenzano, i, 208. The formation of the new Ministry was a difficult business: Castelnuevo's friend Airolti refused to come in on any terms; while Belmonte grumbled that this was obviously going to be Castelnuevo's Ministry and threatened to retire from politics—Bentinck 'anticipated him by entering very angry and cursing the hour when I put my foot first in Sicily': Journal, 25 Oct. In the end it was settled that Belmonte and Castelnuevo should be members of the Council, along with the Princes of Fitalia and Cattolica, without becoming Ministers.

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both of the Prince and of the People. Bentinck to Castlereagh, 1 Nov., (private) 19 Oct. 1813. FO 70/59.

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having them written at his will. Ferdinand's *Giornale d'Affari*, early Nov. 1813.

the Moses of Sicily. Journal, 12, 19, 24 Nov., 19, 20, 23 Feb.; letters to Bentinck from Maj.-Gen. Montresor (10, 30 Dec.) and A. Barrow (26 May, 22, 24 June 1814) concerning appointments to government posts, B.P.; from Butera (12 Nov. 1813), Princess Leonforte (whose marriage with a young British lieutenant Bentinck made possible by overcoming the objections of her father, Butera) (12 Jan., 13 Feb. 1814), from the Senates of Palermo and Augusta, the Sheriff of Syracuse, various M.P.'s and Peers at Catania, all in B.P. It was Bentinck and Bonanno who worked out a list of appointments to high government offices: the Prince to Bentinck, 25 Nov., *ibid.* *had arbitrarily arrested in 1811.* Bianco, 212ff. Bentinck tried to arrange a reconciliation with Anjou, but failed: Journal, 4, 5 Nov. The King commented: 'I do not believe any man in London would dare undertake such a proceeding': *Giornale d'Affari*, early Nov.

laughing he went away. Intelligence report [by Abate Milano], 27 Dec., B.P.

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as soon as British power was withdrawn. Bentinck to Castlereagh, 10, (private) 25 Nov., 27 Dec. 1813, FO 70/59; Journal, 12, 15, 18, 19, 22 Nov., 28 Dec., 3 Jan., 20, 24 Feb.; Giornale d'Affari, 11, 24 Nov. 'I never saw the Prince more reasonable . . . or more apparently sincere—but *nimum ne crede!*': Journal, 14 Feb. And Bentinck told Orleans that 'I should not be surprised if the King resumed and the Queen returned': *ibid.*, 24 Jan.

not to let him be more than a figurehead. Balsamo, 159-61, 166; Journal, 12, 13 Nov. Originally, the Ministry contained two Belmontists (Villafranca and Carini) and two Villermosists (Settimo and Bonanno); the Councillors were similarly divided, with Belmonte and Cattolica on one side, Castelnuovo and Fitalia on the other. Balsamo says that Bonanno went over to the Belmontists 'because he did not know that Belmonte was in disgrace with Bentinck'!

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its full and free operation. Bentinck to Castlereagh (private) 20 Dec., FO 70/59; James Graham's Memorandum to Castlereagh (expressing Bentinck's views), 21 Feb. B.P.

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They were poets. Journal, 22 Nov., 26 Jan., 26 Feb.

abolish the order altogether. *Ibid.*, 26 Jan., 16 Feb. Bentinck was as usual in two minds about the Sicilians. Some of them were ready enough to encourage him in his intermittent contempt for them: one Padre Pazzi remarked to him that 'Tasso had said of them *vili in guerra—traditori in pace*—St. Paul also said—all islands are bad—but most of all Sicily . . . a nation de singes'. And Princess Paternò, one of the leading Constitutionalist ladies, told him 'speaking of the Sicilians . . . if you were to do me all the good possible . . . serving me for years together—in a moment of humour, I might be capable of becoming your most violent enemy': Journal, 2, 14 Nov.

ce qui leur convient. Joinville to Bentinck, London 30 Nov. 1813, B.P.

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the island was perfectly quiet. Journal, 5, 22 Nov.; Balsamo, 155-6; Bentinck to Pretore of Palermo, 21 Feb. (draft), B.P. Balsamo complained in particular that Bentinck, instead of establishing a regular procedure for Council meetings, seemed to regard the Council as 'a private and changeable thing, always dependent on the will and pleasure of the Vicar and generally of the executive power'. Balsamo may have been a little prejudiced, however, for Bentinck had paid no attention to the elaborate projects for constitutional reform which he had drawn up in October 1813.

a more equal distribution of landed property. 'Memoria ossiano istruzioni per l'estimo di tutti i beni rivelati a norma di quanto prescrisse il Parlamento del 1810' presented to Bonanno, 11 May 1814, by Giovanni Corvaja (an economist, evidently a disciple of Adam Smith and Verri, many of whose proposals for reform echo those put forward in the 1780's by the Viceroy Caracciolo and his counsellor Simonetti): Arch. Stato Palermo, R. Segreteria Incart. 5430; Bianco, 217-19. The following is an illustration of Bentinck's relations with Bonanno: 'Tell him [Bonanno] that Messina is the worst disposed place I have seen and pray tell him and Carini that I am anxious no arrangement should be made for the appointments there until I see them. I do not know who Bonanno means to be Segreto of Catania, but tell him that the Cavaliere Paternò has great claims upon our regard. I should have written to Bonanno myself, if I could have explained my ideas in Italian': Bentinck to Douglas, Syracuse 11 Dec. 1813, PRO GD 7/1. For Bentinck's views on the redistribution of land, see page 147.

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a committee of the Council sat to work out new codes. Bentinck to Castlereagh, 1 Nov. 1813, FO 70/59; Journal, 18 Nov., 27 Dec., 21 Jan.; Bianco, 217-9.

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How then did Italy and Sicily stand? Castlereagh to Bentinck, 22 July, 7 Aug. 1813, FO 70/56; Bathurst to Bentinck, 22 Sep., FO 70/62; Weil, *Prince Eugène*, iii, 231-5. to create a free government. Journal, 22 Nov.; Weil, iii, 141-3, 157-8, 213-19; Pellew to Wellington, 26 Dec., W.S.D. viii, 466; La Tour to Bentinck, 23 Feb., Graham to Bentinck (private) 29 Jan., B.P.

Bourbons would be restored to Naples. 'That the cause of Italian Independence ever had any importance in the Kingdom of Naples, I never heard—that an independent nation and distinct in many particulars from the rest of the Italians should wish to become a province is altogether contrary to reason': Bentinck to Wm. A'Court, 1 Oct. 1815 (draft), B.P.

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the only kind of government for which they are fit. Journal, 20 Nov. 1813, 12 Feb. 1814; Graham to Bentinck (private) 6 Mar. 1814, B.P.

nothing was done. Journal, 15, 17, 20, 22, 25 Nov., 13 Jan. For an example of the way in which Castalcicala deliberately attempted to prejudice the British Government against the Sicilian, see W. Maturi, 'Il Congresso di Vienna e la restaurazione dei Borboni a Napoli' (in *Rivista Storica Italiana*, Sep., Dec. 1938), 1, 47-8.

to all appearances a triumph. Journal, 27 Dec.; Bentinck to Douglas, 11 Dec., GD 7/1; to Castlereagh (private) 20 Dec., FO 70/59; fragment of Journal (on loose sheet), 2 Dec., B.P.; *Gazzetta Britannica*, 22, 29 Dec., 5 Jan.; Balsamo, 157-8; Bianco, 220-1.

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with military aid. The full text of Bentinck's proposal is given in Appendix B, from Capograssi, *Gl'Inglese in Italia*, 156.

proposal of compensation on the mainland. Wilson, *Diary*, i, 58; Bentinck to Wellesley, 11 Jan. 1812, FO 70/51; the Queen to Fagan, 16 Apr. 1813, in Bianco, 347; the Prince to Castalcicala, . . . Dec. 1813, in Capograssi, 163-4. Shortly before the voting of the Bases in July 1812, the Queen wrote to her former Minister Medici (then in London) that if Britain could arrange at a peace for Naples to be extended to the Po (the Pope being left only Rome and the Patrimony of St Peter) she could then take over Sicily if she wished. A fortnight later, after an agitating interview with Bentinck, the Queen told Medici that Sicily was as good as lost: he had better sell it, therefore, to Britain for £6 million. Sicily, she added, deserved no better: the Queen to Medici, 14 July, 1 Aug., 3 Sep. 1812, in Corti, 636, 640, 645.

scarcely aware. M. Amari, preface to 4th edition of *La Guerra del Vespro Siciliano* (Florence, 1851), v-vii.

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some deep-laid British design on Sicily. Balsamo, 156-7; Weil, *Prince Eugène*, iii, 182; Bianco, 219-20. Croce writes that in 1848-9 Ferdinand II 'reconquered Sicily, thus foiling the designs of England, who ever since Bentinck's day had had her eye on the island': *Storia del Regno di Napoli* (Bari, 1925), 247-8.

from no other source whatever. Bentinck to the Prince, 14 Dec., in Bentinck to Castlereagh, 16 Feb. 1814, FO 70/63.

left it at that. See Capograssi, *op. cit.*, chapter x; Romeo, 126.

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the instrument of Italian independence. Bentinck to Castlereagh, 6 Feb. 1814, *Castlereagh Corr.* ix, 238. 'I perhaps ought to apologise for having taken upon myself to originate propositions of such high interest without any knowledge of the wishes of the British Government. But the moment offered, and there was no time for reference, and I considered myself as much bound by duty as prompted by inclination to put it in the power of the British Government to have made an arrangement which in my judgment would have been beneficial to all parties, but especially to Sicily and Great Britain—to the first by the restoration of its ancient greatness and of its long lost happiness—to the latter by adding to its possessions a source of infinite honour and strength without the ordinary disadvantages of foreign dominions': Bentinck to Castlereagh, 16 Feb., FO 70/63.

the evidence of their own senses. Croce, *Storia del Regno di Napoli*, 268-9.

only through British protection. Bentinck to Douglas, Syracuse 11 Dec. 1813, GD 7/1; fragment of Journal (on loose sheet), 2, 3, Dec., B.P. Of Taormina Bentinck noted: 'The most beautiful view I ever saw—Aetna covered with snow on one side—the sea on another and the country immediately adjacent most bold and picturesque.' He was no poet. But the sight may well have affected him. Other travellers of the time were all the more ready to keep in mind Sicily's ancient glories because the island, it seems safe to say, was not then so backward compared to the rest of Europe as it became afterwards. Maj.-Gen. Cockburn, who kept comparing Sicily with Ireland, thought that although its poverty and squalor were appalling it was none the less the better off of the two: *A Voyage to Cadiz . . . in 1810 and 1811* (1815), i, 325-6.

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he dissociated it wholly from British policy. Giornale d'Affari, end Dec. 1813, 27, 29 Apr. 1814; Capograssi, 162ff.

making a better bargain. To Castlereagh, 6 Feb., *Castlereagh Corr.* ix, 238.

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Bentinck's own plans both for Italy and for Sicily. The story of these negotiations has been told in great detail and need not be repeated here: see Weil, *Princ Eugène*, iii, *passim*; Webster, i, 151-2, 159, 253-8; Bentinck to Castlereagh, 14 Jan. 1814, FO 70/63. Bentinck kept up his resistance to Austrian and Neapolitan blandishments from December 12, when he first heard of the talks, to January 18, when Aberdeen's despatch reached him: it had been delayed 'by the negligence of the Austrian Chancellerie': Aberdeen to Bentinck (private) 18 Feb. 1814, B.P.

the British garrison in Sicily. Journal, 6, 9 Feb. 1814.

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keep the Sicilian mission. Graham to Bentinck, 7 Mar., (private) 8 Mar. 1814; Graham to Castlereagh, Chatillon 21 Feb., enclosing Memorandum of same date: all in B.P. Graham's account of the conversation is given at length in Appendix B.

a most difficult problem in all its parts. Castlereagh to Bentinck (private) Chatillon, 21 Feb., B.P.

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did not till yesterday read Mr Graham's paper. Castlereagh to Bentinck, 3 Apr. 1814 (no. 2), *Castlereagh Corr.*, ix, 427ff.

some small doubt must persist. James Graham, whom Weil (iii, 350) absurdly describes as playing *Eminence Grise* to Bentinck's Richelieu, had recently come to Sicily on

his Grand Tour and had been taken on by Bentinck as his private secretary. His letters (among the Bentinck Papers) shew that he was devoted to Bentinck, to whom he confided his unhappy love affairs in a style obviously influenced by *Childe Harold*. Ironically, this same James Graham, who at this time was full of enthusiasm for Italian independence and unity, was, as Home Secretary thirty years later, to be involved in the scandal over the opening of Mazzini's correspondence.

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had involved both himself and us. Capograssi, 165ff.; Liverpool to Castlereagh, 11, 17 Mar. 1814, in Webster, i, 526-7.

an accumulating store. Castlereagh to Bentinck, 3 Apr., *Castlereagh Corr.*, ix, 409ff.; Wm. A'Court to Lady Wm. Bentinck, Paris 30 Apr., B.P.; Bentinck to Castlereagh (private) 10 May, FO 70/64; C. A. A'Court to Lady Wm. Bentinck, 5 May, in G. Gallavresi, 'La rivoluzione lombarda del 1814 e la politica inglese' (in *Arch. Stor. Lombardo*, 1909), 130.

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her independence and constitution as well. Journal, 6, 9, 11-18 Feb.; Bentinck to Castlereagh, 26 Feb., FO 70/63; to Castelnuovo, 13 Feb., and Notes from Villafranca, in Bianco, 374-5.

then Tuscany and Liguria. Maturi, *op. cit.*, I, 36 n.; Journal, 6 Jan; Weil, iii, 371-2, 378-9, 414-5.

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the King needed no encouragement. Circello, however, told Bentinck that the King, in his written refusal to give up his claim to Naples against compensation, had 'contrived for himself a mode of escaping from his own declaration'. Bentinck had not noticed it, 'but I daresay he has': Journal, 23 Jan.

a plot to strip him of his possessions. Giornale d'Affari, Dec. 1813-Feb. 1814, *passim*.

the hour is gone by. Journal, 23 Jan., 13 Feb.; Bentinck to Adm. Hallowell, 25 Jan., B.P.; to Castlereagh, 14 Jan., FO 70/63.

put ourselves in the way of Fortune. Journal, 23 Jan., 14, 20 Feb.

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what Spain now is. Weil, iv, 351ff., v, 34. Bentinck's proclamation in *British and Foreign State Papers*, ii, 316. The Prince wrote to Castelcicala—presumably for the benefit of the British Government—that his own proclamation to the troops had been issued at Bentinck's instigation: Maturi, i, 35. Bentinck, however, recorded that the Prince had shewn him the draft proclamation and he had commented merely that he 'could not object' to it: Journal, 18 Feb. Of course—as Castlereagh was quick to point out—after the armistice it was his business to object.

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decisive effects in Sicily. Detailed accounts of these events already exist and little can now be added to them: see Webster, I, 258-60, 285, and especially Weil, *Prince Eugène*, iv, v. The latter, though an almost exhaustive history of Italian events in 1813-14, is somewhat marred by Commandant Weil's determination to shew Bentinck as a Machiavellian arch-intriguer and as the man who almost singlehanded brought about Murat's downfall: see for instance *op. cit.*, iv, 600.

the people are now the only barrier. Weil, ii, 489, iii, 122, 212, 230 n., 291, 302, 345 n., 401 n., 647; Castlereagh to Aberdeen, 28 Sep., 15 Oct. 1813, in Webster, *British Diplomacy 1813-1815* (1921), 99, 102.

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in Italy was anchored to Austria's. On landing at Leghorn Bentinck received letters from Graham which left him in no doubt that Castlereagh wanted him to cooperate with Murat: Graham to Bentinck, 7, 8 Mar. 1814, endorsed as received 13 Mar., B.P. Frederick Lamb, Bentinck's former Secretary, now attached to the Vienna Embassy, wrote to him that 'In Italy your views have never been at all adopted by the British Government, nor our evidence held to be worth anything—this is the real ground of the system which has been adopted there—if England had wished it I think Austria could have been induced to take another line. . . . Discard the fancy which I see you still have that the Italian game may be thrown into your hands, it never will, and so you may e'en content yourself': Lamb to Bentinck, 19 Mar., B.P.

to throw Murat out of the coalition altogether. Weil, iv, *passim*. This quarrel originated partly in a convention signed by Bentinck and Neipperg at Naples on 6 Feb., in which they agreed that the British expedition should have a base of operations in Tuscany: Neipperg increased the confusion by failing to inform either Murat or the Austrian commander Bellegarde of what he had done: Bentinck to Castlereagh, 6 Feb., FO 70/63; Weil, iii, 515-8, iv, 165ff.

more like Maria Carolina than anyone he had ever seen. Bentinck to Castelnuevo, 7 Apr., in Bianco, 371; to Castlereagh, 19 Apr., *Castlereagh Corr.*, ix, 476.

a reversal of British policy towards Naples. Bellegarde to the Emperor, 28 Feb., Metternich to Mier, 8 Mar.: Weil, iv, 271, 356 (two instances out of many of Austrian distrust of Murat); Castlereagh to Bathurst, 27 Apr., Hist. MSS. Comm. *Bathurst MSS.*, 274 (the words quoted are omitted from the letter as printed in *Castlereagh Corr.*, ix, 512); Castlereagh to Liverpool, 18 Dec. 1814, *W.S.D.* ix, 485.

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a good chance of succeeding. Graham to Bentinck (private) 7 Jan. 1814, Bentinck to Adm. Hallowell, 25 Jan., B.P. There is a little evidence that Bentinck once or twice thought of backing Murat as the likeliest champion of Italian independence, but it is highly dubious: see Maturi, i, 34; Capograssi, 213.

other patriotic societies. See for this evidence Valente, 94-8; Capograssi, chs. xi, xii. Nothing is to be found among the Bentinck papers concerning the secret societies, beyond one anonymous and merely descriptive 'Memoria sopra l'unione Carbonica'. Bentinck, however, described Alessandro Turri (an emissary of the Italian secret societies—cf. page 102 n.) as having drafted the proclamation which was to be issued at Leghorn: Journal, 18 Feb. But there is no telling whether the proclamation as issued was in fact identical with Turri's draft.

whether they needed it or not. Capograssi, 213; Ferdinand to Castalcicala, 25 May, in Maturi, i, 40-1.

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whatever arrangement they pleased. For a more detailed account of Bentinck's conduct at Genoa see Appendix C.

hoped to force a constitution on Murat. G. Gallavresi, 'La Rivoluzione Lombarda del 1814 e la politica inglese', in *Arch. Stor. Lombardo* (1909); Bentinck to Castlereagh, 17 Apr., 10, 25, May, FO 70/63; Castlereagh to Liverpool, 5 May, *W.S.D.* ix, 65. Bentinck did tell the Milanese agents who came to see him that 'their act came too late . . . they could do nothing now . . . they must depend upon the Allies . . . it was a pity they had not begun this before when the British cooperation could have been given and the fate of Italy decided—At present I was too distant and in the impossibility of aiding them . . . the most I could do was to give them countenance, by sending to Milan General MacFarlane. . . . I sent him accordingly with the most guarded

instructions': Italian Campaign Diary, 26 Apr., B.P. But even this 'guarded' measure was enough to arouse great and mistaken hopes at Milan.

Sovereigns we can trust. Castlereagh to Bentinck, 3 Apr. (no. 3), *Castlereagh Corr.* ix, 427 ff.

it is most absurd. Castlereagh to Liverpool, 5 May, *W.S.D.* ix, 65 (part of the text is omitted in *Castlereagh Corr.* x, 9).

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we can converse on this subject. C. A. A'Court to Lady Wm. Bentinck, Paris 5 May, in Gallavresi, 'Rivoluzione lombarda', 130; Castlereagh to Bentinck, 7 May, *Castlereagh Corr.* x, 17. It was in this letter that Castlereagh told Bentinck that 'It is impossible not to perceive a great moral change coming on in Europe . . . the principles of freedom are in full operation. The danger is, that the transition may be too sudden to ripen into anything likely to make the world better or happier. We have new constitutions launched in France, Spain, Holland and Sicily. Let us see the result before we encourage farther attempts. The attempts may be made, and we must abide the consequences; but I am sure it is better to retard than accelerate the operation of this most hazardous principle which is abroad. In Italy, it is now the more necessary to abstain, if we wish to act in concert with Austria and Sardinia. Whilst we had to drive the French out of Italy, we were justified in running all risks; but the present state of Europe requires no such expedient; and, with a view to general peace and tranquillity, I should prefer seeing the Italians await the insensible influence of what is going on elsewhere, than hazard their own internal quiet by an effort at this moment.'

his last visit to Sicily. When A'Court was first appointed in January 1814, he understood that he was going out as, officially, Bentinck's *locum tenens*, but that he would succeed to the mission if Bentinck gave it up: Hamilton to Castlereagh, 14 Jan., 8 Feb., *Castlereagh Corr.* ix, 159, 253; A'Court to Hamilton, 26 Jan., 8 Feb., FO 70/68. By May, however, it was tolerably clear that Bentinck would have to give up the mission whether he liked it or not.

which alone could make it work. Castalcicala to Ferdinand (Jan. 1814?), in Capograssi, 168-9; A'Court's Memorandum to Hamilton, 20 Feb., FO 70/68.

on the part of the Crown. Secret Memorandum to A'Court, 9 Mar., FO 70/65 (Bentinck's copy is endorsed 'given by H.M. Ministers at home': B.P.).

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could not fail greatly to revolt them. Liverpool to Castlereagh, 11 Mar., in Webster, i, 526.
what could be saved of the constitutional system. Bentinck to Castelnuevo, Leghorn, 7 Apr., in Bianco, 371; Balsamo, 168-9.

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irreproachably constitutionalist. Cf. a great many instances of interference by the *Capitani Giustizieri* (Sheriffs) with the Councils, lists of electors, etc., in a whole volume of documents concerning these transactions: Arch. Stato Palermo, Real Segreteria Incart. 5430. These were got together to indict the Constitutionalist Government, but the evidence seems plausible enough.

was to be expected. Balsamo, 162-4, 166-7.

'recover' Sicily from Naples. The King to Castalcicala, 23 May, in Maturi, i, 32.

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Bentinck returned to Palermo. Castelnuevo to Bentinck, . . . , 26 Apr., in Bianco, 372-3; Balsamo, 172-3. San Marco and the other King's Friends sometimes maintained as a theoretical proposition that Sicily could not be independent, in the sense that if

she was not governed by Naples she must be by England; but it is clear from their later conversations with Bentinck that what they were afraid of was that she should relapse into the status of a province if the King returned to Naples: Journal, 17, 21 June. *giving up politics altogether*. On 11 June Castelnovo, who had not yet seen Bentinck, wrote to his friend Settimo: 'You must have noticed as you left me last night that I was bewildered rather than angry—let me tell you that ever since then, until 4 o'clock this morning, I stayed up thinking over this culmination of all our troubles. . . .' Finally he decided to write to Bentinck and tell him that if he, Bentinck, decided to countenance the present conduct of the government (i.e. of the Belmontists) then he would withdraw into private life rather than put up any opposition. 'Labouring as my mind was under the thought that I might perhaps displease, however slightly, a man to whom we owe so much, and under the necessity of forcing myself not to trust my pen with any stronger expression, I was almost unable to put a single idea down on paper, and I scarcely know how I managed to write those few lines . . .': Arch. Stato Palermo, Fondo Fitalia, No. 61 (where listed as 11 June 1813—but from internal evidence the right date is 1814).

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mixing the Ministry. Journal, 16-23 June, is the source for this account of Bentinck's negotiations over the proposed coalition. Cf. Balsamo, 173 ff.

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the good will of his people. Bentinck to Castlereagh, 4 July, FO 70/64.

to begin at home in Sicily. Ibid.; Maturi, i, 48-56. This interpretation of the King's behaviour, and of the events to which it gave rise, is substantially that arrived at by Prof. Maturi on the basis of the diplomatic correspondence in the Bourbon Archives; it seems to be the correct one, though it has been controverted by Prof. Valente (*op. cit.*, 283-4).

somehow it was adopted. Journal, 23 June; Balsamo, 175-9.

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washing his hands of the whole business. Bentinck suggested to the Prince that he should send Belmonte to compliment Louis XVIII, as a means of getting rid of him: Journal, 25 June.

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should ever be minded to do so. Bentinck to Castlereagh, 4 July, enclosing copy of the Prince's Memorandum, FO 70/64; to La Tour, 6 July, B.P.; Journal, 24-30 July. Bentinck, though he refused to sign the Prince's Memorandum, did endorse it 'ce papier a été fait avec mon intelligence et accord'.

were being hissed in the streets. Bentinck to Castlereagh, 5 July, FO 70/64; Journal, 2-7 July; Balsamo, 180-2.

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the King's professions of constitutionalism. Bentinck to Castlereagh, 5 July, FO 70/64; (private) 5 July, B.P. (not in F.O. or *Castlereagh Corr.*); Journal, 5 July.

the Constitution cannot and shall not succeed. Journal, 1, 9-12 July; Ferdinand's *Giornale d'Affari*, 7-12 July. A'Court reported that Bentinck, 'having brought this comedy to the fifth act . . . seems to be by no means sorry to get away before the *dénouement* actually takes place': to Hamilton (private) 3 July, FO 70/65. That, however, was before the King's resumption.

sailed from Palermo for the last time. Balsamo, 185-6. Bianco states (p. 235) that, before

leaving, Bentinck suspended the subsidy in an attempt to coerce the King once more; but in fact he suspended it before the King's resumption, and only to remind the Sicilian government of their outstanding debts to Britain: Bentinck to Villafranca, 30 June, to Castlereagh, 4 July, FO 70/64. A'Court's statement said that despite the difference of opinion between them, he would take no step 'tending to overthrow the arrangements made by Lord William Bentinck'; as Bentinck seemed to think that non-intervention on England's part was tantamount to active opposition to the 'system', A'Court promised to support it by every means short of violence. All this, however, he undertook only because Bentinck's absence and his own tenure were still officially temporary; and it was subject to the Government's instructions: A'Court's Memorandum to Bentinck, 15 July, B.P. In fact A'Court was almost certain that Bentinck would not return: to Hamilton (private) 3 July, FO 70/65.

out of the government service for the next thirteen years. Liverpool to Bathurst, 12 Sep. 1814, Bathurst MSS., 286. In October Castlereagh asked Bathurst to stop Bentinck (who had spent the summer in England) from going out to Italy again: 'the dread of his Whiggish and revolutionary politics in Italy would add to the alarms of Austria. . . . I have had an express representation from Metternich on this subject, and I am sure, if his Lordship's appearance in this quarter can ever be wise or useful (of which I entertain considerable doubts), it can only be in the event of hostile measures being actually decided on, and being on the point of execution': to Bathurst (private) 4 Oct. 1814, *ibid.*, 295. To which Bentinck, who was already in Paris, replied that he would rather resign his command than 'sanction an imputation . . . not less unfavourable to my honour than to my judgment. . . . If Florence is thought too near the Austrian States, I can as easily remove to Rome, and I will answer for His Holiness not objecting either to my religion or my politics, *tout heretick et revolutionnaire* as I may be': Bentinck to Bathurst (private) 23 Oct., *ibid.*, 301. (Bentinck had made a friend of the Pope by giving him aid and comfort while he was making his way from Northern Italy to Rome at the end of the war.) The occasion that precipitated Bentinck's final recall was an approach which he and William Hill, the Minister at Turin, made to the Piedmontese Minister Vallaise, urging that the King of Piedmont should grant a constitution and so raise Northern Italy against Murat: Bathurst to Bentinck (private) 26 Apr. 1815, B.P.; cf. F. Lemmi, 'La Restaurazione dello Stato Sardo nel 1814-15', in Università di Torino, *Miscellanee della Facoltà di Lettere e Filosofia*, ser. 2 (1938). Bentinck's protest against his recall (to Bathurst, 18 June 1815—see p. 168 and note) defended his conduct since 1811: by his exertions, he said, Sicily, which had never before contributed to the Allied cause, had been enabled to send 12,000 men to Spain in 1812, and a further 12,000 to Italy in 1814; his hostility to Murat had been justified by later events; his explanation of the Genoa episode appears in Appendix C. He accordingly asked either 'to be told in what my crime has consisted, and to be heard in my defence', or else to be allowed to stay in the government service. Bathurst's reply (20 June 1815) was formal and non-committal (B.P.). Already, when the news of Bentinck's recall had first come out, his friend Pellew (now Lord Exmouth), who shared all his views on Italy, had written to him: 'I can perceive the evil finger of Lord C . . . gh throughout. . . . It is possible you may trace the noble Lord's disinclination towards you to causes more remote when he was not so popular as he is now with Canning under his thumb': to Bentinck, 23 Apr. 1815, B.P. Bentinck was not employed again until 1828, when he became Governor of Bengal. As late as 1824 his notoriety had not faded: 'They are in the greatest fuss now for fear Lord William Bentinck should be appointed . . . High Commissioner of the Ionian Islands. Metternich said all the Italian Sovereigns, and first among them the Emperor himself, would protest loudly against it. They have a greater horror of Lord William than of any other radical in Europe and last year, when Lady William was in Italy, they never allowed her to get a single letter from Lord William':

The Journal of Mrs Arbuthnot, ed. F. Bamford and the Duke of Wellington (1950), i, 288-9 (24 Feb. 1824).

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this political digression. Bentinck to Hamilton, Rome 25 Jan. 1815, FO 70/71.

à une meilleure postérité. Bentinck to Hamilton, Florence 30 Dec. 1814, FO 67/45; to Castelnovo, 29 Dec. 1814, in L. Salemi, *I Trattati antinapoleonici dell'Inghilterra con le Duc Sicilie* (Palermo, 1937), 169. Castelnovo replied: 'I can never forget you, as I am sure my country can never forget what she owes to you. I understand that you have good reason to complain of her, but you must keep in mind that, as ancient and modern history shews, those who have done good to the peoples have been ill-rewarded. . . and have reaped the gratitude of posterity alone': to Bentinck, 16 Jan. 1815, B.P. Cf. similar letters to Bentinck from Settimo, Spaccaforo (Cassaro's son), Airolidi, Carini: B.P.

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Sicily's constitution and independence. See the King's very clear-headed estimate of Sicilian opinion, in a letter to Medici, 30 Aug. 1814: Maturi, i, 67-8.

speedily confirmed. A'Court to Bentinck (private) 24 July 1814, B.P. The history of Sicily between Bentinck's departure in July 1814 and the King's return to Naples in May 1815 is dealt with at length by Bianco, 251 ff. He is mistaken, however, in stating that A'Court supported the King's reactionary policy from the first. It is clear from the King's *Giornale d'Affari* that he was much annoyed at what he considered A'Court's unwarranted interference on behalf of the 'persecuted' constitutionalists. Actually, that 'persecution' amounted to little more than the loss of places and official favour.

a 'posthumous conquest of Napoleon'. L. Blanch, 'Luigi de' Medici', 166. By the decrees of December 1816 Ferdinand changed his title to Ferdinand I, King of the Kingdom of the Two Sicilies; the whole existing system of local government was abolished, and seven new provinces set up each under an *Intendente*, with new municipal councils to be nominated by the King. Conscription was introduced. The annual revenue was fixed at the 1813 level (which, however, had included the British subsidy); any increases would have to be 'approved by Parliament'. Previously, the Sicilian flag, the separate Sicilian army, and the freedom of the Press had been abolished: Bianco, 278-94.

Austria's Italian territories. Strictly speaking, the secret Austro-Neapolitan treaty applied to Naples only; but Austria objected as much to a constitutional system in Sicily as in Naples.

a plain, honourable, and consistent tale. A'Court to Stewart, 6 Nov. 1816. The course of these negotiations is followed in detail by Webster, ii, 108-12. Sir Charles Webster's comment is that this was 'one of the most equivocal [episodes] in which Castlereagh took part'.

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to restore the Constitution. Romano, 'Notizie intorno a . . . Belmonte' (Bibl. Com. Palermo, MSS. 4 Qq D 81 f. 76); I. La Lumia, 'Carlo Cottone Principe di Castelnovo', in *Storie Siciliane*, iv, 700-17; letters of Bentinck and Castelnovo, quoted in note to p. 152.

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supported him by 69 votes to 35. *Parliamentary Debates*, New Series, v, 1234 ff. (debate of 21 June 1821). Among the supporters of Bentinck's motion were Grattan, Mackintosh, Ricardo, Tierney, Wood, Whitbread.

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very much underrate. G.M. Trevelyan, *Lord Grey of the Reform Bill* (1920), 147.

attributed the loss of Naples. Elliot to Charles James Fox, 3, 7 June 1806, FO 70/27. 'With an essential part of government in the hands of a French emigrant, the Neapolitan Court became the centre of the intrigues of a designing set of persons, who were careless of the interests of Naples, and inimical to those of Great Britain': Elliot's summing-up of his mission, in Countess of Minto, *Memoir of the Rt. Hon. Hugh Elliot* (Edinburgh, 1868), 402.

both in war and in commerce. Grenville to Fox, 22 June 1806, Hist. MSS. Comm., *Fortescue MSS.* viii, 196.

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to do their best to secure it. Howick to Drummond, 3 Oct. 1806, with *projet* of treaty, FO 70/30.

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wrote home for instructions. Bunbury, 177, 183-5; Elliot to C.J. Fox (private) 6 Aug. 1806, FO 70/27; Elliot to Gen. Henry Fox, 28 Aug. 1806 (private and secret) FO 70/29; correspondence between Gen. Fox, William A'Court, Circello, and Sir Sidney Smith, Sept., Oct. 1806, FO 70/29; the Queen to Damas, 26 Nov. 1806, Damas, ii, 368; Drummond to Howick, 11 Mar. 1807 (private) FO 70/30; to Canning, 26 Mar. 1808, FO 70/32 (review of his mission); to Gen. Fox, 27 Jan. 1807, Bunbury, 297; Moore, *Diary*, ii, 137, 139. Drummond's first despatches to Howick are missing from the Foreign Office files up to 6 Feb. 1807, but their contents can be deduced from the despatches to Howick, Canning and Gen. Fox quoted above.

the control of France. To Drummond, . . . March 1807, FO 70/30, draft (not sent). The draft is unsigned: that it is Howick's is proved by a passage from Spencer Perceval's memorandum of 13 Apr. 1811: 'The last administration had determined on this revolution, all our representatives civil and military, and almost all individual officers in our army, and all resident English have been talking the same language which led Lord Grey to prepare the dispatch to which I allude': Add. MSS. 37, 292, f. 360. According to Lady Holland, the decision to intervene was 'on account of Erskine's extraordinary imprudence in talking . . . to be kept a secret from the Cabinet, and only known to a few . . . [if the British demands are not complied with], we are to declare we cannot defend the island, and if refused, force employed to effectuate them': Elizabeth Lady Holland, *Journal*, ed Lord Ilchester (1908), ii, 211-2 (8 Mar. 1807).

his cooperation in the war. Canning to Drummond, 12 June, 15 Aug., 26 Dec. 1807, FO 70/30. Canning did not write to Drummond until June because no despatches arrived from Sicily for months after those of 11 and 12 Mar. 1807 (announcing Drummond's change of policy, and received at the F.O. on 14 April, i.e. after Howick's fall).

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a Sicilian Parliament than a British camp. Drummond to Howick, 11 Mar. 1807 (private), 9 Apr. 1807, FO 70/30; to Canning, 24 Feb., 26 Mar., 6 July 1808, FO 70/32.

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not particularly disposed to require. Drummond to Howick, 11 Mar. 1807 (private), 6 Feb. 1807 (private and secret), FO 70/30.

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to pin his hopes on the King. Drummond to Howick, 11 Mar. 1807, FO 70/30; Moore, *Diary*, ii, 145, 153, 163, 165 (Jan.-Apr. 1807); Moore to Gen. Fox, 25 July 1807,

Bunbury, 305; Castlereagh to Hawkesbury, 8 Oct. 1807, *Castlereagh Corr.* viii, 89; Drummond to Howick, 9 Apr. 1807, to Canning, 24 Oct., 9 Nov. 1807, FO 70/30; to Canning, 12, 18, 27 Jan., 24 Feb., 25, 26, 27 Mar., 31 May, 6 July, 19 Oct. 1808, FO 70/32.

recalled him at once, in September 1808. Bunbury, 204-17, 224-6; Canning to Drummond, 26 Dec. 1807, FO 70/30; to Drummond, 25 June, 5 Aug., 22 Sep. 1808, FO 70/32.

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not yet over officially. 'Amidst these glorious and decisive successes, I must still impress upon Your Lordship the necessity of leaving nothing to chance . . . it is of the last importance that the state of Italy should not be such as to afford [Bonaparte] an asylum if, under the favour of Providence, the Allies should succeed in driving him from France': Castlereagh to Bentinck, Dijon, 5 Apr., *Castlereagh Corr.* ix, 442.

her reputation as Perfidious Albion. Proclamation printed in *British and Foreign State Papers*, ii, 317; Castlereagh to Bentinck, 30 Mar., *Castlereagh Corr.* ix, 409. 'Je vois que depuis le fameux manquement de foi de la nation anglaise envers les Génois (proclamation signée Bentinck), la vertu anglaise passe ici pour de la pure tartuferie': Stendhal, *Rome, Naples et Florence* (Paris, 1865, 1st ed. 1817), 165.

not only advisable but necessary. Bentinck to Bathurst, 18 June 1815, B.P. (fair copy; also several rough drafts, more bitter in tone than the final version—this was Bentinck's protest against his summary recall from the Mediterranean command in April 1815).

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make whatever arrangement they pleased. Bentinck's Italian Campaign Diary, 22-26 Apr. 1814, B.P. Lt.-Col. Catinelli, an officer in Bentinck's Italian Levy and one of his Italian patriotic friends, later explained to Bathurst that Bentinck had also been moved by respect for the glories of such States as Genoa and Venice, 'dont l'origine et l'existence se basaient non pas sur des conquêtes ou des traités de mariage mais d'une certaine manière sur la création du sol habité par leurs peuples': Catinelli's Memorandum to Bathurst and Bunbury, London, 1 Mar. 1815, B.P. (copy). Bathurst, for his part, pretended to believe—both for Bentinck's benefit and for that of the House of Commons—that 'you did not mean to pledge the faith of your Government to the final re-establishment of it, but simply as establishing that as a Provisional Government, until the Regent's pleasure was made known': to Bentinck (private) 29 Mar., 1815, B.P.

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